

HOMER

THE ILIAD

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Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

FORWARD

By A. Thucydides

The discord between Achilles and Agamemnon, spurred by Chryses' plea and the subsequent plague, laid bare the fragility of command. Even in that renowned assembly, accounts differed on the affront and the ensuing pestilence. The logistics of leading a thousand ships, though formidable, could not overcome the deep-seated rivalries that turned warriors against their own. Such internal strife, like a hidden reef, threatens even the grandest expeditions.

Later, when the Achaeans falter before Troy's walls, the embassy to Achilles reveals the intractable nature of human will. Offers of gold and women could not mend the slight to a warrior's honor, nor could the urgent need for victory overcome the memory of insult. The very structures of command, built on hierarchy and expectation, became the instruments of their own undoing, turning men into mere numbers, expendable against the stone walls of a city.

Thus, the body of Hector, so long the prize of contention and the measure of Achaean wrath, was returned to Troy. This exchange, wrought by an old king's entreaty and a warrior's fleeting pity, marked a pause in the struggle. It showed that command, even when absolute, must at last reckon with the cost not of glory, but of bodies and the sorrow within the walls of a household. For all the boasts of conquest, the true tally was found in the empty spaces left behind.

BOOK I

First-pass working translation

Sing, goddess, of the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles,
the ruinous wrath that brought unnumbered grief
upon the Achaeans, and sent many brave souls
before their time into the house of Hades,
making their bodies prey for dogs and every bird—
while Zeus's will was brought toward fulfillment—
from that first hour when Atreus' son, the king
of men, and godlike Achilles stood at odds.
Who, then, among the gods joined them in strife?
The son of Leto and of Zeus. For he,
angered against the king, sent through the host
a deadly plague; and the people perished,
because Agamemnon had dishonored Chryses,
the priest, who came before the swift ships,
to ransom his dear daughter, bearing gifts
beyond all measure, and in his hands the wreath
and golden staff of far-darting Apollo;
he prayed to all the Achaeans, but most of all
to Atreus' sons, the marshals of the people.
The priest came then to the shore, and prayed to Apollo,
the lord who bears the silver bow, and called upon him:
“Hear me, you of the fair hair, you who keep Chryse
and holy Cilla, and who rule Tenedos in power;
if ever I have built you a pleasing temple,
or burned for you the rich thigh-pieces of bulls
and goats, grant this desire: let the Danaans pay
for my tears beneath your arrows.” So he prayed,
and Phoebus Apollo heard him. Down from Olympus
he came, his heart full of anger, carrying his bow
and covered quiver. The arrows rang upon his shoulder
as the god moved; and he sat apart from the ships,
then loosed a shaft. First the mules and swift hounds
he struck; afterward he turned his bitter arrows
against the men. Through all the camp the pyres

burned without rest.
For nine days the shafts of the god
went forth.
On the tenth, Achilles called the
people to assembly.
Hera of the white arms had put the
thought within him,
grieving for the Danaans as she
watched them perish.
When they had gathered, Achilles
rose among them:
“Son of Atreus, soon we shall be
driven back again,
wandering among the waves, if any
man remains alive.
Come, let us ask a seer, or priest, or
interpreter
of dreams—for dreams are also from
Zeus—to tell us
why Phoebus is so bitter, whether he
blames our vows
or hecatombs, and whether he might
meet us again
and ward the ruin off by the savor of
lambs
and goats made perfect in sacrifice.”
He sat, and Calchas rose among
them, Thestor's son,
the best of augurs, who knew what is,
what was, and what will be,
and who had led the Achaean ships
to Ilium
by that prophetic art Apollo gave to
him.
With thoughtful speech he answered
them and said:
“Achilles, dear to Zeus, you ask me to
declare
the wrath of Apollo, lord of the
far-shooting bow.

I will speak it;
but swear to stand beside me, and be
ready in word
and hand. For I think that man
will soon be angered against me, the
one who rules
the Argives, and whose word the
army must obey.
No light thing is a king's resentment;
stronger
is a king when angered against a
lesser man. If he hides
his anger for a day, it grows and
waits for payment.”
Achilles answered him: “Speak freely.
No one here,
while I draw breath and look upon
the light of day,
shall lift a hand against you—not
Agamemnon,
though he names himself the greatest
of the Greeks.”
Then the blameless seer took courage
and spoke:
“No vow, no hecatomb, no offering is
lacking.
The god's wrath is for Chryses and
his daughter,
whom Agamemnon will not release.
Send her home,
without a price or ransom; sacrifice
at Chryse.
Then the god may turn from us and
end the plague.”
Agamemnon, anger still black
around his heart,
rose and spoke to Calchas first:
“Prophet of evil, never have you
spoken good to me.

You love to prophesy what brings the
army sorrow;

you have never spoken a good word
or brought it to pass.

And now among the Danaans you
declare that the far-shooter
deals them pain because I would not
accept the shining ransom
for Chryseis, because I desired to
keep her in my house.

I prefer her even to Clytemnestra,
my wedded wife;
she is not less than Clytemnestra in
form, in stature,
in mind, or in the work of her hands.
Still, I will give her back,
if that is better. I would rather keep
my people safe than see them die.
But make ready another prize for me
at once, so that I alone
among the Argives do not go
without my honor—you all see
that my prize is being carried
elsewhere.”

Achilles, swift of foot, looked at him
darkly and answered:

“Son of Atreus, most glorious and
most greedy of all men,
how shall the great-hearted
Achaeans give you a prize?

We know of no common stores lying
in abundance here:

the spoils from the cities we took
have been divided,
and it would not be fitting to gather
the people together
and make them give those portions
back. Send this girl

to the god now; and when we take
Troy's well-built city,

we shall pay you three and four times
over, if Zeus grants it.”

Agamemnon, king of men, replied:

“Do not, godlike Achilles, though
you are good, hide your thought
and try to deceive me; you will not
slip past me or persuade me.

Do you want to keep your own prize
while I sit here without one,
and command me to give this girl
away? If the great-hearted Achaeans
give me a prize, making it fit my
desire, so be it. But if they do not,
I myself will take one—yours, Ajax's,
or Odysseus's—and carry it away.

The man I visit will be angry; we
shall settle that another time.

For now, haul the black ship down to
the shining sea,

gather rowers in proper number, put
the hecatomb aboard,
and send fair-cheeked Chryseis. Let
one of the counselors lead:

Ajax, Idomeneus, godlike
Odysseus—or you, son of Peleus,
most terrible of men—so that you
may appease the far-shooter
by performing the holy rites.”

Achilles, looking darkly at him,
answered:

“Ah, clothed in shamelessness and
bent on gain—who among the
Achaeans

will follow you freely, whether to
march or fight in battle?

I did not come here to fight the
spear-famed Trojans for my own
sake:

they have never wronged me. They
never drove off my cattle or my

horses;
they never in Phthia, rich in soil and
men, destroyed my harvest—
there are shadowed mountains and
the sounding sea between us.
No: we followed you, great shameless
one, to win honor for Menelaus
and for you, dog-face, from the
Trojans—though you neither notice
nor care.
And now you threaten to take from
me the prize for which I labored,
which the sons of the Achaeans gave
me. I never receive a prize equal to
yours
when the Achaeans sack a
well-inhabited Trojan city;
my hands bear the greater burden of
the furious war.
But when the division comes, your
prize is far larger,
while I carry a small but cherished
portion to my ships,
after I have grown weary fighting.
Now I will go to Phthia:
it is far better to sail home in my
curved ships
than to remain here dishonored and
heap up wealth and treasure for you.”
“Go, then, if your heart urges you; I
do not beg you to stay for my sake.
There are others here who will honor
me, and Zeus above all,
the counselor. You are the most
hateful of the kings he nourishes.
Strife, wars, and battles are always
dear to you.
If you are mighty, some god has
given you that gift.

Go home with your ships and
companions, rule your Myrmidons;
I care nothing for your wrath, nor do
I count it as a threat.
But this I tell you: as Phoebus Apollo
takes Chryseis from me,
I will send her away in my ship with
my companions;
then I myself will go to your hut and
take fair-cheeked Briseis,
your prize, so that you may know
how much stronger I am than you,
and that every other man may fear to
call himself my equal.”
Then grief and anger gathered in
Achilles' chest.
He weighed two thoughts: to draw
his sword from his thigh
and scatter the assembly, or to
master his heart and endure.
As he drew the great blade, Athena
came down from heaven,
sent by the white-armed goddess
Hera, who loved both men.
She stood behind him, visible to him
alone, and caught his hair.
Achilles turned and said: “Why have
you come, child of Zeus?
To watch the insolence of
Agamemnon? I tell you this:
his life, I think, will soon pay for
what he has done.”
The goddess of flashing eyes
answered him:
“I came to restrain you. Put away the
sword.
Speak against him as fiercely as you
will, but do not strike.
One day, for this dishonor, gifts
three times over

will be set before you. Hold your hand and obey.”

Achilles answered: “A man must obey you, goddess, though anger burns. It is better so. Whoever obeys the gods, the gods hear him in return.” He drove the blade back into its sheath, and Athena rose again to Olympus.

Then he faced the son of Atreus and spoke once more:

“You who wear a dog's eyes and carry a deer's heart, never do you arm with the people for battle, never go with the best into an ambush or the line.

That would be death to you. It is easier to walk the camp and strip a man of his prize. You rule men who obey you, because you are a king who feeds upon his own people.

Otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage.

But I swear a great oath: by this staff, which will never again put forth leaf or branch, since bronze cut it from the mountain and stripped its bark, and now judges carry it in their hands, judges who keep the laws that come from Zeus—

so surely shall a day come when all the Achaeans will long for Achilles. Then, though you suffer, you cannot help them, when Hector, breaker of ranks, kills men beside their ships.

You will tear your heart for the champion you dishonored.”

He flung the gold-studded staff upon the ground and sat.

Across from him Agamemnon still raged. But Nestor rose, the clear-speaking elder from Pylos, whose tongue flowed sweeter than honey. Two generations of mortal men had passed before him, and now he ruled among the third. He addressed them:

“What sorrow has come upon the Achaean land!

The Trojans would rejoice, and Priam's sons, and all the rest, if they could hear you. End this quarrel. You are both younger than I, and I have stood beside men greater than you.

Yet they listened when I spoke, and followed my counsel.

Listen now. You, Agamemnon, do not take the girl;

let her remain. And you, Achilles, do not contend

with the king, since no other scepter-bearing man has honor equal to his. If you are the stronger, still he is greater in rank, and more men obey him.”

Achilles cut him off: “No coward would endure your words.

Let others take your commands; do not command me:

I do not think I shall obey you any longer. And mark this well:

I will not fight you with my hands for the girl's sake,

nor you, nor any other man, since
you have taken her from me.
But of all the other things I have
beside my swift black ship,
you shall carry off none against my
will. Come—try it,
so that these men may see: your black
blood will run around my spear.”
They broke the assembly. Achilles
went to his ships
with Patroclus and his companions.
Agamemnon hauled a swift ship
down to the sea, chose twenty
rowers, and put aboard
the hecatomb for the god. He led
fair-cheeked Chryseis aboard,
and set wise Odysseus as captain.
They climbed in and sailed
the wet roads of the sea; meanwhile
Agamemnon ordered the army
to cleanse itself. They washed and
cast the filth into the sea,
then sacrificed perfect hecatombs of
bulls and goats to Apollo
beside the shore of the barren sea;
the smoke curled upward to heaven.
But the king did not cease from the
quarrel he had first threatened.
He called Talthybius and Eurybates,
his heralds and eager servants:
“Go to the hut of Achilles, son of
Peleus; take fair-cheeked Briseis
by the hand and lead her here. If he
will not give her, I myself
will come with more men and take
her—and that will be worse for him.”
They went unwillingly along the
barren shore and came to the huts
and ships of the Myrmidons. They
found Achilles sitting beside

his hut and black ship. He was not
glad to see them. They stood,
afraid and ashamed before the king,
and said nothing.
Achilles knew why they had come
and spoke first:
“Hail, heralds, messengers of Zeus
and of men. Come nearer.
You are not to blame; Agamemnon is
to blame, who sent you
for the girl. Patroclus, beloved
companion, bring her out
and give her to them. Let these two
be witnesses before the blessed gods,
before mortal men, and before the
harsh king himself, if ever again
there is need of me to ward
disgraceful death from the others.
For he sacrifices with a mind bent on
destruction; he does not know
how to think at once of what is
before him and what is behind,
so that the Achaeans beside the ships
might fight in safety.”
Patroclus obeyed his beloved
companion. He led fair-cheeked
Briseis
from the hut and gave her to the
heralds, who returned to the
Achaean ships.
The woman went unwillingly.
Achilles sat apart from his
companions,
weeping, on the shore of the gray sea,
and looked out across the boundless
water.
He stretched both hands toward his
dear mother and prayed:
“Mother, since you bore me though I
was doomed to a short life,

at least Olympian Zeus, the
high-thundering one, should have
granted me honor;
but now he has honored me not even
a little. Agamemnon,
son of Atreus, wide-ruling, has
dishonored me: he has taken my
prize,
and keeps it for himself.”

His mother heard him from the
depths of the sea, seated beside her
old father.

Swiftly she rose from the gray sea
like a mist, sat before her weeping
son,

caressed him with her hand, and
called him by name:

“Child, why do you weep? What grief
has come into your heart?

Speak out; do not hide it within you.
Let us both know.”

With a heavy groan Achilles
answered:

“You know it. Why should I tell it all
to you, who know it already?

We went to sacred Thebes, the city
of Eetion; we sacked it

and brought everything here. The
sons of the Achaeans divided it fairly
among themselves, but they chose
fair-cheeked Chryseis for
Agamemnon.

Then Chryses, priest of far-darting
Apollo, came to the swift ships
of the bronze-clad Achaeans to
ransom his daughter, bringing
immeasurable gifts and holding in
his hands the wreath and golden staff
of the far-shooting god. He begged
all the Achaeans,

and above all the two sons of Atreus,
commanders of the people.

All the other Achaeans approved:
they urged reverence for the priest
and acceptance of the shining
ransom. But Agamemnon's heart did
not consent;

he sent the old man away harshly and
laid a strong command upon him.

The old man went back in anger, and
Apollo heard his prayer,

for he loved him dearly. He shot a
deadly arrow among the Argives,
and the people died one after
another as the god's shafts moved
everywhere

through the wide camp of the
Achaeans. Then the prophet who
knew the god's will

spoke among us. I was the first to
order that the god be appeased.

But anger seized the son of Atreus;
he rose at once and threatened me—

and the threat is now fulfilled. The
Achaeans are sending Chryseis
to Chryse in the swift ship, with gifts
for the lord;

and heralds have just taken from my
hut Briseis,

the girl the sons of the Achaeans
gave me. Now, if you can,

protect your son: go to Olympus and
supplicate Zeus. If ever

you helped his heart by word or
deed—for many times in my father's
house

I heard you boast that you alone
among the immortals saved the
dark-clouded

son of Cronus from disgrace, when
Hera, Poseidon, and Athena
wanted to bind him. You came and
loosed him, goddess,
quickly calling to high Olympus the
Hundred-Handed One,
whom the gods call Briareus and men
Aegaeon, stronger even than his
father;
he sat beside the son of Cronus in
glory, and the blessed gods feared
him
and did not bind Zeus. Remind him
of this, sit beside him, and clasp his
knees,
if he will somehow help the Trojans,
drive the Achaeans back to their
ships
and the sea, and let them be cut
down, so that all may profit by their
king;
so that Agamemnon may learn what
madness he committed when he
dishonored
the best of the Achaeans.”
Thetis answered him, weeping:
“Ah, my child, why did I raise you,
bearing such bitter grief?
Would that you could sit beside the
ships without tears and without
pain,
since your portion of life is short and
not long at all.
But now you are short-lived and
more miserable than all men;
for an evil destiny I bore you in my
halls. I will go myself
to Olympus, to Zeus who delights in
thunder, and tell him these things,

to see if he will listen. But for now sit
beside your swift ships,
hold your wrath against the
Achaeans, and withdraw altogether
from war.
For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean
and the blameless Ethiopians to
feast,
and all the gods went with him. On
the twelfth day he will return to
Olympus;
then I will go to his bronze-floored
house, clasp his knees,
and I think I shall persuade him.”
Meanwhile Odysseus reached sacred
Chryse,
bringing the holy hecatomb. When
they entered the deep harbor,
they furled the sails, laid them in the
black ship,
lowered the mast into its rest, and
rowed swiftly to anchorage.
They cast out the anchors and made
fast the stern-lines;
then they stepped ashore through the
breakers,
and brought out the hecatomb for
the far-shooting god.
Chryseis too came down from the
seafaring ship.
Wise Odysseus led her to the altar,
placed her in her dear father's hands,
and spoke: “Chryses, Agamemnon,
king of men, sent me
to bring your child and sacrifice this
holy hecatomb to Phoebus
for the Danaans, so that we may
appease the lord
who has brought such grievous
sorrows upon the Argives.”

He placed her in her father's hands,
and the old man received his child
with joy. The Achaeans then set the
well-built hecatomb
around the altar of the far-shooter,
washed their hands,
and lifted the barley for the rite.
Chryses prayed aloud,
his hands raised to heaven:
“Hear me, god of the silver bow, who
guard Chryse,
holy Cilla, and rule Tenedos in
strength.
You heard me before when I prayed;
you honored me
and struck the Achaean people with
a great blow.
Grant me this wish once more:
defend the Danaans now
from their shameful plague.”
So he prayed, and Phoebus Apollo
heard him.
When they had prayed and scattered
the barley, they drew back the heads,
cut the throats, flayed the victims,
and cut out the thighs.
They wrapped them in fat, laid raw
flesh upon them,
and the old man burned them on
split wood, pouring bright wine over
them;
young men stood beside him with
five-pronged forks in their hands.
When the thighs had burned and
they had tasted the inward parts,
they cut the rest into pieces, pierced
it on spits,
roasted it carefully, and drew all the
meat away.

When the work was finished and the
feast prepared,
they ate, and no man's heart lacked
an equal portion.
When they had satisfied hunger and
thirst, the young men filled the
mixing bowls,
and poured the wine into every cup,
beginning on the right.
All day the young Achaeans
appeased the god with song,
singing the beautiful paean and
praising the far-shooter;
and he rejoiced to hear them.
When the sun had set and darkness
came, they slept beside the ship.
When rose the early-born,
rosy-fingered Dawn,
they sailed back toward the wide
Achaean camp.
The far-shooter sent them a fair
wind. They raised the mast,
spread the white sails, and the wind
filled the middle canvas.
The purple wave roared around the
speeding ship's stern,
and she ran across the sea, cutting
her road through the water.
When they reached the broad camp
of the Achaeans,
they hauled the black ship high upon
the mainland sand,
set long props beneath it, and
scattered to their huts and ships.
But godlike Achilles, swift of foot,
remained beside his swift ships,
holding his wrath. He never went to
the assembly that brings men glory,
never went out to battle; his dear
heart wasted where he sat,

longing for the battle-cry and the war.

When the twelfth dawn had appeared, all the everlasting gods went together to Olympus, with Zeus leading them.

Thetis did not forget her son's command. She rose from the sea and climbed like mist through the great heavens to Olympus.

She found the wide-seeing son of Cronus sitting apart from the others on the highest peak of many-ridged Olympus. She sat before him, clasped his knees with her left hand, touched his chin with her right, and supplicated Zeus, the son of Cronus:

"Father Zeus, if ever among the immortals I helped you by word or deed, fulfill this wish for me.

Honor my son, who is doomed to die before all others.

Agamemnon, king of men, has dishonored him;

he took his prize and keeps it for himself.

But honor him, Olympian Zeus, counselor of the gods; give the Trojans strength until the Achaeans honor my son and increase his standing."

She spoke. Zeus, gatherer of clouds, did not answer.

He sat long in silence. Thetis held fast to his knees

and asked him once more:

"Give me an unfailing promise and incline your head,

or refuse me—there is no fear in you—so I may know

how utterly I am dishonored among the gods."

Zeus groaned heavily and answered:

"Ah, what a difficult task you set me: Hera will quarrel with me when she taunts me with reproachful words.

Even without this, she is always scolding me before the immortals, and says that I aid the Trojans in battle.

Go back now, before Hera notices. I will remember this and bring it to fulfillment. To make you trust me,

I will nod with my head; there is no greater sign among the immortals.

What I confirm with a nod cannot be revoked, denied, or left unfulfilled."

The son of Cronus bent his dark brows and nodded.

His immortal hair streamed forward from his head,

and he shook great Olympus beneath him.

So they took counsel and parted.

Thetis plunged into the deep sea from bright Olympus, while Zeus went to his own house.

All the gods rose from their seats together when their father approached;

none dared remain seated to meet him.

Hera of the white arms had not failed to see him. She knew

that the silver-footed Thetis,
daughter of the old man of the sea,
had shared his counsels. At once she
spoke with taunting words:

“Who was it now, crafty one, who
shared your secret counsel?

You always love to think in secret,
apart from me,
and never willingly tell me what you
have decided.”

The father of gods and men
answered her:

“Hera, do not hope to know all my
thoughts.

They will be difficult for you, though
you are my wife.

No one else, god or man, will learn
first the thought
that I wish to keep apart from
everyone.”

Ox-eyed, revered Hera answered:

“Most terrible son of Cronus, what
have you said?

I neither ask you nor question you;
sit quietly and think
whatever you wish. But I fear terribly
that silver-footed Thetis,
daughter of the old man of the sea,
came to you at dawn,
sat beside you, and clasped your
knees.

I think you promised her truly to
honor Achilles
and destroy many Achaeans beside
their ships.”

Zeus, gatherer of clouds, answered:

“Strange one, you are always
thinking and never escape my notice.
Yet you will accomplish nothing; you
will only become farther from my

heart.

And that will be worse for you. Sit
down in silence and obey my word,
lest all the gods on Olympus fail to
help you when I stretch
my invincible hands against you.”

Hera fell silent, afraid, and sat with
her heart subdued.

The heavenly gods within Zeus's
house were troubled.

Then Hephaestus, famous for his
craft, rose to speak,
bringing comfort to his dear,
white-armed mother:

“This will be a disastrous and
unbearable thing
if you two quarrel so over mortal
men,
and bring disorder among the gods.
There will be no joy
in the good feast, because the worse
thing has prevailed.

I urge my mother—and she knows
this herself—to bring comfort
to our dear father Zeus, so that he
will not scold her again
and disturb our feast.”

He leapt up and placed a beautiful
double cup
in his mother's hands, and spoke
again:

“Endure, my mother, and bear it,
though you love me dearly,
lest I see you struck before my eyes
and be unable to help you.
It is hard to stand against the
Olympian. Once before,
when I came eager to defend you, he
seized me by the foot

and hurled me from the threshold of
heaven.

All day I fell, and at sunset I landed
in Lemnos,

with little life remaining. There the
Sintian men cared for me at once.”

He spoke, and the white-armed
goddess Hera smiled,
smiling, she accepted the cup from
her son's hand.

He poured sweet nectar for all the
other gods in turn,
drawing it from the mixing bowl.
Unquenchable laughter rose
among the blessed gods when they
saw Hephaestus bustling through the
hall.

So they feasted all day until the sun
went down,
and no heart lacked its equal
portion—not Apollo's beautiful lyre,
nor the Muses' lovely answering song.
When the sun's bright light had set,
each god went to his own house,
where famous, lame-footed
Hephaestus had built a dwelling
with his knowing mind. Zeus,
Olympian lord of the thunderbolt,
went to the bed where he had slept
before whenever sweet sleep came
upon him.

He climbed into it and slept; beside
him lay Hera of the golden throne.

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draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Apollo descending upon the Achaean camp
Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by Blake's visual language but not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 2

First-pass working translation

When the other gods and the armed
men had slept
through the dark night, Zeus who
gathers clouds kept wake.
He thought how he might honor
Achilles, and bring
the Achaeans to destruction beside
their ships.
At last he found the counsel best:
send a false dream
to Agamemnon, son of Atreus, king
of men.
He called the Dream, and spoke with
winged words:
“Go now, deceptive Dream, and
stand beside the bed
of Agamemnon, in the likeness of old
Nestor,
who is most trusted by the king. Tell
him every word
as I command. Say: ‘Arm all the
long-haired Achaeans.
Now you may take the city of
broad-streeted Troy.
The gods who hold Olympus no
longer disagree;
Hera has persuaded them, and ruin
hangs above the Trojans.’”
So he spoke, and the Dream went
swiftly on its errand.
It stood above the king’s head, and
took the likeness
of Nestor, who spoke to him in sleep:
“Son of Atreus, do you sleep? It is not
right for a man

who bears the cares of armies to lie
awake no longer.
Zeus has sent me to say that the gods
are now united;
though he is far away, he cares for
you and takes pity on you.
He commands you to arm the
Achaeans without delay.
You will take wide-wayed Troy. Do
not let the message
escape your mind when sweet sleep
has released you.”
The Dream withdrew, leaving him to
cherish in his heart
the thoughts it had
planted—thoughts that were never
to be fulfilled.
He thought the immortal voice had
spoken truth,
not knowing what Zeus had devised,
and that on that very day
he would take Priam’s city. He did
not know what the son of Cronus
was still preparing: more pain and
groaning for Trojans and Danaans
through the violence of battle.
and rose at once, putting on his soft
wool tunic.
Over it he threw a great cloak, and
bound beneath his feet
his shining sandals. Then he slung
the silver-studded sword
across his shoulders, and took the
scepter of his fathers,
imperishable, with which he went
among the Achaeans.
When Dawn, the goddess, climbed
high Olympus
to announce the light to Zeus and
the other immortals,

he first called the heralds,
clear-voiced men,
to summon the long-haired
Achaeans to assembly.

They called, and the people gathered
swiftly.

First Agamemnon summoned the
council of the great-hearted elders
beside Nestor's ship, and made his
careful plan:

"Friends, a divine dream came to me
through the ambrosial night.

It looked most like Nestor in form,
size, and stature;

it stood above my head and spoke:
'Do you sleep, son of Atreus?

It is not right for a counselor, with
peoples entrusted to him,
to sleep all night. Listen quickly: I am
a messenger of Zeus,

who, though he is far away, cares
greatly for you and pities you.

He commands you to arm the
long-haired Achaeans at once.

Now you might take broad-wayed
Troy, for the immortals who dwell
in Olympus no longer deliberate
apart: Hera has bent them all,
and grief hangs over the Trojans by
Zeus's will.'

So it spoke and flew away, and sweet
sleep released me.

Come now, if we can, let us arm the
sons of the Achaeans.

First I will test them with words, as
custom allows,

and order them to flee with their
many-oared ships;

you must hold them back, each man
speaking from his place."

He sat, and Nestor, king of sandy
Pylos, answered:

"If another Achaean had told us of
this dream,

we would call it false and urge a
stronger flight.

But the man who claims to be the
greatest of the Achaeans
saw it. Come, let us arm the sons of
the Achaeans."

So he spoke, and the council rose and
obeyed the shepherd of the people.

As bees stream from a hollow rock in
endless clusters,

when spring flowers open across the
field,

and some fly in a cloud while others
settle in the meadow—

so the many tribes of the Achaeans
came from ships and shelters,
filing before the deep shore into
assembly.

Rumor, Zeus's messenger, burned
among them and urged them
forward.

The gathering roared, the earth
groaned beneath the seated people,
and nine heralds shouted until they
could quiet the noise enough
for the god-nourished kings to be
heard. The people sat in haste,
and the clamor ceased. Agamemnon
rose, holding the scepter
that Hephaestus made and gave to
Zeus, and Zeus to Hermes,
the messenger who slays Argus;
Hermes gave it to Pelops,
the horse-driving king; Pelops left it
to Atreus, shepherd of the people,

and dying Atreus left it to Thyestes,
rich in flocks;

Thyestes left it to Agamemnon to
carry, that he might rule
over many islands and all Argos.

Leaning upon it, he spoke:

“Friends, heroes, Danaans, servants
of Ares, Zeus the son of Cronus
has bound me in a great and ruinous
delusion—cruel Zeus,
who once promised and nodded that
I would return after sacking
well-built Ilium, but now has devised
a wicked deception
and commands me to return to
Argos without glory,
having lost so many people. So, it
seems, it pleases mighty Zeus,
who has destroyed the crowns of
many cities and will destroy more:
his power is greatest. It would be
shameful for those yet unborn
to hear that we, so many, fought an
unprofitable war
against fewer men and never reached
its end.

If Achaeans and Trojans were
counted under a faithful truce,
if the Trojans gathered all who live
within their city,
and we Achaeans were arranged in
tens, each ten choosing a Trojan
to pour the wine, many tens of us
would still lack a cupbearer:
so much greater, I say, is our number
than theirs.

But allies from many cities stand
beside them, spear-bearing men,
who keep me from taking the
well-inhabited city of Ilium.

Nine years of great Zeus have already
passed;

the timbers of our ships have rotted
and the rigging has slackened.

Our wives and little children sit at
home awaiting us,

while our work here remains
unfinished, for which we came.

Come now, let us all obey what I say:
let us flee in our ships

to our dear fatherland. We shall
never take broad-wayed Troy.”

So he spoke, and stirred the hearts of
all those who had not heard
the council. The assembly moved like
the long waves of the Icarian Sea,
when East and South leap upon them
from the clouds of Father Zeus;
or as when the West Wind comes
upon a deep field of grain,
driving violently over the ears and
bowing the standing corn.

The assembly broke. They surged
toward the ships,

shouting like waves that the south
wind drives upon a beach,

when a deep sea runs in beneath the
open shore.

But Hera, who watched the
Achaeans scatter, said to Athena:

“Daughter of Zeus, will the Argives
leave this land,

and give the glory of Helen to Priam
and his sons?

Go now among them, and hold each
man in place.”

Athena went down through the
crowd. She found Odysseus,
whose mind was equal to the gods,
still standing by his scepter.

He did not touch a ship, nor prepare to flee.

She stood beside him and said: "Son of Laertes,

why do you run as though every man were rushing home?

Sit here, and let the others sit as well.

The king's speech

was a test, not an order to abandon the war."

Odysseus turned, and went among the men, taking the scepter from any noble who held it. To a king he spoke with courtesy:

"It is not fitting for you to stand like a coward.

Sit and listen. Others will hear you later."

But when he found a common man shouting, he struck him

with the scepter and rebuked him:

"Friend, stay quiet and listen to those who have greater honor.

You are weak in war, and weak in counsel. No one man can rule us all. There must be one king."

The people returned from the ships.

The gathering became

like a high wave breaking, then settling in its bed.

Only Thersites remained, still pouring out his unmeasured words.

He knew many shameful things, but knew no order in his speech;

he loved to quarrel with kings and say whatever seemed laughable

to the Argives. He was the ugliest man who came to Ilium:

bandy-legged, lame in one foot, his shoulders hunched together

over his chest, and above them his pointed head was thinly covered

with down. Achilles and Odysseus hated him most of all,

for he was always abusing them. Now

he shrilled against Agamemnon,

and the Achaeans grew angry and resented him in their hearts.

He shouted loudly and reproached the shepherd of the people:

"Son of Atreus, what are you blaming now, and what do you lack?

Your huts are full of bronze, and many women are there,

chosen out for you first whenever we take a city.

Do you still lack gold, some ransom a horse-taming Trojan

will bring from Ilium for his son,

whom I or another Achaean

has bound and led away? Or a young woman, to join with her in love,

whom you alone keep apart from the others? It is not fitting

that the leader of our troubles should heap more trouble upon us.

Soft, shameful Achaeans, no longer men—let us sail home

with our ships and leave this man

here in Troy to consume his prizes,

so that he may see whether we are of any use to him or not—

the man who has dishonored

Achilles, a far better man than he,

and taken his prize for himself. Yet

Achilles is not angry enough;

otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage."

So Thersites mocked Agamemnon,
shepherd of the people.
At once godlike Odysseus stood
beside him and looked him down:
“Thersites, reckless speaker, hold
your tongue. Do not try alone
to quarrel with kings. I say there is
no worse mortal than you
among all who came with the sons of
Atreus to Ilium.
Therefore do not carry the kings’
names in your mouth,
or heap insults upon them, or urge
the people home.
We do not yet know how these
matters will end,
whether we Achaeans will return
well or badly.
You sit here abusing Agamemnon,
shepherd of the people,
because the heroes of the Danaans
give him many gifts,
and you speak by taunting. But I tell
you—and this shall be fulfilled:
if I find you raving again as now, let
Odysseus have no head on his
shoulders,
and let me no longer be called
Telemachus’s father,
if I do not strip your cloak and tunic,
the garments that cover your shame,
and send you weeping to the swift
ships, beaten with disgraceful blows.”
He struck his back and shoulders
with the golden scepter.
Thersites bent, tears fell thickly, and
a bloody welt rose beneath the
scepter.
He sat trembling, wiped away the
tear, and looked helplessly around.

The army, though grieved for him,
laughed aloud, and one man said to
another:
“Odysseus has done countless good
things, leading counsel and arming
war;
but this is the best he has done
among the Argives:
he has stopped this abusive
loudmouth from insulting kings.”
So the multitude spoke. Then
city-sacking Odysseus rose,
holding the scepter; beside him
bright-eyed Athena,
in the likeness of a herald, ordered
the people to be silent,
so that the first and last of the
Achaeans might hear
and understand the counsel.
Odysseus spoke thoughtfully:
“Son of Atreus, the Achaeans now
want to make you,
their king, the most disgraced of all
mortal men.
They do not fulfill the promise they
made when they left Argos:
that they would return after taking
well-built Ilium.
They groan like young children and
widowed women,
each longing to go home. It is painful
to stay and return
after a single month away from one’s
wife on a many-benched ship,
when winter winds and the troubled
sea hold a man in place.
But we have spent nine turning years
here; I do not blame
the Achaeans for grieving beside
their curved ships.

Yet it is shameful to remain long and
return empty-handed.

Endure, friends, and stay a little
longer, until we learn
whether Calchas truly prophesies or
not. We know this well,
and you are all witnesses who
escaped the fate of death:

when the Achaean ships gathered at
Aulis, carrying slaughter
to Priam and the Trojans, we
sacrificed perfect hecatombs
beside the spring, under a beautiful
plane tree where clear water ran.

There a great sign appeared. A
red-backed, terrible serpent,
sent into the light by Zeus himself,
darted from beneath the altar
and rushed to the plane tree. There
were eight sparrow nestlings,
young chicks huddled beneath the
leaves on the highest branch;
their mother was the ninth, who had
hatched them.

The serpent ate them as they chirped
pitifully;

the mother flew around mourning
her dear young,

but the serpent seized her by the
wing as she cried out.

When it had eaten the chicks and
their mother, the god who showed it
made the serpent conspicuous,
turning it to stone.

We stood astonished at what Zeus
had done.

Then Calchas spoke among us,
interpreting the omen:

‘Why are you silent, long-haired
Achaean? Mighty Zeus

has shown us this great sign, late in
appearing but late to fulfill,
whose glory shall never die. As the
serpent ate the eight chicks
and their mother, the ninth, so shall
we fight here for nine years;
in the tenth we shall take the
broad-wayed city.’

That is what he said, and now all is
being fulfilled.

Stay here, well-greaved Achaeans,
until we take Priam's great city.”

He spoke, and the Argives shouted
loudly; the ships roared terribly
under the Achaeans' cry, praising
godlike Odysseus.

Then Gerenian Nestor, the
horseman, spoke:

“Shame on you—you speak like
children, like infants

who know nothing of the work of
war. Where are our agreements
and oaths now? Let our counsels and
plans, our libations

and right hands pledged in trust,
burn in fire.

We quarrel with words and find no
remedy, though we have been here
long.

Agamemnon, hold the unbending
counsel you had before
and lead the Argives through the
harsh battle.

Let those who plan apart from the
Achaeans wither, one or two at a
time;

their plan will not succeed. Before we
return to Argos,

we must learn whether the promise
of Zeus who bears the aegis

was false or not. For I say that
mighty Cronus's son nodded
on the day we boarded our swift
ships, carrying death to Troy,
showing favorable signs with
lightning on our right.

Let no one hurry home before he has
slept beside a Trojan wife
and taken vengeance for Helen's
striving and groaning.

If anyone still fiercely desires to go
home, let him touch
his black, well-benched ship, so that
he may meet death and fate
before the others. And you, king,
plan well and listen to another word:
sort the men by tribes and clans,
Agamemnon,
so clan may help clan and tribe may
help tribe.

If you do this and the Achaeans obey,
you will know

which leader is bad and which is
good, and which common man is
brave:

they will fight in their own divisions.

You will know too

whether you will fail to take the city
because of your men's weakness
or because of their lack of knowledge
in war."

Agamemnon answered him:

"Old man, you win the assembly
again. If only Zeus the father,

Athena, and Apollo would give me
ten counselors such as you among the
Achaeans,

Priam's city would soon bow and be
sacked beneath our hands.

But Zeus, son of Cronus, has given
me grief: he throws me into
useless quarrels and disputes.

Achilles and I fought over a girl,
and I began it in anger. If we ever
agree in one counsel again,

Troy's suffering will no longer be
delayed, not even for a little.

Now go to dinner, so that we may
join battle.

Let each man sharpen his spear well,
set his shield well,

feed his swift-footed horses well, and
inspect his chariot carefully,

so that all day we may be tested in
hateful Ares.

There will be no pause, not even for
a little, unless night comes

to divide the force of men. The
shield-strap will sweat

around the chest of one man, his
hand will grow weary on the spear;

another's horse will sweat as he
strains the polished chariot.

But whoever I see willingly lingering
apart from battle

beside the curved ships will not
escape the dogs and birds."

The Argives shouted loudly, like
waves breaking upon a high shore

when the South Wind rises and
drives them against a projecting
rock;

the waves never leave it, whatever
wind blows from this side or that.

They rose, scattered among the ships,
and kindled fires in the huts;

each man sacrificed to the
everlasting gods, praying to escape
death

and the labor of Ares. Agamemnon sacrificed a five-year-old, fat ox to mighty Zeus, and called the oldest and best of the Pan-Achaean:

Nestor first, then King Idomeneus; the two Ajaxes, then Tydeus's son, and sixth Odysseus, whose mind was equal to Zeus's.

Menelaus came of his own accord, for he knew in his heart how his brother labored. They stood around the ox, lifted the barley, and Agamemnon prayed:

"Most glorious and greatest Zeus, dark-clouded lord of the sky, let not the sun go down and darkness come before I cast the smoky roof of Priam's house upon its face and burn its doors with hostile fire, and tear Hector's shirt across his breast with bronze, while many of his companions fall around him face-first in the dust and bite the earth."

So he prayed, but the son of Cronus did not grant his prayer; he accepted the sacrifice, but increased the labor without end.

When they had prayed and scattered the barley, they drew back the heads, cut the throats and flayed the victim, then cut out the thighs, wrapped them in fat, and laid the raw flesh upon them.

They burned these on leafless sticks over the fire, and held the inward parts above the flame. When the thighs were burned

and they had tasted the inward parts, they cut the rest into pieces, pierced them on spits, roasted them carefully, and drew away the meat.

When the labor was finished and the feast prepared, they ate; no man's heart lacked an equal portion.

When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, Gerenian Nestor, the horseman, spoke first:

"Most glorious son of Atreus, king of men, let us no longer keep speaking here or delay the work the god places in our hands.

Let the heralds summon the bronze-clad Achaeans and gather them by the ships; we will go together through the broad army and awaken sharp Ares."

So he spoke, and Agamemnon did not disobey. At once he ordered the clear-voiced heralds to proclaim battle and gather the long-haired Achaeans.

They called, and the people assembled swiftly. Around Agamemnon

the god-nourished kings rushed to their places, and with them went bright-eyed

Athena, bearing the precious, ageless, deathless aegis; from it hung a hundred golden tassels, each worth a hundred oxen.

With it she flashed through the Achaean ranks, urging them forward, and put an unwearied strength into every heart to fight and make war.

Then battle became sweeter to them
than sailing home
in their hollow ships to their dear
fatherland.

As a ruinous fire blazes through an
immense forest on a mountain's
crest,
and its light is seen from far away, so
from the bronze of the advancing
host

a light rose through the air and
reached heaven.

As the many tribes of winged
birds—geese, cranes, or long-necked
swans—

fly here and there on the Asian
meadow beside the streams of
Cayster,

settling joyfully on their wings with
clamor that rings across the meadow,
so the many tribes poured from ships
and huts onto the Scamandrian
plain.

The earth beneath their feet and
horses thundered terribly.

They stood on the flowering
Scamandrian plain, countless as
leaves and flowers

that come in their season. As
countless swarms of flies wander
through

the shepherds' fold in spring, when
milk drenches the pails,
so many long-haired Achaeans stood
on the plain, eager to break the
Trojans.

As goatherds easily sort wide flocks
of goats after they mingle in the
pasture,
so the leaders arranged them here
and there for battle.

Agamemnon stood among them, like
Zeus who delights in thunder
in eyes and head, like Ares in his
belt, like Poseidon in his chest.

As a bull stands conspicuous above
all the cattle gathered in a herd,
so Zeus made the son of Atreus
conspicuous and foremost among the
many heroes.

“Tell me now, Muses, who dwell in
Olympian houses—

you are goddesses, present and
knowing all things;

we hear only rumor and know
nothing for ourselves—

who were the leaders and
commanders of the Danaans?

I could not name the multitude or
tell its number,

not if I had ten tongues and ten
mouths, an unbreakable voice,
and a bronze heart within me, unless
the Olympian Muses,

daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus,
remembered all who came to Ilium.

I will tell the leaders of the ships and
all the ships themselves.”

First came the Boeotians. Peneleus
and Leitus led them,

Arcesilaus, Prothoenor, Clonius
beside them—

men of Hyria, rocky Aulis, Schoenus,
and Scolus,

of Eteon, Thespia, Graia, and broad
Mycalessus,

of Harma, Eilesion, Erythrae, and
Eleon,

of Hyle, Peteon, Ocalea, and
well-built Medeon,

of Copae, Eutresis, deep-rifted
Thisbe,
of Coronea, grassy Haliartus, Plataea,
and Glisas; of lower Thebes, well
built,
of holy Onchestus, Poseidon's
shining grove,
of vine-rich Arne, Mideia, sacred
Nisa,
and Anthedon, at the world's far
edge.
Fifty ships came from them, and in
each ship
one hundred and twenty young
Boeotians embarked.
Aspledon and Minyan Orchomenos
sent their people,
under Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons
of Ares,
whom Astyoche, daughter of Actor,
bore to the god—
the modest maiden had climbed to
her upper room,
and the strong god lay with her in
secret.
Thirty hollow ships marched behind
them.
The Phocians were led by Schedius
and Epistrophus,
sons of great-hearted Iphitus,
Naubolus' son;
they held Cyparissus, rocky Pytho,
sacred Crisa,
Daulis, Panopeus, Anemoria, and
Hyampolis,
the dwellers beside divine Cephissus,
and those who held Lilaea by the
springs of Cephissus.
Forty black ships followed them. The
Phocians formed

their ranks beside the Boeotians, on
the left.
Ajax, swift son of Oileus, led the
Locrians—
the lesser Ajax, not so great as
Telamonian Ajax,
but much smaller, lightly armored, a
little man;
yet with his spear he surpassed all
Panhellenes
and Achaeans. His men held Cynus,
Opus, Calliarus,
Bessa, Scarphe, lovely Augeia,
Tarphe, and Thronium,
around the streams of Boagrius.
Forty black ships
followed the Locrians, who live
beyond holy Euboea.
The Abantes held Euboea, breathless
for battle:
Chalcis, Eretria, vine-rich Histiaea,
Cerinthus,
the sea-cliff city of Dios, Carystus,
and Styra.
Elephenor, son of Chalcodon, led
them,
great-hearted chief of the Abantes.
Behind him came
the swift-haired spearmen, eager
with ashwood lances
to break the corslets on their
enemies' chests.
Forty black ships followed them.
Those who held Athens, the city well
built,
the people of great-hearted
Erechtheus—whom Athena,
daughter of Zeus, once raised, and
the grain-giving earth

bore, then set within her rich temple
in Athens,
where Athenian youths appease him
with bulls and lambs
as the years turn—were led by
Menestheus, son of Peteus.
No man on earth could equal him in
ordering
horses and shielded men for battle;
only Nestor,
older by birth, contended with him.
Fifty black ships
followed. Ajax brought twelve from
Salamis
and stationed them beside the
Athenian ranks.
The men of Argos held Tiryns with
its walls,
Hermione and Asine deep in their
bay,
Troezene, Epidaurus thick with
vines,
Ægina, Mases, and the Achaean
shore.
Diomedes, strong in battle, led them,
with Sthenelus, beloved son of
famous Capaneus,
and Euryalus, godlike, son of king
Mecisteus,
son of Talaus. Diomedes led them all.
Eighty black ships followed.
The men of Mycenae, the well-built
city, came too,
of wealthy Corinth and well-built
Cleonae,
of Orneia, lovely Aretbyrea, and
Sicyon,
where Adrastus first reigned, and of
Hyperesia,

high Gonoessa, Pellene, Ægium, and
the shore
all along Aegialus, around broad
Helice.
Agamemnon, son of Atreus, led one
hundred ships;
with him came the most numerous
and best of the people.
He himself put on the flashing
bronze and shone,
conspicuous among the heroes, since
he was best
and led a people far more numerous
than the rest.
The men of hollow Lacedaemon
came, of Pharis,
Sparta, Messa, Bryseiae, lovely
Augeiae,
Amyclae, Helos, the city by the sea,
Laas, and Oetylus. Menelaus, his
brother,
led them—strong in battle—with
sixty ships.
They formed apart; he went among
them trusting
his own courage, urging the war, for
most of all
his heart desired to avenge Helen's
distress and tears.
The Pylia people held Pylos and
lovely Arene,
Thryon at the ford of Alpheius,
well-built Epi,
Cyprisiseis, Amphigenia, Pteleos,
Helos, and Dorion,
where the Muses met Thamyris the
Thracian,
coming from Oechalia, from Eurytus
of Oechalia;

he boasted that he would defeat the
Muses themselves
if they, the daughters of Zeus who
bears the aegis,
should sing. Angered, they blinded
him and stripped him
of his wondrous song, making him
forget the lyre.
Gerenian horseman Nestor led them;
ninety hollow ships
marched in his wake.
The Arcadians held the steep
mountain under Cyllene,
by the tomb of Aepytus, where men
fight at close quarters;
Pheneus, many-sheeped
Orchomenos, Ripe, Stratia,
windy Enispe, Tegea, lovely
Mantineia,
Stymphalus, and Parrhasia.
Agapenor, son of Ancaeus,
led them in sixty ships. Agamemnon
himself,
son of Atreus, supplied the
strong-benched vessels,
for the Arcadians knew nothing of
the sea;
they embarked in them to cross the
wine-dark water,
many Arcadian men in every ship,
skilled in war.
The men of Buprasium and divine
Elis inhabited
the land from Hyrmine to Myrsinus
at its edge,
from the Olenian rock to Alesium
enclosed within.
Four leaders held them; ten swift
ships followed each,

and many Epeans embarked.
Amphimachus and Thalpius
led two divisions, sons respectively of
Cteatus and Eurytus,
the Actorian pair; mighty Diores,
son of Amarynceus,
led the third, and godlike Polyxenus,
son of Agasthenes,
son of Augeias, led the fourth.
From Dulichium and the sacred
Echinades islands,
which lie beyond the sea opposite
Elis, came the people.
Meges, equal to Ares, led them—son
of Phyleus,
beloved of Zeus, the horseman.
Phyleus had once left
Dulichium in anger with his father.
Forty black ships
followed Meges.
Odysseus led the great-hearted
Cephalenians,
who held Ithaca, forest-shaking
Neritum,
rough Ægilipa, Zacynthus, Crocylea,
and Asteria, and who held the
mainland opposite.
Odysseus, equal to Zeus in counsel,
commanded them;
twelve red-cheeked ships followed.
Thoas, son of Andraemon, led the
Aetolians.
They held Pleuron, Olenus, Pyléné,
sea-near Chalcis,
and rocky Calydon. The sons of great
Oeneus were gone,
and Oeneus himself was gone; blond
Meleager had died.
So Thoas had been charged to rule all
the Aetolians.

Forty black ships followed him.
Idomeneus, famous with the spear,
led the Cretans.
They held Cnossus, well-walled
Gortyna, Lyctus,
Miletus, bright Lycastus, Phaestus,
and Rhytium,
well-inhabited cities, and all who
held Crete,
the land of a hundred cities.
Idomeneus led them.
Meriones, equal to Enyalios the
slayer, stood beside him;
eighty black ships followed the
Cretan leaders.
Tlepolemus, Heracles' tall and noble
son,
brought nine ships from Rhodes. The
Rhodians lived
in three divisions—Lindus, Ialysus,
and shining Camirus.
Tlepolemus, famous with the spear,
was born to Heracles
and Astyoche, whom Heracles
brought from Ephyra,
after sacking the cities of the
god-reared people.
When Tlepolemus had grown in his
great house,
he killed his father's aged maternal
uncle, Licymnius,
an offshoot of Ares. He built ships at
once,
gathered a great people, and fled
across the sea,
for Heracles' other sons and
grandsons threatened him.
After suffering much, he reached
Rhodes, and settled there

in three tribes; Zeus, lord of gods and
men, loved them
and poured great wealth upon them.
Nireus brought three equal ships
from Syme—
Nireus, son of Aglaia and King
Charopus,
the fairest man to come beneath
Ilium after Peleus' son;
but he was weak, and few followed
him.
The men of Nisyros, Crapathus,
Casus, and Cos,
the city of Eurypylus, and the
Calydnian islands,
were led by Pheidippus and
Antiphus, two sons
of Thessalus, Heracles' royal son.
Thirty hollow ships
marched behind them.
Those who held Pelasgian
Argos—Alos, Alope, and Trachis,
Phthia and lovely Hellas—were
called Myrmidons,
Hellenes, and Achaeans. Achilles led
their fifty ships,
but they did not remember the harsh
battle: no one was there
to lead them into line. Swift-footed,
godlike Achilles lay
beside the ships, angry over
fair-haired Briseis,
whom he had taken from Lyrnessus
after much toil,
when he sacked Lyrnessus and the
walls of Thebes,
and killed Mynes and Epistrophus,
spear-famed sons
of King Evenus, Selepius' son. There
he lay in grief,

but soon he would rise.
Those who held Phylace, flowery
Pyrasus, Demeter's precinct,
Iton, mother of sheep, Antron by the
sea, and meadowed Pteleon,
were led by warlike Protesilaus while
he lived;
now the black earth held him. His
wife, tearing her cheeks,
was left in Phylace, and his house
stood unfinished:
a Dardanian killed him as he leapt
first from his ship.
Nor were his people leaderless,
though they longed for him;
Podarces, son of Iphiclus, rich in
sheep, led them,
Protesilaus' own brother, younger by
birth. Yet Protesilaus
had been first and better. Forty black
ships followed.
Those who held Pherae beside Lake
Boebe, Boebe, Glaphyrae,
and well-built Iolcus were led by
Eumelus, dear son of Admetus,
whom Alcestis, fairest of Pelias'
daughters, bore to Admetus.
Eleven ships followed him.
Those who held Methone,
Thaumacia, Meliboea,
and rough Olizon were led by
Philoctetes,
skilled with the bow, in seven ships;
fifty oarsmen,
skilled in war, embarked in each. But
Philoctetes lay
on Lemnos, suffering cruel pain from
a deadly serpent's wound,
where the sons of the Achaeans had
left him. There he lay

in anguish; soon the Argives by the
ships would remember
their lord Philoctetes. Nor were his
men leaderless:
Medon, Oileus' bastard son, whom
Rhene bore to the sacker
of cities, arranged them. Seven ships
followed.
Those who held Tricca, rocky
Ithome, and Oechalia,
the city of Eurytus of Oechalia, were
led by the two sons
of Asclepius, good physicians,
Podalirius and Machaon.
Thirty hollow ships followed. Those
who held Ormenius,
the spring of Hypereia, Asteria, and
the white peaks
of Titanus were led by Euryphylus,
glorious son of Euaemon,
in forty black ships.
Those who held Argissa, Gyrtone,
Orthe, Elone,
and white Oloosson were led by
city-sacker Polypoetes,
son of Pirithous, whom immortal
Zeus fathered through
Hippodameia on the day the Lapiths
punished the shaggy Centaurs
and drove them from Pelion among
the Aethices. With him came
Leonteus, an offshoot of Ares, son of
the great-hearted
Coronus, son of Caeneus. Forty black
ships followed.
Guneus brought twenty-two ships
from Cyphus;
the warlike Enienes and
Perrhaebians followed him,

those who made their homes around
wintry Dodona,
and those who worked beside lovely
Titaesius,
whose clear water runs to Peneius
but never mingles with him—
it flows above him like oil, for it is a
branch of Styx's oath.
Prothous, son of Tenthredon, led the
Magnetes,
who lived beside Peneius and
forest-shaking Pelion.
Swift Prothous commanded them;
forty black ships followed.
These were the leaders and lords of
the Danaans. Now, Muse,
tell me who among them was
best—the men themselves and the
horses
that followed the sons of Atreus. The
best horses were those
of Eumelus, swift as birds, alike in
age and color,
mares whom Apollo of the silver bow
had bred in Pieria,
carrying the terror of Ares. Of men,
Telamonian Ajax was best
while Achilles nursed his anger—for
Achilles was far better,
and his were the horses that bore the
blameless son of Peleus.
But Achilles lay in his sea-going
ships, angry with Agamemnon;
his people played beside the water
with discus, javelins, and bows,
while the horses stood by their
chariots grazing lotus and marsh
celery.
The chariots lay covered in the tents,
and the men, longing for their

war-loving leader, wandered through
the camp and did not fight.
They moved like a fire sweeping
across the whole earth;
the ground groaned beneath their
feet, as when thunder-loving Zeus,
angry at Typhoeus, lashes the earth
around Arima, where they say
Typhoeus has his bed. So the earth
groaned beneath their feet,
and they crossed the plain swiftly.
Swift-footed Iris came to the Trojans
as a messenger
from Zeus who bears the aegis,
carrying a grievous message.
They were speaking in assembly at
Priam's gates,
young and old gathered together. Iris
stood near,
took the voice of Polites, Priam's
son—the swift scout
who sat atop old Aesyetes' highest
tomb, watching
for the Achaeans to depart from
their ships—and spoke:
"Old man, your speeches are always
dear to you,
as in peacetime; but war without
respite has risen.
I have entered many battles, yet
never saw
such a people, so many, moving
across the plain,
like leaves or grains of sand, to fight
before the city.
Hector, I charge you above all: do
this.
Many allies dwell throughout Priam's
great city,

and many tongues belong to these
scattered peoples.
Let each commander signal those he
rules,
and marshal his own citizens and
lead them out.”
So she spoke, and Hector understood
the goddess.
He swiftly dissolved the assembly.
The gates opened wide;
the people poured out, footmen and
horsemen, and a great tumult rose.
Before the city stood a steep,
isolated, rounded hill,
which men called Batieia, but
immortals knew as the tomb
of leaping Myrine. There the Trojans
and their allies formed apart.
Great Hector, crested in bronze, led
the Trojans;
with him, by far the greatest and best
of the armed people,
eager with their spears. Aeneas,
noble son of Anchises,
led the Dardanians—Aphrodite bore
him to Anchises
in the folds of Ida, when the goddess
lay with a mortal.
He was not alone: Antenor’s two
sons, Archelochus
and Acamas, who knew every art of
war, stood beside him.
The Trojans of Zeleia, rich and
drinking the dark water
of the Aesepus beneath Ida’s lowest
foot, followed Pandarus,
glorious son of Lycaon, to whom
Apollo himself gave the bow.
Adrastus and Amphius, lightly
armored sons of Merops

of Percote, led those who held
Adrasteia, Apaesus,
Pityeia, and steep Mount Tereia.
Merops knew prophecy
better than any man and forbade his
sons to enter
the death-bringing war, but the
black Fates drove them on.
Those who held Percote, Practius,
Sestus, Abydos,
and divine Arisba were led by Asius,
son of Hyrtacides—
Asius whom great, fiery horses
brought from Arisba,
beside the stream of Selleis.
Hippothous and Pyleus, offshoots of
Ares and sons
of Pelasgian Lethus, led the
spear-famed Pelasgians
who dwelt in deep-soiled Larisa.
Acamas and hero Pirous
led the Thracians held within the
rushing Hellespont;
Euphemus, son of Troezenus and of
Ceyx, led the spearmen
of the Cicones. Pirechmes brought
the Paeonians,
their crooked bows, from distant
Amydon beside broad Axios,
whose fairest water spreads across
the land.
Great-hearted Pylaemenes led the
Paphlagonians from Eneti,
where the race of wild asses is born;
from Cytorus and Sesamus,
from their houses beside the
Parthenius, from Cromna,
Aegialus, and the high Erythini.
Odus and Epistrophus

led the Halizonians from distant
Alybe, birthplace of silver.
Chromis and Ennomus the augur led
the Mysians;
but augury could not save Ennomus
from black death:
swift-footed Aeacides struck him
down in the river,
where Achilles was slaughtering
Trojans and their allies.
Phorcys and godlike Ascanius led the
Phrygians,
come from far-off Ascania, eager for
battle.
Mesthles and Antiphus, sons of
Talaemenes,
whom the Gygaean lake bore, led the
Maionians
born beneath Tmolus. Nastes led the
Carians,
barbarous-speaking men from
Miletus, Mount Phthira,
the banks of Maeander, and the steep
peaks of Mycale.
Amphimachus and Nastes, splendid
sons of Nomion,
led them. Nastes went to war
wearing gold, like a girl,
a foolishness that could not ward off
his grievous death;
swift-footed Aeacides killed him in
the river,
and discerning Achilles carried off
his gold.
Sarpedon and blameless Glaucus led
the Lycians,
come from far Lycia, from the
whirling Xanthus.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — The false dream and mustering of the Achaean host

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; new generated composition informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual direction, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 3

First-pass working translation

When each host had taken its place
beside its leaders,
the Trojans came with shouting,
with a clamor,
as cranes that flee before the winter
weather,
the measureless rain, and fly above
the Ocean,
crying, and bearing death to little
men,
the Pygmies; high in air they wage
their quarrel.
The Achaeans moved in silence,
breathing courage,
resolved in heart to stand for one
another.
As when the South Wind pours a
mist upon
the mountain peaks—unwelcome to
the shepherd,
yet better than the night for one who
steals,
whose sight reaches no farther than a
stone—
so rose the dust beneath their feet,
and swiftly
they crossed the plain.
When they had drawn together,
godlike Alexander
stood before the Trojan ranks,
clothed in leopard skin,
with bow curved, and sword; he
brandished two spears
of bronze, and challenged every
Argive champion.

When war-loving Menelaus saw him
striding
before the host, he rejoiced as a lion
rejoices
when he discovers a great carcass—a
horned stag,
or wild goat—and hunger drives him
to feed,
though hounds run after him, and
young hunters.
So Menelaus rejoiced to see his
enemy;
he thought to punish the man who
had wronged him,
and leapt at once from his chariot,
armed.
But when godlike Alexander saw him
among the champions,
his heart was struck with fear; he
withdrew among
his people, shunning death. As when
a man sees
a serpent in a mountain cleft, and
steps backward,
while trembling seizes all his limbs,
and pallor
spreads over both his cheeks, so he
sank again
among the proud Trojans, afraid of
Atreus' son.
Then Hector saw him, and rebuked
him:
“Paris, handsome beyond measure,
mad for women, deceiver—
would you had never been born, or
died unmarried!
That were my prayer, and better far
than this:
to be a public shame, a common
reproach.

The long-haired Achaeans surely
laugh at you,
and call you champion because your
face is fair,
though there is no strength within
your heart,
no courage. Was it as such a man that
you
crossed the sea in ships, gathered
companions,
mingled with strangers, and carried
away
a beautiful woman from a distant
land,
your father's grief, your city's, and all
the people's—
a joy to foes, but shame to you? Will
you not stand
before war-loving Menelaus, and
learn the man
whose young wife you keep? Your
lyre will not avail,
nor Aphrodite's gifts, your hair, your
looks,
when you are lying in the dust. The
Trojans fear you;
for all your evil you would already
wear
a tunic made of stone.”
Godlike Alexander answered:
“Hector, you have rebuked me
with justice, not beyond it; your
heart is hard
and tireless, like an axe that a skilled
workman
drives through a ship's timber,
adding strength
to every stroke. So is the mind within
your breast.

But do not cast against me the lovely
gifts
of golden Aphrodite; the glorious
gifts
the gods bestow cannot be cast away,
nor can a man choose them
according to his will.
If you desire that I should fight, then
bid
the other Trojans and Achaeans sit
down;
set Menelaus and me between the
hosts,
to fight for Helen and her
possessions.
Let the better man, the stronger,
take the woman
and all the goods, and lead them to
his home;
the rest shall cut a faithful covenant,
and dwell in fertile Troy, while they
return
to horse-breeding Argos and
Achaëa.”
Hector rejoiced to hear this speech.
He went into the midst
and halted the Trojan ranks,
gripping his spear
by the middle. The long-haired
Achaeans bent
their bows, and aimed their stones;
but Agamemnon
cried aloud: “Hold, Argives! Do not
shoot,
young Achaeans. Hector of the
shining crest
claims that he will speak.” They
ceased from fighting
and fell silent. Hector spoke between
the hosts:

“Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved
Achaean; hear
the word of Alexander, for whose
sake this quarrel rose.
Let all the others lay their beautiful
armor
upon the earth; let him and
war-loving Menelaus
alone fight in the midst for Helen
and all
her possessions. Whoever wins, and
proves the stronger,
let him take all the goods and take
the woman home;
the rest of us shall cut a bond of
friendship.”
He spoke, and all were silent.
Menelaus answered:
“Hear me as well. Above all else, the
pain
reaches my heart. I think the Argives
now
and Trojans should be parted, for
you have suffered
enough because of my quarrel and
Alexander’s.
Let him for whom death and fate are
fashioned die;
let all the rest be parted quickly.
Bring two lambs,
one white, one black, for Earth and
Sun, and a dark
boar for Zeus. Bring mighty Priam,
that he himself
may cut the oath, for his sons are
insolent
and faithless; lest the transgression of
one man
destroy the covenant of Zeus. The
minds of youth

are ever shifting; an elder sees before
and also after, that his counsel may
be best
for either side.”
The Trojans and Achaeans rejoiced,
hoping to end
the wretched war. They drew back
their horses,
dismounted, stripped their armor,
and set it down
close together, with little space
between.
Hector sent two heralds toward the
city to fetch
the lambs and call Priam;
Agamemnon sent
Talthybius to the hollow ships to
bring a lamb.
Talthybius did not disobey the
godlike king.
Then Iris came, a messenger, to
white-armed Helen,
in likeness of Laodice, fairest
daughter
of Priam, wife of Antenor’s son,
Helicaon.
She found her in the chamber,
weaving a great
double-folded purple cloth, and on it
working
the many labors of the horse-taming
Trojans
and bronze-clad Achaeans—the
griefs they suffered
for Helen at the hands of Ares.
Swift-footed Iris said:
“Come, dear bride, and see the deeds
of the Trojans
and bronze-clad Achaeans, those
who once

bore tearful Ares against each other
upon the hateful field, greedy for
war.
Now they sit in silence by their
shields;
their long spears stand planted.
Alexander
and war-loving Menelaus will fight
for you
with long spears; the victor will call
you
his beloved wife.”
So the goddess stirred in Helen’s
heart desire
for her first husband, city, and her
parents.
At once she veiled herself in shining
linen,
and left the chamber, shedding
tender tears;
she was not alone, for two attendants
followed,
Aethra, daughter of Pittheus, and
ox-eyed Clymene.
Soon they reached the Scaean Gates.
Around Priam sat Panthous,
Thymoetes, Lampus,
Clytius, Hicetaon, scion of Ares,
Ucalegon,
and wise Antenor—the elders of the
city,
released by age from war, but
excellent speakers,
like cicadas in the forest, perched in
trees,
and sending forth their lily-clear
voices.
Such were the Trojan leaders on the
tower.

When they saw Helen coming on the
wall, they murmured:
“There is no blame if Trojans and
well-greaved Achaeans
suffer long for such a woman.
Terribly she resembles
an immortal goddess. Yet let her go
in the ships,
and not remain a grief to us and to
our children.”
Priam called Helen by name: “Come
here, dear child,
and sit before me, that you may show
me now
your former husband, kinsmen, and
your friends.
You are not blameworthy in my eyes;
the gods
are blameworthy, who brought this
tearful war
upon the Achaeans. Tell me of that
man,
that enormous Achaean, strong and
tall.
Some are taller in the head, but never
have I seen
one so stately; he resembles a king.”
Helen, divine among women,
answered: “You are worthy
of honor, and dreadful to me,
father-in-law.
Would evil death had pleased me
when I followed
your son here, leaving chamber, kin,
my child,
and my beloved companions. But it
did not;
therefore I waste away in tears. I will
tell

you whom you ask about. That is
Atreus' son,
wide-ruling Agamemnon, a good
king
and mighty spearman; once he was
my brother-in-law."
The old man marveled: "Happy
Atreus' son,
born under fortunate stars, and
greatly blessed!
Many sons of the Achaeans obey
your word.
Once I entered vine-rich Phrygia,
and saw
the greatest host of Phrygian men,
with horses
of dappled hide—the armies of
Otreus
and godlike Mygdon, camped beside
the banks
of Sangarius. I too was counted there
among their allies, on the day the
Amazons came;
but even they were not so many as
these
bright-eyed Achaeans."
Then the old man saw Odysseus:
"Tell me, dear child,
of this man. He is shorter in head
than Atreus' son,
but broader in shoulders and in
chest. His armor
lies on the earth, while through the
ranks he moves
like a ram among a great flock of
white sheep."
Helen, daughter of Zeus, answered:
"That is Laertes' son,
many-counseled Odysseus, raised in
rocky Ithaca,

skilled in every kind of trick and
close-woven counsel."
Wise Antenor replied: "Woman, your
word is wholly true.
Once divine Odysseus came here
with Menelaus,
war-loving, as your embassy. I
received them
within my house, and learned the
nature of both,
their close counsel. Among the
gathered Trojans
Menelaus surpassed him in the
breadth of shoulder;
but when they sat, Odysseus was
more majestic.
When they wove their speeches and
their plans,
Menelaus spoke with speed, in few
words,
but very clearly, since he was
younger still.
When many-counseled Odysseus
rose, he stood
with eyes fixed on the ground, and
held the scepter
neither before nor behind him, but
upright,
like one unskilled in public
speech—you might have called him
angry, and foolish. Yet when he sent
his great voice
from his chest, and words like winter
snow,
no mortal could contend with him;
we no longer
marveled at his form."
The old man saw Ajax and asked:
"Who is that other Achaean,

so strong and tall, the foremost of
the Argives
in head and broad shoulders?" Helen,
trailing
her robe, answered: "That is towering
Ajax,
the bulwark of the Achaeans. On the
other side
stands Idomeneus among the
Cretans, like a god;
around him gather all the Cretan
leaders.
Often war-loving Menelaus
welcomed him
within our house, when he came
from Crete.
I see the other bright-eyed Achaeans,
whom I could
recognize and name; but I cannot see
the two
commanders of the people, Castor,
breaker of horses,
and Polydeuces, good with the
fists—my brothers,
born from the same mother as I.
Either they came not
with lovely Lacedaemon's army, or
else they came
here in the ships, but will not enter
battle,
fearing the shame and all the
reproaches that are mine."
So she spoke; but the life-giving
earth already held them
in Lacedaemon, their dear native
land.
At last Idaeus brought the victims
from the city.
Priam climbed down, and
Agamemnon met him there

between the lines. The heralds
gathered up
the oath-gifts of the gods; they mixed
the wine
within the bowl, and poured it over
the hands
of the kings. Agamemnon drew the
knife that hung
beside his great sword, and cut the
lambs' hair;
the Trojan and Achaean heralds bore
it out
among the leaders. Atreus' son raised
his hands
and prayed:
"Father Zeus, most glorious and
greatest, lord of Ida;
Sun, seeing and hearing all things;
rivers and earth;
and you beneath, who punish among
the dead
whoever swears falsely—be witnesses,
and guard this faithful oath. If
Alexander kills
Menelaus, let him keep Helen and
her possessions,
and let us turn again in our seafaring
ships.
But if golden-haired Menelaus kills
Alexander,
let the Trojans return Helen and her
possessions,
and pay the Argives honor, such as
shall be remembered
among men yet to come. If Priam
and his sons
refuse to pay the honor due me when
Alexander falls,
then I will stay, and fight on for
recompense,

until the war has reached its end.”
He cut the lambs’ and the boar’s
throats with pitiless bronze,
and laid them on the earth; they
gasped as metal
took their strength. Then from the
bowl they drew
the wine into the cups, and poured it
forth,
praying to the gods who live forever.
Someone
among the Trojans and Achaeans
spoke:
“Father Zeus, most glorious and
greatest, and you,
all other gods—whichever side first
shall harm
this oath, may their brains be poured
upon
the ground, as this wine, their own
and their children’s;
and may their wives be taken by
other men.”
So they spoke, but Cronus’ son did
not yet fulfill
the prayer. Dardanian Priam
addressed them:
“Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved
Achaeans.
I go again to windy Ilium; I cannot
bear with my own eyes to see my
dear son fight
war-loving Menelaus. Zeus and the
immortals
know which of these two has been
assigned to death.”
He set the lambs within the chariot,
mounted,
and drew the reins; Antenor climbed
beside him,

and they drove toward Ilium.
Hector, son of Priam, and brilliant
Odysseus
first measured out the ground. Then
they shook
the lots within a bronze-studded
helmet, to learn
which man should cast his bronze
spear first.
The people prayed, raising their
hands to heaven:
“Father Zeus, lord of Ida, most
glorious and greatest,
grant that the man who brought
these deeds upon
both peoples may die, and enter
Hades’ house,
while friendship and faithful oaths
become ours.”
Hector shook the helmet and looked
back; Paris’ lot
leapt forth first. The men sat in their
ranks,
where each man’s horses and bright
armor lay.
Godlike Alexander, husband of
fair-haired Helen,
put on his armor: first the beautiful
greaves,
with silver clasps about the ankles;
then the breastplate
of his brother Lycaon, fitted to his
body;
around his shoulders he hung the
bronze sword,
with silver studs, and then the great,
heavy shield.
Upon his head he set the well-made
horsehair helmet,

its crest nodding terribly above him,
and took
the mighty spear that fitted to his
palm.
Menelaus armed himself in the same
manner.
They came from either side into the
space between
the armies, looking terribly at one
another;
wonder seized Trojans and Achaeans
alike.
They stood close, measuring the
ground, and shook
their spears in anger. Paris cast first
his spear,
long-shadowed, striking Atreus' son's
shield;
the bronze did not break through,
but its point bent
within the strong shield. Menelaus,
son of Atreus,
prayed, and cast his own:
"Father Zeus, grant that I may punish
Alexander,
who first wronged me; subdue him
beneath my hands,
so that a man unborn may tremble to
do evil
to one who offers friendship as a
guest-friend."
He hurled the long-shadowed spear.
It struck the shield
of Priam's son, passed through the
shining metal,
and lodged within the elaborate
corselet;
it tore the tunic by his flank, but
Paris bent

aside, and escaped the black Fates.
Atreus' son
drew forth his silver-studded sword,
and struck
the helmet's crest. Around the
helmet the blade
broke into three and four pieces, and
fell from his hand.
He groaned, and looked into the
broad sky:
"Father Zeus, no god is more
destructive than you.
I thought to punish Alexander for his
evil,
but now the sword has shattered in
my hands,
and the spear flew useless from my
palm."
He sprang forward, seized the
horsehair of Paris' helmet,
and dragged him round toward the
well-greaved Achaeans.
The embroidered chin-strap beneath
his throat
was strangling him; and he would
have dragged him off,
winning immeasurable glory, but
Aphrodite,
the daughter of Zeus, saw it and
broke the strap
with force like an ox slaughtered for
sacrifice.
The empty helmet followed
Menelaus' strong hand;
he whirled it, and threw it among the
Achaeans,
and his faithful companions carried
it away.
Menelaus rushed again, eager to kill
with bronze,

but Aphrodite, lightly as a goddess,
snatched
Paris away, wrapped him in a dense
mist,
and set him down within his fragrant
chamber,
filled with incense.
Aphrodite went again to call
white-armed Helen.
She found her on the high tower,
surrounded
by many Trojan women. Taking the
form of an old
woman, a spinner who had lived
beside Helen
in Lacedaemon, and whom she loved,
the goddess
shook her fragrant robe, and spoke:
“Come here.
Alexander calls you home. He lies
within his chamber,
upon the turned bed, shining in
beauty and dress.
You would not think he had come
from fighting a man,
but from a dance, or from sitting
down after the dance.”
The goddess stirred desire within her
heart.
When Helen saw her lovely throat,
her longing breast,
and flashing eyes, she marveled, and
named her:
“Strange woman, why do you long to
deceive me?
Will you carry me farther to some
city rich in people—
Phrygia, or lovely Maeonia—if
another mortal man

is dear to you there? Menelaus has
defeated
godlike Alexander, and would lead
hateful me home.
Is that why you stand here, weaving
deceit?
Go sit beside him yourself; leave the
gods’ road,
and do not turn your feet toward
Olympus again.
Worry over him always, till he makes
you his wife,
or else your slave. I will not go to
him;
it would be shameful to tend his bed.
Each Trojan woman
would reproach me. I carry griefs
without number
within my heart.”
Golden Aphrodite answered in
anger: “Do not provoke
me, wretched woman, lest I leave you
in my anger.
I will make you hated as terribly as I
have loved you,
and set a hateful enmity between
Trojans and Danaans;
you shall perish in an evil fate.”
Helen, daughter of Zeus, was afraid.
She went
in silence, veiled in bright linen, seen
by none
of all the Trojan women, and the
goddess led her.
When they reached Alexander’s
beautiful house,
the attendants turned at once to
their work.
Helen entered the high-roofed
chamber. Smiling

Aphrodite brought a chair, and set it
opposite
Alexander. Helen sat, turned away
her eyes,
and rebuked her husband:
“You have come back from war.
Would you had perished there,
conquered by the strong man who
was once my husband!
You boasted that you were better
than war-loving Menelaus
in strength, and hands, and spear. Go
challenge him again;
but I tell you, do not meet him face
to face,
lest soon his spear bring you down.”
Paris answered: “Do not wound my
heart with harsh reproaches.
Menelaus defeated me with Athena
at his side;
another time I shall defeat him, for
the gods
are with us. Come, let us turn to love,
and lie together.
Never before has desire so wrapped
my mind—not even
when first I carried you away from
lovely Lacedaemon
in seafaring ships, and joined with
you in love
and bed upon Cranae’s island. So
now I love you,
and sweet longing takes hold of me.”
He went first to the bed, and his wife
followed.
They slept within the bed’s
perforated frame,
while Atreus’ son went prowling
through the host

like a wild beast, seeking Alexander.
No Trojan,
no famous ally, could point him out.
No one hid him
from love—he was hateful to them
all, as hateful
as black death. Agamemnon called
across the ranks:
“Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and
allies: victory
plainly belongs to war-loving
Menelaus. Give up
Argive Helen, and all the possessions
with her,
and pay the honor due—an honor
that shall remain
among men yet to come.”
So Atreus’ son spoke, and the other
Achaeans
applauded him.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Helen upon the walls of Troy with the Trojan elders
Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 4

First-pass working translation

The gods sat beside Zeus, and held
their council
upon the golden floor. Among them
Hebe,
royal, poured nectar; in golden cups
they took it, looking toward the city
of Priam.
The son of Cronus sought to provoke
Hera,
and spoke with cutting words: “Two
goddesses
have helped Menelaus—Hera of
Argos,
and Athena of Alalcomenae. They sit
apart,
and rejoice; but smiling Aphrodite
always
stands near him, and wards the Fates
away.
Even now she saved him when he
thought to die.
Yet victory belongs to war-loving
Menelaus.
Come, let us consider what shall now
be done:
shall we stir dreadful war again, or
set
friendship between the peoples? If
this were pleasing
to all, Priam’s city might remain
inhabited,
and Menelaus lead Argive Helen
home.”
Athena sat apart, her anger held
within her,

and fierce resentment burned against
her father.

Hera could not contain her anger:
“Most terrible
son of Cronus, what have you said?
Would you make
my labor fruitless—the sweat I spent
in toil,
while my horses were worn out
gathering the people
for Priam and his sons? Do it; but
none of the gods
will praise you.”
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered in
displeasure:
“Strange woman, what have Priam
and his sons
done to you, that you rage without
rest to destroy
well-built Ilium? If you could enter
through
the gates and walls, and devour
Priam, his sons,
and all the Trojans raw, your anger
might be healed.
Do as you wish; but let this quarrel
between us
not grow into a greater strife. I say
this too:
when I desire to destroy a city where
your people
live, do not delay my anger; let me
act.
For I gave way to you, though
unwillingly.
Of all the cities beneath the sun and
starry sky,
holy Ilium, Priam, and his
well-speared people

were most dear to me. Never did my altar lack its equal feast, libation, or savor of sacrifice; that honor was our portion.” Ox-eyed Hera replied: “Three cities are most dear to me—Argos, Sparta, and broad-wayed Mycenae. Destroy them when they anger you; I will not stand before you, nor begrudge it. But do not make my labor fruitless. I too am a goddess, born from the same source as you; Cronus of crooked counsel bore me eldest, and I am called your wife, while you rule among the immortals. Let us yield to one another, you to me, and I to you; the other gods will follow. Now command Athena to go swiftly into the battle, the grievous battle of Trojans and Achaeans, and see whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans, breaking the oaths.” Her father, father of the gods, did not disobey. He spoke his winged words to Athena: “Go swiftly among the Trojans and Achaeans; see whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans,

breaking the oaths.” So he urged Athena, already eager. She shot down from Olympus’ peaks, like the bright star that Cronus’ son sends forth as a sign to sailors, or a mighty army, from which innumerable sparks leap into the dark. In its likeness Pallas Athena rushed to earth, and sprang into the midst. Wonder seized the Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans; each man said to the man beside him: “Will dreadful war rise again, or will Zeus establish friendship between the peoples?” Athena entered the Trojan crowd in the likeness of Laodocus, son of Antenor, a strong spearman, seeking godlike Pandarus. She found Lycaon’s son, blameless and powerful, standing among the dense ranks of shield-bearing men who had followed him from the streams of Aesepus. Standing near, she spoke: “Would you obey me, Lycaon’s son? Would you dare to shoot a swift arrow at Menelaus? You would win the favor and glory of all the Trojans, above all of King Alexander. He would first give shining gifts if he saw Menelaus, son of Atreus, struck by your arrow,

and climbing to the grievous pyre.
Shoot glorious
Menelaus; vow to Apollo, famous
archer of Lycia,
that when you return to sacred
Zeleia you will sacrifice
a splendid hecatomb of first-born
lambs.”
The goddess won the foolish man.
He took down
his polished bow, made from the
horns of a wild goat
that he himself had struck beneath
the breast,
as it sprang from the rock; the
animal fell backward
upon the stone. Its horns were
sixteen palms in length.
A horn-worker joined and polished
them, and set
a golden tip upon them. Pandarus
laid the bow down,
while his excellent companions held
their shields
before him, lest the warlike sons of
the Achaeans
leap forth before Menelaus was
struck.
He opened the lid of his quiver, and
drew an arrow
not yet shot, the source of black pain.
Quickly
he fitted the bitter arrow to the
string, and vowed
again to Apollo. He drew together
the notch
and ox-hide cord; the great bow bent
in a circle,
twanged, the string cried aloud, and
the sharp arrow

leapt through the host, eager to fly.
Yet the blessed gods had not
forgotten you, Menelaus.
First Athena, the spoil-taking
daughter of Zeus,
stood before you, and turned aside
the deadly arrow,
as a mother brushes a fly from her
sleeping child.
She guided it to the place where the
golden clasps
held fast the belt, where the double
breastplate met.
The bitter arrow struck the fitted
belt, passed through
the decorated belt and elaborate
corselet,
and pierced the guard that kept the
skin from spears—
the guard that saved him most; yet
the arrow passed
beyond it, and grazed his flesh. Dark
blood at once
ran from the wound. As a Maeonian
or Carian woman
stains ivory with purple, to adorn a
horse's cheek—
kept in a chamber, desired by many
riders,
an ornament and glory for horse and
charioteer—
so well-formed thighs and beautiful
legs, Menelaus,
were stained with blood.
When Agamemnon saw the dark
blood from the wound,
he trembled; war-loving Menelaus
trembled too,
but when he saw the sinew and
arrow-barbs outside,

his heart gathered itself again.
Agamemnon groaned,
holding Menelaus' hand, while his
companions lamented:
"Dear brother, I cut the oath that set
you alone
before the Achaeans to fight the
Trojans;
and now the Trojans have struck
you, and trampled
the faithful oath. Yet oath, lambs'
blood, libations
unmixed, and the right hands we
trusted shall not
be vain. Though Olympus' lord does
not fulfill it
at once, he will fulfill it later; and
they shall pay
dearly, with heads, wives, and
children. I know
within my heart the day shall come
when holy Ilium,
Priam, and Priam's well-speared
people are destroyed;
when Zeus himself, dwelling in the
upper air,
shakes his dark aegis over them in
anger at this deceit.
These things shall not fail; but my
grief for you,
Menelaus, will be terrible if you die,
and fulfill the appointed end of life."
Menelaus answered: "Take heart, and
do not alarm
the army. The wound is not deadly;
the arrow's point
did not remain, and belt and corselet
held it back."
Agamemnon summoned Talthibius:
"Call Machaon,

son of Asclepius, the blameless
healer, to see
whether he can heal Menelaus."
Talthibius passed
through the ranks, and found
Machaon, good physician,
among the shield-bearing men who
followed him
from Tricca. He brought him before
Menelaus.
Machaon cut away the shining belt,
corselet, and guard;
he drew the clotted blood out of the
wound,
and laid soothing medicines upon
it—medicines once given
by Cheiron to his father, Asclepius.
When the Trojans' ranks came on
again, no one could see
divine Agamemnon sleeping,
shrinking from the fight,
or refusing it. He hurried to the
battle that gives
men glory. He left his horses and
bronze-decorated
chariot apart, in care of Eurymedon,
son of Peiraeus,
son of Ptolemy, charging him to
bring them near
when weariness should seize his
limbs, after commanding
so many. On foot he moved among
the ranks;
whomever he saw eager, he stood
beside and encouraged:
"Argives, do not let your fierce
courage slacken.
Father Zeus will not help a lie. Those
who first harmed

the oath shall have their tender flesh
devoured
by vultures, while we shall carry
wives and children
aboard the ships, when we have
taken the city.”
But those he saw shrinking from the
hateful war he rebuked:
“Argives, soft with arrows, objects of
shame! Do you
not respect yourselves? Why stand
amazed like fawns
that, after running over a great plain,
stand still,
their courage gone? Will you wait for
the Trojans
to come close to the ships drawn
stern-first beside
the gray sea, and see whether Cronus’
son will extend
his hand above you?”
So he went through the ranks, and
came among the Cretans.
They armed around wise Idomeneus.
Idomeneus stood
in the front ranks, like a boar in
strength,
while Meriones urged the rearward
lines. Agamemnon
rejoiced to see them, and spoke
gently to Idomeneus:
“Idomeneus, I honor you above the
swift Achaeans,
in war, in every work, and at the
feast, when the best
of the Argives mix the bright wine
within the bowl.
Though other long-haired Achaeans
drink their portion,

your cup stands full, as mine does, to
drink whenever
your heart commands. Rise to war, as
you have always
claimed that you would.”
The Cretan leader answered: “Atreus’
son, I shall remain
your faithful companion, as I first
promised and nodded.
Urge the other long-haired Achaeans
on, that we may fight
at once. The Trojans have spilled the
oaths, and death
and grief shall follow them, since
they first damaged
the covenant.”
Agamemnon passed on gladly and
came to the two Ajaxes.
They armed themselves, and a dense
cloud of footmen followed.
As when a goatherd sees from a
watchpoint a cloud coming over the
sea
under the West Wind’s sound—black
as pitch from far away,
bringing a mighty storm, and he
shudders and drives the sheep
into a cave—so the dark,
shield-and-spear-bristling ranks
moved
with the divinely reared young men
beside the Ajaxes into war.
Agamemnon rejoiced, and addressed
them: “Ajaxes,
leaders of the Argives, you need no
urging;
I do not command you. You
yourselves drive your people
to fight with all their strength.
Would that Zeus,

Athena, and Apollo gave such
courage to every heart!
Then Priam's city soon would bow to
our hands,
taken and sacked."
He left them, and found Nestor,
clear-voiced speaker
of the Pylians, arranging and urging
on his friends:
great Pelagon, Alastor, Chromius,
Haimon, lord Bias,
and shepherd of the people. He
placed the horsemen
first, with horses and chariots, and
many excellent
footmen behind them, a wall of war;
the cowards
he drove into the middle, so that
even unwilling men
should fight beneath compulsion. To
the horsemen
he first gave commands: "Keep your
horses in check;
do not let them plunge among the
crowd. Do not trust
in horsemanship and courage to rush
alone before
the others, or to fall back; your line
grows weaker.
When one man reaches another
chariot from his own,
let him reach forth with his spear. So
older warriors
destroyed cities and walls, holding
this thought
and courage in their breasts."
Agamemnon rejoiced to see the old
man: "Elder,
would that your knees followed the
spirit in your breast,

and that your strength remained
firm! But age wears you down.
Would another man possess your
years, and you
belong among the young!"
Gerenian horseman Nestor replied:
"Atreus' son,
I too would wish to be as I was when
I killed
godlike Ereuthalion. Yet the gods do
not give
all things to men at once. If I were
young again,
or if strength were firm within my
limbs, I would stand
among the horsemen, and lead them.
Now urge on
the younger men; I shall follow with
my counsel,
and they will obey, as is right."
The son of Atreus went on, rejoicing
in his heart. He found
Peteus' son Menestheus standing,
and round him
the Athenians, masters of the
battle-cry.
Nearby stood Odysseus, rich in
counsel,
and round him the unshaken
Cephalenians.
Their people had not yet heard the
battle-call;
the newly gathered phalanxes waited,
watching
for another Trojan tower to advance
and begin.
Agamemnon rebuked them:
"Son of Peteus, Zeus-nourished king,
skilled

in crooked counsel, why shrink back
and wait
for others? You should stand among
the first,
meet the burning battle, and hear my
feasts
proclaimed before the elders, when
we prepare them.
There you gladly eat roast meat and
drink
honey-sweet wine as long as you
desire;
now you would gladly see ten
Achaean towers
fighting before you.”
Many-counseled Odysseus looked
darkly at him:
“Atreus’ son, what word escaped the
fence
of your teeth? How can you say that
we slacken
the war, when we stir sharp Ares
against
the horse-taming Trojans? You shall
see,
if you desire it, Telemachus’ dear
father
mingling among the foremost ranks.
Your words
are wind.”
Agamemnon smiled, knowing the
man was angry,
and took back his speech: “God-born
son of Laertes,
rich in counsel, I do not rebuke or
command you.
I know your heart devises gentle
plans,
the same plans I devise. Let those
words be healed

hereafter, if any harm was spoken;
may the gods
make all of it wind.” He left them
and found
Tydeus’ high-hearted son Diomedes
standing
among his horses and close-fitted
chariots,
with Sthenelus beside him, son of
Capaneus.
Agamemnon rebuked him:
“Son of Tydeus, why shrink back,
why watch the bridges of battle?
It was not dear to Tydeus to shrink
so, but to fight far before his friends,
as those who saw him labor said. I
never met him, but so they tell me.
He entered Mycenae as a guest with
godlike Polynices, gathering a
people,
when they campaigned against the
sacred walls of seven-gated Thebes.
They begged us for famous allies, and
we agreed; but Zeus turned us back,
showing signs against our will. When
they had gone and reached
deep-reeded
Asopus, the Achaeans sent Tydeus as
messenger. He went and found many
Cadmeans feasting in the house of
mighty Eteocles. Though a guest and
alone
among many Cadmeans, horseman
Tydeus was not afraid; he challenged
them
to contests and won them all
easily—for Athena helped him.
The angry Cadmeans set an ambush
on his return, fifty young men led by
two:

Maeon, like an immortal, and
Polyphontes, son of Autophonus.
Tydeus gave them all a shameful
death, sending Maeon home alone,
because he trusted the gods' signs.
Such was Tydeus, the Aetolian;
but he fathered a son worse than
himself in war, though better in
council."

Strong Diomedes said nothing,
ashamed before the honored king.
But Sthenelus, glorious son of
Capaneus, answered: "Son of Atreus,
do not lie when you know the truth.
We boast that we are better than our
fathers.

We took seven-gated Thebes with
fewer men, bringing an army
beneath its wall,
trusting the gods' signs and Zeus's
help; our fathers perished through
their folly.

Do not place our fathers' honor on
the same scale as ours."

Diomedes looked beneath his brows:
"Friend, sit silent and obey my word.
I do not resent Agamemnon,
shepherd of the people, for urging
the well-greaved

Achaeans to fight. Glory will follow
him if the Achaeans sack the Trojans
and take sacred Ilium; great grief will
follow him if the Achaeans are
destroyed.

Come, then, let us remember our
fierce courage."

He leapt from his chariot in his
armor; the bronze rang terribly on
the king's
chest, and fear would have seized
even the steadfast.

When the two hosts came together,
the ranks
advanced without pause. Each
commander gave
his orders; the rest moved
silently—you would not think
so many people possessed voices—for
they feared
their officers' commands, while the
variegated armor
flashed about them as they marched.
The Trojans raised a cry like sheep
within
the courtyard of a rich man,
thousands waiting
to be milked, and bleating without
end
when they hear the lambs' voices.
Thus confusion
rose through the Trojan host: no
single voice,
no single language, but a mingling of
tongues,
men called from many lands. Ares
stirred some,
bright-eyed Athena others, and
Deimos, Phobos,
and unwearied Strife, the sister and
companion
of man-slaying Ares. Her head at
first is small;
soon she plants it in heaven, while
her feet
walk upon earth. She cast mutual
hatred
among them, and increased the
groan of men
as through the ranks she moved.
When they reached one place, hide
struck hide;

spears and the strength of
bronze-clad men
struck together, and bossed shields
crashed on shields.
A mighty tumult rose: groans and
shouts of triumph
from men who killed and men who
died, and blood
ran over the ground. As when two
winter torrents,
rushing down the mountains, pour
their waters
together in a hollow ravine from
great springs,
and a shepherd hears their thunder
far away
among the hills, so from the armies'
meeting
came clamor and pain.
Antilochus was first to kill a Trojan
champion,
Echepolus, son of Thalysius. First he
struck
the horsehair crest of Echepolus'
helmet;
the bronze point fixed in his
forehead, passed
through bone, and darkness covered
his eyes.
He fell, a tower struck down in
furious battle.
Elephenor, son of Chalcodon,
great-hearted
leader of the Abantes, seized him by
the feet
and dragged him from the missiles,
eager to strip
his armor. But his labor was brief.
Agenor saw him,

and as he bent beside the shield,
drove his spear
into the ribs exposed beneath it and
loosed his limbs.
Thus Elephenor's spirit went.
Trojans and Achaeans
fought terribly above the body,
rushing together
like wolves, while man struck man.
Telamonian Ajax struck Simoeisius,
flourishing son
of Anthemion, whom his mother
bore beside
the banks of Simoeis, coming down
from Ida
with her parents to see the flocks.
Therefore
they named him Simoeisius. He
never repaid
his dear parents for their upbringing;
his life
was short, and Ajax's great-hearted
spear brought him down.
Ajax struck his chest beside the right
nipple;
the bronze passed out through the
shoulder,
and he fell in dust like a smooth
poplar grown
in a broad, wet meadow, branches
high at the crown,
cut by a chariot-builder with shining
iron
to bend it into a beautiful
chariot-rim,
then left beside the river.
Antiphus, Priam's son, cast his sharp
spear
at Ajax, missed, and struck Leucus
instead,

Odysseus' excellent companion, as he
dragged
a corpse aside. The dead man fell
from his hands;
Leucus fell over him. Odysseus grew
fiercely angry
at his companion's death. Helmeted
in bright bronze,
he passed among the champions,
stood near,
and cast his shining spear. The
Trojans shrank,
but not in vain did he cast: he struck
Democoon,
Priam's bastard son, who came from
Abydos
beside the swift horses. At the
temple Odysseus struck;
the bronze went through, and
darkness covered his eyes.
His armor clattered as he fell.
The champions and radiant Hector
withdrew;
the Argives raised a mighty shout,
drew off
the dead, and advanced much
farther. Apollo,
looking down from Pergamos, grew
angry and called:
"Rise, horse-taming Trojans; yield
not to the Achaeans.
Their flesh is neither stone nor iron,
proof
against the bronze that cuts the flesh.
Nor does Achilles,
fair-haired Thetis' son, fight; he
nurses still
his heart-paining anger beside the
ships."

The terrible god spoke from the city,
while Athena,
glorious daughter of Zeus, stirred the
Achaeans
wherever she saw them slacken.
There Fate caught Diores,
son of Amarynceus: a jagged stone
struck beside
his ankle, crushing tendons and
bones of his right leg.
Peirous, son of Imbrasus, leader of
the Thracians
who came from Aenus, had thrown
it. Diores fell
backward in the dust, stretching
both hands
to his companions, and breathing out
his spirit.
Peirous, who had struck him, rushed
forward;
Thoas the Aetolian stabbed him
above the nipple,
and the bronze lodged deep within
his lung.
Thoas came close, pulled the great
spear from his chest,
drew his sharp sword, and struck his
belly,
taking away his life. He could not
strip the armor:
the Thracians with their long spears
stood around,
and though he was great, strong, and
splendid,
they drove Thoas back. Thus the two
leaders lay
stretched beside each other in the
dust—one leader
of Thracians, one of bronze-clad
Epeans—and many

others were killed around them.
Then no man could blame a man for
moving through
the middle of battle, still unstruck,
unwounded
by sharp bronze, if Pallas Athena
took him by the hand
and turned the missiles aside. For on
that day
many Trojans and Achaeans lay
face-down together
in the dust.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 5

First-pass working translation

Then Pallas Athena gave courage and strength
to Tydeus' son Diomedes, that he
might shine
among the Argives and win enduring fame.

From helmet and shield she kindled
an unwearied fire,
like the autumn star that shines most brightly
after bathing in Ocean. Such a fire
she lit

from head to shoulders, and drove
him into the midst,
where the greatest number pressed
together.

Among the Trojans lived a rich and blameless man,

Dares, priest of Hephaestus. Two sons he had,

Phegeus and Idaios, skilled in every art of war.

They drove straight against
Diomedes—one from the car,
the other on foot. When they came near, Phegeus
cast first his long-shadowed spear; its point passed
over the left shoulder of Diomedes
and missed.

The son of Tydeus cast next, nor flew his spear
in vain: it struck Phegeus in the chest
between
the nipples, and thrust him from his horses.

Idaios sprang away, leaving the lovely chariot;

he could not stand above his brother.
Nor would he

have escaped black Fate, but
Hephaestus saved him,
covering him in night, that the old priest might not
be left altogether childless. Tydeus' son drove

the horses to his friends, to lead them to the ships.

When the great-hearted Trojans saw one son fleeing,

the other slain beside the chariot, their hearts

were shaken. Bright-eyed Athena took Ares by the hand:

"Ares, Ares, destroyer of mortals, wall-breaker,

let us leave Trojans and Achaeans to fight,

and withdraw, avoiding Zeus's anger. Whichever side

he grants the glory, let that side possess it."

So she led fierce Ares from the battle and seated him

beside the sandy Scamander. The Danaans drove

the Trojans back, and every captain killed a man.

First Agamemnon struck great Odius down,

leader of the Halizonians; as he turned,

the spear drove between his shoulders, passed

through his chest, and made his armor ring.

Idomeneus killed Phaestus, son of
Borus' son Maeon,
who had come from deep-soiled
Tarne. As Phaestus
mounted his horses, Idomeneus
struck his right shoulder;
hateful darkness took him, and his
attendants stripped
his armor.
Menelaus killed Scamandrius,
Strophius' son,
a skilled hunter whom Artemis
herself had taught
to strike each wild creature the forest
breeds.
But Artemis, mistress of the bow, did
not help him then.
As Scamandrius fled, Menelaus
struck his back;
the spear passed between his
shoulders through the chest.
Meriones killed Phereclus, son of
Tecton's son
Harmonides, who knew to make all
intricate things
with his hands, and was beloved by
Athena. For Alexander
he built the equal ships that brought
evil on Troy
and Paris, since he knew not the
gods' decrees.
Meriones pursued and struck his
right buttock;
the point passed beneath the bone
and came out
at the bladder. He fell upon his
knees, crying aloud,
and death covered him.
Meges killed Pedaeus, Antenor's
bastard son,

whom noble Theano raised as
tenderly as her own,
for her husband's sake. Phyleus'
famous son drew near
and struck him at the nape; the sharp
spear passed
under his tongue, between his teeth,
and cold bronze
took away his spirit.
Eurypylus, son of Euaemon, killed
Hypsenor,
the godlike son of Dolopion, priest of
Scamander,
honored among the people like a
god. As Hypsenor fled,
Eurypylus overtook him and cut his
heavy arm away
at the shoulder; the bloodied hand
fell on the plain,
and purple death seized him.
So they labored through the strong
battle. You could not
have known whether Diomedes
stood among Trojans
or Achaeans; he swept across the
plain like a winter torrent
that quickly breaks the bridges.
Neither bridges nor fences
of flowering orchards restrain it
when Zeus' rain descends
in force, and many fine works of
young men fall before it.
So beneath Diomedes' hands the
Trojan ranks were scattered;
even their multitude could not stand.
When Lycaon's glorious son saw him
rushing,
driving the ranks before him, he bent
his curved bow

and struck Diomedes in the right
shoulder,
where the corselet swelled. The
bitter arrow passed through;
blood stained his armor. Pandarus
cried aloud:
“Rise, great-hearted Trojans, drivers
of horses!
The best of the Achaeans is
wounded; surely he will not
long endure the bitter arrow, if the
son of Zeus
truly sent me here from Lycia.”
But the swift arrow did not subdue
Diomedes.
He withdrew before his horses and
his chariot,
and called to Sthenelus, Capaneus’
son:
“Rise, dear friend; leap down from
the chariot,
and draw the bitter arrow from my
shoulder.”
Sthenelus sprang down and pulled it
straight through;
blood spurted through the twisted
tunic. Then Diomedes prayed:
“Hear me, daughter of aegis-bearing
Zeus, unwearied one.
If ever you stood kindly beside my
father in fierce war,
be kind to me now, Athena. Grant
me to kill the man
who struck me, who shot first, and
boasts that I shall not
long behold the sun’s bright light.”
He prayed, and Pallas Athena heard.
She made his limbs
light, and quickened hand and foot;
then, standing near,

she spoke winged words: “Take heart
now, Diomedes,
and fight the Trojans. I have set
within your breast
your father’s courage, the fearless
force Tydeus carried
behind his shield. I have taken from
your eyes the mist
that lay there before, so that you may
recognize
god and man. If any god comes here
to test you,
do not fight the other immortals face
to face.
But if Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,
enters battle,
wound her with sharp bronze.”
So bright-eyed Athena withdrew.
Diomedes returned
to the front ranks, already eager for
the Trojans;
now his courage was threefold. As
when a shepherd
wounds a lion leaping over the
sheepfold, yet cannot tame it,
and the wounded beast’s strength
rises while the shepherd
will not defend himself—the sheep
huddle together,
and the lion leaps from the deep
fold—so the mighty
son of Tydeus entered the midst of
the Trojans.
He killed Astynous, shepherd of the
people,
with bronze above the nipple;
Hypeiron he struck
with his great sword at the
collarbone, severing

shoulder, neck, and back. Leaving them, he pursued Abas and Polyidus, sons of old Eurydamas, a dream-reader who did not read their returning dream. Strong Diomedes stripped them of their arms. Then he went against Xanthus and Thoon, both beloved sons of Phaenops, whom grievous old age wore down. He had no other son to leave his possessions. Diomedes killed them both, leaving their father grief and bitter mourning; he would not receive his sons alive, and their kinsmen divided the inheritance. Then he seized two sons of Priam, Echemmon and Chromius, in one chariot. As a lion springs among cattle and breaks the neck of calf or heifer, so Tydeus' son hurled both unwilling from their horses, stripped their armor, and gave the horses to his friends to drive toward the hollow ships. When Aeneas saw Diomedes scattering the ranks, he crossed the battle seeking Pandarus. He found Lycaon's son within the dense shield-wall of men who followed him from Aesepus. Aeneas asked

where his bow was, and urged him to shoot the man who had done such harm to Troy. Pandarus answered that he knew Diomedes by his shield, his helmet, and his horses, but suspected a god stood near him. The arrow he had already shot through Diomedes' shoulder had not subdued him. His horses and chariot were absent; at home eleven new chariots stood in Lycaon's house, but he had come on foot, trusting in a bow that had drawn blood from Tydeus' son and Atreus' son. If he returned to his native land, his wife, and his high-roofed house, he would break the bow in bright fire; it had followed him uselessly. Aeneas told him that nothing would change until they went together against Diomedes. He offered his chariot, praising its Trojan horses, who knew to chase and flee. Pandarus answered: "Keep the reins; the horses know your voice. I shall meet the attack with my spear." They mounted the variegated chariot and drove against Diomedes. Sthenelus saw them and warned Diomedes:

“Two powerful men are coming
against you—
Pandarus, the famous bowman, and
Aeneas,
son of Anchises, whose mother is
Aphrodite.
Let us withdraw upon the horses, lest
you lose your life.”
Diomedes answered that he would
not flee or crouch;
his strength remained, and Pallas
Athena forbade his fear.
He ordered Sthenelus to hold their
horses,
and, if Athena granted him both
deaths, to seize
Aeneas’ horses and drive them from
the Trojans.
They descended from the chariot and
rushed together.
Pandarus cast his long-shadowed
spear at Diomedes’ shield;
the bronze passed through and
touched the corselet.
He shouted that Diomedes was
wounded through the flank
and would not long endure.
Diomedes answered:
“You have missed. Neither of us shall
cease
before one man falls and satisfies
fierce Ares.”
Athena guided his spear beside
Pandarus’ eye;
it broke his white teeth, cut the root
of his tongue,
and passed beneath his chin. He fell
from the chariot,
his bright armor clattering, while his
swift horses ran loose.

Aeneas leapt down with shield and
long spear,
circling the body like a lion, eager to
kill
whoever approached. Diomedes
lifted a stone—
a great feat for two men of the
present age—
but swung and hurled it alone. It
struck Aeneas
at the hip, crushed the socket, and
tore both tendons.
Aeneas fell to his knees and propped
himself
with his broad hand; black night
covered his eyes.
Aphrodite, his mother, saw him and
cast her white arms
around her son, spreading a fold of
her shining robe
before him as a shield against the
arrows.
She carried him away from war.
Sthenelus remembered
Diomedes’ command, held back their
horses, seized
Aeneas’ fine-maned team, and drove
them toward the ships.
He gave them to Deipylus, his
trusted companion;
then mounted his own horses and
pursued Diomedes.
Diomedes charged Aphrodite,
knowing she was a powerless
goddess—not Athena, nor Enyo, who
rule the wars of men.
When he reached her, he wounded
the soft top of her hand
with his sharp spear. Bronze pierced
the ambrosial robe

the Graces had made; immortal ichor
flowed, for the gods
eat no grain and drink no dark wine.
Aphrodite cried out
and dropped her son. Phoebus
Apollo caught him in his arms,
covering him with a dark cloud, lest
any swift-footed Danaan
drive bronze into his chest and take
away his life.
Diomedes shouted after Aphrodite:
“Yield, daughter of Zeus, who rules
the battle and the strife!
Is it not enough that you deceive
defenseless women?
If you come again to war, I think you
will shudder
at the very name of battle, even when
you hear it elsewhere.”
Iris, the wind-footed, took her from
the throng,
her beautiful skin darkening beneath
the pain.
She found swift Ares on the battle’s
left, sitting;
his spear lay in the mist, and his swift
horses stood nearby.
Falling upon her knees, she pleaded
with her brother:
“Dear brother, care for me; give me
your horses,
that I may reach Olympus, the seat
of the immortals.
I suffer greatly from the wound a
mortal man has given me,
Tydeus’ son, who would fight even
father Zeus.”
Ares gave her his golden-maned
horses. Aphrodite

climbed into the chariot, her heart in
grief;
Iris sat beside her, took the reins,
and lashed the team.
Swiftly they reached Olympus, the
steep seat of the gods.
Iris halted the horses, unharnessed
them, and laid
ambrosial food before them.
Aphrodite fell upon her knees
before her mother Dione. Dione
embraced and stroked her,
asking which Uranian god had done
this rash deed,
as though her child had been caught
in some evil act.
Aphrodite answered: “The
high-hearted son of Tydeus,
Diomedes, wounded me, because I
carried my dear son
Aeneas from the battle; he is dearest
to me.
This is no longer war only between
Trojans and Achaeans—
the Danaans now fight the
immortals.”
Dione told her to endure: many who
dwell in Olympus
have suffered hard pain at mortal
hands. Ares endured
when the Aloadae, Otus and
Ephialtes, bound him
in bronze bonds for thirteen months,
until Hermes
secretly rescued him. Hera endured
when Amphitryon’s
strong son shot her in the right
breast. Hades endured
the swift arrow Heracles shot at him
in Pylos,

and went in pain to Zeus's house, the
arrow lodged
within his shoulder. Paeon poured
pain-soothing medicines
upon Hades, for he was not mortal.
Dione rebuked the violent archer
who had harmed the gods.
Athena had set Diomedes against
Aphrodite; foolishly
he did not know that a man who
fights the immortals
does not return long from war. Let
him beware, lest his wife,
wise Aegialeia, Adrastus' daughter,
should wake from sleep
and lament for her husband, the best
of the Achaeans,
Diomedes, tamer of horses. She
wiped the ichor
from Aphrodite's hand; the hand was
healed,
and the heavy pains grew still.
Hera and Athena watched, and
teased Zeus with sharp words.
Athena began: "Father Zeus, will you
be angry if I speak?
Cypris has surely urged one Achaean
woman to follow
the Trojans she loves; and, while
caressing one of our
well-robed Achaean women, she
scratched her delicate hand
upon a golden brooch." The father of
gods and men smiled,
and called golden Aphrodite near:
"My child, warlike deeds
are not given to you; pursue instead
the lovely works
of marriage. Let swift Ares and
Athena attend to these."

While they spoke, Diomedes rushed
again at Aeneas,
knowing Apollo himself held his
hands above the hero.
Yet he did not fear the great god;
still he desired
to kill Aeneas and strip his famous
armor. Three times
he charged to kill him; three times
Apollo struck
his shining shield aside. At the
fourth, like a god,
Apollo shouted: "Beware, son of
Tydeus, and draw back.
Do not think as the gods do; no equal
race is run
between immortals and men who
walk the earth."
Diomedes withdrew a little, avoiding
the far-shooter's anger.
Apollo set Aeneas apart in sacred
Pergamus, where his temple stood;
Leto and Artemis healed and
honored him in the great sanctuary.
Apollo made an image like Aeneas,
in form and armor,
and around that image Trojans and
Achaeans beat one another,
striking their rounded ox-hide
shields. Then Phoebus called Ares:
"Ares, destroyer of mortals,
wall-breaker, will you not
go into battle and draw this man,
Diomedes, out?
He would fight even father Zeus
now. First he wounded
Cypris near the wrist; then against
me he rushed like a god."
So Apollo sat upon the height of
Pergamus, while Ares

entered the crowd in the likeness of
Acamas,
leader of the Thracians, urging on
the Trojans.

The Trojans' ranks were urged on by
fierce Ares,
who had taken the form of swift
Acamas,
leader of the Thracians. He called to
Priam's sons:

"Sons of Priam, Zeus-nourished king,
how long
will you let the Achaeans kill your
people?

Will you wait until they fight around
your well-built gates?

Aeneas lies there, a good companion
whom we honored
like Hector. Come, let us save him
from the tumult."

His words stirred every heart.

Then divine Sarpedon rebuked
Hector:

"Hector, where has the courage gone
that once you had?

You said you could hold the city
without its people
or allies, alone with brothers and
sons-in-law.

Now I see none of them; they shrink
like dogs

around a lion, while we fight as allies
you summoned.

I came from far-off Lycia beside the
whirling Xanthus,

leaving a dear wife, a little son, and
many possessions;

yet I urge my Lycians, and myself, to
meet a man.

Here I have nothing for an Achaean
to carry away,

but you stand idle, and do not
command your people

to remain and guard the walls. Take
care lest you and yours

become prey, caught like flax in a
snare, while the enemy

soon sacks your city. Entreat the
famous allies,

night and day, to stand without
ceasing,

and lay aside your harsh reproach."

His speech pierced Hector's heart.

Hector leapt

from his chariot in armor, shook his
sharp spears,

and moved throughout the host,
rousing dreadful battle.

They turned and faced the Achaeans;
the Argives stood

together and did not flee. As a wind
carries chaff

across a sacred threshing floor when
men winnow grain,

and the straw heaps grow white
beneath it, so the Achaeans

grew white in dust, as hooves drove
dust upward

to the bronze sky and drivers
wheeled their teams.

But fierce Ares covered the Trojans
with darkness,

moving everywhere to aid them and
fulfilling Apollo's command,

who sent him to raise Trojan courage
when he saw

Athena withdraw, leaving aid to the
Danaans.

Apollo himself brought Aeneas from
the sanctuary
and put strength into him. His
companions rejoiced
when they saw him alive, unhurt, and
full of courage,
but did not ask what had happened:
another labor
was being raised by Apollo, Ares,
and unwearied Strife.
The two Ajaxes, Odysseus, and
Diomedes urged
the Danaans to fight. They did not
fear Trojan strength
or arrows, but stood like clouds that
Cronus' son holds
still upon the mountain peaks until
Boreas' force,
and that of the other fierce winds,
sleeps.
So the Danaans stood fast and did
not flee.
Agamemnon moved among them,
calling:
"Be men, friends; take a valiant heart,
and honor one another in the fierce
battle.
More men survive when shame is
felt;
among the fleeing there is neither
glory nor courage."
He cast his spear and struck
Deicoon, companion
of Aeneas, son of Pergasus, honored
like Priam's sons
because he fought among the first.
The spear passed
through shield and belt into his
lower belly;
he fell, and his armor rang upon him.

Aeneas killed two excellent
Achaeans,
Crethon and Orsilochus, sons of
Diocles,
a wealthy man in well-built Pherae,
whose line descended
from Alpheius, the broad-flowing
river of Pylian land.
Diocles fathered twins skilled in war.
When they grew,
they followed the Argives to Ilium,
to win honor
for Agamemnon and Menelaus; but
death's end covered them.
As two lions raised by their mother
in thick forest
raven cattle and sheep in the folds of
men,
until sharp bronze killed them in
men's hands,
so Aeneas subdued them, and they
fell like tall firs.
The war-loving Menelaus pitied the
fallen pair.
Helmeted in flashing bronze, he
passed through
the foremost ranks, brandishing his
spear. Ares,
meaning him to fall beneath Aeneas'
hands,
stirred his courage. Antilochus,
Nestor's great-hearted son,
saw him and hurried through the
battle, fearing for
the shepherd of the people, lest the
day's labor be lost.
The two stood face to face, eager for
the fight;
Antilochus kept close beside
Menelaus.

Aeneas, though swift in war, would
not wait
when he saw the two champions
joined. They dragged
the dead back among the Achaeans,
laid the fallen
in their companions' hands, and
turned again
into the foremost line. There they
slew Pylæmenes,
leader of the great-shielded
Paphlagonians:
Menelaus struck him beneath the
collarbone.
Antilochus felled Mydon, his
charioteer,
striking the elbow that held the
reins. The ivory-white
reins dropped in dust; Antilochus
sprang upon him
with the sword and drove him from
the well-built car,
face and shoulders buried in sand,
until the horses
were seized and led away among the
Achaean ranks.
Hector saw them and came shouting
against them,
with Trojan battalions behind. Ares
led the way,
and Enyo bore the shameless tumult
of war.
Ares swung his enormous spear, now
before Hector,
now behind him. Diomedes, seeing
the god, shuddered
like a helpless traveler who, standing
above a river
pouring foaming into the sea, sees
the flood and runs back.

He called to his friends: "Look how
we marvel at Hector,
noble spearman and daring warrior!
Some god always
stands beside him, warding off
destruction—and now
that god is Ares, made like a mortal
man. Face the Trojans,
but give ground ever backward.
Desire not to fight
the gods by force."
The Trojans came close. Hector
killed Menesthes
and Anchialus, two companions in
one chariot.
Great Telamonian Ajax pitied them,
stood near,
and cast his bright spear at Amphius,
son of Selagus,
a wealthy man who dwelt in Paesus
among grain fields,
but whom fate led to fight beside
Priam and his sons.
Ajax struck him beneath the belt; the
long-shadowed spear
fixed in his belly, and he fell with a
crash.
Ajax ran to strip his armor, but
Trojan spears poured
around him, and his shield received
them all.
He tore the bronze from the dead,
yet could not take
the beautiful armor; the press of the
many and the brave
drove him back, and he staggered
beneath their charge.
Then Fate, strong and pitiless, set
against godlike

Sarpedon the tall and excellent
Tlepolemus,
son of Heracles. When they drew
near—son and grandson
of Zeus who gathers the
clouds—Tlepolemus first addressed
the Lycian captain:
“Sarpedon, counselor of the Lycians,
what compels
you to crouch before the battle, a
man unpracticed
in war? They lie who call you son of
aegis-bearing Zeus;
you fall far short of those men said to
have sprung
from him in earlier days. My father
Heracles was brave
and lion-hearted. He came here once
for Laomedon’s horses,
with six ships and few men, and laid
Ilium waste,
leaving its streets bereaved. But your
spirit is poor,
and your people waste away. No
defense shall you be
to Troy, though you came from
Lycia; beneath my spear
you shall be subdued, and pass
through Hades’ gates.”
Sarpedon answered: “Tlepolemus,
that man destroyed
sacred Ilium through proud
Laomedon’s blindness,
who repaid good service with an evil
word and would not
give the horses for which Heracles
came from far away.
But here, I tell you, you shall find
death and black Fate.

Slain beneath my spear, you shall
give glory to me,
and your spirit to Hades, lord of the
famous horses.”
They raised their spears. Both shafts
flew wide; then Sarpedon
struck Tlepolemus’ neck, and the
grievous point passed through.
Black night covered his eyes.
Tlepolemus struck Sarpedon’s left
thigh;
the spear drove through and lodged
against the bone,
yet Zeus’ son was not wholly
overcome. His dear companions
carried him from battle, the long
spear dragging after him,
for no one thought to draw the ash
from his thigh
as they hurried beneath that burden.
The well-greaved Achaeans bore
Tlepolemus away.
Odysseus saw him, and his brave
heart burned. He wondered
whether to pursue Zeus’ son or take
the lives of many Lycians,
but it was not his portion to kill the
mighty son of Zeus.
Athena turned his spirit toward the
Lycian multitude,
and he slew Coeranus, Alastor,
Chromius, Alcander,
Halios, Noemon, and Prytanis.
He would have killed more, but
Hector, great-helmed son
of Priam, saw the danger and crossed
the foremost ranks,
bringing dread to the Danaans.
Sarpedon, son of Zeus,

rejoiced at his coming and spoke in grief:
“Priam’s son, do not leave me as prey
for the Danaans.
Defend me, and then let life abandon
me here in your city.
I was not destined to return home
and gladden
my dear wife and little son.” Hector
gave no answer,
but rushed past, eager to thrust back
the Argives
and take the lives of many. His
companions set Sarpedon
beneath Zeus’ beautiful oak. There
strong Pelagon,
his beloved friend, drew the ash from
his thigh.
His spirit left him, and mist covered
his eyes;
then the breath of the North Wind
blew upon him,
and he revived, gasping and faint.
But once Ares and bronze-clad
Hector entered the battle,
the Argives neither advanced toward
the black ships
nor stood to meet them; they gave
ground continually
when they heard that Ares was
among the Trojans.
Whom did Hector and bronze Ares
first and last strip of life?
Teuthras; horse-driving Orestes; the
spearman Trechus;
Oenomaus; Helenus, son of Oenops;
and Oresbius
with the bright belt, who dwelt
beside the Cephissian lake

in Hyle, rich in goods, while other
Boeotians lived near him
upon their fertile land.
White-armed Hera saw the Argives
falling in hard battle
and spoke to Athena: “Shame! Shall
our promise to Menelaus
be vain—that well-walled Ilium
should fall—if we let
destructive Ares rage so? Let us put
forth our strength.”
Athena did not refuse. Hera
harnessed her swift
golden-maned horses. Hebe fitted
the curved eight-spoked wheels
upon the iron axle: their rims were
gold, their tires bronze,
a wonder to behold, their rounded
spokes of silver.
The chariot was stretched with
golden and silver straps,
and two rails ran around it. From its
front the silver pole
extended; at its tip Hera fastened the
beautiful golden yoke
and laid on the reins.
Athena cast her embroidered robe at
her father’s feet,
put on Zeus’ warlike tunic, and
armed herself with the tasselled
aegis, crowned with Fear, Strife,
Strength, and the dreadful
Gorgon head. Upon her head she set
the four-crested golden helmet,
fitted for a hundred cities; she
mounted the flaming car
and took the great spear with which
she breaks the ranks
of heroes who have angered her
strong father.

Hera urged the horses on. Of their own accord the gates of heaven groaned—the gates held by the Hours, who open and close the dense cloud between Olympus and the sky.

They passed through and found Zeus sitting apart from all the gods upon the highest peak of Olympus.

White-armed Hera stopped her horses there and spoke:

“Father Zeus, are you not angered when you behold the deeds of Ares—how many Argives he has destroyed, heedless of order? Yet Cypris and far-shooting Apollo delight in loosing that mad one, who knows no law.

Father Zeus, will you be angry if I drive him from battle, struck grievously?”

“Bring Athena, the spoiler of hosts,” Zeus answered;

“she is the one most often accustomed to draw near him with bitter pains.” Hera did not refuse. She lashed the horses; they flew between the earth and the starry heaven. As far as a man can see the haze while seated on a lookout over the wine-dark sea, so far the high-driving horses of the gods leapt at once.

When they reached Troy, where the two rivers meet, Simoeis and Scamander, Hera stopped them, unhitched them,

and cast a deep mist around them.

Simoeis raised ambrosia for the horses to eat. Hera and Athena went on like shy doves toward the place where the best of the Argives stood around horse-taming Diomedes, gathered like lions or boars whose strength is not easily broken.

Hera cried in the voice of Stentor, whose bronze voice

equaled the voices of fifty men:

“Shame, Argives—cowards in beautiful bodies! While noble Achilles walked among you, the Trojans never dared leave the Dardanian gates, so greatly they feared his terrible spear. Now they fight far from the city, beside the hollow ships.” Her cry

awakened courage in them all.

Athena found Diomedes beside his horses and chariot, wiping the wound

that Pandarus’ arrow had made.

Sweat tormented him beneath the broad

shield-strap; his arm grew weary as he wiped the dark blood away.

The goddess touched the yoke and spoke:

“Little did Tydeus beget a son like himself!

Tydeus was small in body, but a fighter.

When I forbade him to fight, or burst into the tumult,

and he came as messenger to Thebes
among the Cadmeans,
I told him to feast quietly within the
halls.
Yet his strong spirit challenged the
young men
and defeated them all, for I stood
beside him.
I stand beside and guard you also.
Fight freely.
Has long weariness weakened your
limbs,
or does fear hold you? You are no son
of Tydeus,
the battle-wise Oeneid.”
Diomedes answered: “I know you,
goddess,
daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, and
will hide nothing.
Neither fear nor cowardice holds me;
I remember still
the commands you gave me—not to
fight the blessed gods
openly. Yet if Aphrodite, daughter of
Zeus,
comes into battle, I may wound her
with sharp bronze.
Therefore I withdraw and bid the
other Argives gather;
I know that Ares rules the fight.”
Athena replied: “Diomedes, dear to
my heart,
fear neither Ares nor any other
immortal;
I am your defense. Drive your
sure-hoofed horses
straight at Ares. Strike him close; do
not dread
that mad, shifting god, who lately
boasted to Hera and me

that he would fight for Troy and aid
the Argives,
but now mingles with the Trojans
and forgets his promise.”
She thrust Sthenelus from the
chariot and drew him back
with her hand; he sprang away. Then
the goddess mounted
beside Diomedes. The beech axle
groaned beneath
the weight of a god and a great man.
Pallas Athena
took the reins and drove first against
Ares.
Ares was stripping the armor from
huge Periphas,
best of the Aetolians, when Athena
put on the helmet
of Hades, that the mighty god might
not see her.
As soon as Ares, the bane of mortals,
saw Diomedes,
he left Periphas where he had first
slain him
and came straight against the
horse-tamer.
Ares thrust over yoke and reins,
eager to take
the mortal’s life; Athena caught the
spear
and drove it aside, so that it flew in
vain.
Diomedes thrust with his bronze
spear;
Athena guided it beneath the belly,
where the belt
was fastened. He struck Ares, tore
the beautiful flesh,
and drew the spear away. The brazen
god cried

as loudly as nine or ten thousand
men cry
when war's quarrel brings them
together;
a shudder seized Achaeans and
Trojans alike.
As dark air appears from clouds
when the hot wind rises
from a stormy quarter, so bronze
Ares appeared
to Diomedes, rising among the
clouds toward broad heaven.
Swiftly he reached Olympus, sat
beside Zeus,
and showed the immortal blood that
ran from his wound.
"Father Zeus," he lamented, "do you
not see these deeds?
We gods suffer always through one
another's will,
bringing favor to mortal men. We all
fight
because you begot this senseless,
ruinous daughter,
whose mind is ever set on lawless
deeds.
The other gods in Olympus obey you
and bow beneath
your will, but you restrain her
neither in word nor deed,
because you yourself fathered this
destructive child.
She has driven arrogant Diomedes
against the immortals:
first he wounded Cypris at the wrist,
then rushed upon me as though he
were a god.
My swift feet saved me; else I should
have suffered long

among the dreadful dead, or lived
powerless beneath bronze."
Zeus looked at him darkly: "Do not
sit beside me
and whimper, you who turn against
your own side.
You are the god I hate most among
the Olympians.
Strife, war, and battle are always
dear to you.
You have your mother's unyielding
temper—Hera's;
even I can scarcely master her with
words.
I think her counsels have brought
you this pain.
Yet I will not endure your suffering
long,
for you are my child, and your
mother bore you to me.
Had you been born from another
god, destructive one,
you would long ago have been lower
than the sons of Heaven."
He commanded Paeon to heal him.
Paeon spread
pain-soothing medicines upon the
wound, and it closed
at once, for Ares was not fashioned
mortal.
As curdling fig-juice quickly
thickens white milk
when stirred, so quickly the medicine
healed the furious god.
Hebe washed him and dressed him in
shining garments;
he sat beside Zeus in glory. Hera of
Argos
and Athena of Alalcomenae returned
to the great house

of Zeus, having stopped murderous
Ares in his slaughter.

Source range: Book 5. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 6

First-pass working translation

The battle rolled on, terrible,
between the Trojans and the
Achaeans;
their bronze-shod spears drove
straight against one another between
the streams of Simoeis and Xanthus.
Great Telamonian Ajax, the rampart
of the Achaeans, broke the Trojan
line first and brought light to his
friends.

He struck Acamas, son of Eussorus,
the best and tallest of the Thracians;
the bronze point pierced the
horse-haired crest, entered his
forehead,

and darkness covered his eyes.

Diomedes slew Axylus, son of
Teuthras,

a rich man who dwelt in well-built
Arisbe and loved all men: his house
stood beside the road, and every
traveler found welcome there. Yet no
one

could stand before Diomedes and
save him from the fatal day; he took
both

Axylus and his charioteer Calesius,
and the two went down together in
dust.

Euryalus stripped Dresus and
Opheltius, then went on against
Aesepeus and

Pedasus, twin sons whom the
water-nymph Abarbarea bore to
noble Bucolion.

Bucolion was the eldest son of proud
Laomedon, but his mother bore him
in secret. While he tended sheep he
lay with the nymph, who conceived
and brought forth the twins; now the
son of Mecisteus broke their strength
and took the shining armor from
their shoulders. War-loving
Polypoetes
slew Astyalus; Odysseus struck down
Percosius with bronze, and Teucer
felled Aretaon. Antilochus, Nestor's
son, killed Ablerus with his bright
spear;

Agamemnon, lord of men, killed
Elatus, who dwelt beside the
fair-flowing

Satnioeis near steep Pedasus. Leitus
took Phylacus as he fled, and
Eurypylus

stripped Melanthius of life.

Menelaus seized Adrastus alive. His
frightened horses, startled across the
plain, broke the curved chariot's pole
against a tamarisk branch; they ran
toward the city where the others
fled, while Adrastus rolled headlong
from

the car and fell face-first in the dust.
Menelaus stood above him with his
long-shadowed spear. Adrastus
clasped the Atrid's knees and
pleaded:

"Take me alive, son of Atreus, and
accept a ransom worthy of me. My
wealthy

father has bronze, gold, and
much-worked iron stored in his
house; he would

give you measureless gifts if he heard
that I was alive among the Achaean

ships.”

His words moved Menelaus' heart,
and he was already about to send
Adrastus

to the swift ships, into the hands of a
servant, when Agamemnon came
running

and called aloud: “My good
Menelaus, why do you care so for
these men? Have

the Trojans treated your house so
well? Let none escape the steep death
from

our hands—not even the unborn
child carried in its mother's womb.
Let all of

Ilium perish, unburied and unseen.”
His brother's words turned
Menelaus' mind;

he thrust Adrastus away, and
Agamemnon struck him beneath the
ribs. As he fell,

the Atريد planted his foot upon his
chest and tore the ash spear free.

Then Nestor cried to the Argives:
“Friends, Danaan heroes, servants of
Ares,

let no one linger now beside the
spoils, loading his hands with armor
to carry

back to the ships. Let us kill the men;
afterward, when you stand
untroubled,

you may strip the dead across the
field.” His shout awakened every
heart.

The Trojans would have fled into
Ilium beneath the Achaeans, had not
Helenus,

Priam's son, best of all augurs, come
to Aeneas and Hector and said:

“Aeneas

and Hector, on you above all Trojans
and Lycians the labor rests, because
you

are best in counsel and battle. Stand
here, and hold the people before the
gates,

moving everywhere through the
ranks, before they fall in flight into
women's

hands and become a joy to the
enemy. When you have roused every
battalion,

we will remain and fight the Danaans
here, though we are sorely worn, for
need

drives us. Hector, go through the
city; tell your mother and mine to
gather the

elders, open the temple of gray-eyed
Athena on the city's height, and lay
upon

the goddess' knees the robe she
believes most beautiful and most
large, the one

she loves best in the house. Promise
twelve yearling heifers, never yet
broken

to the goad, if she will pity the city,
the wives of Troy, and their little
children,

and keep the fierce spear of Tydeus'
son, the strong deviser of flight, from
sacred

Ilium. I call him the strongest of all
the Achaeans; not even Achilles, they
say,

though born of a goddess, was ever so
feared. This man rages beyond
measure,

and no one can equal his strength.”

Hector did not disobey his brother.
He leapt from his chariot in his
armor,
shook his sharp spears, and went
everywhere through the army, urging
the battle
and waking the dreadful tumult. The
Trojans turned and stood against the
Achaeans;
the Argives gave ground and stopped
their slaughter, believing that some
immortal
had descended from the starry
heaven to defend the Trojans. Hector
called aloud:
“Trojans, men of high spirit, and
far-famed allies, be men, my friends,
and remember
your furious courage while I go into
Ilium and tell the elders and our
wives to pray
to the gods and promise hecatombs.”
Thus he spoke and went away, and
the shield's
rim, running lowest around its boss,
struck his ankles and the dark skin of
his neck.
Glaucus, son of Hippolochus, and
Tydeus' son Diomedes came together
between the armies, both eager to
fight. When they had drawn near,
Diomedes spoke first, his voice
strong in battle:
“Who are you, best of mortal men? I
have never seen you before
in the glory-making war; yet now
you have gone far beyond all others
in daring, to wait for my
long-shadowed spear. The sons of the
unhappy

who meet my strength do not live
long. If you have come down from
heaven,
I will not fight the gods who dwell
above; even mighty Lycurgus, son of
Dryas,
did not live long when he quarreled
with the immortals. He once drove
the nurses
of raging Dionysus down the holy
slopes of Nysa; they scattered the
fennel wands
while man-slaying Lycurgus beat
them with his ox-goad. Dionysus,
afraid, plunged
beneath the sea, and Thetis received
him trembling in her lap; the man's
shout
had filled him with terror. The gods
who live easily were angered at
Lycurgus,
and the son of Cronus blinded him;
nor did he live long, hated by every
god.
I would not fight the blessed ones.
But if you are one of those mortals
who eat
the fruit of the earth, come nearer,
that you may sooner reach the
boundary of death.”
The shining son of Hippolochus
answered: “Great-hearted son of
Tydeus, why ask
my lineage? Like the leaves, so is the
race of men. The wind scatters one
year's
leaves upon the ground, and the
forest, breaking into flower, grows
others when
spring returns. So one generation of
men comes forth, and another passes

away.

Yet, if you wish to know this too,
that you may know it well, many
men know my house.

“There is a city called Ephyre, in the
heart of horse-breeding Argos. There
lived

Sisyphus, most cunning of men,
Sisyphus son of Aeolus; his son was
Glaucus, and

Glaucus fathered blameless
Bellerophon. The gods gave
Bellerophon beauty and

lovely courage. But Proetus devised
evil against him, and drove him from
the people

of Argos, for he was much stronger
than they; Zeus had placed them
beneath Proetus’

scepter. Then the wife of Proetus,
divine Anteia, was seized with desire
to lie

secretly with him, but Bellerophon
would not yield, for his thoughts
were good.

She lied to King Proetus: ‘Die,
Proetus, or kill Bellerophon, who
sought to lie

with me against my will.’ The king
was angered, yet feared to kill him,
and sent

him to Lycia with a folded tablet
bearing many signs of death,
commanding that

he be destroyed by the man who
received it.

“Bellerophon went under the gods’
good escort. When he reached broad
Lycia and

the flowing Xanthus, the king
welcomed and honored him, feasting

him nine days

and sacrificing nine oxen. On the
tenth dawn he asked to see the
deadly tablet

that Proetus had sent to the king.
When he had received it, he first
commanded

Bellerophon to kill the
unconquerable Chimera, a creature
of divine stock:

in front a lion, behind a serpent, and
in the middle a goat, breathing the
terrible

strength of burning fire. Bellerophon
killed her, trusting the omens of the
gods.

Then he fought the glorious Solymi,
saying that this was the hardest
battle among

men; and third he slew the man-like
Amazons. When he returned, the
king wove another

close snare, choosing the best men
from broad Lycia and setting them
in ambush.

None returned home; blameless
Bellerophon killed them all. At last,
knowing that

he was the dear son of a god, the king
held him there, gave him his
daughter, and

granted him half the royal honor.

The Lycians cut out for him a
beautiful estate,

rich in orchard and plowland, that
he might possess it.

“His wife bore three children to
brave Bellerophon: Isander,
Hippolochus, and

Laodameia. Zeus who counsels all lay
with Laodameia, and she bore

godlike Sarpedon,
armed in bronze. But when
Bellerophon became hated by all the
gods, he wandered
alone across the Aleian plain, eating
his heart and shunning the paths of
men.
Ares, insatiable in war, killed his son
Isander as he fought the glorious
Solymi;
Artemis of the golden reins, angered,
killed Laodameia. Hippolochus
fathered me,
and from him I say that I was born.
He sent me to Troy with many
commands: always
to be best and excel all others, never
to shame the blood of my fathers,
who were
the greatest in Ephyre and in broad
Lycia. Of this lineage and blood I
boast.”
Diomedes rejoiced when he heard
him, planted his spear in the earth,
and answered
the shepherd of the people with
gentle words: “Then you are an
ancient guest-friend
of my father’s house. Noble Oeneus
once entertained blameless
Bellerophon in his
halls for twenty days, and they
exchanged beautiful guest-gifts:
Oeneus gave a
bright purple belt, and Bellerophon a
golden, two-handled cup. I left that
cup at
home when I came here. I do not
remember Tydeus, for I was still a
child when the

Achaean perished at Thebes. So
now I am your guest-friend in Argos,
and you mine
in Lycia, if ever I come among that
people. Let us avoid each other’s
spears in the
crowd; there are Trojans and famous
allies enough for me to kill, whom
some god
may place in my path, and Achaeans
enough for you to kill, if you can. Let
us exchange
armor, so that these men may know
that we boast of being our fathers’
guest-friends.”
They spoke, leapt down from their
chariots, clasped one another’s
hands, and pledged
their faith. But Zeus, son of Cronus,
stole Glaucus’ understanding; he
exchanged
golden armor for bronze, the price of
a hundred cattle for the price of
nine.
Hector reached the Scaean gates and
the beech tree, and the wives and
daughters
of the Trojans ran around him,
asking after their children, brothers,
friends,
and husbands. He told them all to
pray to the gods, for sorrow had
fallen heavily
upon them. When he came to Priam’s
splendid house, built with polished
porticoes,
he found fifty chambers of hewn
stone, set close together, where the
king’s sons
slept beside their wedded wives; and
across the court stood twelve roofed

chambers
for his daughters and their husbands.
There his gentle mother met him,
bringing

Laodice, the fairest of her daughters.
She took his hand and called him by
name:

“My child, why have you left the
fierce battle? Are the hateful sons of
the Achaeans

pressing hard around the city, and
has your heart sent you here from the
wall's

edge to lift your hands to Zeus?

Wait, and I will bring you
honey-sweet wine,

that you may pour a libation first to
father Zeus and the other immortals,
and then

refresh yourself if you drink. Wine
gives great strength to a weary man,
and you

are weary from defending your
companions.”

Great-helmed Hector answered: “Do
not bring me honeyed wine, revered
mother,

lest you weaken my limbs and make
me forget my strength. I am ashamed
to pour

bright wine to Zeus with unwashed
hands, and it is not lawful to pray to
the dark-

clouded son of Cronus while stained
with blood and filth. Go instead to
Athena's

temple, gathering the old women of
the city. Take the robe that seems to
you the

most beautiful and largest in the
house, the one most dear to her, and

lay it upon

the knees of the fair-haired goddess.

Promise twelve yearling heifers,
never yet

broken to the goad, if she will pity
the city, the wives of Troy, and their
children,

and keep the fierce spear of Tydeus'
son from sacred Ilium. I will seek
Paris and

call him, if he will listen. Would that
the earth might open and swallow
him!

The Olympian has bred him as a
great plague to Troy, to Priam, and
to his sons;

if I saw him going down to Hades, I
think my spirit might forget its
grief.”

His mother went into the perfumed
chamber and called her attendants;
they gathered

the old women throughout the city.
Hecuba descended to the chamber
where lay the

embroidered robes made by
Sidonian women, whom godlike
Alexander had brought from

Sidon across the wide sea by the
same route on which he carried
Helen, high-born

daughter of Tyndareus. She lifted
one robe, most beautiful in its
pattern and the

largest of all, shining like a star, and
lying beneath the others. With it she
went,

and many aged women followed.

When they reached Athena's temple
on the city's height,

Theano, fair-cheeked daughter of
Cisseus and wife of horse-taming
Antenor, opened
the doors; the Trojans had made her
priestess of Athena. All raised their
hands with
the ritual cry. Theano took the robe
and laid it upon the knees of the
fair-haired
goddess, praying: "Lady Athena,
glorious among goddesses, break
Diomedes' spear,
and make him fall forward before the
Scaean gates. Then we will sacrifice
twelve
yearling heifers in your temple, if
you will pity the city, the wives of
Troy,
and their little children." So she
prayed, but Pallas Athena turned her
face away.
Hector went to the beautiful house
of Paris, built by the best craftsmen
of fertile Troy beside the houses of
Priam and Hector. He entered with
his
eleven-cubit spear in his hand, the
bronze point shining before him and
the golden socket running around it.
Paris was there, putting on his fine
armor, shield and breastplate, and
bending his curved bow; Argive
Helen sat
among her maidservants, directing
their famous work. Hector rebuked
him:
"Strange man, you nurse this anger in
your heart while the people perish
around the steep wall. For your sake
battle and war have kindled this city;

you yourself would fight another if
you saw him shrinking from the
hateful
war. Rise, before the enemy's fire
consumes the town."
Godlike Paris answered: "Hector, you
have rebuked me justly, and not
beyond
what is just. I did not sit here from
anger toward the Trojans, but
because
I wished to yield to grief. My wife
has urged me toward the battle with
gentle
words, and I too think it is better.
Wait a little; I will put on my armor,
or go ahead, and I will soon catch
you."
Hector did not answer him. Helen
spoke to Hector with gentle words:
"Brother of my husband, dog that I
am, full of hateful contrivance!
Would that
the storm had carried me away on
the day my mother bore me, to
mountain or
wave-beaten sea, before these deeds
were born. But since the gods have
appointed
these evils, would that I had been the
wife of a better man, one who knew
the
shame and many reproaches of men.
This man has no steady mind now,
nor will he
have one later; I think he will reap
what he has sown. Come in and sit
upon this
bench, my brother, since the labor
has weighed most heavily upon your
heart,

because of me, hateful as I am, and
because of Alexander's ruin. Zeus set
this

evil fate upon us, that we should be
sung as a song for generations yet to
come."

Great-helmed Hector answered: "Do
not ask me to sit, Helen, though you
love me;

you will not persuade me. My heart
already urges me to defend the
Trojans, who

long for me while I am gone. Stir this
man, and let him hurry, so that he
may

find me still within the city. I will go
home too, to see my wife and my
little

son; for I do not know whether I
shall return to them again, or
whether the gods

will bring me down beneath
Achaean hands."

He spoke and left. At once he
reached his well-inhabited house, but
did not find

Andromache in the hall. She had
gone with her child and a richly
dressed attendant

to the great tower, lamenting and
grieving. Hector stood at the
threshold and asked

the servants: "Tell me truly: where
has white-armed Andromache gone
from the house?

Has she gone to my sisters or my
brothers' well-robed wives, or to
Athena's temple,

where the other fair-haired Trojan
women seek to appease the dreadful
goddess?"

The busy housekeeper answered:

"Since you command me to tell the
truth, she has

gone neither to your sisters nor to
your brothers' wives, nor to Athena's
temple

where the women pray. She heard
that the Trojans were worn down
and that the

Achaean strength had grown great;
she hurried to the wall like a mad
woman,

and her nurse carried the child with
her."

Hector ran out of the house and back
through the well-built streets. As he
passed

the gates, where he was about to
cross into the plain, his richly gifted
wife

Andromache came running to meet
him, daughter of great-hearted
Eetion, who dwelt

beneath wooded Placus in Thebe of
Cilicia. She had been Hector's wife.
Her attendant

carried at her breast their little child,
beloved Astyanax, whom Hector
called

Scamandrius, while all others called
him Astyanax, "lord of the city," for
Hector

alone defended Ilium.

Hector smiled silently when he saw
the child. Andromache came close,
shedding tears,

took his hand, and called him: "Your
own strength will destroy you,
pitiless man;

you have no pity for your little child
or for me, soon to be your widow.

The Achaeans

will soon kill you, all rushing upon
you together. It would be better for
me, if I

lose you, to go beneath the earth; I
shall have no other comfort once you
meet your

fate, only sorrow. I have no father or
honored mother. Achilles killed my
father,

and sacked high-gated Thebe, the
well-inhabited city of Cilicia. He
killed Eetion,

but did not strip him, for he feared
to do that in his heart; he burned
him in his

beautiful armor and raised a mound
over him, and the mountain nymphs,
daughters of

aegis-bearing Zeus, planted elms
around it. I had seven brothers in the
house;

all went down to Hades on one day,
for swift-footed Achilles killed them
among

their shambling cattle and white
sheep. He carried away my mother,
who ruled beneath

wooded Placus, with the rest of the
spoil, then released her for a
measureless ransom;

but Artemis of the bow struck her
down in the house of my father.

“Hector, you are now my father,
honored mother, brother, and strong
husband. Come,

then, pity me and stay here upon the
tower; do not make your child an
orphan and your

wife a widow. Set the army beside
the fig tree, where the city is easiest

to climb

and the wall most open to attack.

Three times the best of them have
tried that place,

around both Ajaxes, glorious
Idomeneus, the Atrids, and the brave
son of Tydeus—

perhaps some prophet told them, or
perhaps their own courage drove
them on.”

Great-helmed Hector answered: “All
this lies within my heart, woman.

But I would be

deeply ashamed before the Trojans
and their trailing-robed wives if I
shrank from the

battle like a coward. My spirit does
not allow it; I have learned to be
brave and to

fight always among the first Trojans,
winning great glory for my father
and myself.

For I know this surely in my mind
and heart: the day will come when
sacred Ilium,

Priam, and the people of Priam,
strong in the spear, will all be
destroyed. But the

future grief of the Trojans, of
Hecuba herself, of lord Priam, and of
my many brave

brothers when they fall in the dust
beneath hostile men does not pain
me so much as

yours, when some bronze-clad
Achaean leads you away weeping,
taking your free day

from you. In Argos you will weave at
another woman's loom, or carry
water from

Messeis or Hypereia, unwilling, and harsh necessity will lie upon you.
Then someone
may see you in tears and say: 'There is the wife of Hector, who was best in battle
among the horse-taming Trojans when they fought around Ilium.' So he will speak,
and your grief will be new, lacking such a husband to ward off the day of slavery.
May the piled earth cover me dead before I hear your cry and see you dragged away."
When he had spoken, glorious Hector reached toward his child; but the boy turned
back toward the nurse's richly belted breast, crying, frightened by his dear father's
appearance and by the bronze and the horsehair crest nodding terribly from the top
of the helmet. His father and honored mother laughed. At once Hector took the helmet
from his head and set it shining upon the ground. He kissed his beloved son, rocked
him in his arms, and prayed to Zeus and the other gods:
"Zeus and all gods, grant that this child may become, as I am, eminent among the
Trojans, strong in courage, and rule Ilium by his might. May someone one day say,
'He is far better than his father,'
when he returns from battle carrying the bloody

armor of an enemy he has killed; and may his mother's heart rejoice."
He placed the child in his dear wife's arms. She received him into her fragrant
bosom, smiling through tears. Her husband pitied her, stroked her with his hand,
and called her by name: "Dear one, do not grieve so deeply. No man can send me to
Hades before my appointed portion; and no man, coward or brave, has ever escaped
his fate once he was born. Go home, and tend to your own work, the loom and distaff,
and command your attendants to keep at their labor. War shall be the concern of all
the men born in Ilium, but most of all of me."
He spoke and lifted the horsehair helmet. His wife went home, turning often to look
back and shedding tears; the attendants raised a common lament, believing Hector
would not return from battle. Paris did not linger in his high house.
Once he had
put on his shining armor, he hurried through the city, bright as a well-fed horse
that breaks its tether and runs proudly to the river. He soon found his noble brother
as Hector was turning away from the place where he had spoken with his wife.

“Brother,” Paris said, “I have detained
you by waiting, and have not come as
quickly
as you commanded.” Hector
answered: “No decent man could
despise your work in battle,
for you are strong; but you hold back
by choice, and my heart aches when I
hear the
shame the Trojans endure because of
you. Come. We shall make amends, if
Zeus ever
grants us to raise a mixing bowl in
the halls of heaven after victory.”

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 7

First-pass working translation

Hector sprang from the gates, and
Alexander followed him, both eager
to fight. As when a god gives wind to
sailors who have labored across
the sea, their limbs worn out with
toil, so the two appeared to the
Trojans,
longing for battle. They killed
Menesthius, son of the club-bearing
king
Areithous, and Hector struck
Eioneaus beneath the bronze rim of
his helmet,
loosening his knees. Glaucus, son of
Hippolochus and leader of the
Lycians,
hit Iphinous, son of Dexias, as he
leapt upon his swift horses, and
brought
him down with his shoulder pierced.
Gray-eyed Athena saw the Argives
falling in the hard battle and rushed
down
from Olympus toward sacred Ilium.
Apollo, watching from Pergamus
and wishing
victory for the Trojans, rose to meet
her beside the beech tree. Apollo
spoke:
“Why have you come in such
eagerness from Olympus, daughter of
great Zeus?
Do you mean to give the Danaans a
victory that turns the battle? You do
not

pity the Trojans as they perish. If you
would listen, it would be far better:
let us stop the war and slaughter for
today; afterward they may fight
again
until they find the appointed end of
Ilium, since it is dear to both of us
to destroy this city.”
Athena answered: “Let it be so,
Far-shooter. I too came from
Olympus with
that purpose, between the Trojans
and Achaeans. But tell me how you
mean
to end the fighting.”
Apollo said: “Let us rouse Hector’s
strong heart, that he may challenge
one
of the Danaans to stand alone against
him in the hateful battle. Then the
bronze-greaved Achaeans, angered,
will send one champion against
godlike Hector.”
Athena agreed. Helenus, Priam’s
beloved son, understood the counsel
that
pleased the gods, came to Hector,
and said: “Hector, son of Priam,
equal to
Zeus in counsel, will you listen to
me, your brother? Make all the
Trojans
and Achaeans sit, and call one of the
Danaans, the best he can be, to fight
you face to face. You are not yet
fated to die; so I heard the voice of
the
ever-living gods.”
Hector rejoiced at the word. He
went into the midst of the Trojan
ranks,

grasped his spear at its center, and
halted the whole line. Agamemnon
seated
the well-greaved Achaeans; Athena
and silver-bowed Apollo sat like
vultures
upon the high beech of aegis-bearing
Zeus, delighting in the men below.
The ranks sat close in the plain,
bristling with shields, helmets, and
spears,
like the ripples that Zephyr pours
newly over the sea, darkening the
water.
Hector spoke between the two
armies: "Hear me, Trojans and
well-greaved Achaeans,
while I say what my heart
commands. High-seated Zeus has not
made our oaths
come to fulfillment; instead he
devises evil for both sides, until
either you
take well-walled Troy, or you
yourselves are overcome beside the
sea-going ships.
Among you are the best of all the
Pan-Achaeans. Let whichever man's
heart urges
him to fight Hector come here and
stand before me.
"I speak this, and let Zeus be our
witness. If he kills me with the
long-edged
bronze, let him strip my armor and
carry it to the hollow ships; but let him
return my body, so that the Trojans
and their wives may give me the
portion of

fire after death. If I kill him, and
Apollo gives me glory, I will strip his
armor,
carry it to sacred Ilium, and hang it
in the temple of far-shooting Apollo;
but
I will give his body back to the
well-benched ships, that the
long-haired Achaeans
may bury him and raise his mound
beside the broad Hellespont. Then
some man of
the generations yet to come, sailing
the wine-dark sea in a many-oared
ship,
will say: 'This is the grave of a man
who died long ago, whom glorious
Hector
killed when he excelled in battle.' So
men will speak, and my fame shall
never die."
All fell silent. They were ashamed to
refuse, yet afraid to accept the
challenge.
At last Menelaus rose and rebuked
them: "Ah me, Achaean women, no
longer Achaeans!
This will be a shame beyond measure
if no Danaan now goes against
Hector. May you
all become water and earth, sitting
here without spirit or glory; I myself
will arm
against him, though the ends of
victory lie with the immortal gods."
He began to put on his beautiful
armor, but then his brother
Agamemnon seized him
by the right hand and said: "You are
mad, Menelaus, beloved of Zeus.
Rise, though

you grieve, and do not choose to
fight Hector, the son of Priam, a
better man whom
others hate. Even Achilles feared to
meet him in the man-making battle,
though he
is far stronger than you. Sit now
among your companions; the
Achaean will raise
another champion. However fearless
and tireless he is, I say that his knee
will bend
gladly if he escapes the enemy and
the terrible fighting.”
His brother persuaded him with
words that were just, and willing
attendants removed
the armor from his shoulders. Then
Nestor rose and cried: “What grief
has come upon
the Achaean land! Old horseman
Peleus, counselor and speaker of the
Myrmidons, would
groan if he heard that all the best
Argives now shrink beneath Hector.
I wish I were
young again, as when the Pylians and
spear-famed Arcadians gathered
beside the walls
of Phea and I fought godlike
Ereuthalion, wearing the armor of
King Areithous, whom
men and women called the
Club-bearer because he broke the
ranks with an iron club,
not with bow or long spear. Lycurgus
killed him by ambush in a narrow
road, striking
him through before the club could
help him, then stripped the armor
which brazen Ares

had given him. In his old age
Lycurgus gave it to his beloved
servant Ereuthalion,
who challenged every champion
while wearing it. All trembled and
refused, but my own
heart urged me to fight; I was the
youngest of them all, and Athena
gave me glory.
I killed that great and strongest man,
and his huge body lay stretched in
the dust.
If only I were young again, and my
strength were still firm, Hector
would soon find
an opponent. Yet not one of you, the
best of the Pan-Achaean, comes
willingly against him.”
The old man’s rebuke made all nine
rise: first Agamemnon, then strong
Diomedes,
the two Ajaxes in their warlike
strength, Idomeneus and his
companion Meriones,
Eurypylus, son of Euaemon, Thoas
son of Andraemon, and godlike
Odysseus. All wished
to fight Hector. Nestor told them to
cast lots straight through a helmet,
for the
chosen man would benefit the
well-greaved Achaeans and himself,
if he escaped the
enemy and the dreadful battle. Each
marked his lot and dropped it into
Agamemnon’s
helmet. The army prayed, lifting
their hands to heaven: “Father Zeus,
let Ajax, or
the son of Tydeus, or the king of
gold-rich Mycenae draw the lot.”

Nestor shook the helmet, and out
sprang the lot they wanted: Ajax's.
The herald carried
it through the crowd and showed it
from right to left to each champion,
but none knew
it. When he came to Ajax, who had
marked and placed it in the helmet,
Ajax stretched
out his hand and recognized the sign.
He threw the lot at his feet and said:
"Friends,
the lot is mine; my heart rejoices, for
I think I shall overcome godlike
Hector. Bring
me my warlike armor while you pray
to Zeus, son of Cronus—silently, so
the Trojans do
not hear, or openly, for I fear no
man. No one shall drive me
unwillingly from the fight
by strength or skill; I do not think I
was born and raised so helplessly in
Salamis."
Ajax armed himself in flashing
bronze. When he had clothed his
body in every
piece, he sprang forward like
enormous Ares going to war among
men whom the son
of Cronus has joined in a devouring
quarrel. So Ajax rose, the giant
rampart of
the Achaeans, smiling with a terrible
face, taking long strides and shaking
his
long-shadowed spear. The Argives
rejoiced to see him; dread seized
every Trojan,
and Hector's own heart beat hard.
Yet he could neither draw back nor

hide among
his people, for he himself had called
the champion forth.
Ajax came near carrying a shield like
a tower, bronze-faced and sevenfold
in hide,
which Tychius, best of
leather-workers, had made for him in
Hyle. Seven hides of
well-fed bulls were sewn together,
and over them he had hammered an
eighth layer
of bronze. Telamonian Ajax held it
before his chest and stood close to
Hector:
"Hector, you shall learn plainly,
standing alone, what champions the
Danaans have,
and that there are many such even
after Achilles, the lion-hearted
breaker of ranks.
He lies beside the curved ships in
anger against Agamemnon, shepherd
of the people;
but we are here, many enough to
meet you. Begin the battle and war."
Great-helmed Hector answered: "Do
not test me, son of Telamon, as
though I were
a helpless child or a woman who
knows nothing of war. I know how
to fight and kill;
I know how to wield the hide shield
to right and left, and how to leap
into the
tumult of swift horses. I know how
to dance in the close battle of
dreadful Ares.
Yet I will not strike you secretly
while watching my chance; I will
strike openly,

if I can.”

He balanced his long-shadowed
spear and hurled it. It struck the
terrible sevenfold
shield at its highest bronze layer, the
eighth surface, and the tireless metal
cut
through six hides before the seventh
held it. Ajax then threw his
long-shadowed spear
and struck Priam’s son on his
perfectly round shield. The mighty
point passed through
the bright shield and lodged in the
richly wrought breastplate, tearing
the tunic
beside his flank; Hector bent aside
and avoided black death. Both drew
out their
long spears and fell upon one
another like lions that eat raw flesh,
or boars whose
strength is not easily broken.
Hector stabbed the center of Ajax’s
shield, but the bronze bent at the
point and did
not break through. Ajax leapt and
thrust; his spear passed across the
shield, drove
Hector backward, cut his neck, and
black blood spurted. Yet Hector did
not stop.
He drew back and seized a great
rough black stone that lay in the
plain, and hurled
it at the terrible shield’s central boss;
the bronze rang around it. Ajax
raised a
still larger stone, whirled it, and
drove it against Hector’s shield. The
millstone-

shaped rock broke the shield inward
and wounded Hector’s knees; he lay
stretched
backward, pinned beneath it. But
Apollo quickly raised him. They
would have fought
at close quarters with swords, had
not the heralds, messengers of Zeus
and of men,
come between them.

At last Idaeus for the Trojans and
Talthybius for the bronze-clad
Achaean came
between them, both wise heralds,
and held their staffs between the
champions.

Idaeus spoke: “Do not fight any
longer, dear sons; do not make war.
Zeus who
gathers the clouds loves you both,
and both are spearmen—we all know
that. Night
has already come; it is good to obey
the night.”

Telamonian Ajax answered: “Idaeus,
tell Hector to say this. He himself
called
all our champions forth. Let him
begin, and I will gladly obey
whatever he says.”

Hector replied: “Ajax, since the god
has given you great size, strength,
and wisdom,
and you are the best of the Achaeans
with the spear, let us now stop the
battle
and slaughter for today. Later we
shall fight again until the god
separates us and
gives victory to another. Night has
come; it is good to obey the night. So

you may
make all your friends rejoice beside
the ships, above all your companions
and dear
comrades; and I will gladden the
Trojans and their trailing-robed
wives in Priam's
great city, who will enter the sacred
contest and pray for my return.
Come, then,
let us give one another famous gifts,
so that Achaeans and Trojans may
say: 'They
fought in the spirit of consuming
strife, yet parted after joining in
friendship.'"
Hector gave Ajax a silver-studded
sword with its sheath and a finely cut
baldric;
Ajax gave Hector his bright purple
war-belt. They parted, one going
among the
Achaean people and the other into
the Trojan tumult. The Trojans
rejoiced when
they saw Hector alive and whole,
escaped from Ajax's strength and
unwearied hands;
they led him toward the city, no
longer expecting to see him safe. The
well-greaved
Achaeans brought Ajax, exultant in
victory, to the noble Agamemnon.
The Achaeans gathered in
Agamemnon's hut, and the lord of
men sacrificed
a five-year-old bull to mighty Zeus.
They flayed it, divided it, cut it into
pieces, roasted it carefully, and laid
out the meal. When their hunger and
thirst

were satisfied, Agamemnon honored
Ajax with the long back portions.
Then Nestor,
whose counsel had always been best,
began to weave his plan:
"Atrid and all you champions of the
Pan-Achaeans, many long-haired
Achaeans
have died; sharp Ares has scattered
their dark blood around the flowing
Scamander,
and their spirits have gone down to
Hades. At dawn stop the battle. Let
us gather
the dead here with oxen and mules,
burn them a little before the ships, so
that each
man may carry his bones home when
we return to his fatherland. Let us
raise one mound
around a common pyre, bringing the
bodies in from the plain, and quickly
build high
towers beside it as a defense for the
ships and ourselves. Let us make
doors fitted
within them, that chariots may pass
through, and outside dig a deep
trench to hold
back horses and men, lest the war of
the proud Trojans press upon us."
All the kings praised his counsel. In
high Ilium, meanwhile, the Trojans
gathered
in a rough assembly before Priam's
doors. Wise Antenor spoke first:
"Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and
allies. Let us give Helen of Argos,
and the
possessions she brought, to the sons
of Atreus. We have broken our

faithful oaths
and fight for nothing; I do not expect
a good end unless we do this.”
He sat down. Godlike Alexander,
husband of fair-haired Helen, rose
and answered:
“Antenor, your words are no longer
pleasing to me; you could have
devised a better
speech. If you truly speak this in
earnest, the gods themselves have
destroyed your
mind. I will declare my answer to the
horse-taming Trojans: I will not give
back the
woman, but all the possessions I
brought from Argos I will give, and I
will add other
treasures from my own house.”
He sat down, and Priam, son of
Dardanus, equal to the gods in
counsel, rose and told
the Trojans: “Take your supper
through the city as before, remember
the watch, and
stay awake, each man. At dawn let
Idaeus go to the hollow ships and tell
the Atrids,
Agamemnon and Menelaus,
Alexander’s answer—the cause of our
strife. Let him also ask
whether they will cease from the
harsh war until we have burned the
dead. Later we
shall fight again, until the god
separates us and gives victory to
others.”
The Trojans listened and obeyed.
Idaeus went at dawn to the Achaean
ships and found

the sons of Atreus in council.
Standing among them, he declared
Alexander’s offer:
“He will not return Helen, but he
will return all the possessions he
brought from
Argos and add more from his own
house, if the sons of Atreus will
accept them.”
All sat silent, until Agamemnon
answered: “No; we will not accept
the possessions,
nor will we accept Helen. The
Trojans have suffered enough already
to understand
that their ruin is near.”
The Trojans took their supper
through the army, and at dawn
Idaeus went to the
hollow ships. He found the Danaans
assembled beside Agamemnon’s
stern and stood
among them to deliver the proposal:
“Atrid and other champions of the
Pan-Achaeans,
Priam and the noble Trojans have
ordered me to say, if it is pleasing to
you, what
Alexander offers, for whose sake the
quarrel arose. He will give back all
the goods
he brought to Troy in the hollow
ships—and add other possessions
from his own house;
but he will not return Menelaus’
wedded wife, though the Trojans
urge him. They also
ask whether you will cease the harsh
war until we have burned the dead;
afterward

we shall fight again until the god
separates us and gives victory to
others.”

All were silent. At last Diomedes,
breaker of horses, spoke: “Let no one
accept

Alexander’s possessions or Helen;
even a child can see that the end of
destruction

already hangs over the Trojans.” All
the Achaeans shouted approval.

Agamemnon turned
to Idaeus: “You hear the answer of
the Achaeans yourself. I also approve
it. We do

not refuse to burn the dead; no one
should spare the bodies once life is
gone. Let

Zeus, the loud-thundering husband
of Hera, witness our oaths.” He lifted
his staff

to all the gods, and Idaeus returned
to sacred Ilium.

The Trojans and Dardanians sat
gathered in assembly, waiting for
Idaeus. He came

and told them the answer. At once
both sides armed: some went to
bring in the dead,

others went for wood. The sun had
only just touched the fields, rising
from deep-

flowing Ocean, when the armies met.

It was hard to recognize each man;
washing away

the blood with water, they lifted the
dead upon the wagons, shedding hot
tears.

Great Priam forbade the Trojans to
weep: silently, hearts grieving, they
carried

their dead to the pyre, burned them,
and returned to sacred Ilium. In the
same way

the well-greaved Achaeans carried
their dead, burned them, and went
back to the

hollow ships.

Before dawn, while the night was
still dim, the Achaeans gathered
around the pyre.

They raised one mound from the
bodies brought in from the plain,
built a wall beside

it with high towers as a defense for
the ships and themselves, made
well-fitted gates

for the chariot road, and dug a
broad, deep trench outside, setting
stakes within it.

The long-haired Achaeans labored at
the work. The gods, seated beside
Zeus who

delights in lightning, watched the
great work of the bronze-clad men.
Earth-shaking

Poseidon began to speak:

“Father Zeus, is there still a mortal
who will tell the gods his mind and
counsel?

Do you not see how the long-haired
Achaeans have built a wall over their
ships and

dug a trench around it, giving no
famous hecatombs to the gods? Its
fame will spread

as far as the dawn, while men will
forget the wall that Phoebus Apollo
and I built

with labor for Laomedon.”

Zeus, deeply angered, answered:

“What a thought you have spoken,

wide-strength Earth-
shaker! Some other god, far weaker
than you in hands and strength,
might fear it;
but your fame will spread as far as
the dawn. When the long-haired
Achaeans depart
with their ships for their dear
fatherland, tear down the wall and
pour it all into
the sea; cover the broad shore again
with sand, so that the Achaeans'
great wall
may be wholly forgotten.”
Thus they spoke. The sun set, and
the Achaeans' work was finished.
They sacrificed
oxen among the huts and took their
supper. Many ships came from
Lemnos bringing wine,
sent by Euneus, son of Jason and
Hypsipyle. For Agamemnon and
Menelaus alone he sent
a thousand measures of wine. The
long-haired Achaeans bought it,
some with bronze,
some with shining iron, some with
hides, some with whole cattle, and
some with slaves;
they laid out a rich feast. All night
the Achaeans feasted, while the
Trojans and
their allies sat through the city. All
night Zeus, the counselor, devised
evil for
them, thundering terribly; green fear
seized them, and they poured wine
from their
cups upon the ground, unwilling to
drink before they had poured a
libation to mighty

Cronus' son. Then they slept and
received the gift of sleep.

Source range: Book 7. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 8

First-pass working translation

Dawn spread her saffron robe across
the earth, and Zeus, delighting in
thunder,
called the gods to council on the
highest peak of many-ridged
Olympus. He spoke,
and all the gods listened: "Hear me,
every god and goddess, while I say
what my
heart commands. Let no female or
male god attempt to break my word;
all together
approve it, that I may bring this
work to its swift end. If I see any one
of you
going apart from the others to aid
either Trojans or Danaans, he shall
return to
Olympus beaten and dishonored, or I
will seize him and throw him into
misty Tartarus,
far down, where the iron gates and
brazen threshold lie as far beneath
Hades as
heaven is above the earth. Then you
will learn how much I am the
strongest of all.
"Come, test it, gods, so that you may
all know. Hang a golden chain from
heaven,
and take hold of it, every god and
goddess together; you could not drag
highest
Zeus from heaven to earth, though
you labored greatly. But if I wished
to pull,

I could draw you up with the earth
and the sea, bind the chain around
the ridge
of Olympus, and leave all things
suspended. So far do I stand above
gods and men."
He spoke, and all sat silent,
astonished by the force of his word.
At last gray-eyed
Athena said: "Our father, son of
Cronus, you know that your strength
cannot be
opposed. Yet we pity the
spear-bearing Danaans, who will
perish in an evil fate.
We will keep away from the war as
you command, but we will give the
Argives counsel
that may help them, lest they all
perish beneath your anger."
Cloud-gathering Zeus smiled and
answered: "Take courage,
Tritogeneia, dear child;
I do not speak in anger, but wish to
be gentle with you." He harnessed his
bronze-
hoofed horses with their golden
manes, clothed his body in gold,
seized the golden
whip, and mounted the chariot. The
willing horses flew between earth
and the
starry heaven. He reached Ida, rich in
springs, mother of wild beasts, and
Gargarus,
where he had a sacred grove, altar,
and incense. There the father of gods
and men
unharnessed the horses, hid them in
deep mist, and sat upon the peak in
his glory,

looking toward the city of Troy and
the Achaean ships.

The long-haired Achaeans took their
meal quickly among the huts and
armed themselves;

the Trojans armed throughout the
city, fewer than before, yet
determined by necessity

to fight before their children and
wives. All the gates opened, and
footmen and

horsemen rushed out amid a great
uproar. When they met in one place,
hide struck hide,

spear struck spear, and the courage
of bronze-clad men collided. The
bossed shields

crashed together; cries rose from
those who killed and those who died,
and the earth

ran with blood.

As the sacred day grew, missiles
struck both sides and men fell. When
the sun stood

at mid-heaven, Zeus stretched out
his golden scales and set in them the
two fates

of death, one for the horse-taming
Trojans and one for the bronze-clad
Achaeans.

He lifted the balance at its middle:
the Achaeans' day sank toward the
earth,

while the Trojan fate rose toward the
broad heaven. Zeus thundered
terribly from

Ida and cast a blazing flash among
the Achaeans; they were seized by
green fear.

Neither Idomeneus nor
Agamemnon, nor either Ajax, dared

remain; only Nestor stayed,
not willingly, for an arrow shot by
Paris, husband of fair-haired Helen,
struck his

horse at the top of its head where the
first mane grows, the most
vulnerable place.

The horse sprang in pain; the shaft
entered its brain, and it tangled the
others

in the bronze. While the old man cut
the traces with his sword, Hector's
swift

horses came through the uproar
carrying their driver, and the old
man would have

lost his life had Diomedes not seen
him. Diomedes cried to Odysseus:

"Son of Laertes, where do you flee,
turning your back like a coward?

Beware lest a spear be planted in
your fleeing back; stand here with
me,

That we may drive this savage man
away from the old king."

But Odysseus did not hear; he ran
toward the hollow ships.

Then Diomedes himself joined the
foremost fighters, stood before
Nestor's horses,

And called: "Old man, the young
warriors wear you down; your
strength is gone,

And age has come upon you. Your
servant is weak, and your horses
slow.

Come, mount my chariot, and see
what Trojan horses can do—

How swiftly they pursue and flee
across the plain. I took them from
Aeneas.

Let my servants tend to yours; we
two will drive against the
horse-tamers,
And learn whether Hector will meet
us.”

Hector urged the Trojans: “Fools,
who devised this wall, weak and
useless!

It will not hold back my strength;
our horses will easily leap the trench.
When I reach the hollow ships,
remember the fire: I will burn them
and kill

the Argives beside them, choking in
the smoke.” He called to his
horses—Xanthus,
Podargus, Aethon, and divine
Lampus—and told them to repay the
rich fodder and

wine Andromache, daughter of
Eetion, had given them in former
days. If they drove
swiftly, he said, they might seize
Nestor’s shield, all gold in its hoops
and boss,
and Diomedes’ wrought breastplate,
made by Hephaestus; then the
Achaean might board
their ships that very night.

Hera shook her throne in anger and
said to Poseidon: “Earth-shaker, do
you feel no

pity for the dying Danaans, who
carry many beautiful gifts to Helice
and Aegae? If

we who aid the Argives wished, we
could drive back the Trojans and
hold off Zeus.”

Poseidon answered: “Bold Hera, what
word is this? I would not fight Zeus,
who is far

stronger than all of us.”

Hector’s men and horses filled the
space between the ships and the
trench, penned

in by the deep cut ground. Hector,
favored by Zeus, would have set fire
to the ships,

but Hera put a new thought into
Agamemnon’s mind. He took a great
purple cloak,

went through the huts and ships, and
stood upon Odysseus’ black ship,
midway between

the tents of Ajax and Achilles. With
his voice carrying both ways he cried:
“Shame, Argives, beautiful in form
but evil in reproach! Where are your
boasts,

when on Lemnos you claimed that
each man could face a hundred or
two hundred

Trojans? Now we are not worth even
one Hector, who will soon burn the
ships.

Father Zeus, have you blinded some
great king, robbing him of honor? I
never passed

your beautiful altar with a
many-oared ship without burning
the fat and thighs of

oxen, eager to destroy well-walled
Troy. Grant me at least this prayer:
let the

Argives escape and not perish,
though you allow the Trojans to
overcome them.”

The father pitied him, shedding a
tear, and nodded that the people
should live and

not be destroyed. At once he sent the
most perfect of flying birds, an eagle

carrying
a fawn in its talons. He dropped it
beside Zeus' beautiful altar where the
Achaean
made sacrifice. When they saw the
bird from Zeus, they leapt more
fiercely against
the Trojans and remembered their
courage.
No one among the many Danaans
dared drive his horses from the
trench and fight before
Diomedes. He was first to kill a
helmeted Trojan, Agelaus son of
Phradmon, striking
him between the shoulders as he
turned his horses; the spear passed
through his chest,
and his armor rang as he fell.
Agamemnon and Menelaus followed,
then the two Ajaxes,
Idomeneus and Meriones, Eurypylus,
and Teucer ninth, drawing his
recurved bow.
Ajax carried his shield before him;
each time Teucer shot and felled a
man, he slipped
back beneath it like a child beneath
its mother. Teucer first killed
Orsilochus,
Ormenus, Opheltes, Daitor,
Chromius, Lycophontes, Amopaon,
and Melanippus.
Agamemnon rejoiced and called:
"Teucer, beloved head, son of
Telamon, lord of the
people, shoot so that you become a
light to the Danaans and to your
father who raised
you from childhood, though you
were born outside the marriage bed.

Give him fame
though he is far away; I tell you how
it shall be fulfilled."
Teucer answered: "Most glorious
Atreid, why urge me when I am
already eager? Since we
drove them back toward Ilium I have
not stopped, but have killed eight
men with my
long-tongued arrows. Yet I cannot
strike this rabid dog." He sent
another shaft at
Hector, but Apollo turned it aside; it
struck Archeptolemus, Hector's
brave charioteer,
in the chest beside the breast. He fell
from the car, and his horses sprang
away.
Hector grieved terribly for his
companion, yet left him lying and
told his brother
Kebriones to take the reins. Then
Hector leapt from the chariot with a
dreadful cry,
seized a jagged stone, and rushed
upon Teucer.
Teucer drew a bitter arrow and bent
the bow, but as he pulled it beside
the shoulder,
where the collarbone guards the
neck, Hector struck him with the
stone. The cord broke,
his hand went numb, and he fell
upon his knees; the bow dropped
from him. Ajax did not
forget his brother: he ran around him
and covered him with the bright
shield, while
two faithful companions, Mecisteus
and Alastor, lifted the groaning man
and carried

him to the hollow ships.
The Olympian roused the Trojans
again. They drove the Achaeans
straight toward the
deep trench, and Hector went first,
eyes blazing like Gorgon's and
murderous Ares.
As a hound pursues a boar or lion
from behind, darting at its hips and
turning aside
from its jaws, so Hector followed the
long-haired Achaeans, killing the last
man in
the line. They crossed the stakes and
trench in flight; many Trojans also
fell beneath
their hands, while the Achaeans held
by the ships, calling to one another
and lifting
their hands to every god.
Hera pitied the Danaans and said to
Athena: "Daughter of aegis-bearing
Zeus,
shall we no longer care for the dying
Argives, who will perish by one
man's assault,
while Hector, son of Priam, rages
beyond endurance?" Athena
answered: "Would that
he might lose his strength beneath
Argive hands and die in his own
land! But my
father's mind is mad and cruel,
always opposing my will. He
remembers nothing of
how often I saved his son Heracles
from Eurystheus' labors. If I had
known this day
when he sent Heracles to fetch the
hound from Hades, he would never
have escaped

the steep waters of Styx. Now he
hates me, but has fulfilled Thetis'
prayer, who
kissed his knees and clasped his
beard to honor city-sacking Achilles.
There will
be a day when he calls his gray-eyed
daughter dear again. Harness the
horses; I
will arm in Zeus' house and see
whether Hector rejoices when we
appear in the fight,
or whether his flesh feeds dogs and
birds beside the Achaean ships."
Hera harnessed her golden-maned
horses, while Athena cast her
embroidered robe at
her father's feet, clothed herself in
Zeus' battle-tunic, and took the great
spear
with which she breaks the ranks of
heroes. Hera urged the team on. The
gates of
heaven opened of themselves, gates
held by the Hours, who open and
close the dense
cloud over Olympus; through them
the goddesses drove. But Zeus saw
them from Ida
and was fiercely angry. He sent
golden-winged Iris with a message:
"Go quickly and
turn them back. Do not let them
come against the battle. I will lame
their swift
horses beneath the chariot, throw
them from the car, and break their
chariot; even
after ten years their wounds would
not heal if struck by my lightning.
Then Athena

will learn what it means to fight her father. I am less angry with Hera, for she always contradicts whatever I say.” Iris met them at Olympus and said: “Where are you hastening? The son of Cronus does not permit you to aid the Argives. He threatens to lame your horses, throw you from the car, and strike your chariot; even ten years would not heal the wounds. He says he is less angry with Hera, but calls you, Athena, a shameless dog if you dare raise your mighty spear against Zeus.” Hera answered: “Daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, I will no longer let us fight the father for mortal men. Let one die and another live, whoever happens to meet his fate; let Zeus judge Trojans and Danaans according to his own heart.” She turned the horses back. The Hours unhitched them, tied them beneath ambrosial mists, and leaned the chariot against the shining wall. Hera and Athena sat upon golden chairs among the other gods, hearts wounded. Zeus drove from Ida to Olympus, where Earth-shaker Poseidon unharnessed his horses and placed the chariot beside the altar. Zeus sat on his golden throne, and Olympus

shook beneath his feet. He saw Hera and Athena sitting apart and spoke: “Why are you so grieved? You did not tire of destroying Trojans in the man-making battle. Such is my strength and my unconquered hands that all the gods on Olympus could not turn me. Yet your limbs trembled before you saw war and its terrible work. If I had struck your horses with lightning, you would not have returned to Olympus for ten circling years.” The goddesses muttered together, devising evil for Troy. Athena sat silent, angry with her father; Hera could not contain her resentment: “Most terrible son of Cronus, we know your strength is not weak. Yet we pity the spear-bearing Danaans, who will perish in an evil fate. We will keep away from the war, if you command, but we will give the Argives counsel, lest they all perish beneath your anger.” Zeus answered: “Tomorrow you will see the mighty Cronus’ son destroy many Argives, if you wish, for strong Hector will not cease from war until swift-footed Peleus’ son rises beside the ships on the day the Achaeans fight around Patroclus’ body. So fate has

ordained it. I do not care for your anger, even if you reach the furthest boundaries

of earth and sea, where Iapetus and Cronus sit in Tartarus without the sun's light."

The sun's bright light sank into Ocean and drew black night across the grain-giving earth. The Trojans, unwilling, lost the day; but the Achaeans welcomed the triple-

prayed-for darkness. Hector called the Trojan assembly apart from the ships, beside

the swirling river, where the ground was clear of corpses. They climbed down from

their horses and listened as Hector leaned upon his eleven-cubit spear, its bronze

point shining and its golden socket running around it:

"Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and allies. I thought that before night fell we would

destroy the ships and return to windy Ilium, but darkness came and saved the Argives

and their ships beside the sea. Let us obey the black night. Prepare supper; loose

the fair-haired horses and set fodder before them. Bring cattle and fat sheep from

the city, and buy honey-sweet wine and bread from the houses; gather much wood, so

that all night until early dawn we may burn many fires whose light reaches heaven,

lest the long-haired Achaeans attempt flight across the broad sea in darkness.

"Let them not board their ships without a struggle. Let each carry home a wound,

struck by arrow or sharp spear as he leaps aboard, so that every man may dread to

bring tearful Ares against horse-taming Troy. Heralds should announce through the

city that boys at the edge of manhood and gray-haired elders gather upon the towers

built by the gods; let every woman kindle a great fire in her house, and let a firm

watch stand, lest an ambush enter while the people are away. Let this speech stand

sound for now; at dawn I will address the Trojans again. I hope, praying to Zeus and

the other gods, to drive from here those dogs carried by the fates, driven to our

ships. Tonight we guard ourselves; at first light we arm and wake sharp Ares beside

the hollow ships. Tomorrow I shall learn whether strong Diomedes will drive me from

the ships to the wall, or whether I will kill him with bronze and carry away his

bloody armor. If only I were immortal and ageless, and honored as Athena and Apollo

are honored, as this day has brought evil to the Argives!"

The Trojans shouted in answer. They
loosed the sweating horses, tied them
beside
their chariots, and brought cattle,
sheep, wine, bread, and wood swiftly
from the
city. They made perfect hecatombs
to the immortals, but the winds
carried the sweet
smoke from the plain toward heaven;
the blessed gods would not share it,
for sacred
Ilium, Priam, and Priam's strong
people were hateful to them. The
Trojans, confident
in the war, sat all night beside their
many fires. As stars appear around
the bright
moon when the sky is windless, and
every peak, ridge, and hollow lies
visible beneath
the opened heaven, so the fires of the
Trojans shone between the ships and
the streams
of Xanthus. A thousand fires burned
upon the plain, and beside each sat
fifty men in
the firelight. Their horses cropped
white barley and spelt beside the
chariots,
waiting for the bright-throned dawn.

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional
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BOOK 9

First-pass working translation

The Trojans kept watch, but the Achaeans were held by a terrible companion,
chill fear, and every champion lay beneath unbearable grief. As Boreas and Zephyr suddenly stir the fish-filled sea, raising black waves and scattering seaweed along the shore, so the Achaeans' hearts were torn within them. Agamemnon, pierced by great sorrow, called the leaders quietly to assembly and stood weeping like a dark-water spring pouring down a sheer rock:
"Friends, Zeus, son of Cronus, has bound me in ruinous delusion. Once he promised that we would sack well-walled Ilium and return; now he devises a hateful deception and commands me to go dishonored to Argos, having lost so many men. Come, let us obey my word: let us flee with our ships to our dear fatherland. We shall not take broad-streeted Troy."
Diomedes rose: "Atrid, I will oppose you in your folly, as is lawful in assembly.
You once reproached my courage before the Danaans, but the young and old Argives

know that this was false. Zeus gave you a scepter, honoring you above all, but did not give you the greatest strength. If your heart urges you to go, go: the road is open, and your many ships stand near the sea. Others of us will remain until we have sacked Troy. Sthenelus and I will fight until we find the end of Ilium, for we came here with a god." The Achaeans shouted approval.
Nestor rose: "Son of Tydeus, you are strong in war and best of your peers in counsel; no Achaean will find fault with your speech, but you have not reached its end. You are young enough to be my youngest son, yet you speak wisely to kings. Let us obey the black night, prepare supper, and set guards beside the dug trench. Then, Agamemnon, feast the elders; your huts are full of wine, and men will hear the counsel of whoever offers the best plan. Our enemies burn many fires near the ships; who could be glad? This night will either shatter the army or save it."
The kings obeyed. Agamemnon answered: "Old man, you have not lied in naming my error. I was blinded, and I do not deny it. I will appease Achilles with measureless ransom:

seven tripods, ten talents of gold,
twenty shining cauldrons, twelve
prize-winning
horses, and seven skilled Lesbian
women, with Briseis among them. I
will swear that
I never entered her bed. These shall
be ready at once. If we sack Priam's
city,
Achilles may load his ship with gold
and bronze, choose twenty Trojan
women next to
Helen in beauty, and take one of my
three daughters to Peleus' house
without bride-
price. I will give him seven cities near
the sea, whose people will honor him
like
a god. Let him submit; Hades is
pitiless and unconquerable."
Nestor, the Gerenian horseman,
answered: "Most glorious son of
Atreus,
lord of men, Agamemnon, the gifts
are no longer hidden from Achilles.
Come, let us summon the men who
will go swiftly to the son of Peleus.
Let Phoenix lead them, dear to Zeus;
then great Ajax and shining
Odysseus.
Let the heralds Odios and Eurybates
go with them. Bring water for their
hands,
and command a holy silence, so that
we may pray to Zeus, son of Cronus,
if perhaps he will pity us." Everyone
approved his word.
At once the heralds poured water
over their hands. The young men
crowned the

mixing bowls with wine and served
the cups, beginning with the
customary offering.
When they had poured and drunk as
much as their hearts desired, they set
out
from Agamemnon's shelter. Nestor
gave each man many instructions,
but most of all
he charged Odysseus to persuade the
blameless son of Peleus. They went
beside the
shore of the loud-roaring sea,
praying earnestly to Earth-shaking
Poseidon that
they might easily bend the great
heart of Aeacus' grandson.
They reached the huts and ships of
the Myrmidons and found Achilles
delighting
his heart with a clear, beautiful,
carefully wrought lyre, whose silver
bridge
he had taken from the spoils when he
destroyed Eetion's city. With it he
sang
the famous deeds of men. Patroclus
alone sat opposite him in silence,
waiting
for Achilles to finish his song.
Odysseus led the others forward.
They stood
before him, and Achilles sprang up
in astonishment, leaving the lyre and
the seat
where he had been sitting. Patroclus
rose as well when he saw the men.
Achilles,
swift-footed, greeted them:
"Welcome. You have come as friends,
though I am angry

with the Achaeans; you are the
dearest of all to me.”
He led them within and seated them
on chairs spread with purple rugs.
Then he
called to Patroclus, who stood
nearby: “Set out a larger mixing
bowl, son of
Menoetius, and mix the wine
stronger. These are the dearest men
beneath my roof.”
Patroclus obeyed his beloved
companion. He set a great chopping
block in the glow
of the fire, laid upon it the back of a
sheep, the fat haunch of a goat, and the
richly marbled chine of a well-fed
pig. Automedon held the meat, while
noble
Achilles cut it; Patroclus, a man
equal to the gods, kindled the great
fire.
When the fire had burned the wood
down and the flame faded, he spread
the embers,
stretched the spits above them, and
sprinkled sacred salt. When the meat
was
roasted, he set it into baskets.
Patroclus distributed the bread in
handsome
baskets, while Achilles portioned the
meat. He sat opposite godlike
Odysseus
against the other wall, and
commanded Patroclus to sacrifice
the inner portions
to the gods; Patroclus cast them into
the fire. The guests reached toward
the

food laid before them.
When they had put away their desire
for food and drink, Ajax nodded to
Phoenix,
and noble Odysseus understood. He
filled the cup, raised it toward
Achilles, and
spoke: “Hail, Achilles. Your feast is
not lacking, whether in
Agamemnon’s shelter
or here, for there is abundant food to
share. Yet we cannot give our minds
to this
lovely meal: a great disaster,
heaven-nurtured, stands before our
eyes, and we fear
whether we shall save our
well-benched ships or perish. The
proud Trojans and their
far-famed allies have camped close
beside the ships and wall, lighting
many fires.
They say they will not stop until they
fall upon the black ships. Zeus, son of
Cronus, flashes favorable signs for
them; Hector, exulting in his great
strength,
rages terribly, trusting in Zeus. He
honors neither men nor gods, and
ruinous
madness has entered him. He prays
for the holy Dawn to appear as
quickly as possible,
for he boasts that he will cut off the
ships’ high sterns, burn the ships
themselves
with consuming fire, and kill the
Achaeans beside them as they choke
in the smoke.
“These threats I dread terribly in my
heart, lest the gods fulfill them and it

be
our appointed fate to perish at Troy,
far from horse-pasturing Argos. Rise,
then,
if you are willing, even now, to
rescue the sons of the Achaeans,
worn down beneath
the Trojans' uproar. Afterwards grief
will be yours, and there is no remedy
once the
evil is done. Consider beforehand
how you will ward the evil day from
the Danaans.
"My dear friend, your father Peleus
gave you this charge on the day he
sent you
from Phthia to Agamemnon: 'My
son, Athena and Hera will grant you
strength, if they
will it; but keep your great-hearted
spirit within your breast, for kindly
fellowship
is better. Abandon the quarrel that
breeds evil, so that the Argives,
young and old,
may honor you more.' Thus the old
man charged you, but you forget it.
Even now cease,
and let go the anger that eats your
heart. Agamemnon gives you worthy
gifts if you
will end your wrath. Hear me, and I
will recount all the gifts Agamemnon
promised
in his shelter: seven tripods never
placed upon the fire; ten talents of
gold; twenty
shining cauldrons; twelve horses that
have won prizes with their feet; and
seven

Lesbian women, skilled in excellent
work, whom he took when you
captured well-built
Lesbos and who surpassed all the
tribes of women in beauty. He will
give these to you,
and with them the girl Briseis whom
he took from you. He will swear a
great oath that
he never climbed into her bed or
joined with her, as is the custom
between lord and
woman.
"All these things will be here at once.
If the gods grant us to sack Priam's
great
city, when we divide the spoil among
the Achaeans, you may enter your
ship and load
it with gold and bronze. You may
choose twenty Trojan women, those
who are fairest
after Argive Helen. If we reach
Achaean Argos, the rich breast of the
land, you will
be Agamemnon's son-in-law, and he
will honor you as he honors Orestes,
his beloved
son, raised amid abundance. He has
three daughters in his well-built
house:
Chrysothemis, Laodice, and
Iphianassa. Whichever you wish, you
may lead home to
Peleus' house without bride-price,
and he will give you wedding gifts
such as no man
has ever given his daughter. He will
also give you seven well-inhabited
cities:

Cardamyle, Enope, grassy Hire,
sacred Pherae, deep-meadowed
Antheia, lovely Aipeia,
and vine-covered Pegasus. All lie
near the sea, at the edge of sandy
Pylos; in them
live men rich in sheep and cattle,
who will honor you like a god with
gifts and under
your scepter fulfill bright judgments.
“These things he will accomplish for
you when you have let go your anger.
But if the
son of Atreus is hateful to you in
your heart, him and his gifts, then
pity the other
Achaeans, who are suffering
throughout the camp and will honor
you like a god. You
would win immense glory from them
now, for you could take Hector, who
would come very
near you with his deadly madness; he
claims that no Danaans brought here
in the ships
are his equal.”
Achilles answered: “Odysseus, sprung
from Zeus, son of Laertes,
resourceful man,
I must answer plainly, just as I think,
and just as it will be fulfilled, so that
you will not sit beside me
murmuring one after another from
different directions.
That man is hateful to me as the
gates of Hades who hides one
thought in his heart
and speaks another. I will tell you
what seems best to me. I do not
think I can

persuade Agamemnon, son of
Atreus, or the other Danaans, since
there was no gratitude
for my unceasing fight against the
enemy. The same portion belongs to
the one who
stays and the one who fights hardest:
coward and brave are held in equal
honor,
and both die alike, the man who has
done nothing and the man who has
labored much.
“There is no profit left for me, after I
have suffered pain in my heart and
always
thrown my life into battle. Like a
wingless bird that carries food to its
fledglings
whenever it catches it, and suffers for
its labor, so I have spent many
sleepless
nights and passed bloody days
fighting men for their wives. With
my ships I have
destroyed twelve cities, and on foot I
say I have taken eleven in fertile
Troy.
From all these I carried many
beautiful treasures away and gave
everything to
Agamemnon, son of Atreus. He
stayed behind beside the swift ships,
received the
goods, and distributed only a little;
he kept much for himself. He gave
the rest
as prizes to the best men and the
kings, and their portions remain safe.
From me
alone among the Achaeans he took
the woman I loved, and now he keeps

her. Let him
lie beside her and be glad.
“Why must the Argives fight the
Trojans? Why did the son of Atreus
gather and lead
the army here? Was it not for
fair-haired Helen? Are the sons of
Atreus the only men
who love their wives? Every good and
sensible man loves and cares for his
own, as I
loved her, though I won her by my
spear. Now that he has taken my
prize from my hands
and deceived me, let him not try me
again: I know him, and he will not
persuade me.
Let him, with you and the other
kings, devise how to ward the enemy
fire from the
ships. He has labored greatly without
me: he built a wall and drove a
broad, deep
trench around it, planting stakes
within. Yet even that cannot hold
Hector, killer
of men. While I fought among the
Achaeans, Hector would not venture
far from the
wall, but came only as far as the
Skaian Gates and the beech tree,
where once he
stood alone and barely escaped my
attack.
“Now I do not wish to fight glorious
Hector. Tomorrow I will sacrifice to
Zeus and
all the gods, draw my ships well
down to the sea, and you will see
them, if you care

and if it concerns you, sailing at first
light upon the fish-filled Hellespont,
with
men eager at the oars. If the famous
Earth-shaker grants a fair voyage, on
the third
day I should reach fertile Phthia. I
have much there, and much that I
left behind in
my ruinous journey. From here I will
carry away gold, red bronze,
well-girded women,
and gray iron, all the shares I won.
But the prize he gave me,
Agamemnon, son of
Atreus, has taken back again in his
arrogance. Tell him this openly, as I
command,
so that the other Achaeans may also
be angry if he hopes to deceive
another Danaan,
always wrapped in shamelessness.
Even if he were as bold as a dog, he
would not dare
look me in the face. I will neither
plan with him nor do any work
beside him. He
deceived and wronged me; he will
not deceive me again with words.
Enough for him.
Let him go his way; Zeus the
counselor has robbed him of his wits.
“His gifts are hateful to me, and I
value him at the price of a hair. Even
if he
gave me ten times, twenty times as
much as he possesses now, and as
much more as he
might acquire—no matter how much
flows into Orchomenus or Egyptian
Thebes, where

the greatest wealth lies in houses,
with a hundred gates and two
hundred men issuing
from each with horses and
chariots—even if he offered me as
much sand and dust as
there are, Agamemnon could not
persuade my spirit until he paid back
all the painful
insult.

“I will not marry a daughter of
Agamemnon, son of Atreus, not even
if she rivaled

golden Aphrodite in beauty and
matched bright-eyed Athena in
handiwork. Let him

choose another Achaean, one suited
to him and more kingly. If the gods
save me and

I reach home, Peleus himself will find
me a wife. There are many Achaean
women in

Hellas and Phthia, daughters of the
best men who guard their cities.
Whichever I wish,

I will make my beloved wife. My
proud heart has long urged me to
take a fitting bride
and enjoy the possessions the old
man Peleus won.

“Nothing is worth my life—not all
the wealth they say lies in
well-inhabited Ilium,
the city that once lived in peace
before the sons of Achaeans came,
nor all that the
stone threshold of Phoebus Apollo
encloses in rocky Pytho. Cattle and
fat sheep can

be driven off; tripods and tawny
horses can be acquired. But a man’s

life cannot be

won back, nor captured, once it has
passed through the barrier of his
teeth.

My mother, silver-footed Thetis, tells
me that two fates carry me toward
death.

If I remain here and fight around the
city of the Trojans, my homecoming
is lost,

but my glory will be imperishable. If
I return home to my beloved
fatherland, my

good glory is lost, but my life will be
long, and death’s end will not soon
overtake

me. I would advise the others to sail
home as well, since you will not find
the end

of steep Ilium: Zeus of the wide eyes
has stretched his hand above it, and
its people

have taken courage.

“Go, then, and tell this message to
the Achaean leaders—for that is the
honor of

old men—that they may devise
another plan in their hearts, a better
one, to save

their ships and the Achaean army
upon the hollow ships. The plan they
conceived

while I was angry will not save them.
Let Phoenix sleep here beside us, so
that he

may sail with me tomorrow to my
dear fatherland, if he wishes. I will
not carry him
by force.”

Odysseus returned to the council and
told them the answer.

The chiefs sat in grief. Diomedes said: "Let us eat and sleep. Tomorrow we will fight. A man who trusts his own courage need not beg another's help." Phoenix remained beside Achilles, and the old horseman spoke with tears rising, for he feared the Achaean ships: "If you are set on homecoming, shining Achilles, and will not ward the destructive fire from the swift ships because anger has entered your heart, how could I remain here without you, my dear child? The old horseman Peleus sent me with you on the day he sent you from Phthia to Agamemnon, still a child who knew nothing of equal war or public speech, where distinguished men become leaders. He sent me to teach you all this: to be a speaker of words and a doer of deeds. "For that reason, dear child, I would not willingly be left behind by you, not even if a god promised to scrape old age from me and make me young again, as I was when I first fled lovely Hellas from quarrels with my father, Amyntor son of Ormenus. He was angry over his fair-haired concubine, whom he loved and dishonored my mother. She begged me by my knees to sleep with the woman, so that the old man might hate her.

I obeyed and did it. My father learned of it, cursed me terribly, and called upon the Erinyes never to let a son born from me sit upon his knees. Zeus beneath the earth and dread Persephoneia fulfilled his curses. "My heart could no longer bear to remain in my angry father's house. Friends and cousins tried to restrain me; many fat sheep, twisting-horned cattle, and shining pigs were slaughtered, and much of the old man's wine was drunk. For nine nights they kept watches around me, with fires never going out in the court and before the bedroom doors. On the tenth dark night I broke through the tightly fitted doors, jumped the courtyard wall, and fled unseen by the guards and serving women. I crossed broad Hellas and came to fertile Phthia, mother of sheep, to King Peleus. He welcomed me freely and loved me as a father loves his only, late-born son among many possessions. He made me rich and gave me a numerous people, and I ruled the Dolopes at the edge of Phthia. "I loved you from my heart, godlike Achilles, and raised you so that you would never go to a feast or eat in the halls with another before I had seated you on

my knees,
cut the meat, and poured the wine.
Often you drenched the tunic on my
breast,
spilling wine in your painful
childhood. For you I suffered much
and labored much,
thinking that the gods had not
granted me a child of my own; I
made you my son,
godlike Achilles, so that you might
one day ward an unseemly doom
from me.
“But tame your great spirit, Achilles;
you must not keep a pitiless heart.
The gods
themselves can bend, though their
strength, honor, and power are
greater. Human beings
turn them with sacrifices, gentle
vows, libations, and the savor of
offerings, begging
when someone has transgressed or
gone astray. Prayers are daughters of
great Zeus:
they are lame and wrinkled, and look
sideways; yet they follow afterward,
caring for
ruin. Whoever respects them when
they draw near is greatly helped, and
they hear him
when he prays. Whoever rejects them
and stubbornly refuses them, they go
to Zeus and
ask that ruin follow him, so that,
harmed, he may pay the price.
“Achilles, grant the daughters of
Zeus their honor; they bend the
minds of other good
men as well. If Agamemnon were not
bringing gifts and promising more

later, but always
remained fiercely angry, I would not
ask you to cast off your wrath and
defend the
Argives, desperate though they are.
But now he gives much at once and
has promised much
for later, and he has sent the best
men in all the Achaean army, men
who are dearest to
you. Do not reject their words or
despise their feet. It was not wrong
to be angry
before. We have heard the fame of
men of old who were turned by great
anger, with gifts
and words.
“I remember an ancient deed, and I
will tell it among you all. The
Curetes and the
great-hearted Aetolians fought
around lovely Calydon, killing one
another. Artemis,
golden-throned, sent evil upon them
because Oineus failed to sacrifice
first-fruits
to her, though the other gods feasted
upon hecatombs. Whether he forgot
or failed to
notice, he was deeply mistaken. The
archer goddess, enraged, sent a wild
boar with
white tusks that ravaged Oineus’
orchards, throwing great trees to the
ground, roots,
blossoms, and fruit together.
“Meleager, Oineus’ son, killed it after
gathering hunters and hounds from
many cities;
it was too great to be brought down
by a few mortals, and it sent many to

the painful
pyre. Artemis raised a loud quarrel
over the boar's head and shaggy hide
between the
Curetes and the proud Aetolians.
While Meleager fought, the Curetes
suffered and could
not remain outside the walls, though
they were many. But when anger
entered Meleager—
the anger that swells even in the
breast of a thoughtful man—he lay
beside his lovely
wife Cleopatra, nursing the wrath
caused by his mother Althaea's
curses. She had prayed
to Hades and dread Persephoneia for
her brother's death, beating the
nourishing earth
with her hands and kneeling in tears;
the Erinyes heard her from Erebus,
with her
pitiless heart.
“Soon the clash and din rose around
the gates as towers were struck
down. The elders
of the Aetolians begged Meleager
and sent their best priests, promising
a great gift:
in the richest plain of Calydon he
might choose a beautiful
fifty-ploughland estate,
half planted in vines and half open
for the plow. His father Oineus
begged him from
the threshold, shaking the fitted
doors on his knees; his sisters and
queenly mother
begged him, and his closest
companions as well. But they could
not move his heart

until the Curetes were already upon
the chamber and burning the great
city.

“Then his well-girded wife came
weeping and told him all the evils
that befall people
when a city is taken: the men are
killed, the city is burned, and
strangers carry off
the children and deep-girdled
women. His spirit was stirred when
he heard of these
deeds. He rose, put on his radiant
armor, and warded the evil day from
the Aetolians,
yielding to his own heart. Yet they
did not fulfill the many beautiful
gifts they had
promised; he warded the evil without
them.

“Do not let your mind turn toward
this, Achilles; do not let some god
lead you there.

It would be worse to ward the evil
only when the ships are burning. Go
toward the gifts:

the Achaeans will honor you like a
god. If you enter the man-killing
battle without

gifts, you will not have equal honor,
even though you drive war away.”

Achilles answered: “Old Phoenix,
father dear, you have said all this
from love;

but I do not need this honor. I think
I am honored by Zeus' decree, and
that honor

will remain with me beside my
curved ships as long as breath stays
in my breast and

my knees move. I tell you this: do not trouble my heart, grieving and mourning for the sake of Agamemnon. You should not love him, lest you become hateful to me while you are dear to me. It is good to care for the one who cares for me. Rule beside me as an equal and share half my honor. These men will carry the message; you remain here and sleep on a soft bed. At dawn we will consider whether to return home or stay.” He nodded silently to Patroclus, who spread a thick bed for Phoenix, so that the old man might decide whether to sail home with him. Great Ajax, son of Telamon, then spoke: “Resourceful Odysseus, son of Laertes, let us go. I do not think our mission will be completed by this road. We must report the message quickly, even though it is bad, to the Danaans who now sit waiting. Achilles has set a wild, great-hearted spirit in his breast. He is pitiless and does not turn from the love of his companions, by which we honored him above all beside the ships. A man accepts compensation for a murdered brother or son, and once he receives the price, his heart and proud spirit are restrained. But the gods have put an unending, evil

temper in your breast because of a single woman. We offer you seven excellent women and many other things besides. Put a gracious spirit in yourself and respect your own roof; we are beneath it, chosen from all the Danaans, and we wish to be your dearest and most beloved companions among the Achaeans.”

Achilles, swift-footed, answered: “Ajax, son of Telamon, lord of the people, you have spoken all according to my heart. But my heart swells with anger whenever I remember

how Agamemnon treated me before the Argives, as though I were some dishonored wanderer.

Go, then, and report my message. I will not concern myself with bloody war until

Hector, Priam’s wise son, reaches the huts and ships of the Myrmidons, killing Argives and burning the ships. Around my hut and black ship, I think, Hector, eager for battle, will be stopped.”

So he spoke. Each man took the two-handled cup, poured a libation beside the ships, and went back; Odysseus led them. Patroclus ordered his companions and the serving women to spread a thick bed for Phoenix at once. They obeyed, laying fleeces, a rug,

and a fine linen covering. There the
old man lay waiting for bright Dawn.
Achilles
slept in the innermost part of the
well-built shelter; beside him lay
Diomedes, the
beautiful daughter of Phorbas, whom
he had brought from Lesbos.
Patroclus lay on the
other side, and beside him lay
well-girded Iphigeneia, whom Achilles had
given him after
capturing steep Scyros, Enyalios' city.
When the embassy reached
Agamemnon's shelter, the sons of the
Achaeans welcomed them
with golden cups, rising one after
another and asking what they had
found. First
Agamemnon, lord of men, asked:
"Tell me, renowned Odysseus, great
glory of the Achaeans:
does he wish to ward the enemy fire
from the ships, or has he refused, and
does anger
still hold his great-hearted spirit?"
The much-enduring godlike
Odysseus answered: "Most glorious
son of Atreus, Agamemnon,
lord of men, he does not wish to
extinguish his anger; it burns in him
still more.
He rejects you and your gifts. He
tells you to devise among the Argives
how you may
save the ships and the Achaeans. He
himself threatened that, when bright
Dawn appears,
he will drag his well-benched ships
into the sea. He advised the others to
sail home,

since you will not find the end of
steep Ilium: Zeus of the wide eyes has
stretched
his hand above it, and its people have
taken courage. Ajax and both wise
heralds,
who followed me, can say the same.
Phoenix has lain down, as Achilles
commanded,
so that he may sail with him
tomorrow to his beloved fatherland,
if he wishes; he
will not carry him by force."
He spoke, and all were silent,
astonished at the force of the answer.
For a long time
the sons of the Achaeans sat in
sorrow. At last Diomedes, loud in
battle, said:
"Most glorious son of Atreus,
Agamemnon, lord of men, you
should never have begged the
blameless son of Peleus with
countless gifts. He is proud enough
without them, and now
you have driven him deeper into
pride. Let us leave him, whether he
goes or stays;
he will fight again whenever his heart
commands and a god rouses him.
Come, let us do
as I say: sleep now, having satisfied
the heart with food and wine, for
these give
strength and courage. When fair,
rose-fingered Dawn appears, quickly
marshal the men
and horses before the ships, urge
them on, and fight yourself among
the foremost."

All the kings praised the speech of
horse-taming Diomedes. They
poured libations and
went each to his shelter, where they
slept and received the gift of sleep.

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 10

First-pass working translation

The other chiefs, the best of all the
Achaeans, slept beside the ships,
overcome by gentle sleep. But
Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
was not held by

sweet sleep, for many thoughts drove
through his mind. As the husband of
Hera,

fair-haired queen, flashes lightning
while he prepares immeasurable rain,
hail,

or snow, or opens the great mouth of
war, so Agamemnon groaned deeply
from his

heart, and his thoughts trembled
within him. Whenever he looked
toward the Trojan

plain, he marveled at the many fires
burning before Ilium, and at the
sound of

flutes, pipes, and the tumult of men.
Whenever he looked toward the
ships and the

Achaean army, he tore great locks
from his head for Zeus above and
groaned from
his victorious heart.

At last the best plan seemed to him
to go first to Nestor, son of Neleus,
and see

whether together they might shape
some blameless counsel that could
ward disaster

from all the Danaans. He rose, put on
his tunic, bound his fine sandals
beneath

his shining feet, wrapped himself in
the red hide of a great tawny lion
that fell

to his heels, and took his spear.

Menelaus was seized by the same
trembling; sleep

would not settle upon his eyelids, for
he feared that the Argives might
suffer harm,

having crossed the sea to Troy for his
sake and entered the bold war. He
first

covered his broad back with a
dappled leopard skin, lifted a bronze
helmet upon his

head, and took a spear in his
powerful hand. He went to rouse his
brother, who ruled

all the Argives and was honored
among the people like a god.

He found Agamemnon fitting his
beautiful armor beside the stern of
the ship, and

was welcome when he came.

Menelaus spoke first: "Why are you
arming yourself like

this, brother? Are you going to send
one of your companions as a spy
among the

Trojans? I greatly fear no one will
undertake this work alone, to scout
hostile

men through the immortal night,
unless he has an exceptionally bold
heart."

Agamemnon answered: "We need a
profitable plan, you and I, dear
Menelaus, one that

may rescue and save the Argives and
their ships, now that Zeus' mind has
turned.

He has set his heart more strongly upon Hector than before. I have never seen or heard of one man devising so many grievous deeds in a single day as Hector, dear to Zeus, has wrought against the sons of Achaeans—neither son of a goddess nor favorite of a god. He has done things that I say will long trouble the Argives; so many evils has he planned for them. Go now, run swiftly to Ajax and Idomeneus beside the ships. I will go to noble Nestor and urge him to rise and come to the holy watch, and to give the orders. They will obey him most readily, since his son commands among the guards, as does Meriones, Idomeneus' companion; we entrusted the watch chiefly to them.” Menelaus asked: “What do you command me to do? Should I wait here among them until you return, or run back to you after I have given them your orders?” Agamemnon answered: “Remain here, so that we do not miss one another among the many paths through the camp. Call loudly wherever you go, waking each man by his father's name and honoring them all. Do not carry yourself proudly; let us labor ourselves as well. Zeus is surely sending this heavy evil upon us.”

He sent his brother away with careful instructions and went to Nestor, shepherd of the people. He found the old man beside his hut and black ship, lying on a soft bed; near him lay his figured shield, two shining spears, and a bright, many-colored belt with which the old man armed himself whenever he led the people into man-destroying war, refusing to yield to grievous old age. Nestor raised his head on his elbow and asked: “Who are you, walking alone through the camp and the dark night, when other mortals sleep? Are you seeking one of the watchmen, or one of your companions? Speak; do not approach me silently. What do you need?” Agamemnon answered: “You will recognize me, Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans: Agamemnon, whom Zeus has set among unending labors until breath remains in my breast and my knees move. I wander because gentle sleep does not settle upon my eyes; war and the cares of the Achaeans consume me. I dread terribly for the Danaans; my heart is not steady, I am shaken, my heart leaps from my breast, and my bright limbs tremble. If you have any plan—for sleep does not visit you

either—
let us go down among the guards and
see that fatigue and sleep have not
overcome
them so that they have entirely
forgotten the watch. The enemy lies
close by, and
we do not know whether they might
even be eager to fight through the
night.”
Nestor, the Gerenian horseman,
replied: “Most glorious son of Atreus,
lord of men,
Agamemnon, Zeus the counselor will
not fulfill every thought Hector now
expects.
I think he will suffer still more
trouble if Achilles turns his dear
heart away
from his bitter anger. I will follow
you, and we will rouse Tydeus’
famous son,
Odysseus, swift Ajax, and the brave
son of Phyleus. Let someone also go
call the
godlike Ajax and lord Idomeneus,
since their ships are farthest away. I
will rebuke
Menelaus, dear though he is and
worthy of respect, and I will not hide
that he sleeps
while he has left you alone to labor.
He should have worked among all
the best men,
begging them, for the need has
become intolerable.”
Agamemnon answered: “Old man, at
other times I would tell you to blame
him; often
he gives way and does not wish to
labor, neither from cowardice nor

from dullness,
but watching me and awaiting my
impulse. Now he woke before me and
came to me first.
I sent him to call those whom you
name. Let us go; we will find them
before the
gates among the guards, where I told
them to gather.”
Nestor said: “No Argive will resent
or disobey him when he urges and
commands.”
He dressed, bound his sandals,
fastened a long double crimson cloak
with its thick
nap, and took a powerful spear
sharpened with bronze. He went
through the ships of
the bronze-clad Achaeans.
First Nestor woke Odysseus, equal in
counsel to Zeus. His voice quickly
reached the
hero’s mind, and Odysseus came out
of his shelter, asking: “Why do you
wander alone
through the ships and the immortal
night? What urgent need has come
upon you?”
Nestor answered: “Do not be angry,
resourceful son of Laertes. Such grief
has fallen
upon the Achaeans. Come with us,
and let us wake another man suited
to counsel,
whether we must flee or fight.”
Odysseus went into his shelter, slung
his patterned shield over his
shoulders, and
followed them. They came to
Diomedes, son of Tydeus, and found
him outside his hut

with his armor on. His companions
slept around him, their shields
beneath their
heads and their spears planted
upright in the butt, the bronze
flashing far off like
the lightning of father Zeus. The
hero slept upon the hide of a
field-ox, with a
bright rug spread beneath his head.
Nestor stood beside him, nudged
him with his foot, and roused and
rebuked him:
“Wake, son of Tydeus. Why do you
waste the whole night in sleep? Do
you not hear
that the Trojans are camped on the
rise of the plain close beside the
ships, and
that only a little space holds them
back?”
Diomedes sprang up quickly and
said: “Old man, you are relentless;
you never stop
working. Are there not younger sons
of the Achaeans who could go among
the kings
and wake each one in turn? You are
impossible, old man.”
Nestor answered: “Yes, dear friend,
you have spoken rightly. I have
blameless sons,
and many people, and one of them
could go calling. But a great need has
fallen upon
the Achaeans: now all stand upon a
razor’s edge, between grievous death
and life.
Go and rouse swift Ajax and the son
of Phyleus; you are younger, if you
pity me.”

Diomedes wrapped the hide of a
great tawny lion around his
shoulders, took his spear,
and went to rouse them. He led them
to the gathered guards. They did not
find the
leaders of the watch asleep: all sat
awake in their armor. As dogs
around a sheepfold
lose sleep when they hear a fierce
beast moving through the hills, with
a great tumult
of men and dogs rising against it, so
the sweet sleep had vanished from
the eyes of
the guards as they watched through
the evil night, always turning their
faces toward
the plain whenever they heard the
Trojans advancing.
The old man rejoiced when he saw
them, encouraged them with his
words, and said:
“Guard the camp faithfully, dear
children; let sleep seize no one, lest
we become a
joy to our enemies.” He crossed the
trench, and the kings of the Argives
who had
been summoned to council followed
him. Meriones and Nestor’s shining
son joined them,
for the kings themselves had called
them to share the counsel. They
crossed the dug
trench and sat in a clear place where
the ground showed the bodies of
those who had
fallen, the place from which mighty
Hector had turned back, killing
Argives, when

night first covered the field.
There they sat and spoke among
themselves. Nestor began: "Friends, is
there some man
who trusts his own brave spirit
enough to go among the proud
Trojans and seize one of
the enemy stragglers, or learn some
word among the Trojans—what they
are planning,
whether they intend to remain by
the ships away from the city, or
withdraw into the
city now that they have defeated the
Achaeans? If he learned all this and
returned
unharmd, he would win great fame
beneath the sky among all men, and
an excellent
reward. Every one of the best men
who command the ships would give
him a black ewe,
with a suckling lamb at her side; no
possession would equal it, and it
would always
be present at feasts and banquets."
All fell silent. Then Diomedes, loud
in battle, spoke: "Nestor, my heart
and proud
spirit urge me to enter the enemy
camp, since the hostile men are close.
But if some
other man would accompany me, the
work would be easier and more
confident. When two
go together, one sees before the other
and finds the advantage; a solitary
man, even
if he has thought deeply, is slower to
discover and weaker in counsel."

There they sat, and Nestor asked
whether some man trusted his own
brave heart
enough to enter the proud Trojans'
camp, seize an enemy straggler, or
learn what
the Trojans planned—whether they
meant to remain by the ships or
withdraw into
the city now that they had defeated
the Achaeans. If he learned
everything and
returned unharmd, he would win
great fame beneath the sky and a fine
reward:
each of the best ship-commanders
would give him a black ewe with a
suckling lamb,
a prize that would always attend his
feasts and banquets.
All were silent. Diomedes spoke:
"Nestor, my heart and proud spirit
urge me to
enter the enemy camp, since the
hostile men are close. But if another
man would
come with me, the work would be
warmer and more secure. When two
go together,
one sees first what is to be done; a
solitary man, even if he has thought
deeply,
has a narrower mind and a thinner
counsel."
Many wished to follow him: both
Ajaxes, servants of Ares; Meriones;
Nestor's son;
Menelaus, famous with the spear;
and enduring Odysseus, whose spirit
always dared

to plunge into the Trojan crowd.
Agamemnon answered: "Son of
Tydeus, Diomedes,
dear to my heart, choose whichever
companion you wish, the best of
those who have
offered themselves. Do not leave the
better man behind out of respect for
birth,

and take the worse because he is
more kingly."

Diomedes answered: "If you
command me to choose a
companion, how could I forget
godlike Odysseus? His heart and
proud spirit are ready for every
labor, and Pallas

Athena loves him. With him beside
me we could return even from
burning fire, for

he understands how to discover a
path."

Odysseus replied: "Do not praise or
rebuke me too much; these things are
already

known among the Argives. Let us go:
night is passing, dawn is near, the
stars have

advanced, more than two parts of the
night are gone, and the third alone
remains."

They clothed themselves in terrible
armor. Thrasymedes gave Diomedes
a two-edged

sword, since his own had been left
beside the ship, and a shield; he set
upon his

head a bull-hide helmet without boss
or crest, called a skull-cap, which
protects

the heads of young men. Meriones
gave Odysseus a bow, quiver, and
sword, and set

upon his head a helmet made of hide,
strengthened inside by many straps
and bristling

outside with the closely set white
teeth of a boar. Autolycus had once
taken it

from the house of Amyntor son of
Ormenus and given it to
Amphidamas of Cythera;

Amphidamas gave it as a guest-gift
to Molus, and Molus gave it to
Meriones. Now

Meriones gave it to Odysseus, and it
covered his head securely.

When they had put on the dreadful
armor, they set out, leaving all the
best men

behind. Pallas Athena sent a heron
close beside their road on the right,
but they

could not see it through the dark;
they heard only its cry. Odysseus
rejoiced and

prayed: "Hear me, daughter of
aegis-bearing Zeus, who stand beside
me in every

labor and never escape my notice
when I am moved. Be with me now
above all, and

grant that we return to the famous
ships after doing a great deed that
will trouble
the Trojans."

Diomedes prayed in turn: "Hear me,
daughter of Zeus, unconquered
Athena. Come with

me as when you followed my noble
father Tydeus to Thebes, when he

went as messenger
before the Achaeans. He left the
bronze-clad Achaeans beside Asopus
and carried a
gentle message to the Cadmeans, but
on his return he devised terrible
deeds with
you beside him, divine goddess,
standing freely at his side. Stand
with me now and
guard me. I will sacrifice to you a
broad-browed yearling heifer,
unbroken and never
brought beneath a man's yoke; I will
pour gold over her horns and offer
her to you.”
So they prayed, and Pallas Athena
heard them. They set out like two
lions through
the black night, through slaughter,
among corpses, armor, and dark
blood.
Hector did not let the bold Trojans
sleep either. He summoned all the
leaders and
masters of the people and devised a
careful plan: “Who will promise to
perform this
work for a great gift? His reward will
be sufficient. I will give a chariot and
two
long-necked horses, the best beside
the swift ships of the Achaeans, to
the man who
dares approach the ships, learn
whether they are guarded as before,
or whether,
defeated by our hands, the Achaeans
are planning flight and do not wish
to watch

through this terrible fatigue-filled
night.”
All fell silent. But among the Trojans
was Dolon, son of the herald
Eumedes, a man
rich in gold and bronze, ugly in
appearance but swift of foot, the
only son among
five sisters. He spoke to the Trojans
and Hector: “Hector, my heart and
proud spirit
urge me to approach the swift ships
and learn what is there. Raise the
scepter for
me and swear that you will give me
the horses and decorated chariot that
carry the
blameless son of Peleus. I will not be
a useless spy for you; I will go
straight
through the army until I reach
Agamemnon's ship, where the best
men are likely now
deliberating whether to flee or fight.”
Hector took the scepter in his hands
and swore: “Let Zeus himself,
loud-thundering
husband of Hera, witness that no
other Trojan will mount those
horses; I say you
alone will have the glory of them.”
He swore falsely and roused Dolon.
At once Dolon
slung his curved bow around his
shoulders, wrapped himself in the
hide of a gray wolf,
set a marten-skin cap upon his head,
took a sharp spear, and went from
the camp toward
the ships. He would not return from
the ships to carry his message to

Hector.
When he had left the horses and men
behind and gone some distance,
godlike Odysseus
saw him approaching and said to
Diomedes: "There is a man coming
from the camp. I do
not know whether he is a spy for our
ships or a plunderer of the dead. Let
us first
let him pass a little way across the
plain; then we can spring upon him
and seize him.
If his feet outrun us, drive him from
the camp toward the ships with your
spear, so
that he cannot escape toward the
city."
They spoke and crouched beside the
road among the corpses. Dolon ran
past them in
reckless haste. When he had gone as
far as the tails of mules, which are
better than
oxen at dragging a well-made plow
through deep fallow, the two sprang
out. Hearing
the noise, he stopped, thinking his
companions were returning from the
Trojans at
Hector's command. But when they
were a spear's cast or less away, he
recognized
hostile men, and his swift knees
carried him into flight.
As two sharp-toothed dogs, trained
for the hunt, chase a fawn or hare
without rest
through a wooded place while the
creature runs before them crying, so
the son of

Tydeus and city-sacking Odysseus
pursued him without cease. When he
was nearly about
to reach the guards fleeing toward
the ships, Athena put strength into
Diomedes, so
that no other bronze-clad Achaean
might strike first and claim the
glory, leaving him
second. Diomedes sprang with his
spear and called: "Stop, or I will
reach you with my
spear; you will not long escape a
steep death from my hand." He
threw and deliberately
missed. The spear's polished point
passed over Dolon's right shoulder
and fixed itself
in the ground. Dolon stopped, struck
with terror, his teeth chattering, his
skin pale
with fear. The two panting men
reached him and seized his hands.
Dolon cried through his tears: "Take
me alive, and I will ransom myself.
At home I
have bronze, gold, and much-worked
iron; my father would give you an
immeasurable
ransom if he heard that I was alive
among the Achaean ships."
Resourceful Odysseus answered:
"Take courage; let death not be in
your heart. Tell me
plainly: why have you come alone
toward the ships through the dark
night, when other
mortals sleep? Were you plundering
the corpses, or did Hector send you
to spy out

everything among the hollow ships,
or did your own spirit drive you?"

"Hector led me here," Dolon said, his
limbs trembling. "He promised to
give me the
single-hoofed horses of the great son
of Peleus and the chariot worked
with bronze.

He ordered me to go quickly through
the black night to the hostile men
and learn

whether the swift ships were still
guarded as before, or whether the
Achaeans,

overcome by terrible fatigue and
defeated by our hands, were
planning flight and
did not wish to watch through the
night."

Odysseus smiled: "So your heart was
reaching after great gifts—the horses
of the

warrior Aeacides? They are difficult
for mortal men to master or drive,
except for

Achilles, whose mother is immortal.
Now tell us plainly: where did you
leave Hector,

shepherd of the people? Where are
his armor and horses? How are the
other Trojans'

guards and beds arranged? What do
they plan among themselves—will
they remain here

by the ships, away from the city, or
withdraw into the city after
defeating the

Achaeans?"

Dolon answered: "I will tell you all of
this exactly. Hector is among the
counselors,

deliberating beside the sacred tomb
of Ilus, far from the uproar. The
guards you ask

about are not assigned and set apart
to protect the army. The Trojans
whose fires

are burning must keep awake and
urge one another to watch. But the
far-called allies

sleep; they have handed the guard to
the Trojans, for their children and
wives are

not close by."

Odysseus asked: "How do they
sleep—mixed among the
horse-taming Trojans or apart?
Tell me, so that I may know."

Dolon answered: "Toward the sea lie
the Carians, Paeonians with bent
bows, Leleges,

Caucones, and godlike Pelasgians.
Toward Thymbra are the Lycians,
haughty Mysians,

horse-fighting Phrygians, and
Maeonians with their horses. But
why do you question

me about each one? If you intend to
enter the Trojan crowd, the
Thracians lie apart,

newly arrived and farthest from the
others. Their king is Rhesus, son of
Eioneus.

I saw his horses: the fairest and
largest, whiter than snow and swift
as the winds.

His chariot is beautifully worked in
gold and silver, and he brought
golden armor,

immense and a wonder to
behold—not armor for mortal men,
but armor that seemed fit

for immortal gods. Now take me to
the swift ships, or bind me here in a
pitiless bond
until you return and test whether I
have spoken truly.”
Diomedes looked at him grimly: “Do
not put flight into your heart, Dolon,
though you
have brought good news and fallen
into our hands. If we released you
now, you could
come again to the swift ships to spy
or fight against us. But if you lose
your life
under my hands, you will no longer
be a trouble to the Argives.”
Dolon reached toward Diomedes’
beard to beg, but Diomedes sprang
and struck the
middle of his neck with his sword,
severing both tendons. Dolon’s head
fell into
the dust while he was still speaking.
Odysseus and Diomedes took from
him the
marten-skin cap, wolf-hide,
back-bent bow, and long spear.
Odysseus lifted them
high in his hand to Athena, the
goddess of spoil: “Hail, goddess. We
will give
these first among all the immortals
in Olympus; but now send us again
to the
horses and beds of the Thracian
men.”
He raised the spoils and placed them
upon a tamarisk, marking the place
with broken
reeds and flowering branches, so that
they would not miss it when they

returned
through the black night. They went
onward through armor and dark
blood and quickly
reached the end of the Thracian men.
The Thracians slept, overcome by
fatigue; their
beautiful weapons lay in order beside
them, three ranks deep, and each
man had a
pair of horses beside him. Rhesus
slept in the middle, and his swift
horses were
tied at the outer edge of his chariot
by the reins.
Odysseus saw him first and pointed
him out to Diomedes: “There is the
man, Diomedes,
and there are the horses Dolon told
us about. Do not stand here uselessly
in your
armor. Loosen the horses—or kill the
men, and I will attend to the horses.”
Athena, bright-eyed, breathed
strength into Diomedes. He struck
among the sleeping
men, and an ugly groan rose from
those cut down; the ground
reddened with blood.
As a lion leaps upon unwatched
sheep or goats with evil intent, so the
son of Tydeus
went through the Thracians until he
had killed twelve. Odysseus, standing
behind him,
dragged each man struck by
Diomedes aside by the foot, thinking
that the horses with
their beautiful manes might pass
easily and not grow afraid when they
trampled the

dead, since they were not yet used to the slaughter.

When Diomedes reached the king, he took away his sweet life as he gasped for breath;

a bad dream had stood above him through the night, sent by Athena's counsel. Odysseus

loosed the horses from the chariot and tied them together with the reins. He did not

drive them out of the camp, fearing that, unaccustomed to the dead, they might shy.

While Odysseus was loosening the single-hoofed horses, gathering them with the reins,

and driving them out of the crowd by flicking his bow because he had not thought to

take the bright whip from the decorated chariot, Diomedes stood wondering what bold

deed he should do next—drag away the chariot where the beautiful armor lay, or lift

it high and carry it out, or take the lives of still more Thracians.

As he considered, Athena stood close beside him and spoke: "Remember the return,

son of great-hearted Tydeus, to the hollow ships, lest another god awaken the Trojans

and you come back in fear."

Diomedes understood the goddess' voice, quickly mounted

the horses, and Odysseus struck them with his bow. They flew toward the swift ships.

Apollo, god of the silver bow, saw Athena following the son of Tydeus and, angered,

plunged among the Trojan crowd and roused Hippocoon, a noble cousin of Rhesus. When

he sprang from sleep and saw the deserted place where the swift horses had stood and

the men dying in the harsh slaughter, he groaned and called his companion by name.

Then clamor and measureless uproar rose among the Trojans as they rushed together,

marveling at the terrible deed those men had done before going to the hollow ships.

When the two reached the place where they had killed Hector's spy, Odysseus halted

the swift horses. Diomedes leaped to the ground, placed the bloody spoils in

Odysseus' hands, mounted again, and lashed the horses. They flew willingly toward

the hollow ships, for that was dear to their hearts.

Before the words were finished, Nestor heard the thunder of swift horses and called:

"Friends, leaders and masters of the Argives, shall I tell a falsehood or speak the

truth? My ears are struck by the pounding of swift-footed horses. If only Odysseus

and mighty Diomedes were driving horses from the Trojans in this way! Yet I fear

terribly that the best of the Argives
have suffered beneath the Trojan
uproar.”

Before he could finish, the men
themselves arrived. They climbed
down from the
horses, and the chiefs greeted them
with right hands and gentle words.
Nestor first
asked renowned Odysseus, great
glory of the Achaeans: “Tell me how
you took these
horses. Did you enter the Trojan
crowd and take them, or did some
god meet you and
give them to you? They shine like
rays of the sun. I mingle with the
Trojans often,
though I am an old warrior and do
not remain idle beside the ships, but
I have never
seen or imagined horses like these. I
think a god gave them to you on
meeting you,
for Zeus the cloud-gatherer loves you
both, and so does Athena, daughter
of aegis-
bearing Zeus.”
Resourceful Odysseus answered: “A
god who wished it could easily give
even better
horses, old man, for these are far
superior. These are Thracian horses
newly arrived;
the good Diomedes killed their king
and twelve of his best companions.
The thirteenth
was the spy near the ships, the man
whom Hector and the other splendid
Trojans sent
to scout our army.”

With that he drove the single-hoofed
horses across the trench, laughing
aloud, and
the other rejoicing Achaeans
followed. When they reached
Diomedes’ well-built hut,
they tied the horses with carefully
cut straps at the manger where
Diomedes’ swift
horses stood eating tender wheat.
Odysseus placed Dolon’s bloody
spoils in the stern
of the ship, intending to prepare
them as a sacred offering for Athena.
They stepped
into the sea and washed the sweat
from their legs, shoulders, and
thighs. When the
sea’s wave had cleansed their heavy
sweat and cooled their hearts, they
entered the
polished bathing tubs, washed, and
anointed themselves richly with oil.
Then they
sat down to supper, and from a full
mixing bowl they poured sweet wine
as a libation
to Athena.

Source range: Book 10. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK II

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose from the bed of noble
Tithonus,
Bringing light to immortals and to
mortals.
But Zeus sent Strife to the swift
ships of the Achaeans,
A sign of war holding its violence in
both hands.
She stood upon Odysseus' great
black ship,
Midway between the stations of
Ajax, son of Telamon,
And Achilles, whose ships lay at the
two ends,
Trusting in their courage and their
strength.
There she cried aloud, a great and
terrible cry,
And put unwearied battle-strength
into
Each Achaean heart. War grew
sweeter to them
Than sailing home in hollow ships
toward
Their beloved fatherland.
Agamemnon shouted, and ordered
the Argives to arm.
He clothed his body in the bright
bronze. First
He fastened greaves, beautiful, with
silver ankle-pieces,
Around his shins; then put the
breastplate on
That Cinyras had given him, a
guest-gift.

Cinyras, hearing in Cyprus that the
Achaeans
Would sail to Troy, had sent it to
please the king.
Ten dark-blue bands ran around it,
twelve of gold,
And twenty of tin; three dark-blue
serpents rose
Toward the neck on either side, like
rainbows
The son of Cronus sets within a
cloud,
A sign to mortal men.
Around his shoulders he hung a
sword with golden nails,
Its silver scabbard held by golden
straps. He took
A great shield, elaborate and terrible:
ten bronze
Rings circled it, twenty white bosses
of tin,
And at its center one dark-blue boss.
Upon it
Was the grim-eyed Gorgon; around
her Deimos walked
And Phobos. A silver strap held the
shield,
And a dark-blue serpent twisted
along it,
Three heads arising from a single
neck.
He set upon his head a four-bossed
helmet,
Horse-haired, with a dreadful crest,
and took two spears,
Powerful, sharpened with bronze.
The bronze flashed
Toward heaven, while Athena and
Hera thundered

In honor of the king of golden
Mycenae.
Each man instructed his charioteer
to hold the horses
In order by the trench. The foot
soldiers, armed,
Surged forward; an unquenchable
cry rose before morning.
Chariots reached the trench first;
horsemen followed,
A little way behind. From above,
Zeus sent
A bloody mist of dew from the clear
air,
Because many strong heads were
destined for Hades.
On the other side the Trojans
gathered round
Great Hector, blameless Polydamas,
and Aeneas,
Honored among them like a god,
with the three sons
Of Antenor—Polybus, shining
Agenor,
And Acamas, like immortals. Hector
bore
A shield that covered him on every
side;
At times he shone among the
foremost like a baleful star
That breaks from cloud, then sinks
again in shadow.
So he appeared in front and then
behind,
Giving his orders; all his bronze
flashed like
The lightning of aegis-bearing Zeus.
Trojans and Achaeans rushed on one
another,

Like reapers driving rows against
each other
Through the rich field of a wealthy
man, cutting
Wheat or barley, while the dense
handfuls fall.
They slaughtered, and neither side
remembered
Ruinous flight. The battle held them
equal;
The fighters rushed like wolves.
Strife alone rejoiced.
None of the other gods came among
them, but sat
At ease in their own halls on Mount
Olympus.
All blamed dark-clouded Cronus'
son, because
He meant to give the Trojans glory.
But the Father
Did not care; he sat apart, rejoicing
in his power,
Watching Troy and the Achaean
ships, the flash
Of bronze, the killing and the killed.
While morning lasted and the sacred
day grew strong,
Missiles struck both sides, and men
fell. But when
A woodcutter has prepared his meal
among
The mountain valleys, his hands
tired from cutting
Tall trees, and hunger has come upon
him, then
The Danaans, calling rank by rank,
broke
The battalions. Agamemnon sprang
first.

He killed Bienor, shepherd of the
people, who leapt
From his horses and stood against
him; straight
Through his forehead drove the
spear, and heavy bronze
Passed through the bone and
scattered all his brains.
Then he struck Oileus, the
horse-driver,
As he came on, and left both men
there,
Their shining breastplates stripped.
Then he came upon Isus and
Antiphus, two sons
Of Priam, borne together in a single
car—
One bastard-born, the other from
the marriage bed.
Achilles, once upon the slopes of Ida,
Had found them shepherding, and
bound them fast
With pliant willow; then he let them
go,
Accepting ransom. Now the son of
Atreus
Struck Isus through the breast;
beside the ear
He drove the sword into Antiphus
and cast
Them from the horses. Eagerly he
stripped
Their shining armor, knowing it
from the day
When swift Achilles led them down
from Ida.
As when a lion in the forest finds
The hidden fawns of a swift deer,
and bears

The tender young away, while far off
runs
The mother, trembling through the
shadowed trees,
So none could save the sons of Troy
that day;
They fled before the Argives, each
from each.
Then Agamemnon seized Pisander,
strong
Hippolochus, the sons of
Antimachus,
Who, bribed with Alexander's
shining gold,
Had barred the return of fair-haired
Menelaus
With Helen. Both were driven in one
chariot;
Their horses fled, and from the reins
they fell,
Confounded, on their knees before
the king.
"Take us alive, O son of Atreus; take
Our ransom. In Antimachus's house
lie stores
Of bronze and gold and iron
wrought with care.
Our father, hearing that we still
drew breath
Among the ships, would pay an
endless price."
But Agamemnon answered, hard as
bronze:
"If you are sons of that Antimachus
Who once in Troy's assembly urged
the death
Of Menelaus and the godlike son
Of Laertes, when they came as
messengers,

Then pay your father's shame." He
struck Pisander
Through the chest and hurled him
from the car.
Hippolochus leapt down; the sword
took hands
And neck, and sent his body rolling
through
The crowd, as down a hillside rolls a
stone.
Then, with the bronze-clad Danaans,
he rushed
Wherever battle thickened. Footmen
slew
The footmen fleeing; horsemen
struck the horsemen;
Dust climbed beneath the
hammering hooves, and bronze
Fed on the ranks, while Agamemnon
pressed
Behind them, shouting, driving on
the Argives.
As when a wind-fed fire runs
through a wood
Grown dry beneath the summer sun,
and shrubs
Fall root and branch before the
leaping flame,
So Trojan heads fell underneath the
king;
And many high-necked horses
dragged their cars
Unmanned through battle, grieving
for the hands
That once had held them. There the
dead lay strewn,
More welcome to the vultures than
their wives.
But Zeus drew Hector from the
spears, the dust,

The slaughter and the blood.
Agamemnon still
Pressed after, shouting orders to the
ranks.
They crossed the plain beside the
ancient mound
Of Ilus, Dardanus's son, and near
The fig tree, making for the city
walls.
Hector came crying, both his hands
blood-stained.
At last, beneath the Skaian Gates,
beside
The beech, the Trojans wheeled and
formed their line;
Yet many fled across the middle
plain.
As cattle scatter when a lion springs
Upon them in the darkness, seizes
one
By the neck, and first breaks it with
his teeth,
Then tears the blood and entrails
from its body,
So Agamemnon hunted those who
lagged,
And still he killed them as the
Trojans fled.
When now the host drew near the
steep city wall,
Zeus, father of the gods and men,
had come
Down from the sky and sat upon the
heights
Of Ida, holding thunder in his hand.
He sent gold-winged Iris to summon
Hector:
"Swift Iris, go; deliver this to Hector:
While he beholds the shepherd
Agamemnon

Raging among the foremost, cutting
down
The ranks of men, let him withdraw
and bid
The rest stand fast within the
hard-fought battle.
But when the king is struck by spear
or arrow
And leaps among his horses, I will
give
Hector the strength to kill until he
reaches
The well-benched ships, until the sun
goes down
And holy darkness gathers over all.”
Wind-footed Iris obeyed and came
to Troy.
She found the son of Priam among
the cars
And horses joined together, and
spoke near him:
“Hector, son of Priam, equal in
counsel
To Zeus, your father sends this word:
while still
You see the son of Atreus raging
forth
And cutting men, give ground before
him; order
The army’s rest to meet the enemy’s
shock.
But when spear or arrow strikes him,
and he leaps
Into his horses, Zeus will give you
power
To kill until you reach the ships,
until
The sun goes down and holy
darkness comes.”

Hector sprang from his chariot,
shook his spears,
And passed through all the host,
awakening
The hateful battle. Ranks turned face
to face;
The Argives closed their own. The
lines were set,
And Agamemnon leapt before them
all,
Eager to fight in the foremost place.
Tell me now, Muses, who inhabit
Olympus,
Who first came forth against the son
of Atreus,
Trojan or famous ally. Iphidamas,
The noble son of Antenor, first stood
there.
In fertile Thrace, the mother of
sheep, he grew;
Cisseus, his mother’s father, raised
him young,
Then kept him in his house when
manhood came,
And gave to him his daughter. From
her chamber
The bridegroom came with honor,
bringing twelve
Curved ships; he left them moored at
Perkote,
And walked to Ilium. There he met
the king.
Their spears flew wide. Iphidamas
struck below
The breastplate’s belt and leaned his
whole weight on it;
The spear could not pass through the
many-colored
Belt, but turned back like lead
against bright silver.

Agamemnon seized it in his broad
hand,
And tugged, a lion's strength, until it
broke
From Iphidamas. Then with the
sword he struck
His neck and loosed his limbs. Far
from his bride
He fell into the bronze sleep, without
joy
Of marriage, though he had
promised for her sake
A hundred cattle first, then thousand
goats
And sheep to fill her father's house.
The son of Atreus stripped his armor
clean
And bore it through the Achaean
throng. But Coon,
The eldest son of Antenor, saw his
brother fall;
Grief darkened both his eyes.
Unseen, he came
Beside the king and struck his arm
below
The elbow; the spear's point passed
through. The lord
Of men shuddered, yet did not leave
the fight.
He rushed at Coon with spear aloft,
while Coon
Dragged by the foot Iphidamas,
calling out
To all the strongest. As he drew the
body
Beneath his bossed shield,
Agamemnon drove
The bronze into him, loosed his
knees, and stood

Above him, cutting off his head. So
both
The sons of Antenor fulfilled their
fate
Beneath the hand of Atreus and went
down
Into the house of Hades.
Still Agamemnon moved among the
ranks
With spear and sword and stones,
while warm blood rose
From his wound. When the wound
grew dry and blood
No longer flowed, a sharper pain
came on—
As when the daughters of harsh
Hera, birth's
Relentless powers, send cutting
pangs through one
In labor. So the pain entered the
king.
He leapt into his chariot and ordered
his
Driver to bear him to the hollow
ships;
His heart was troubled. Then he
called aloud:
"Friends, leaders, masters of the
Argives, now
Defend the seafaring ships against
this war.
Zeus the counselor has not allowed
me
To fight the Trojans through the
whole long day."
The driver lashed the long-maned
horses on;
They flew toward the ships, foam
upon their chests,

Dust rising underneath them,
bearing off
The king, exhausted by the work of
war.
When Hector saw Agamemnon
leave, he called
To Trojans, Lycians, Dardanians,
men
Who fight at close range: "Be men,
my friends,
Remember your warlike strength.
The best has gone;
The son of Cronus grants me glory
now.
Drive your one-hoofed horses
straight against
The strong Danaans, and win greater
fame."
He roused each heart, then fell upon
the Greeks
As a hunter slips the white-toothed
dogs
Against a wild boar or a mountain
lion.
Like murderous Ares, Priam's son
drove on
The great-hearted Trojans. He
himself moved first,
And struck the battle like a sudden
wind
That leaps upon the violet sea and
stirs it.
Then Hector cut down the Danaans'
leaders,
And after them the multitude, as
when
The West Wind drives the South
before a storm,
Rolling a mighty wave and scattering
foam

Beneath the wandering blast. The
people's heads
Fell under Hector; helplessness and
ruin
Would have swept through them,
driving them to the ships,
Had not Odysseus called to
Diomedes:
"Son of Tydeus, what has become of
us?
Have we forgotten all our warlike
courage?
Come, dear companion, stand beside
me here.
It will be shame if Hector takes the
ships."
Diomedes answered: "I will stay and
endure;
Yet brief will be our joy, for Zeus,
the gatherer
Of clouds, desires to strengthen
Troy, not us."
He struck Thymbraeus from his
horses through
The left breast; godlike Molion fell
Beneath Odysseus. Leaving both
behind,
They passed through all the crowd,
rejoicing
As two wild boars that turn upon the
hounds.
Trojans died before them; and the
Greeks,
Who had fled, drew breath from
Hector's hands.
They seized a chariot and the two
best sons
Of Merops of Percote. Their father
knew

The arts of prophecy and had
forbidden
His sons to enter man-destroying
war;
But they would not obey. The black
fates led them.
Diomedes, famous with the spear,
stripped
Them of their lives and splendid
armor; then
Odysseus killed Hippodamus and
strong
Hypeirochus. From Ida Cronus's son
Watched, stretching battle evenly;
both sides
Struck down their enemies, neither
yielding.
The son of Tydeus struck
Agastrophus,
The Paeonian, in the hip. His horses
stood
Too far away; his spirit had gone
astray,
And while his driver held them off,
he walked
Among the foremost and
surrendered life.
Hector saw him through the ranks
and sprang
Against them, shouting, with the
Trojans after.
Diomedes shuddered when he saw
him come,
And called to his companion: "This
great Hector
Rolls ruin toward us. Let us stand
and turn him."
He cast his long-shadowed spear and
struck

The crown of Hector's helmet.
Bronze glanced off
The metal, and did not touch his
lovely flesh;
Apollo's triple-layered helmet held.
Hector sprang back, fell upon his
knees, and leaned
Upon his broad hand; blackness
covered him.
While Diomedes ran through the
foremost ranks
To take his spear, Hector recovered
breath,
Leapt to his chariot, drove into the
crowd,
And for that moment escaped the
black death.
Diomedes shouted after him: "Dog,
again
You have escaped death. Evil came
close,
But Phoebus saved you, the god you'll
pray to
When once you enter where the
spears resound.
I will destroy you later, if some god
Will stand beside me. Now I'll follow
those
Whom I can reach." Then he
stripped the life
From that renowned Paeonian.
Alexander, Helen's fair-haired
husband,
Stretched his bow against the
shepherd Diomedes,
Leaning beside the pillar of the
ancient
Tomb of Dardanian Ilus. While the
son

Of Tydeus stripped the breastplate,
shield, and helm
From Agastrophus, Paris drew the
bow
And shot. The arrow did not leave
his hand
In vain: it struck the instep of the
right
Foot and stood fixed in the earth.
Then Paris sprang
From hiding and laughed softly:
“You are hit; my arrow has not flown
in vain.
Would that it had struck your belly
and taken
Your life! Troy then would breathe
again, as goats
Bleat before a lion when they see him
come.”
Unshaken, Diomedes answered:
“Archer,
Foul boaster, watcher of girls—if you
dared
To meet me face to face in bronze,
your bow
And thick arrows could not protect
you. You have
Scratched my foot and boast as if
you’d achieved
Some great deed; I care no more than
if a woman
Or foolish child had struck me. A
coward’s shaft
Is dull. But even the smallest arrow I
Send makes a man lie dead: his wife
will tear
Both cheeks, his children stand as
orphans, and he
Will redden earth while birds gather
more thickly

Around him than women at a
funeral.”
As he spoke, renowned Odysseus
came near
And stood before him. Diomedes sat
behind
His shield, pulled the swift arrow
from his foot,
And grievous pain ran burning
through his flesh.
He leapt into his chariot and ordered
The driver toward the hollow ships;
his heart
Was troubled.
Odysseus stood alone with spear in
hand;
None of the Argives stayed beside
him. Fear
Had seized them. Grieving, he spoke
to his proud heart:
“What shall I do? It is a bitter thing
To flee in fear of numbers; worse to
be
Taken alone. Cronus’s son has driven
The Danaans away. Yet why does my
heart
Reason like this? I know the coward
leaves
The battle; whoever is best in war
Must stand his ground, whether he
has struck
Or has himself been struck.”
While he considered, Trojan ranks
closed round
And hemmed him in, bringing
disaster to
Their own midst. As strong young
hounds surround
A wild boar from the forest,
sharpening

Its white tusk between its curved
jaws, while he
Stands fast despite their danger, so
the Trojans
Rushed around Odysseus, dear to
Zeus.
He struck Deïopites above the
shoulder,
Killed Thoön and Ennomus; when
Chersidamas
Sprang from his horses, Odysseus
struck him low
Beneath the bossed shield, beneath
the navel.
He fell in dust and clutched the
earth.
Odysseus left them and struck
Charops, son
Of Hippasus, and Socus's own
brother.
Socus, a man like a god, came to
guard him,
And stood close by:
"Much-praised Odysseus, insatiable
For toil and trickery, today you'll
boast
Of killing both the sons of Hippasus
And bearing off their armor; or
today
Your spirit leaves you, struck
beneath my spear."
He struck Odysseus' shield. The
mighty spear
Passed through the shining shield
and breastplate bright,
And tore the flesh from his side—but
Pallas Athena
Would not permit it to reach his
entrails.

Odysseus knew the wound was not
yet mortal.
He stepped back and spoke: "Poor
man, your steep
Death has already found you. You
have stopped
My fighting, but today black fate is
yours.
Struck by my spear, you'll give me
glory here
And give your soul to Hades." Socus
turned
And fled; but as he showed his back,
Odysseus
Planted the spear between his
shoulders. Bronze
Came through his chest, and down
he fell with a crash.
Odysseus cried in triumph: "Socus,
son
Of Hippasus, death's end has reached
you; you
Have not escaped it. Neither father
nor
Your queenly mother will close your
eyes in death;
The raw-eating birds will drag you,
spreading wide
Their wings around you. But if I
should die,
The noble Achaeans will give me
burial."
He pulled the heavy spear from flesh
and shield;
Blood rushed out from the wound
and troubled him.
When the great-hearted Trojans saw
his blood,
They rushed upon him shouting. He
drew back

And called his comrades. Three
times he cried aloud,
As loudly as a man's head can
contain;
Three times Menelaus, dear to Ares,
heard.
He quickly called to Ajax, Telamon's
son:
"Godlike Ajax, lord of men, the cry
Of steadfast Odysseus reaches me,
Like one surrounded by the Trojans,
alone.
Come through the crowd; it is our
task to guard him.
I fear that, isolated there, this
excellent
Man will be harmed, and all the
Danaans grieve."
He led the way; and Ajax, equal to
the gods,
Followed. They found Odysseus
surrounded
By Trojans, as red wolves surround a
stag
With antlers wounded. While the
warm blood and strength
Remain, the stag escapes; but when
the arrow
Overcomes him, flesh-eating wolves
tear him
Apart in shadowed hills. A god had
driven
The wolves upon him; yet they
scattered when
Ajax came near, and he stood over
his friend
As a lion stands above its cubs.
Many strong Trojans followed; Ajax
came,

Bearing a shield as broad and tall as a
tower.
He stood beside him, and the
Trojans scattered.
Menelaus, dear to Ares, led Odysseus
By the hand out of the crowd, until
the driver
Drove near the horses. Ajax sprang
among
The Trojans and struck Doryclus,
bastard son
Of Priam, then Pandocus, Lysander,
Pyrus,
And Pylarte. As a swollen river
rushes
Down from the mountains after
Zeus's rain,
Carrying dry oaks and pines into the
sea,
And casting driftwood in heaps upon
the shore,
So shining Ajax drove them over the
plain,
Cutting down horses and men.
Nor had Hector yet heard of this, for
he
Was fighting on the left beside the
banks
Of Scamander, where the heads of
men fell thick,
And round old Nestor and
Idomeneus
The battle's cry rose without end.
With spear
And chariot Hector mingled in the
fight,
And broke the ranks of young men,
till the Greeks
Had yielded ground; but Alexander,
husband

Of fair-haired Helen, checked
Machaon,
The shepherd of the people, with an
arrow
Three-pointed, striking through his
right shoulder.
Then all the Achaeans, drawing
breath in fear,
Were troubled lest the battle turn,
and they
Should lose the healer whom they
loved.
Idomeneus called aloud to Nestor:
“Come, son of Neleus, glory of the
Greeks;
Mount now your chariot, and let
Machaon
Climb up beside you. Drive your
single-hoofed
Horses with all their speed toward
the hollow ships.
A healer is a man of worth to many:
He cuts the arrows out, and lays on
them
The quiet medicines that soothe the
pain.”
Then Nestor climbed the chariot,
and Machaon,
The blameless son of Asclepius,
mounted.
He touched the horses with the
shining lash;
And willingly they flew toward the
ships,
For there they loved to be.
But Cebriones, who stood beside the
son
Of Priam, saw the Trojan ranks
confused,

And spoke: “We fight the Danaans at
the edge
Of this hard battle, while the other
Trojans
And all their horses mingle in the
crowd.
Telamonian Ajax drives them back;
I know him well: his broad shield
covers him.
Let us drive there, where horsemen
and the men
On foot, with hateful strife, destroy
each other,
And where the shouting cannot be
restrained.”
He struck the long-maned horses
with the lash.
They bore the chariot through the
Greeks and Trojans,
Over the dead, over the shields; the
axle
And rims were splashed with blood
from hooves and wheels.
Hector desired to enter that dense
human
Wave and break it, yet feared the
great Ajax.
Then Zeus, the father, sent a sudden
fear
Upon the son of Telamon. Amazed,
He threw his sevenfold shield behind
him, turned
And looked about him, shifting knee
by knee,
Like some wild beast that leaves the
fold at dawn.
As shepherds and their dogs drive off
a tawny
Lion, and through the night deny it
flesh,

While it moves forward still, yet
gains no ground,
For spears of fire spring round it; so
Ajax,
His heart unwilling, drew away,
afraid
For the Achaean ships.
As when a patient ass beside a field
Breaks through the boys, though
many sticks are broken
Upon its back, and though they beat
it hard,
Yet drive it forth at last only when it
has
Eaten its fill; so Trojans and their
allies
Kept thrusting at the shield of
mighty Ajax.
At times remembering all his
battle-strength,
He turned and checked the
horse-taming Trojans;
Then turned again and fled. Yet all
the while
He kept them from the ships, and
stood between
The Greeks and Troy. The spears of
eager hands
Stuck in the shield, some in its face;
and some,
Before they touched his flesh, fell
into earth.
Eurypylus, the glorious son of
Euaemon,
Saw Ajax pressed by that unceasing
storm.
He stood beside him and cast forth
his spear,
And struck Apisaon beneath the
liver.

His knees gave way; Eurypylus
sprang upon him
And stripped the armor from his
shoulders. Then
Alexander saw him bending over the
slain,
And drew his bow; the arrow struck
the thigh
Of Eurypylus, and broke within the
flesh.
His leg grew heavy. He withdrew
among
His comrades, fleeing death, and
called aloud:
“Friends, princes and commanders of
the Greeks,
Turn, stand against this evil day, and
save
Great Ajax, crushed beneath the
flight of arrows.
I do not think he will escape this
battle.
Stand firmly round him!”
He spoke, though wounded; and the
men drew close,
Their shields together, lifted up their
spears.
Ajax came toward them, turning
back his face
To see his comrades. The two armies
fought
Like a fire burning through a field.
Meanwhile old Nestor’s horses,
sweating, bore
Machaon from the battle.
Swift-footed Achilles,
Standing upon the stern of his great
ship,
Saw them and watched the terrible
exchange,

The strife of men, the tears. At once
he called
To his companion, Patroclus; and his
voice
Was heard beside the ship. Patroclus
came
From the shelter like the god of
war—then first
The beginning of his evil came upon
him.
“Why call me, noble Achilles?” he
asked.
“What service do you need of me?”
Achilles answered: “Dear Menoetius’
son,
Beloved of my heart, I think the
Greeks
Will soon stand round my knees and
beg for aid;
So great a need has fallen on them
now.
Go, dear Patroclus, ask old Nestor
whom
He carries wounded from the field.
From behind
The man appeared like Machaon to
me,
The son of Asclepius; but I could not
See his face, for the horses swept
between us.”
He spoke, and Patroclus obeyed his
friend,
Running beside the huts and hollow
ships.
Then Nestor and Machaon, from the
chariot,
Stepped down upon the earth beside
the sea,
And wiped the sweat from off their
tunics, while

The sea-wind cooled them. In the
shelter, then,
Hecamede of the lovely braided hair,
The daughter of Arsinoüs, whom
Achilles
Had taken from Tenedos, and the
Greeks
Had given to old Nestor for his
excellence,
Set forth a polished table, dark of
foot.
Upon it stood a cup of bronze,
four-eared,
With golden studs, and doves of gold
beside
Each handle; and she mingled
Pramnian wine
With cheese of goat, scraped by the
bronze, and meal
Of shining barley, and bade them
drink.
Then Patroclus came near. The old
man rose
And welcomed him; but he refused
the seat.
“No time for sitting,” he replied, “is
here.
Tell me whom you have brought,
struck down from battle.”
Already, looking closely, he had seen
Machaon, son of that great healer,
and
Would bear the tidings to Achilles’
tent.
And Nestor answered: “Why does
Peleus’ son,
Though he can see the grief of all the
host,
Not understand the grief that fills
our ranks?

The chiefs are wounded: Diomedes
lies
Apart, and the spear wounded
Odysseus;
Agamemnon also suffers, and
Eurypylus is stricken in the thigh.
The best of us lie helpless by the
ships.
Will Achilles wait until the black
ships burn,
And all the Argives perish at the
sea?"
Then Nestor told the strength of
former days,
When he had fought the Epeans for
their debt.
He slew Itymoneus, and took their
teams,
Fifty dark chariots, and from each
two men;
The sons of Actor, famous horsemen
both,
The Moliones, he had nearly slain,
Had not Poseidon hidden them in
mist.
He told how from Pylos they drove
away
The cattle, sheep, and swine, and
mares of war;
How through the night they
marched, and how Athena
Had called him to the battle; how his
father,
Old Neleus, hid his horses, thinking
him
Unpracticed in the handling of a
team;
How by the Minyeian river they
Made offering to Zeus, Alpheius,
lord

Of silver streams, Poseidon of the
deep,
And bright-eyed Pallas; how the
Epeans fell.
There Mulius, son-in-law of Augeias,
And husband of Agamede, fell—she
knew
The medicines that the nourishing
earth brings forth—
And Nestor seized his chariot, and
took fifty
More teams. The sons of Actor
escaped alone,
When mist from their sea-father hid
them there.
"If youth and strength were mine
again," he said,
"Then Achilles would win a glory
greater
Than any valor of my former time.
Yet tell him what your father
charged you, when
You left the house of Menoetius. He
said:
'Achilles is the greater, by his birth
And strength; but you are older.
Speak wise words
Before him, and advise him. If he still
Withholds himself, obeying
prophecy
Or his dear mother's warning, go
forth armed
With all the Myrmidons. Put on his
arms,
And let the Trojans think Achilles
comes.
So might the Argives draw a little
breath,
Though only for a moment, from the
war.'"

He ceased; and Patroclus ran beside
the ships,
Toward where Achilles waited. But
Eurypylus,
The son of Euaemon, limped from
battle,
An arrow fast within his thigh. The
sweat
Ran down his shoulders and his
head, and dark
Blood streamed from that grievous
wound; his mind,
Though shaken, still remained
steadfast. He saw
Patroclus and cried out: "Save me,
my friend!
Lead me within your hut; draw forth
the shaft
That pierces me, and wash away the
blood
With warm water. Then sprinkle
gentle herbs,
The medicines, men say, that
Achilles learned
From Chiron, justest of the
Centaurs. Our
Physicians, Podalirius and Machaon,
Are wounded or are needed
elsewhere; and I
Have held my ground until you
came."
Then pity seized Patroclus. "I cannot
leave
A man in such distress," he answered
him,
"For Nestor sent me to the son of
Peleus."
He led him to the hut. A servant
spread

The hides; Patroclus stretched the
wounded thigh,
And with his knife cut out the bitter
arrow.
He washed the black blood with
warm water, then
Ground down a bitter root and
rubbed it in.
The wound grew dry; the dark blood
ceased to flow;
Yet still the anguish held Eurypylus.

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Patroclus tends Eurypylus and carries the crisis toward Achilles

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's
Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 12

First-pass working translation

While Patroclus within his shelter
cared
For wounded Eurypylus, the Argives
fought
With Troy in close confusion; yet the
trench
And wall above it could no longer
hold.
The wall was broad, and built to
guard the ships,
With a deep trench driven round it.
Not with rites
And hecatombs that please the
deathless gods
Had mortal hands laid its
foundations there;
And therefore it was never made to
stand.
So long as Hector lived, while still
Achilles
Nursed his anger, and Priam's city
Remained unbroken, so long that
great work
Endured. But when the bravest
Trojans fell,
And many Argives too, and Priam's
town
Was taken in the tenth returning
year,
And all the Greeks sailed homeward,
then Poseidon
And Apollo would devise its ruin.
They
Would turn the rivers on it: Rhesus,
clear
Heptaporus, Caresus, Rhodius,

Grenicus, Aesepus, sacred
Scamander,
And Simoeis, where so many shields
And helmets sank, and races born of
gods.
Apollo would turn all their mouths
against
The wall, and drive their waters nine
full days;
And Zeus would rain continually,
until
The sea-born work grew smooth.
Earth-Shaking Lord
Poseidon, holding his trident, would
lead on,
And send the stones and timbers of
its base
Away upon the waves. Then on the
shore
Beside the loud Hellespont he would
level it,
Cover the beach with sand, and turn
the streams
Back to the channels where they ran
before.
Such things the gods would
accomplish afterward;
But now the battle burned around
the wall,
And towers rang beneath the
striking spears.
The Argives, scourged by Zeus, were
penned beside
The hollow ships, and feared the
strength of Hector.
He moved before them like a
whirlwind; as
A boar or lion turns and tests the
dogs

And men who stand in ranks, while
spears fly thick,
Yet does not tremble or withdraw,
although
His courage is his death; wherever he
Rushes, the close ranks open—so did
Hector
Urge his companions to cross over.
But
His horses snorted at the trench, and
stood
Upon its edge. It was too broad and
steep
To leap or enter, and the stakes
stood thick
Above its banks, a fence against the
foe.
No chariot could pass; the footmen
longed
To find a way.
Then bold Polydamas stood near and
spoke:
“Hector, and you, commanders of the
Trojans
And allies, we drive our eager horses
blind
Into the trench, though stakes stand
there, and make
The passage hard. The way is narrow;
there
We cannot fight on horseback, and I
fear
Our men will be struck down. If
Zeus, who now
Has evil thoughts for us, will aid the
Trojans,
Then I would gladly see the Argives
die
Here, nameless, far from Argos. But
if they

Should drive us back, and cast us in
the trench,
No messenger, I think, would reach
the town
Again, once they had closed their
ranks around us.
“Come, let us follow counsel. Let
attendants
Hold fast the horses here beside the
trench;
We, clothed in bronze, will follow
Hector on foot,
Together. If destruction has indeed
Been fastened on the Greeks, they
will not stand.”
So Polydamas spoke, and Hector
welcomed
The harmless counsel. From his
chariot
He leapt in armor; all the others too
Left their swift horses. Each man
charged his driver
To keep the teams in order by the
trench.
Then they were ranged in five
assembled bands.
With Hector and Polydamas went
the first,
The largest and the best, most eager
to break
The wall and fight beside the ships;
with them
Went Cebriones. Paris led the next,
With Alcathous and Agenor.
Helenus
And godlike Deiphobus, Priam’s
sons,
Led the third band, and Asius, son of
Hyrtacus.
Aeneas, splendid son of Anchises, led

The fourth, with both the sons of
Antenor,
Archelochus and Acamas, skilled in
war.
Sarpedon led the famous allies, and
chose
Beside him Glaucus and
Asteropeon,
Whom, after himself, he judged the
best.
All others followed Polydamas's
word;
But Asius, lord of men, would not
leave
His horses and attendant. Fool, he
drove
Toward the ships, though never
would he flee
The evil death that waited there, nor
turn
To windy Ilium in pride again.
Idomeneus, Deucalion's son, would
meet him.
Asius came upon the left of all the
ships,
Where Greeks returned from battle
with their cars.
The gates stood open, and the long
bar was not
Drawn against the fugitives; two
Lapiths stood
Before them, Polypoetes, son of him
Who once was Pirithous, and
Leonteus,
Like murderous Ares among mortal
men.
They stood before the lofty gates like
oaks
Upon a mountain, whose deep roots
hold fast

Against the rain and wind. Trusting
their hands,
They waited without fear. The
Trojans came
With shields of ox-hide, raising one
great cry,
And gathered round their leaders.
Within,
The Greeks called out to one
another, "Save
The ships!" But when they saw the
assault draw near,
The two sprang forth like boars
within the hills,
That wait the hunters and their dogs,
then turn
And break the thicket, striking
sideways, till
A man brings one beneath the spear.
The bronze rang on the chests of
men who met;
From tower to tower the rough
stones fell, to guard
The wall, the huts, the ships. They
fell like snow
When violent wind shakes dark
clouds and pours
Them thickly over earth. From either
hand
The weapons streamed; the hollow
shields and helmets
Cried beneath blows.
Then Asius struck his thigh and
groaned aloud:
"O Father Zeus, you too are wholly
false!
I thought the Greeks could never
stand before
Our strength, when no one could
restrain our hands."

Yet still the two stood firm, like
wasps or bees
Whose house is by a rugged road;
they will not
Leave their hollow dwelling, but
defend their young
And drive the hunters from it. So
they stayed
Before the gates, until they killed, or
fell.
Nor did the mind of Zeus bend to
the words
Of Asius; for his heart desired the
glory
Of Hector.
Elsewhere the battle rose at every
gate;
Hard would it be for me, though like
a god,
To tell the deeds of all. A storm of
stones
Was everywhere; and under force the
Greeks
Defended the ships. The gods who
stood beside
The Danaans were troubled, and the
Lapiths
Came into battle. There Polypoetes
struck
Damasus through his bronze-cheeked
helmet; spear
And bone gave way. Then Pylon and
Ormenus
He stripped. Leonteus, branch of
Ares, struck
Hippomachus beneath the belt; then
drew
His sword and, leaping through the
crowd, struck down
Antiphates. After him fell Menon,

Iamenus, and Orestes, one by one.
While they stripped the armor from
the fallen,
The first and greatest companies
stood still,
Uncertain by the trench, though
eager to
Break through the wall and set the
ships aflame.
Then from the left an eagle crossed
the sky,
High in the air, and in his crooked
claws
He carried a great serpent, red and
living.
The snake, though held, had not
forgotten war:
It twisted backward, struck the bird
beneath
The breast beside the throat. The
eagle writhed
Against the pain, and let the serpent
fall
Among the ranks; then, crying, flew
away
Upon the breath of wind.
The Trojans shuddered at the
gleaming snake,
The sign of Zeus who bears the aegis.
Then
Polydamas stood close to Hector:
“You
Rebuke me in the assembly when I
speak
What seems the better course; you
say a common
Man must not pass the council’s
bounds. But now
I say: let us not fight beside the ships.

This sign has come to those who
wished to cross.
The eagle flew upon the left and held
The people back; he carried that
great snake
Alive, but could not take it to his
home
And feed it to his children. So,
although
We break the wall and gates by force,
we shall
Not all return along the road we
came;
Many will lie beside the ships. If one
Among us standing here declared the
sign,
No army would resist him. To my
mind
The meaning is plain: we shall force
the wall,
But shall not all come home.”
Then Hector, helmet-bright, looked
darkly at him:
“Your words no longer please me,
Polydamas.
You know to contrive a better speech
than this;
But if you speak it in earnest, then
the gods
Have taken reason from you. Would
you have me
Forget the will of Zeus, who thunder
speaks,
The will he promised me and sealed
with a nod?
You bid me heed the long-winged
birds; I care
Not whether they fly toward the
dawn and sun,

Or toward the misty darkness on the
left.
Let us obey the purpose of great
Zeus,
Who rules the mortal and immortal
kind.
“One omen is the best: to fight for
home.
Why fear the battle and the work of
death?
Though all the rest should fall beside
the ships,
You have no fear of being killed;
your heart
Is neither warlike nor steadfast. But
if you
Hold back from battle, or by words
turn one
Man from the fight, then underneath
my spear
You shall at once lose all the breath
of life.”
So speaking, he led on; and all
behind
Followed with a clamor. Zeus, who
loves the
Thunder, raised from Ida a storm of
wind
That drove the dust straight toward
the ships,
And clouded all the Achaeans’
minds, while glory
Was given to the Trojans and to
Hector.
Trusting the sign and their own
strength, they sought
To break the mighty wall.
They tore the battlements from off
the towers,

Threw down the parapets, and pried
up pillars
That first the Greeks had planted in
the earth
To strengthen their defenses.
Dragging these away,
They hoped to shatter all the
Achaean work;
Yet still the Danaans held fast, and
fenced
The parapets with ox-hide shields,
and hurled
Their weapons at the men below the
wall.
The two Ajaxes went from tower to
tower,
Calling commands, and stirring up
the strength
Of all the Greeks. One man they
urged with gentle
Words, another they rebuked,
whenever one
Abandoned wholly the defense:
“Friends of Argos,
Whether you stand among the first,
the middle,
Or those less strong, this labor is for
all.
You know that men are not alike in
war.
Let no man turn toward the ships
when he hears
Our cry; draw courage from your
fellow, and Zeus,
The thunder-bearing Olympian, may
grant
That we drive back the foe, and
chase him even
To the city.”

Thus they called out, and stones flew
from both sides,
As snowflakes fall upon a winter day
When Zeus has risen, stilling all the
winds,
And pours the flakes upon the
nourishing earth,
Covering the mountain peaks, the
headlands,
The lotus-bearing plains, and all the
works
Of men; it covers the gray sea, the
harbors,
And beaches, and the wave that
strikes the shore
Holds the thick snow upon it. So the
stones
Flew thickly from both hands, and
all the wall
Roared underneath their fall.
Nor could the Trojans and bright
Hector then
Have broken through the gates and
their long bar,
Had Zeus, the counselor, not driven
his own son,
Sarpedon, at the Argives like a lion
Turned upon cattle. Round before
his breast
He held a rounded shield, beautiful,
Beaten from bronze, which some
smith hammered and
Then lined with many hides of oxen,
sewn
In circles, fastened with the golden
rods.
Two spears he brandished, moving
like a lion
That hunger for the flesh has long
consumed,

And fearless courage drives against
the fold.
Even when shepherds, dogs, and
spears guard there,
He is not ignorant of the attack:
He either springs and carries off his
prey,
Or, in the foremost, falls beneath a
spear.
So Sarpedon's heart urged him at the
wall
To tear the battlements away. He
called
To Glaucus, son of mighty
Hippolochus:
"Glaucus, why are we honored above
all others
In Lycia—in our seats, our portions,
and
The fuller cups of wine? All men
look on us
As on the gods, and we possess a
great
Estate beside the Xanthus: lovely
orchards,
And wheat-bearing fields. Therefore
we must stand
Among the foremost, meet the
burning fight,
That some Lycian in his close armor
say:
'Our kings do not rule Lycia without
glory.
They eat the fat sheep and drink
excellent,
Honeyed wine; but their strength too
is noble,
For they fight in the foremost ranks.'
"If fleeing from this war could make
us always

Without old age or death, I would
not fight
Among the first, nor send you into
danger
Where men win glory. But the
countless fates
Of death stand near; no mortal can
evade them.
Come, then: let us give another glory,
Or let another give that glory to us."
So he spoke; and Glaucus did not
turn away,
Nor would he refuse. Together they
advanced,
Leading the great Lycian host.
Mnestheus, the son of Peteus, saw
them come,
And shuddered, for they carried ruin
toward
His tower. He searched the wall for
one who might
Defend his friends, and saw the two
great Ajaxes,
Never weary in the war, and Teucer
near,
Newly returned from his shelter. But
the din
Was so immense he could not make
his voice
Be heard above the cries that reached
the sky,
The blows on shields and
horse-haired helmets, and
The gates where every entrance was
beset.
At once he sent the herald Thoötes:
"Run, noble herald, call the two
Ajaxes.
Let both come here; the steep edge of
destruction

Will soon be met. The Lycian leaders
rise
With all the strength they showed in
former battles.
But if the conflict has begun here
too,
Let Telamonian Ajax come alone,
The strong one, and let Teucer
follow him,
Skilled in the bow.”
The herald did not disobey. He ran
Beside the wall, stood close to both
the Ajaxes,
And spoke: “Leaders of the Argives
in bronze,
The son of Peteus bids you come,
that you
May meet the labor here, if only for
A little while. The steep edge of
destruction
Will soon be met; the Lycian leaders
rise
With strength they showed in former
battles. Yet,
If war has begun here also, let the son
Of Telamon go on alone, and Teucer,
Skilled in the bow, follow him.”
Then great Telamonian Ajax
answered:
“You and strong Lycomedes remain
here,
And rouse the Danaans to fight with
all
Their strength. I will go there and
meet the battle,
Then swiftly come again when I have
brought
Them aid.”
He spoke and went; his brother and
companion,

Teucer, went with him, while
Pandion bore
The curved bows. When they
reached Mnestheus’ tower,
Where need was greatest, the Lycian
leaders
Were mounting the battlements, like
a black storm
Descending. They joined the fight,
and war’s cry rose.
First Telamonian Ajax killed Epicles,
Companion of Sarpedon, with a
stone
That tore the helmet and crushed the
bones of his head.
Epicles had stood high within the
wall;
No man alive could easily have raised
That weight in both hands. But Ajax
lifted it
And threw it down; Epicles fell from
the tower
Like one who dives, and life left all
his bones.
Then Teucer saw the arm of Glaucus
bare,
Where the armor had slipped, and
shot him as he came.
The arrow checked his battle-joy.
Glaucus
Leapt back unseen, that no Achaean
might
Behold his wound and boast of it
aloud.
Sarpedon grieved to see his friend
withdraw,
Yet did not forget the fight. He
struck
Alcmaon, son of Thestor, with his
spear;

Then drew it forth, and Alcmaon fell
face-first,
His ornamented armor clattering
round him.
Sarpedon seized the parapet with
both hands
And dragged it out; the whole work
followed him,
And the wall above lay bare, a road
made wide
For many men.
Ajax and Teucer met him. One shot
struck
The shining strap that circled round
the shield
Upon his breast; but Zeus preserved
his son,
Lest he should fall beside the ships.
Ajax
Leapt at the shield, yet could not
pierce it; only
He drove Sarpedon back a little from
The parapet. The Lycian did not
yield,
But called among his people: "Why
relax
Your warlike strength? It is hard for
me alone,
Though strong, to break the wall and
open here
A road beside the ships. Come after
me;
The work grows better when many
hands are joined."
He spoke; and, fearing their king's
rebuke, they pressed
More fiercely round their leader. On
the other side
The Argives strengthened all their
ranks within.

It seemed a mighty labor: neither
could
The Lycians break the wall and make
a road,
Nor could the Danaans drive them
back again
Once they had reached it.
They fought as two men striving over
land,
With measures in their hands, upon
a field
Held in common, each defending an
equal
Strip of earth. So parapets divided
them;
Above the stones they struck each
other's breasts,
Beneath the ox-hide shields and
round bucklers,
The winged shields. Many were
wounded by
The pitiless bronze: some when they
turned and left
The back exposed, and some straight
through the shield.
The towers and parapets ran red
with blood
Of Greeks and Trojans, poured on
either side.
Yet they could not make the
Achaeans afraid.
They held like scales in a laboring
woman's hand,
Who lifts each side alike—the wool
and weight,
That she may win a wretched wage
for children.
So equal were the battle and the war,
Until at last Zeus gave the greater
glory

To Hector, Priam's son, who first
sprang inside
The Achaean wall.
Then Hector cried so all the Trojans
heard:
"Horse-taming Trojans, rise! Break
through the wall
Of Argos, cast the wondrous fire
upon
The ships!" They heard and rushed
together. Some
Climbed the parapets with their
sharpened spears;
But Hector seized a stone before the
gates,
Thick at its base and sharp above.
Two men
Of those alive today could hardly lift
It from the ground and set it on a
wagon;
But Cronus' crooked-counseling son
made light
The weight for Hector, and he swung
it easily.
As a shepherd carries a ram's fleece,
lifting
It in one hand, and scarcely feels its
weight,
So Hector bore the stone toward the
planks
That held the lofty double gates.
Within,
Two cross-bars braced them, and a
single bolt
Lay fast across. He planted both his
feet,
And hurled the stone into their
middle, so
The blow would not be weak. It
broke the hinges;

The stone fell inward, and the gates
thundered.
The bars could not restrain them;
both the planks
Burst apart beneath the stroke, one
here, one there.
Then bright Hector sprang in, his
face like night;
Dread bronze flashed around him,
and in his hands
He carried two spears. No man could
have stopped
Him as he leapt through, save the
gods alone.
Fire burned in his eyes. He turned
among
The crowd and called the Trojans to
cross over.
They climbed the wall; they poured
through the gates.
The Danaans fled toward the hollow
ships,
And endless tumult rose among
them.

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 13

First-pass working translation

When Zeus had driven the Trojans
and Hector
Toward the ships, he left them there
to labor,
And turned his shining eyes away,
toward Thrace,
The land of horsemen, Mysians close
in battle,
Milk-drinking Abians, most just of
men.
He did not wholly turn his gaze to
Troy;
He thought no god would secretly
arise
To help the Trojans or the Danaans.
But Earth-Shaker Poseidon watched
the war.
He sat upon the highest wooded
peak
Of Samothrace, and Ida, Priam's
town,
And all the Achaean ships lay in his
sight.
He rose out of the sea, and pitied
those
Who were beneath the Trojans
crushed, and felt
A bitter anger toward his brother
Zeus.
Down from the mountain's rugged
side he came;
The ridges trembled and the forest
shook
Beneath the feet immortal. Three
great strides

He made; the fourth brought him to
Aegae, where
His golden halls stand underneath
the sea,
Unfading. There he yoked his
bronze-hoofed steeds,
Swift-flying, with their manes of
gold; around
His deathless body placed the golden
gear,
And took a golden whip, well
wrought, and mounted.
Across the waves he drove. The
creatures of
The sea played round him, knowing
their own lord;
The waters opened, and the bronze
axle stayed
Dry underneath. His eager horses
bore him
Swiftly toward the Achaean ships.
There is a hollow cave beneath the
sea,
Midway between Tenedos and
rugged Imbros.
Poseidon halted there, and loosed the
horses
From the chariot. He set ambrosial
food
Before them, laid unbreakable
golden fetters
Around their feet, that they might
wait until
Their lord returned; then entered the
Achaean host.
The Trojans followed Hector like a
storm,
Or fire, with an unwearied cry. They
hoped

To take the ships and kill beside
them all
The noblest men. But Earth-Shaker
came up
From the deep sea, and took the
form and voice
Of Calchas, tireless in the battle.
First
He spoke to both the Ajaxes, eager
for war:
“Ajaxes, you must save the Achaean
people,
Remembering your strength, and not
give way
Before the chill of fear. Elsewhere I
do not
Fear the invincible hands of those
who crossed
The wall; the well-greaved Greeks
will hold them.
But here I fear the flame of Hector,
who
Boasts that he is the mighty Zeus’s
son.
May some god put this courage in
your hearts:
Stand firm yourselves, and order all
the rest.
Then you could drive this rushing
man away
From the ships, though Olympus
sent him on.”
With his staff the Earth-Shaker
struck them both,
And filled their limbs with strength,
so that their hands
Grew light above, their feet below.
Then like
A hawk that rises from a sheer
cliff-edge

And darts across the plain in pursuit
of a bird,
He sprang away.
Swift Ajax, son of Oileus, knew
The feet departing, and addressed
the greater:
“Ajax, some god who holds Olympus,
wearing
The form of a prophet, bids us fight
beside
The ships. He is not Calchas; I have
seen
The tracks of his feet behind him.
Gods are easy
To know. My heart now presses me
more strongly
Toward battle, and my hands and
feet are eager.”
And Telamonian Ajax answered him:
“So too my hands are eager round the
spear;
My strength has risen, and my feet
already
Move beneath me. I alone desire to
meet
Hector, whose hunger for the fight is
never
Satisfied.” So speaking, they rejoiced
In that great courage breathed into
their hearts;
And Poseidon roused the Greeks
behind them,
Those who had cooled their grief
beside the ships.
Their limbs were loosened by the
grievous labor;
Their hearts grew faint when they
beheld the Trojans
Already past the wall. From
underneath

Their brows they poured their tears,
and thought there was
No escape from ruin. But the god,
assuming
Another shape, went first to Teucer,
Leitus,
Peneleos, Thoas, Deipyros,
Meriones, and Antilochus,
The masters of the war-cry, and
spoke:
“Shame on you, young men of Argos!
I believed
That you would save the ships. If you
abandon
This bitter war, today the Trojans
win.
What marvel do I see—Trojans on
our ships!
Before this they were like frightened
deer
That wander through a forest and
become
The food of panthers, wolves, and
leopards;
They would not stand against the
Achaean hands,
Not even for a little. Now, far off
From their own city, they fight
beside our ships,
Because their chiefs are bad and their
people will not
Stand together. Even if Agamemnon
Is wholly to blame, for he dishonored
swift
Achilles, it is not permitted us
To leave the battle. Heal the wound
at once;
Brave minds are physicians. You, the
best in war,

Must not relax your strength. I
would not blame
A man who held back, weakened by
battle; yet
I am angry with you, for through this
neglect
You make a greater evil. Shame and
just anger
Enter each heart. Hector, skilled in
the cry,
Fights at the ships; he has broken
gates and bar.”
So Earth-Shaker roused them.
Around the Ajaxes
Strong ranks stood, ranks that
neither Ares nor
Athena, driver of hosts, would scorn.
They waited
For Hector and the shining Trojans,
shield
Against shield, spear answering
spear, helmet
Close to helmet, man pressed against
his fellow.
The horsehair crests brushed; the
spears shook forth
From daring hands; and every eye
looked straight
Before it, eager for the fight.
The Trojans struck together, and
Hector came
Like a stone that a winter torrent,
swollen
By ruthless rain, breaks from a
mountain’s rim
And drives high-leaping through the
forest, till
It reaches level ground, where,
though it rushes,

It no longer rolls. So Hector vowed
to pass
Through huts and ships, and kill,
until he met
The close ranks; there his motion
stopped. The Greeks
Received him with their swords and
spears, and drove
Him back; he staggered. Then he
called aloud:
"Trojans, Lycians, Dardanians, stand
firm!
The Greeks will not hold me long,
though now they stand
Like towers. Beneath my spear they
will give way,
If Hera's best and thunder-speaking
husband
Has truly roused me." So he stirred
the hearts
Of every man.
Deiphobus, Priam's son, moved
through the ranks,
Holding his rounded shield before
him. Meriones
Aimed his bright spear and struck
the bull-hide shield;
The shaft broke in its wood, and
Deiphobus
Withdrew, fearing the spear.
Meriones,
Angered at his lost victory and
broken weapon,
Went to the huts and ships to fetch
another.
The others fought; the endless cry
rose higher.
Then Teucer killed Imbrius, son of
Mentor,

Rich in horses, who had lived in
Pedasus
Before the Greeks arrived. He had
made Priam's
Bastard daughter, Medesicasta, his
wife;
But when the ships came, he
returned to Troy,
And Priam honored him as his own
sons.
Teucer struck beneath his ear; the
spear came out,
And Imbrius fell like an ash upon
A mountain, cut with bronze, whose
tender leaves
Lie scattered on the ground.
Teucer bent down to strip his armor.
Hector
Cast his bright spear; Teucer saw it
coming,
And slipped aside a little from the
point.
But Hector struck Amphinachus,
son of Cteatus,
Upon the breast; he fell, and all his
armor
Rang. Hector sprang to seize the
helmet fixed
Upon his temples. Ajax rushed at
Hector
With his bright spear, but could not
touch his flesh,
For bronze enclosed him. Ajax struck
the boss
Of Hector's shield and drove him
back with force.
Hector withdrew from both the
fallen men;
The Achaeans dragged them from
the fight.

Poseidon's heart was angered when
his friend,
His grandson's comrade, fell. He
went among
The huts and ships, and roused the
Danaans,
Making the Trojans grieve.
Idomeneus,
Famous for spear, came from a man
just brought
Back from the battle, wounded
beneath the knee.
His friends had carried him within;
the chief
Had given him to healers, yet his
heart
Still longed to enter war.
Then Earth-Shaker, assuming Thoas'
voice—
Thoas, Andraemon's son, who ruled
Pleuron
And steep Calydon, and whose
people honored
Him like a god—called out: "Where
are the threats
With which the sons of Achaea
threatened Troy?"
The Cretan answered: "Thoas, no
man here,
So far as I can tell, is wholly guilty.
We know the work of war; no man is
held
By helpless fear, nor does his
cowardice
Persuade him to enter this evil battle.
Perhaps it is the will of Cronus' son
That here, far from our Argos,
nameless, we
Should perish. But you, Thoas, who
were brave

Before us, and rouse every man who
yields,
Do not cease urging each."
The god replied in that borrowed
voice:
"May he who leaves the battle never
come
Again from Troy, but feed the dogs,
and be
Their music, who abandons it today.
Take up your arms and come; we
must make haste,
That we two may give help. Joined
strength is good
Even among the wretched; and you
know
How to fight in the ranks of the
brave."
So speaking, he returned into the
labor
Of mortal men. Idomeneus reached
his hut,
Put on his beautiful armor, and took
spears.
He went out like the flash that
Cronus' son
Grasps from bright Olympus,
shaking it as sign
To mortals; so his bronze flashed
round him as
He ran.
Near the hut Meriones, his swift
companion,
Met him, and came to fetch a bronze
spear. Then
Idomeneus, strong in battle, asked:
"Meriones, dear son of Molus, why
Have you left war and come here?
Are you wounded,

And does some point torment you?
Or do you bring
A message? I have no desire to sit
Within the hut; I long to join the
fight.”
Thoughtful Meriones replied:
“Counselor
Of the bronze-clad Cretans, I have
come
To see whether a spear remains for
me
To carry. Mine broke when I struck
the shield
Of overbearing Deiphobus.”
Idomeneus answered: “If you wish,
you’ll find
One spear—or twenty-one—against
the wall,
Bright weapons stripped from
Trojans I have slain.
I am not one to fight my enemies
From far away. Therefore I have
spears,
Bossed shields, helmets, breastplates,
shining bronze.”
Meriones replied: “I too have spoils
Beside my hut and black ship, but
they lie
Too far to fetch. I have not lost my
courage;
Whenever battle rises, I stand first.
Another Greek may fail to know me
there,
But you have seen me.”
“I know your courage,” Idomeneus
said.
“Why tell me this? If now the best
were chosen
To lie in ambush by the ships, then
courage

Would show most clearly, and the
coward stand
Apart from the brave. The coward
changes color;
His heart will not allow him to sit
still,
But shifts him foot to foot; his heart
beats hard
As he imagines death, and his teeth
chatter.
The brave man’s color does not
change; he is
Not greatly frightened when he takes
his place,
But prays to enter quickly into grief.
“There your courage and hands could
not be hidden.
Though missile struck you, or a spear
reached you,
It would not find you from behind,
but meet
Your breast or belly as you went
among
The foremost. Come, let us no longer
stand
Talking like children, lest some man
rebuke us.
Go to the hut and take the mighty
spear.”
Meriones, the equal of swift Ares,
Took up the bronze, and went beside
his friend,
Intent upon the work of war. As
Ares
Goes into battle, and his dear son
Fear,
Strong and unflinching, follows him,
who makes
The boldest warrior tremble—so
they went,

Armored in burning bronze.
Then Meriones asked: "Son of
Deucalion,
Where do you mean to plunge into
the crowd—
The right wing, the middle, or the
left? I do
Not think the long-haired Greeks are
short of war."
Idomeneus replied: "Others defend
The middle ships: the Ajaxes, and
Teucer,
Best of the Achaeans with the bow,
and good
In close combat. They will hold back
Hector,
However eager; hard it is for him
To conquer their hands and courage,
and to set
The ships aflame, unless the son of
Cronus
Himself should cast a burning torch
among them.
Great Ajax yields to no man, if he is
mortal
And eats Demeter's grain. Bronze or
huge stones
May break him; even Achilles,
breaker
Of ranks, cannot surpass him in close
fight,
Though no one runs as swiftly as
Achilles.
We two shall hold the left, and
quickly learn
Whether we give another glory, or
Another gives that glory to us."
Meriones led on until they came
To the appointed place. When the
men beheld

Idomeneus, his comrade, and the
armor
Elaborate upon them, all moved
near.
The battle rose around the sterns like
storms
That race beneath shrill winds upon
a day
When dust lies thick upon the roads;
the gusts
Lift one great cloud of earth. So
fighting met,
And every heart was bent on killing
through
The crowd with sharpened bronze.
The deathly war
Stood bristling with long spears that
cut the flesh;
Bronze flashed on helmets,
breastplates newly polished,
And bright shields. No man whose
heart was not
Of stone could look upon that labor
without grief.
The sons of Cronus, each apart in
thought,
Prepared bitter pain for heroic men.
Zeus wished the Trojans and their
Hector glory,
Honoring swift Achilles; yet he did
not
Desire the Greeks to perish utterly
Before the city, but to glorify
Thetis and her strong-hearted son.
Poseidon,
Stealing from the gray sea, roused
the Argives,
Angered to see them mastered, and
resentful

Of Zeus. One blood was theirs, one
homeland; Zeus
Was born the elder, and knew more.
Therefore
Poseidon would not help them
openly,
But moved among the army in a
man's shape,
Stirring them secretly.
Between the hosts they stretched the
boundary
Of bitter strife, a cord that could not
break,
Yet loosened many men's knees.
There the grizzled
Idomeneus called out to all the
Greeks,
And sprang among the Trojans,
putting fear
Into their hearts.
He killed Othryoneus, newly come
From Cabeus to the fame of war. He
had
Asked Priam for Cassandra, fairest
daughter,
Without a bride-price, promising to
drive
The sons of Achaea from the city.
Priam
Had nodded and accepted; trusting
that promise,
Othryoneus fought. Idomeneus
aimed
His shining spear and struck him in
the chest.
As he fell, the Cretan mocked him:
"Will you now
Marry Priam's daughter? We will
give her you

Without a bride-price, if you follow
me
Back from the city. I too would
promise this,
If you had come and asked the
daughter of
Agamemnon. But take her now
beside
The ships: here is the wedding
made."
He spoke, and sprang to strip the
armor from
The fallen man.
Idomeneus struck Othryoneus as he
sprang;
The bronze could not withstand him,
and the spear
Was fixed within the middle of his
belly.
He fell and groaned. Idomeneus
called out:
"Othryoneus, above all mortal men
I praise you—if you truly will fulfill
The promise made to Priam, and the
king
Will give you his fair daughter. We
too would bring
The fairest daughter of the son of
Atreus
From Argos, if you helped us take
the city.
Come to the ships; we are not poor
arrangers
Of bride-gifts."
He spoke, and dragged the fallen by
the foot
Through battle. Asius came to help
him, walking
Before his horses; breathless, his
driver held

The reins stretched tight above the
horses' necks.
Asius took aim at Idomeneus, but he
Struck first beneath the throat and
through the bronze.
Asius fell like oak, or alder, or
A tall pine felled by woodcutters for
a ship,
New-sharpened axes ringing; so he
lay
Before his horses, roaring in the dust,
And clutching at his blood.
The driver, stunned, dared not turn
back the team
Through enemy hands. Antilochus,
steadfast
In battle, struck him in the middle;
bronze
Could not contain the point, which
entered deep
Into his belly. From the polished car
He fell, gasping; and Nestor's
great-hearted son
Drove off the horses from the
Trojans, toward
The well-greaved Greeks.
Deiphobus came near, grieving for
Asius,
And cast his shining spear.
Idomeneus
Saw it and slipped aside; his
many-layered shield,
Of ox-hide over bronze, received the
stroke.
The spear flew over it, but still the
hand
Was not made empty: Deiphobus
struck down
Hypsenor, son of Hippasus, beneath

The liver; suddenly his knees gave
way.
Then Deiphobus cried: "Asius does
not
Lie without honor here. As he goes
down
To Hades' gates, he will rejoice that I
Have sent a companion." The Greeks
grieved,
And most of all the boast awoke the
anger
Of warlike Antilochus. Yet even
while
He mourned his friend, he did not
leave him; round
The body running, he held up his
shield.
Two faithful comrades, Mecisteus,
son
Of Echius, and splendid Alastor,
bent
To lift the burden, and bore
Hypsenor,
Groaning, toward the hollow ships.
But Idomeneus did not cease his
strength.
He sought either to cover some
Trojan
With dark night, or himself to fall
with a crash
While saving the Achaeans. There he
struck
Alcathous, son of Aesyetes,
son-in-law
Of Anchises. He had married
Hippodamia,
The eldest daughter, loved beyond
the rest
By father and by honored mother;
she

Surpassed her fellows in beauty,
work, and mind,
And therefore the best man of broad
Troy had made
Her his own wife. But Poseidon
made him fall
Beneath Idomeneus: he bound his
limbs,
Bewildered his bright eyes, and
would not let
Him flee, or turn away from the
coming blow.
Idomeneus struck the center of his
breast,
Like some tall pillar or a high-leaved
tree.
The spear broke through the bronze
tunic, once
His defense; he cried, bent around
the weapon,
And fell with thunder. The spear
stood fast
Within his heart; his struggling heart
shook the point,
Until the mighty war-god left him.
Then Idomeneus shouted:
“Deiphobus,
Do you believe three men have fallen
for one,
As you have boasted? Madman, stand
before me,
That you may see what kind of son of
Zeus
Has come here—Minos’ line, who
first was born
To Crete, the blameless king; and
Minos’ son
Was Deucalion, and Deucalion
fathered me,

The ruler of many men. These ships
have borne
Me here to bring destruction on your
father,
On you, and on the other men of
Troy.”
Deiphobus considered, turning two
ways:
To call a great-hearted Trojan back,
or test
The battle by himself. He judged it
best
To go to Aeneas, whom he found
behind
The crowd; for Aeneas was always
angry
With Priam, since the king gave him
no honor,
Though he was good among the men
of war.
He stood beside him: “Aeneas,
counselor
Of Troy, defend your brother-in-law,
if any
Care for him remains. Come aid
Alcathous,
Who raised you in his house when
you were still
A child. Idomeneus, famous for the
spear,
Has struck him down and stripped
him.”
Aeneas’ heart was stirred. He went at
once
Toward Idomeneus, intent upon the
work
Of war. The Cretan did not shrink
like a child;
He stood as a boar that trusts his
strength among

The mountains, waiting for a crowd
of men
Who rush against him in a lonely
place.
His eyes flashed fire; he sharpened
his teeth,
Prepared to face both dogs and men.
So there
Idomeneus stood waiting, and called
out
To Ascalaphus, Aphareus, Deipyros,
Meriones, and Nestor's son,
Antilochus,
The masters of the war-cry:
"Come, dear companions, stand
beside me now,
Though I am alone. I fear Aeneas'
strength;
He comes in youth's first flower,
when strength is greatest,
And kills his enemies. If we were
equal
In age and spirit, one of us would
quickly
Carry away the victory."
They came with one mind, and
leaned their shields
Upon their shoulders. On the other
side
Aeneas called Deiphobus, Paris, and
The godlike Agenor; and the people
followed,
As sheep follow their shepherd from
the pasture,
And the shepherd's heart rejoices. So
did he
Rejoice to see the host go after him.
They rushed around Alcathous; the
bronze

Clashed terribly against their chests.
Two men,
Aeneas and Idomeneus, like Ares,
Sought one another's flesh with
pitiless bronze.
Aeneas cast; Idomeneus saw and
turned.
The point struck earth and quivered,
having sprung
In vain from Aeneas' hand.
Idomeneus
Struck Oenomaus beneath the belly;
through
The hollow breastplate passed the
spear, and drove
Bronze through the entrails. In the
dust he fell,
And grasped the earth with one
extended hand.
Idomeneus drew forth the
long-shadowed spear,
But could not strip the armor from
the dead:
The missiles pressed him, and his
legs had lost
Their power to leap. He could
defend himself
In close combat, but could not easily
flee
The cast spear, or escape it.
Deiphobus, who had long held in his
anger,
Cast at him as he slowly went away;
He missed, and struck Ascalaphus,
the son
Of Enyalios, through the shoulder.
The spear
Held him; Ascalaphus fell and
grasped the earth.

But Ares, loud and mighty, did not know
His son had fallen. Bound beneath the will
Of Zeus, he sat on high Olympus, under
The golden clouds, as all the gods were kept
Apart from battle.
The fighters rushed around Ascalaphus.
Deiphobus tore off his shining helmet;
Meriones, the equal of swift Ares, sprang forward and struck Deiphobus' arm.
The cheeked helmet rang and fell from his hand.
Meriones sprang again, drew out the spear
From where it entered, then withdrew among
His comrades. Polites, Deiphobus' brother,
Reached out his hand and led him from the fight
To where the swift horses and chariot waited.
The others fought; the unquenchable cry rose.
Aeneas rushed at Aphareus, Caletor's son,
And struck his turned neck with the sharp spear.
His head leaned sideways; shield and helmet fell
As death poured over him.
Antilochus saw
Thoon turn, sprang forward, and cut the vein

That rises up the back and reaches the neck.
He fell upon his back, stretching both hands
Toward his friends. Antilochus rushed upon him,
Stripped off the armor, and looked round; the Trojans
Surrounded him, striking his bright broad shield.
They could not reach his tender flesh, for Earth-
Shaking Poseidon guarded Nestor's son
Among the many missiles.
Antilochus was never far from foes;
He wheeled among them, and his spear would not
Rest, but shook and turned as he considered whom
To strike, and where to close. He did not fail
To see Adamas, Asius' son, who aimed
Across the crowd. Adamas struck the center
Of Antilochus' shield at close range.
But
The blue-haired god weakened the spear, hating
His life: one half remained within the shield,
Like a stake charred by fire; the other fell
Upon the ground. Adamas withdrew, avoiding
Fate. Meriones followed, and struck him
Between the navel and the genitals,

Where Ares wounds most painfully.
The spear
Stood fast; he writhed as a bull
herdsmen bind
Against its will, and lead down from
the hills.
For a short while he twisted; then
Meriones
Came near and drew the spear from
out his flesh,
And darkness covered both his eyes.
Menelaus aimed at Helenus; his
arrow
Struck the hollow of Menelaus'
breastplate,
And sprang away, as beans or
chickpeas leap
From a broad shovel in the breath of
wind.
Menelaus cast his spear and pierced
the hand
That held the polished bow; the
bronze went through.
Helenus withdrew among his friends,
His wounded hand hanging. Agenor
drew out
The ash spear and bound that hand
with wool,
Soft from the sheep.
Then Peisander came straight against
the king,
For fate was leading him to death
and to
The victory of Menelaus. The spear
Of Menelaus turned aside; Peisander
Struck at the broad shield, but the
bronze could not
Pass through it; the shaft broke at its
socket.
He rejoiced, hoping for victory. Then

Menelaus drew his silver-studded
sword
And sprang upon him. Peisander
raised beneath
His shield a battle-axe, bronze, long
and bright,
With olive haft. They struck
together: he
Cut through the horsehair crest atop
the helm;
Menelaus struck his forehead above
The brow. The bones cracked;
bloody eyes fell down
Into the dust before his feet. He
twisted,
And Menelaus set his foot upon
His chest, stripped off the armor,
and cried out:
"At last you leave the ships, you
overweening
Trojans, insatiable in shame and
insult,
You evil dogs who dishonored me,
and did
Not fear the anger of
loud-thundering Zeus,
The god of guests, who will one day
destroy
Your steep city. You carried off my
wife,
My lawful wife, and much property,
though she
Had welcomed you; and now beside
the ships
You burn to cast destructive fire, and
kill
The Achaeon heroes. But your
warlike hunger
Will be restrained.

“Father Zeus, they say that you are
wiser than
All gods and men, and everything
comes from you.
Yet see how you favor these insolent
Trojans,
Whose strength is never satisfied. All
things
Have their fill: sleep, love, and sweet
song and dance,
And each of these a man desires
more deeply
Than war. But Troy can never have
her fill
Of battle.”
He stripped the blood-stained
armor, gave it to
His friends, and went among the
foremost. Then
Harpalion, son of King Pylamenes,
Sprang at him. He had followed his
dear father
To Troy, and would not see his
native land.
He struck the middle of the shield,
but could
Not drive the bronze through;
drawing back, he looked
Around him, fearing some man
might reach his flesh.
Meriones sent a bronze-headed
arrow
And struck him in the right buttock;
it passed
Beneath the bone, and through the
bladder.
Harpalion sat within his friends’
arms,
Breathing his life away, like a worm
stretched

Upon the earth; the dark blood
soaked the ground.
Paphlagonians lifted him into a car
And bore him sorrowing toward
sacred Ilium.
His father followed, weeping; no
ransom could
Restore his son.
Paris was angered at his
guest-friend’s death,
And sent a bronze-tipped arrow.
Euchenor,
Rich and noble, son of seer Polyidus,
Had known the fate his father told
him: either
At home to die of grievous sickness,
or
Among the ships beneath the Trojan
hand.
He boarded, fleeing both the hateful
illness
And fear of it; but Paris struck him
under
The jaw and ear, and darkness took
his limbs.
The battle burned. Hector, dear to
Zeus, did not
Know that the Argives on the left
were now
Destroying those he led. They might
have won
The glory, for Poseidon roused them
there;
But Hector stayed beside the ships of
Ajax
And Protesilaus, where the wall was
low
Above the gray sea, and the fighting
fiercest.

There Boeotians, Ionians trailing robes,
Locrians, Phthians, and Epeians rushed
To save the ships, but could not drive away
Bright Hector, flame-like, from the line.
Mnestheus led Athenians, with Pheidias,
Stichius, and good Bias; Phyleides
Meges, Amphion, and Dracius led
The Epeians; Medon and Podarces
The Phthians. Medon, Oileus' bastard son,
And Ajax's brother, lived far from Phylace,
For he had killed a kinsman of his stepmother.
Podarces was son of Iphiclus,
Son of Phylacus. The Phthians fought
In armor before their ships.
Swift Ajax, son of Oileus, no longer
Stood apart from Telamonian Ajax.
They stood together like two wine-dark oxen
That draw one plow across an even field;
The sweat rose round their horns beneath the yoke,
And only the bright plow divided them
As they cut one furrow to its end.
Many good comrades followed Telamonian Ajax,
Taking his shield when toil and sweat reached down
To his knees. But no Locrians followed Ajax,

For they had no heart for close and hand-to-hand
Combat: no bronze helmets with horsehair crests,
No rounded shields, no ash spears.
They trusted
Bows and the carefully twisted wool of sheep,
And came to Troy with arrows, breaking ranks
From far behind the bronze-armed Trojans.
So some fought frontward with elaborate arms,
While others, unseen behind, shot dense arrows
And scattered Troy's courage.
The Trojans would have drawn away from ships
And huts to windy Ilium, had not bold
Polydamas stood near Hector and said:
"You are hard to persuade by another's words.
Because the god has given you the work of war,
You wish in counsel too to know the most.
But no man takes all gifts: one man receives
The war, another dancing, another song
And lyre; and Zeus puts a far-seeing mind
Within another, from which many profit,
And he himself most of all.
"The battle's crown burns round you.
Those who crossed

The wall stand scattered; some have
dropped their arms,
And some fight at the ships, the
fewer against
The many. Withdraw, and call the
leaders here,
That we may plan: whether we fall
among
The many-benched ships, if the god
grants power,
Or come away unharmed. I fear the
Greeks
May find again the strength they had
yesterday;
Beside the ships there remains one
man who is
Insatiable of war, and will not wholly
Refrain.”
The counsel pleased him. Hector
leapt from his car
And spoke: “Hold all the best men
here; I go
To meet the battle, and will quickly
return
When I have given orders.” He went
through
The Trojans like a snow-covered
mountain, shouting;
The others hastened to Polydamas.
Hector
Sought Deiphobus, Helenus,
Adamas,
And Asius; none was safe. Some lay
beside
The ships, some within the wall,
their lives gone out
Beneath the Argive spears.
At last he found his brother
Alexander,

The beautiful, beside the tearful
fight,
Encouraging the Trojans. Hector
stood
Near him and spoke with shame:
“Paris, beautiful
In form, woman-mad deceiver,
where are now
Deiphobus, Helenus, Adamas, and
Asius?
Where is Othryoneus? Ilium falls
From its foundations; and your own
steep death
Is certain.”
The godlike man replied: “Since you
delight
To blame the blameless, I will leave
the battle
More often yet; my mother did not
bear me
Without some courage. Since you
brought the fight
Beside the ships, we have not ceased
to fight
The Danaans, and those you seek are
dead.
Deiphobus and Helenus are gone,
Both pierced through the hand; but
Cronus’ son preserved
Them from their end. Lead where
your heart commands;
We follow gladly, and our strength
will not
Fail while strength remains. Yet no
man can contend
Beyond his power.”
He turned his brother’s mind, and
both went where
The battle raged around Cebriones,
Polydamas, Phalces, Orthæetus,

Polyphates, Palmys, Ascanias,
And Morys, leaders from fertile
Ascania.
They came like storm-winds sent
beneath the thunder
Of Zeus, and met the sea with a great
roar;
Wave followed wave and foamed
upon the water.
So Troy came on in ranks, bronze
flashing, leaders
Among them. Hector led like
murderous Ares,
Holding his many-layered shield
before him.
He tested all the ranks, stepping
before them
To see if they would yield beneath
the shield;
But still the Greeks did not give way.
Ajax strode wide and called him:
“Come, madman, come!
Why frighten Argives? We are not
strangers to
The war; beneath the scourge of Zeus
we have
Been overcome. You hope to take our
ships,
But we too have hands to guard
them. Soon your city,
Well-peopled, might be taken by our
hands;
And for yourself the time is near
when, fleeing,
You will pray that your horses
outrun hawks,
And carry you in dust back to the
town.”
As Ajax spoke, an eagle flew upon

The right; the Greeks cried out,
encouraged by
The sign. Bright Hector answered:
“Ox-like fool,
Speaker of empty words, would that
I were always
The son of Zeus, and Hera had borne
me,
Honored like Athena and Apollo—as
surely
As this day brings destruction to the
Argives,
And you among them, if you stand
and meet
My long spear, which shall stain your
tender flesh,
And feed the dogs and birds with fat
and blood,
Falling beside the Achaean ships.”
So he led on; the Trojans followed
with a cry
Unlike a mortal sound. The Argives
answered,
And did not forget their courage, but
awaited
The leaders. The two armies’ voices
reached
The upper air and the bright rays of
Zeus.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 14

First-pass working translation

Nestor was not unaware of all the cries,
Although he drank; he spoke to Machaon:
“Consider, noble son of Asclepius,
How this affair will end. A greater cry
Rises beside the ships of vigorous men.
Sit here and drink the shining wine until
Hecamede, fair-haired, warms a bath and washes
The blood away. I will go up to the watch
And learn what has befallen.”
He took the bright shield of his own son,
Thrasymedes, which lay within the hut,
And wore his father’s shield; then took a strong
Spear sharpened in bronze, and stood outside.
At once he saw the shameful work: some Trojans
Were driven, others drove the Greeks; the wall
That had defended them lay overthrown.
As when the broad sea darkens under a wave,
And watches all the roads of shrill winds, yet neither
Rolls forward nor retreats until a gust

Chosen by Zeus descends, so in his heart
The old man weighed two counsels: should he go
Among the Danaans, or seek Agamemnon?
He judged it better to go to Atreus’ son.
The men were stripping one another in the fight;
The tireless bronze rang on their flesh beneath
The swords and double-edged spears. Then Nestor met
The kings that Zeus had fostered, coming up
From ships pulled far from the gray sea: Tydeus’ son,
Odysseus, and Agamemnon, all Wounded by bronze. The foremost ships stood toward
The plain, and others had been drawn behind them;
The wall was built behind the sterns. The beach,
Though broad, could not contain the ships, and so
They filled the long mouth of the shore between
The headlands. Leaning on their spears, the kings
Came grieving, eager to know the battle.
Agamemnon said: “Nestor, great glory
Of the Achaeans, why have you left the war?
I fear that Hector now fulfills the word

He spoke in Troy: he would not turn
again
From the ships toward the city till he
burned
Them with fire, and killed us too.
And now
His promise comes to pass. Ah me!
Perhaps
The other Greeks hold anger in their
hearts
Against me, as Achilles does, and
will not
Fight beside the sterns.”
The horseman answered: “These
things have come to be;
Loud-thundering Zeus himself could
not undo them.
The wall we trusted as an
unbreakable
Defense for ships and men lies
overthrown.
Beside the ships they fight without a
pause;
No watchman could discern from
which direction
The Greeks are driven, so confused
the deaths,
So high the cry. Let us consider what
The mind can do; I do not counsel us
To enter battle, for a wounded man
Cannot make war.”
Agamemnon answered: “Since they
fight beside
The sterns, and neither wall nor
trench has helped us—
Though Danaans labored long to
make them, hoping
They would be walls no enemy could
break—

It must be Zeus’ will that we perish
here,
Nameless and far from Argos. Once I
knew
He gladly guarded us; now I know he
honors
The Trojans, and has bound our
strength and hands.
Come, let all follow what I say: drag
down
The ships nearest the sea into the
water,
And moor them high upon the shore
until
The deathless night, if then the
Trojans cease.
In darkness we can draw the rest
away.
There is no shame in escaping evil,
Even by night; better to flee disaster
Than be taken.”
Odysseus looked at him and spoke:
“What word
Has escaped the fence of your teeth,
son of Atreus?
Would that you ruled some other
worthless army,
And not us, whom Zeus has granted,
from our youth
Until old age, to endure grievous war
Until each man is dead. You wish to
leave
The broad-streeted city for which we
suffer?
Be silent, lest another Greek should
hear
This speech, a speech no man of
sound mind, who rules
So many, would utter. I despise the
thought

That while the battle holds you
would draw down
The ships to sea, and make the
Trojan victory
More certain, our destruction nearer.
The Greeks
Will not stand fast while ships are
dragged away;
They will look back and leave the
fight. Your counsel
Will ruin us, commander of the
people.”
Agamemnon answered: “Your bitter
rebuke
Has reached my heart. Yet I did not
command
The sons of Achaea to drag ships
unwilling.
If only someone, young or old, would
speak
A better plan, I would receive it
gladly.”
Then Diomedes, good at the war-cry,
spoke:
“The man is near; we need not seek
him long,
If you will obey and not resent my
words
Because I am the youngest. I too
boast
A noble father, Tydeus, whom the
heaped
Earth covers now at Thebes.
Porthus had
Three blameless sons in Pleuron and
steep Calydon:
Agrius, Melas, and Oeneus,
horseman,
My father’s father, who surpassed
them all.

He stayed there; my father wandered
to Argos,
As Zeus and all the gods desired. He
married
Adrastus’ daughter, and lived rich in
grain,
In orchards, sheep, and wide
prosperity;
With his spear he surpassed the
Achaeans—
You would have heard it, if the tale is
true.
Therefore do not dishonor what I
say,
Thinking my birth poor or my
courage weak.
“Come, let us enter battle, though
our wounds
Compel us; then we will keep away
from spears,
Lest wound be added to a wound,
and rouse
The others who have held back and
no longer fight,
Though once they aided us with all
their hearts.”
They heard and followed him, and
Agamemnon
Led on. Earth-Shaker was not blind
to them;
He came among them in an old
man’s likeness,
Took Agamemnon’s right hand, and
spoke: “Son
Of Atreus, surely now Achilles’
heart,
Destructive, rejoices as he watches
Greeks
Flee and be slaughtered. He has no
understanding.

Let him perish so; but the blessed
gods
Are not yet wholly angry with you.
The chiefs
Of Troy will soon raise dust across
the plain,
And you will see them fleeing toward
the city
From ships and huts.”
He shouted across the field. As nine
or ten
Thousand men cry in battle, so the
god
Sent forth his voice and put great
strength into
The hearts of all the Greeks, to fight
and endure.
Hera of the golden throne saw from
Olympus
Her brother and her lord move
through the battle,
And rejoiced; but when she saw Zeus
seated on
The many-springed Ida’s highest
ridge,
Her heart grew bitter. Then august,
ox-eyed Hera
Considered how to trick the
aegis-bearing god.
This seemed the best: to go to Ida
adorned,
That he might desire her, and a
gentle sleep
Fall on his eyes and understanding.
She entered
The chamber her dear son
Hephaestus made,
Its close-fitting doors secured by a
hidden key

No other god could turn. She shut
the shining doors.
First she washed all stain from her
lovely skin
With ambrosia, then anointed it
with oil,
Sweet and fragrant; when it moved
through Zeus’ bronze-
floored house, its scent reached
earth and heaven. She
Combed out her hair, and braided
shining locks
From her immortal head. Athena’s
hands
Had worked the robe she put on, full
of devices;
With golden pins she fastened it
across
Her breast. Around her waist she
tied a belt
With tassels hundredfold; in pierced
ears
She placed three-jewelled earrings,
from which grace
Shone greatly. Over all she drew a
veil,
Beautiful, new, and white as sun; and
bound
Her splendid sandals underneath her
feet.
When all her adornment lay upon
her body,
She left the chamber, and called
Aphrodite
Apart: “Dear child, will you obey my
word,
Or will you anger because I aid the
Danaans
While you aid Troy? Give me the
love and longing

By which you conquer gods and
mortal men.
I go to Oceanus and mother Tethys,
Who raised me in their house when
Rhea gave me
To them, when Zeus placed Cronus
under earth
And barren sea. I will settle their
long quarrel,
For anger has kept them from the
bed of love.
If I can bring their dear hearts back
together,
They will call me forever dear and
honored.”
Aphrodite smiled: “It is not possible,
Nor fitting, to refuse you, since you
sleep
In Zeus’ embrace, the greatest.” From
her breast
She loosened the embroidered strap
in which
All spells were woven: love, desire,
and intimate
Speech—words that steal the mind
from thoughtful men.
She placed it in Hera’s hands: “Hide
this varied
Strap within your bosom; everything
is wrought
Inside it. You will not return
unsuccessful
In what your mind desires.” Ox-eyed
and august,
Hera smiled, and hid it in her breast.
Then Aphrodite went to Zeus’ own
house,
While Hera, darting from Olympus,
crossed
Pieria and lovely Emathia, and sped

Above the snowy peaks of Thracian
horsemen;
Her feet did not touch earth. From
Athos she
Crossed the swelling sea, and came
to Lemnos,
City of godlike Thoas. There she
found
Sweet Sleep, the brother of Death,
and took his hand:
“Sleep, lord of every god and every
man,
If ever you have heard me, hear me
now.
I shall be grateful all my days. Put
soon
The shining eyes of Zeus to sleep,
when I
Have lain beside him. I will give you
a
Beautiful golden throne,
imperishable;
My son Hephaestus shall make it,
and a foot-
Stool beneath, where you may rest
your feet
When you sit at the feast.”
Sweet Sleep replied: “August Hera,
daughter
Of mighty Cronus, I could easily lull
Another deathless god, even
Oceanus,
From whom all things are born. But I
would not come
Near Zeus, nor put him into sleep,
unless
He gave the order. One command of
yours
Already taught me fear. When
Heracles,

That overbearing son of Zeus, had
sacked
The city, I wrapped the aegis-bearing
god
In gentle sleep; you raised harsh
winds, and drove
The hero far across the sea to Cos,
Away from all his friends. When
Zeus awoke,
He raged, and threw the gods
throughout his house,
Seeking me most of all. He would
have cast
Me unseen from heaven into the sea,
Had Night, subduer of gods and
men, not saved me.
I fled to her; and he, though angry,
stopped,
For he feared doing anything
displeasing
To swift Night. Now you ask another
impossible
Thing of me.”
Ox-eyed Hera answered: “Sleep, why
turn these matters
In your mind? Do you think
wide-seeing Zeus
Now favors Troy as once he favored
them
In anger for his son Heracles? Come,
And I will give you one of the
younger Graces
To marry; she shall be your wife.”
Then Sleep rejoiced: “Swear now
beside the Styx,
The water no god can violate. With
one
Hand touch the nourishing earth, the
other touch

The shining sea, and let the gods
beneath
The earth, the Titans, witness what
we swear.
Swear you will give me Pasithea, one
Of the young Graces, whom I have
desired
Throughout my life.”
Hera did not refuse. She swore as he
asked,
And named the gods below, the
Titans. When
The oath was complete, they left
Lemnos and Imbros,
Clothed in a mist, and swiftly made
their way.
They reached Ida, rich in springs and
mother
Of beasts, at Lecton, where they left
the sea.
The forest-tops shook underneath
their feet.
There Sleep remained, before Zeus
could see him;
He climbed a long fir, tallest upon
Ida,
Reaching the clear air, and sat
among its branches
Like a shrill bird the gods call
Chalcis, men
Call Cypindis.
Hera climbed swiftly to the peak of
Ida,
Gargaron; and the cloud-gathering
god saw her.
Desire covered his prudent mind, as
on
That first day when they joined in
love, concealing

Themselves from both their parents.
Zeus stood before her:
“Hera, why have you come so eagerly
From Olympus? Your horses and
your car
Are nowhere here for you to ride.”
She answered, plotting: “I go to visit
Oceanus,
The father of the gods, and mother
Tethys,
Who raised me in their house when
Rhea gave
Me to them, after Zeus had set down
Cronus
Beneath the earth and barren sea. I
go
To settle their unending quarrel;
long
They have kept separate from bed
and love
Since anger entered them. My horses
wait
Upon Ida’s far ridge, and they will
carry
Me over the nourishing earth. For
your sake
I came from Olympus, lest you
should be angry
If I went silently to Oceanus.”
Cloud-gathering Zeus replied:
“There will be time
To visit them; but now let us turn to
love
And lie together. Never has desire
So flooded and mastered me for
goddess or woman—
Not for Ixion’s wife, who bore
Pirithous,
Wise as the gods; not Danaë, who
bore

Perseus, most renowned among men;
nor her
Whom Phoenix fathered, who bore
Minos and
Godlike Rhadamanthys; not Semele,
Nor Alcmene, mother of strong
Heracles;
Not Demeter, lovely-haired; not
glorious Leto;
Not even you. As I desire you now,
So sweet a longing takes me.”
Hera replied, still plotting: “Terrible
son
Of Cronus, what a word! If you
desire
To lie together here on Ida’s peaks,
Where all things are in sight, how
would it be
If some immortal saw us, told the
gods,
And I could not return to your own
house
After rising from the bed? That
would be shame.
But if you wish it, and it pleases you,
There is the chamber your dear son
Hephaestus
Made, with close-set doors fastened
to their posts.
Let us go there, since the bed pleases
you.”
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered:
“Hera, do not fear
That god or man will see us. I will
cover
Us with a golden cloud so dense that
even
The Sun, whose sharp light sees the
furthest, could not
Look through it.”

The son of Cronus caught his wife
within
His arms. Beneath them the divine
earth sent up
New grass, wet lotus, crocus,
hyacinth,
Dense and soft, lifting them above
the ground.
Around them shone a golden cloud,
and bright
Dew fell from it. There the father
slept
Quietly on Gargaron, conquered by
sleep
And love, and held his wife.
Sweet Sleep ran to the Achaean
ships, to bring
The word to Earth-Shaker Poseidon.
Near
Him standing, he spoke: "Now aid
the Danaans
With a willing heart, and grant them
glory for
A little while, while Zeus is sleeping.
I
Have covered him with soft sleep;
Hera deceived
Him into lying with her."
Sleep went away among the famous
races
Of men. Poseidon urged the Greeks
with greater
Force, and sprang among the
foremost: "Argives,
Shall we give victory to Hector, son
Of Priam, let him take the ships and
win
The glory, since he says Achilles
remains

Beside his ships, angry within his
heart?
We shall not miss him greatly if we
rouse
Each other and defend ourselves. Put
on
The finest, largest shields; cover your
heads
With brightest helmets; take the
longest spears.
I lead you, and Hector, eager as he is,
Will not stand before us. Let the man
who bears
A little shield give it to one less
strong,
And enter underneath the larger
shield."
They heard and did it. The wounded
kings, Diomedes,
Odysseus, and Agamemnon, ordered
them,
Changing the armor: the brave man
took the good,
The weaker took the lesser. When
the bronze
Was fastened round them, they went
forth. Poseidon
Led them, holding in his great hand a
terrible
Sword, long and sharp, like
lightning. No man could
Mingle with it in hateful battle; fear
Held every fighter back. On the
other side
Bright Hector ordered Troy.
Then blue-haired Poseidon and
bright Hector stretched
The dreadful contest between the
hosts—one

For Troy, one for the Argives. The
sea stirred
Toward huts and ships; the armies
came together
With a tremendous cry. No wave
that bitter
North wind raises roars so loud
against
The land; no forest fire speaks so
fiercely;
No wind cries so among the
high-branched oaks,
When anger drives it—such the cry
of Troy
And Achaea.
The cry was terrible as they rushed
on one
Another. Hector cast first at bright
Ajax,
Who faced him; but the two
sword-belts across
The breast of Ajax—one for shield,
one for
The silver-studded sword—saved his
flesh.
Hector was angered that the weapon
flew
In vain, and withdrew among his
friends, escaping
The fates.
But great Telamonian Ajax, as he
went,
Lifted a stone from fragments of the
ships
That rolled beneath the feet of
fighting men.
He struck him near the neck, above
the rim
Of that great shield. As when a tree
falls, torn

Up by the roots beneath the
thunderbolt
Of Father Zeus, and the harsh scent
of brimstone
Rises from it, so Hector's strength
fell quickly
Into the dust. He let the spear fall
from
His hand; shield, helmet, and his
ornamented
Armor rang around him.
The Greeks rushed on with one great
shout, and hoped
To drag him off, and cast their
close-set spears;
But none could wound him, for the
best of Troy
Surrounded him: Polydamas, Aeneas,
Agenor, Sarpedon, leader of Lycia,
And blameless Glaucus. None
neglected him.
They held their rounded shields
before his body,
While lifting arms bore him through
the war
To horses waiting with their car and
driver.
They carried him, groaning, toward
the city.
When they came to the ford of broad
Xanthus,
The river born to Zeus, they lifted
him
From the horses, laid him on the
ground, and poured
Water upon him. He breathed again,
opened
His eyes, sat on his knees, and
vomited

The dark blood. Then backward on
the earth he fell;
Black night covered his eyes, and still
the missile
Held fast his heart.
When the Argives saw him carried
away,
They sprang more fiercely at the
Trojans and
Remembered courage. Swift Ajax,
son
Of Oileus, first struck Satnius, son
Of Enops, whom a water-nymph had
borne
Beside the Satnioeis to the herdsman.
Ajax struck him in the flank; he
turned and fell,
And Trojans and Achaeans closed
around
His body in a hard and crowded
fight.
Polydamas, the son of Panthous,
came
To guard him, and struck
Prothoenor, son
Of Areilycus, in the right shoulder.
The heavy spear held him; he fell
into
The dust and grasped the earth.
Polydamas cried:
“Surely the spear did not leap forth
in vain
From Panthous’ son; an Argive takes
it now
Into his flesh, and leaning on the
spear
Will descend, I think, into the house
of Hades.”
The Greeks grieved at his boast;
most deeply Ajax,

For Prothoenor had fallen near him.
Ajax
Cast his bright spear; Polydamas
leapt aside
And slipped away from death.
Archelochus,
Son of Antenor, received the point
where
The head and neck are joined, the
last vertebra.
It severed both the tendons; head
and mouth
And nostrils struck the earth before
his knees.
Ajax called to blameless Polydamas:
“Consider, tell me truly: was not he
Worth the life of Prothoenor? He
appears
No common man, nor born of
common people;
He was the brother or the son of
horse-
Taming Antenor, and his lineage was
Nearest to yours. You knew him
well.” The Trojans
Were seized by grief.
Acamas struck Promachus, a
Boeotian,
Who stood above his brother, and
dragged him
By both his feet. Acamas shouted:
“Argives,
Insatiate in arrows and in threats,
this labor
And misery shall not be ours alone.
You too shall die here. Remember
how
Promachus sleeps, subdued beneath
my spear,

That vengeance for his brother may
 not long
 Remain unpaid. Perhaps some man
 at home
 Will pray he left a kinsman to defend
 him.”
 The Greeks grieved; and Peneleos
 was stirred.
 He sprang at Acamas, who did not
 wait,
 And struck Ilioneus, son of Phorbas,
 Rich in sheep, whom Hermes loved
 and gave great wealth.
 His mother had borne him as her
 only child.
 Peneleos struck beneath his brow,
 where eye
 And socket meet; the eye was driven
 out,
 The spear went through to nape.
 Ilioneus
 Sat with both hands spread. Peneleos
 drew
 His sword, cut through his neck, and
 severed head
 And helmet; the strong spear stood
 in the eye.
 He lifted it like a poppy, and
 displayed
 It to the Trojans: “Tell Ilioneus’
 Dear father and his mother to mourn
 him there.
 Nor shall the wife of Promachus,
 daughter
 Of Aleenor, greet her husband
 when
 He comes with all the sons of Achaea
 from Troy.”
 At this, trembling seized the Trojan
 limbs;

Each man looked round for some
 escape from death.
 “Tell me, O Muses, who possess
 Olympus,
 Who first took up the bloody spoils,
 when famous
 Earth-Shaker turned the battle.”
 Telamonian
 Ajax first struck Hyrtius, son of
 Gyrtius,
 Leader of the strong-hearted
 Mysians. Then
 Antilochus stripped Phalces and
 Mermes;
 Meriones struck Morys and
 Hippotion;
 Teucer took Prothoön and
 Periphetes;
 And Atreus’ son struck Hyperenor in
 The flank. The bronze poured out his
 entrails, and
 His soul went through the wound;
 darkness covered
 Both his eyes. Ajax, son of Oileus,
 Took the greatest number, for no
 fleeing man
 Could keep his pace when Zeus
 raised terror in
 Their limbs.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional
 draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 15

First-pass working translation

When Zeus awoke upon the peak of
Ida,
Beside the golden-throned Hera, first
He saw the Trojans and the Argives
driven,
Poseidon moving with them, and
bright Hector
Lying upon the plain, and vomiting
blood
After the stone of Ajax. Pity touched
The father, but he looked upon his
wife
With darkened eyes: "You have
contrived this, Hera;
Your helpless trick has stopped the
shining Hector
And frightened all his people. I do
not know
Whether you will be first to profit
from
Your painful fraud, or whether I
must scourge you.
Do you remember when I hung you
from
The upper air, two anvils at your
feet,
An unbreakable golden chain around
Your hands? You hung in cloud; the
gods could not
Come near to free you, and whoever
I seized
I hurled from heaven's threshold
until he reached
The earth, scarcely alive. Yet even
then

The pain of Heracles did not leave
my heart—
Him whom, after persuading the
North Wind,
You sent across the barren sea to
Cos,
Far from his friends. I rescued him
and brought
Him back to horse-pasturing Argos.
I remind
You now, that you may cease this
treachery,
And learn what love and bed can
profit you,
For which you left the gods and came
apart
To deceive me."
Ox-eyed Hera trembled: "Let the
earth,
Wide heaven above, and Styx's
descending water,
The greatest oath among the blessed
gods,
Bear witness; let your sacred head
and our
Marriage bed bear witness, by which
I never
Would swear a falsehood. Poseidon
does not harm
The Trojans and their Hector for my
sake;
His own heart urged him, and he
pitied those
Who suffered by the ships. I would
myself
Advise him to go where you
command."
The father smiled: "If you were
always one

In mind with me, Poseidon would
soon bend
His purpose to our own. But if you
speak
The truth, go now among the gods,
and call
Iris and Phoebus of the famous bow.
Let Iris enter the bronze-clad Greeks
And tell Poseidon to abandon war,
And go among the gods or to the sea.
Let Phoebus rouse up Hector,
breathe strength in him,
Make him forget his pains, and turn
the Greeks
To helpless flight, until they fall
among
The ships of Peleus' son. Then
Hector shall
Stir Patroclus to action; and bright
Hector
Will kill him before Ilium, after he
Has slain the strongest young men,
Sarpedon
Among them. Then Achilles, in his
anger,
Will kill bright Hector. From that
hour I shall
Make the Achaeans drive the Trojans
back,
Until they take the city through the
counsels
Of Athena.
"Before that hour I will not cease my
anger,
Nor let another deathless god defend
The Danaans, until the wish of
Peleus' son
Is finished, as I promised and
confirmed

With my own head, when Thetis
clasped my knees
And begged me to give honor to
Achilles."
Hera did not disobey. She left the
ridge
And came to broad Olympus, swift
as thought
Of a man who, having crossed a
stretch of land,
Turns in his mind where he has been
and where
He will go next. There among the
gods she came.
They rose and offered cups; she took
one from
Fair-cheeked Themis, who had run
to meet her first.
Themis asked: "Hera, why have you
come? You look
As if you were afraid. Has Cronus'
son,
Your husband, frightened you?"
"Do not ask this,"
She answered. "You know how harsh
and overbearing
His heart is. Begin the equal feast
among
The gods, that all may hear what
evils Zeus
Reveals. I do not think that every
heart,
Divine or mortal, will rejoice in
them,
Though one may sit contented at the
feast."
She sat; the gods were troubled in
the house.
She smiled with lips alone; her dark
brows did not

Grow bright. "Fools, why rage
against him in our blindness?
Do we still think to stop him by our
words
Or force? He sits apart, and says that
none
Of the immortals equals him in
strength.
Endure whatever evil he may send.
I think that Ares has already learned
Disaster; his dear son Ascalaphus
Has fallen, whom fierce Ares calls his
own."
Ares struck his thighs and groaned:
"Do not resent
Me, Olympians, if I go to the ships
And avenge my son, although it is
my fate
To lie in blood beneath the
thunderbolt."
He ordered Fear and Terror to yoke
the horses,
And armed himself in shining
bronze.
Then fiercer anger would have risen
beside
The throne of Zeus, had not Athena,
fearing
For all the gods, leapt from the
doorway, left
Her seat, removed the helmet and
the shield
From Ares, laid his spear aside, and
said:
"Madman, your mind is ruined. You
have ears
But do not hear; no sense remains, no
shame.
Did you not hear what white-armed
Hera said,

Returning from the presence of the
god?
Would you, after doing many evils,
come
Against your will to Olympus,
bringing harm
To all the rest? Zeus will leave the
Trojans
And Greeks to themselves, then
come among us, seizing
Each one, the guilty and the guiltless.
Give
Up anger for your son; a stronger
man
Has fallen, or will fall. It is not easy
To rescue every generation born."
She seated furious Ares on his
throne.
Then Hera called Apollo and swift
Iris,
The messenger: "Zeus commands you
both to go
To Ida with all speed. When you
have looked
Upon his face, do whatever he
commands."
She returned to her throne; the two
went forth.
They found the son of Cronus seated
on
Gargaron, crowned by fragrant
cloud. He did not
Grow angry when he saw them, for
they had done
His wife's command. He spoke to Iris
first:
"Go, swift Iris, tell Poseidon all my
word:
Abandon battle; go among the gods,
Or to the shining sea. If he refuses,

Let him consider whether, strong as
he is,
He can endure my coming. I am
stronger
And older by birth, though his heart
does not
Admit the name the other gods all
fear.”
Swift Iris flew from Ida like the snow
Or cold hail driven from clouds
beneath the North
Wind. She stood by dark-haired
Earth-Shaker and spoke:
“Earth-holder, I bring Zeus’
command: abandon
The battle, and go among the gods or
to
The sea. If you refuse, he threatens to
Come face to face, and tells you to
avoid
His hands, for he is stronger and
older born.”
The glorious god groaned: “He has
spoken with
Too much arrogance, if he would
force by strength
An equal. We are three, born to
Cronus
And Rhea: Zeus, myself, and Hades,
lord
Of the dead below. The world was
divided
Three ways; each took his portion.
Mine is the gray
Sea, Hades’ the darkness, Zeus’ the
broad heaven;
Earth and high Olympus remain
common.
I will not live according to his mind.

Let him remain within his third,
however
Strong. Let him not frighten me like
a coward
With threats; let him command his
children so.”
Iris answered: “Shall I carry this hard
word
To Zeus? The mind of a brave man
can turn;
And you know well that the Erinyes
follow
The elder.”
“You have spoken rightly,” he replied.
“It is bitter when one equal in honor
And allotted fate rebukes another.
Yet, though resentful, I will yield.
Hear this:
If without me Athena, Hera,
Hermes,
And lord Hephaestus spare the steep
city,
And Zeus refuses to destroy it, giving
The Argives victory, our quarrel then
Will never be healed.”
So he withdrew; the sea received
him.
The Achaeans missed him as he sank
beneath
The sea. Then Zeus spoke to Apollo:
“Go now
To Hector, bronze-clad.
Earth-Shaker has gone down
To the bright sea, avoiding my anger;
For others born to Cronus would
have heard
Our quarrel. Better that he yields,
since he
Could not complete his work
without great toil.

Take up the tasseled aegis, shake it
before
The Greeks, and terrify them. Let
your care
Be Hector: rouse his courage until all
The Achaeans flee toward ships and
Hellespont.
Then I shall guide the work and
word, so that
They breathe again after their labor.
“Before the wish of Peleus’ son is
done,
I will not cease my anger, nor permit
An immortal to defend the Greeks.
So
I promised Thetis when she clasped
my knees
And begged me to give honor to
Achilles.”
Apollo obeyed. He went from Ida
down
Like a hawk, swiftest among birds,
and found
The son of Priam sitting, no longer
fallen;
His spirit gathered, and he knew the
friends
Around him. Sweat and breath had
ceased; the mind
Of Zeus had roused him. Phoebus
stood beside:
“Why do you sit apart, faint son of
Priam?
Has some grief reached you?”
Hector, still weak, replied:
“Who are you, best among the gods,
that ask
Me face to face? Do you not know
that Ajax

Struck me beside the sterns, killed
my companions,
And stopped my courage? I believed
that I
Would reach the dead and Hades’
house today.”
Apollo said: “Take heart. The son of
Cronus
Sent me from Ida to defend you. I
Am Phoebus, who have saved you
and the city.
Rouse now the many horsemen;
drive their cars
Against the ships. I will go before
you,
Make smooth the road, and turn the
Greeks away.”
He breathed great courage into
Hector. As
A horse kept in the stall, well fed,
breaks free
And runs clattering over the plain,
accustomed
To bathe within a river, proud, his
mane
Flowing, his knees carrying him
quickly through
The fields and pastures he has always
known—
So Hector moved his feet and knees,
and roused
The horsemen when he heard the
god’s voice.
The Greeks came after like hounds
and men who chase
A horned deer or wild goat, until a
rock
Or shadowed forest saves the prey;
then a

Bearded lion appears before them,
turns
Them all, however eager. So the
Greeks,
While they could follow, struck with
sword and spear;
But seeing Hector move among the
ranks,
Fear took them, and their courage
fell beside
Their feet.
Then Thoas, son of Andraemon, best
Among Aetolians, skilled with spear
and good
In close combat, spoke: "What a
wonder! Hector rises,
Escaping death. We all expected Ajax
To kill him. Some god has rescued
him, who loosed
The knees of many Danaans; and he
will
Do so again. Hector does not stand
here
Without the thunder of Zeus. Send
back the host
Toward ships; we who claim the
foremost rank will stand
And first attempt to stop him. Even
Hector,
However eager, will fear to enter us."
They heard and obeyed. Around
King Idomeneus
And Ajax they arrayed Teucer,
Meriones,
And Meges, calling the best to stand
against
The Trojans, while the multitude
withdrew
Toward the Achaean ships.

The Trojans struck together, led by
Hector's stride;
Before him Phoebus walked, a cloud
around
His shoulders, holding the dread
aegis, tasseled,
Shaggy, which Hephaestus made and
gave to Zeus
For terror among men. Apollo held
It and led on the people. The Greeks
stood
Together; a sharp cry arose from
both.
Arrows leapt from strings, and many
spears went forth.
Some fixed in flesh; some stood
midway in earth,
Before they reached the white skin,
hungering
For flesh.
While Phoebus held the aegis still,
the spears
Reached both sides and men fell. But
when he shook
It straight before the swift Danaans,
and
Himself cried terribly, he bewitched
their hearts.
They forgot their strength. As two
wild beasts scatter
A herd of cattle or a flock of sheep
In the black night, when no
herdsman is there,
So was the courage of the Greeks
driven away.
Apollo gave the glory to the Trojans
And Hector.
Man killed man as the ranks broke.
Hector struck

Stichius, leader of the bronze-clad
Boeotians,
And Arcesilaus, friend of Mnestheus.
Aeneas stripped Medon and Iasus.
Medon, Oileus' bastard son and
brother
Of Ajax, lived in Phylace far away,
After he killed his stepmother's
kinsman.
Iasus led Athenians, son of Bucolus.
Polydamas killed Mecisteus; Polites
struck
Echius at the first clash; Agenor
killed
Clonius; Paris struck Deiochus
fleeing,
Low in the shoulder, in the foremost
ranks.
While Troy stripped the fallen, the
Greeks fled through
The trench and stakes, driven here
and there,
And entered their own wall by force.
Then Hector
Cried out: "Rush toward the ships;
leave human spoils.
Whoever I find apart from them, I'll
bring
His death there; his kindred will not
claim him,
But dogs will drag him before our
city."
He lashed his horses, drove along the
ranks;
The Trojans shouted and kept close
their cars.
Apollo went before them, and with
ease
Trampled the banks of the deep
trench, throwing them

Into its middle, making a long broad
road,
As far as when a man tests strength
with a spear.
The Trojans poured in phalanx. He
bore the aegis
And threw the wall down, as a child
beside
The sea builds toys of sand, then
kicks them flat.
So, Phoebus, you confused the
Greeks' long labor,
And roused their flight.
They stood beside the ships and
called to gods,
Lifting their hands. Nestor,
horseman, raised his own:
"Father Zeus, if ever in rich Argos
someone
Burned fat thighs of ox or sheep, and
prayed to sail
Back home, and you promised,
nodding, remember now,
And keep the Greeks from this
pitiless day.
Do not let Troy master us."
He prayed; and Zeus thundered
greatly, hearing him,
The old son of Neleus. When the
Trojans heard
The thunder of the aegis-bearing
god,
They sprang more fiercely and
remembered courage.
As a great wave from the broad sea
falls upon
A ship's wall when the wind drives it,
lifting waves
Most high, so Troy crossed the wall
with one great cry.

They drove their horses among the
sterns, and fought
With spears at close range; some
from chariots,
Some mounting the dark ships,
wielding long poles laid
Upon the decks, shod with bronze
for sea-fight.
While the Trojans and Achaeans
fought before
The swift ships, Patroclus in the hut
Of generous Eurypylus remained,
With kindly words and medicines
upon
The grievous wound, to hush its
black pain.
But when he saw the Trojans surging
over
The wall, and heard the Danaans cry
in fear,
He groaned, and struck his thigh,
and called aloud:
“Eurypylus, I cannot stay, though
gladly
I would help you; such a battle has
arisen.
Let your companion tend you; I will
run
To great Achilles, and persuade him,
if
The gods should grant my words to
move his heart.
Good is the counsel brought by a
friend in need.”
Away he went. The Argives still
stood firm,
Though fewer, by the ships; nor
could they drive
The Trojans back, nor let them
through the ranks

To mingle with the huts and vessels.
There
The battle held its balance, straight
as when
A craftsman lays a rule against a
beam,
Who knows each art Athena taught
to men.
Around one ship great Ajax and
Hector fought,
And neither could compel the other
back;
The god had joined them there for
that hard labor.
Ajax, Clytius’ son, struck Caletor
Within the breast, as he bore fire
toward
The ship. He fell, and from his
loosened hand
The torch dropped flaming. Hector
saw his cousin
Fall in the dust before the
dark-prowed ship,
And called to Trojans and Lycians:
“Do not give way within this narrow
place!
Save Clytius’ son, lest Argive hands
strip off
His armor when he falls among the
ships!”
He cast his shining spear at Ajax, but
It missed its mark and struck
Lycopyhron,
Mastor’s son, a Cytherean guest
And Ajax’s companion, who had
lived
Within his house since blood-price
drove him out
From sacred Cythera. Hector’s spear

Struck him above the ear; backward
he fell
From off the stern into the dust, his
limbs
Loosened beneath him. Ajax
shuddered, then
Called to his brother:
“Teucer, our faithful friend is
slain—the man
We honored in our house as if our
parents
Had borne him. Hector has cut him
down.
Where are your death-swift arrows
and your bow,
The gift Apollo gave you?”
Teucer heard,
And came beside him with his
crooked bow
And arrow-bearing quiver. He shot
down
Cleitus, son of Peisenor, who held
The reins beside Polydamas, his
friend.
He labored hardest where the horses
drove
The thickest ranks for Hector and
the Trojans;
The sudden arrow entered through
his neck.
He fell from the chariot, and the
horses
Rang empty harness. Polydamas saw,
Ran before them, and gave them to
Astynous,
Protiaon’s son, commanding him to
hold
Them close; then hurried back into
the front.

Teucer drew one more arrow against
Hector,
And might have ended all his
fighting there,
Had Zeus not guarded Hector from
that fate.
The newly twisted bowstring broke
as Teucer
Bent back the bow; the
bronze-tipped arrow veered,
And bow and string fell from his
hands. He cried:
“A god has rooted out our
battle-plans!
He cast my bow away and snapped
the string
I twisted this same morning, that it
might
Endure the arrows leaping from it.”
Then Ajax,
The great Telamonian, answered
him:
“Let bow and arrows lie. The god has
mixed
Them into grief for the Danaans.
Take
The long spear and the shield upon
your shoulder;
Fight, and rouse the rest. Let not the
enemy
Take our well-benched ships without
a struggle.
Remember now the courage we have
learned.”
Teucer set the bow within the hut,
and hung
The fourfold shield around his
shoulders. He put
The horse-haired helmet on his head;
its crest

Nodded above him terribly. He
seized
The bronze-sharpened spear and
took his stand
Beside his brother.
When Hector saw the arrows
blunted, he called:
“Trojans, Lycians, Dardanians,
remember
Your strength, and be men beside the
hollow ships!
The arrows of a foremost man a god
Has turned aside. The strength Zeus
gives to men
Is known in this: to one he grants
great glory,
Another he diminishes—as now
He lessens Argive might and helps
us. Fight
In one mass by the ships. Let him
who falls
And meets his death lie dead; there is
no shame
In dying for the fatherland. His wife,
His children, house, and unviolated
fields
Remain secure if Argive ships depart
And sail at last toward their beloved
land.”
His speech stirred every heart. Ajax
cried
From the other side: “Shame,
Argives! Now we must
Either be saved or perish. Do you
hope
That when Hector takes the ships
each man will walk
Back to his fatherland? Do you not
hear

How he commands his people to
burn them?
He calls no dance; he calls us to the
fight.
We have no counsel better than to
join
Our hands and strength together.
Better to die
At once, or live, than waste our
breath beside
The ships beneath men worse than
we.”
Their hearts were stirred. Then
Hector struck Schedius,
Perimedes’ son, the Phocian leader;
Ajax struck Laodamas, Antenor’s
son,
The footmen’s captain. Polydamas
killed
Otus, companion of Phyleus, chief
Among the great-hearted Epeians.
Meges
Sprang at Polydamas; he bent
beneath
The spear, and Apollo would not let
Panthous’ son
Fall there. Instead Meges struck
Croesmus
Within the chest; he fell with a crash,
and Meges
Stripped the bronze armor from his
shoulders.
Then Dolops, skilled with spears,
sprang at Meges.
His spear struck the shield’s middle,
but the close
Fitted breastplate saved him—the
guest-gift once
Brought from Ephyra by Phyleus,
given

By King Euphetes to protect a friend
In war, and now protecting Phyleus'
son.

Meges struck the horse-haired
helmet's crest

And broke away its plume; the
helmet fell

Into the dust like a young palm-tree
newly

Cut down, still shining. As he fought
and hoped

For victory, warlike Menelaus came
To stand beside him, hidden, and
drove his spear

Into Dolops' shoulder from behind.
The bronze passed through his chest;
forward he fell.

They moved to strip the dead man's
armor off,

When Hector called his brothers,
and first rebuked

Melanippus, Hicetaon's son, who
once

Had grazed his cattle far from battle,
near

Perkote. While the ships were still
away,

He lived apart; but when they
reached the land,

He came to Troy and shone among
its spearmen.

When the curved ships had come,
Melanippus

Returned to Ilium, and beside the
house

Of Priam made his dwelling; Priam
honored him

As he would honor any of his sons.

But Hector called him by his name
and said:

"Will you, Melanippus, rest? Have
you no shame
Within you for your cousin who has
fallen?

Do you not see the Achaeans
carrying off

The armor of Dolops? Come with
me. No room

Remains for fighting from afar with
Argives:

We must either slay them, or take
steep Troy

And all her people."

He spoke, and led the way;

Melanippus,

Godlike, followed at his side. Great
Ajax

Urged the Argives: "Be men, friends,
and set shame

Within your hearts; respect each
other in

The hard encounter. When men
remember

Their fellows, more are saved than
slain; but flight

Of cowards brings no glory and no
strength."

He spoke; and they desired to drive
the danger

Away, and took his words into their
hearts,

Fencing the ships with bronze. Then
Zeus awoke

The Trojans' courage. Menelaus
called

To young Antilochus: "No Achaean
is

Younger than you, or swifter on his
feet,

Or braver in the fight. Leap forth,
and strike
Some Trojan down.”
He sprang among the foremost,
Looked round, and cast his shining
spear. The Trojans
Drew back before it, yet the spear
did not
Fly vainly: Melanippus, Hicetaon's
son,
Returning from the battle, took the
bronze
Below the breast, beside the nipple.
Down
He fell; black darkness covered both
his eyes.
Antilochus leaped upon him as a
hound
Upon a wounded fawn, when from
its lair
The hunter strikes it, loosening its
limbs.
So on Melanippus, exulting in war,
He sprang to strip the armor. Hector
saw,
And came running through the
battle to oppose him.
Antilochus, though swift and
practiced, did not
Await him. Like a beast that has
done a deadly
Deed and flees the crowd that
gathers after it
Has killed a dog or herdsman by the
herd,
So fled the son of Nestor. Hector and
The Trojans poured their groaning
shafts behind him,
Until he turned and stood among his
friends.

Then like flesh-eating lions Troy
rushed on
The ships, fulfilling Zeus's will. He
roused
Their courage, bewitched the
Argives' hearts,
And took their glory from them. For
he wished
To grant the greater glory to brave
Hector,
That he might cast the fire of heaven
upon
The curved ships, and complete the
dreadful prayer
Of Thetis. Zeus desired to see
himself
The bright flame of a burning vessel;
then
He would drive Troy in flight away
from the ships,
And give the Danaans their glory
back.
For this he roused great Hector
beside the ships—
Though Hector needed no such
urging—raging
Like spear-fighting Ares, or a fire
That tears through mountain forest.
Foam stood round
His mouth; beneath his terrible
brows his eyes
Flashed, and his helmet shook above
his temples.
Zeus from the upper air defended
him,
Honoring Hector, granting him
alone
The glory, though his day would
soon be brief;
For Pallas Athena had already raised

The destined hour beneath the hands
of Peleus' son.
Hector sought the place where men
stood thickest,
And where the finest armor flashed;
yet there
He could not break them. Joined as a
tower,
Or as a cliff beside the gray sea, they
waited
Unmoved for all the shrieking roads
of wind,
For waves that thundered on the
rock. So stood
The Danaans, holding Troy, and did
not yield.
But Hector, bright with fire on every
side,
Leaped into them as a wave falls on a
ship,
A storm-wave lifted underneath the
clouds
When wind drives hard; the ship is
hidden under foam,
The sail roars, and the sailors
tremble, carried
But a short distance from the jaws of
death.
So in the Achaeans' breasts their
hearts were broken.
As when a savage lion falls upon
The cattle in a marsh, thousands
grazing wide,
And the herdsman has not yet
learned to fight
The beast for the death of one
horned ox—he walks
Beside the first and last, but leaps
upon

The middle, and the whole herd
recoils—so then
The Achaeans fled in terror before
Hector
And father Zeus.
Hector alone struck down
Periphetes,
Mycenaean, beloved son of Copreus,
Who once had served as herald, in
the might
Of Heracles, before Eurystheus, king.
His son surpassed his father far in
excellence,
In feet, in war, in judgment;
foremost among
Mycenae's men he had been shaped.
But then
He turned in flight, and stumbled on
the rim
Of the long shield he carried against
the spears.
His feet were caught; he fell upon his
back;
The helmet rang around his temples.
Hector
Saw him at once, ran near, and drove
his spear
Into his breast beside his grieving
friends.
They could not help him: Hector's
terror held them.
The Argives drew inward; the first
ships enclosed
Them round, and Troy poured over
them. They withdrew
By force from those that stood in the
foremost line,
But stayed together near the huts;
they did not

Scatter through the camp. Shame
and fear restrained them;
They called continually from man to
man.
Then Nestor, Gerenian guardian of
the Greeks,
Kneeled and entreated each by his
parents' names:
"Be men, dear friends, and set shame
within your hearts."
"Remember the children, wives, and
lands; remember
The fathers of the living and the
dead,
Who lie beneath the earth. For their
sake I kneel,
Though they are not here. Stand fast,
and hold your strength;
Do not turn your faces into fear."
He spoke, and stirred the courage in
their breasts.
Athena swept the wondrous mist
away
From both their eyes. A light arose
on either side,
Toward ships and battle, where the
ranks met.
They saw bright Hector and his
companions—those
Who stood behind and would not
fight, and those
Who fought beside the swift ships.
Great-hearted Ajax
No longer found it pleasing to
remain
Where other Achaeans had
withdrawn.
Across the long decks of the vessels
he paced,

Taking great strides, and wielded in
his hands
The sea-fighting spear, joined with
rings of bronze,
Two-and-twenty cubits in its length.
As when a horseman skilled to guide
his team
Joins four together, driving from the
plain
Toward the city on the public
road—many
Men and women marvel as he leaps
secure
From one to another, while they fly
beneath him—
So Ajax crossed the many ships, and
strode
Their long decks; his voice reached
heaven. Without pause
He shouted terribly, commanding all
The Danaans to guard their ships
and huts.
Nor Hector stayed within the
close-packed press
Of bronze-clad Trojans. As a shining
eagle
Falls on a flock of birds beside a
river—
Geese, cranes, or long-necked swans
feeding in a meadow—
So Hector sprang straight toward a
dark-prowed ship.
Zeus drove him on with his
tremendous hand,
And roused the people who
advanced with him.
Again a sharp battle rose beside the
ships.
You would have thought that
deathless, tireless men

Were meeting one another, such
desire
For combat burned in them. The
Achaean vowed
They would not flee from evil, but
would die;
Each Trojan heart hoped to burn the
ships and kill
The Achaean heroes.
With this purpose they stood
Against each other. Hector seized
the stern
Of a seafaring ship, swift and
beautiful,
The ship that carried Protesilaus to
Troy
And never bore him home to his own
land.
Around it Greeks and Trojans
slaughtered men
At close quarters. They no longer
kept apart
For arrows or for spears, but stood
nearby
With one mind, fighting with sharp
axes, hatchets,
Great swords, and double-edged
spears. Many handsome,
Black-hilted swords fell from the
hands of men;
Others slipped from shoulders; black
earth ran with blood.
When Hector grasped the stern, he
would not let it go.
Holding the curved stern-post in his
hands,
He called the Trojans: "Bring fire,
and rise
Together with one cry! Now Zeus
has given

A day worth all our prayers—to take
the ships
That came against the gods' will,
bringing us
So many sorrows through our elders'
folly.
They held me back when I desired to
fight
Beside the sterns, and held the
people back.
But if wide-seeing Zeus then
darkened our minds,
He now himself commands us and
drives us on."
He spoke; they rushed more fiercely
on the Argives.
Ajax could no longer keep his place;
the shafts
Pressed hard around him. He
withdrew a little,
Believing he would die there, he gave
ground
Along the seven-foot bridge, and left
The level timbers of the ship.
There he stood watching, and with
his spear
Continually drove from the ships
each Trojan
Who bore the tireless fire. Always he
shouted:
"Dear friends, Danaan heroes,
servants of Ares,
Be men, my friends, remember
furious strength!
Do we imagine helpers somewhere
behind us,
Or some stronger wall that might
ward destruction off?
There is no city here with towers,
where we might

Defend ourselves, holding another
people
Behind our backs. We lie in Troy's
open plain,
Close-packed in bronze, our faces
toward the sea,
Far from our fatherland. Our light is
in
Our own hands, not in any gentle
kind of war.”
He spoke, and in his fury drove them
back
With his keen spear. Each Trojan
carrying fire
Toward the hollow ships, encouraged
by
Hector's command, Ajax awaited
there
And struck him with his long spear.
Twelve he wounded
Before the ships, in close encounter.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 16

First-pass working translation

So they fought around the
well-benched ship,
And Patroclus came before Achilles,
The shepherd of the people, pouring
tears
Like a dark spring that spills its
shadowed stream
Down the face of a steep rock. When
swift-footed
Achilles saw him, pity touched his
heart:
“Why do you weep, Patroclus, like a
girl
Who runs beside her mother,
clutching at her robe,
And holds her back though she is
hastening on,
Looking up, and weeping till she is
taken
Into her arms? Do you bring news for
us—
For the Myrmidons, or for me alone?
Have you heard word from Phthia?
They say that still
Menoetius, Actor's son, and Peleus,
Aeacus' son, live among the
Myrmidons.
We should grieve bitterly if either
died.
Or do you mourn the Argives, how
they perish
Beside the hollow ships through their
own fault?
Speak out; do not hide it in your
heart,

That we may know the matter both
together.”
With a deep sigh Patroclus answered
him:
“Achilles, son of Peleus, greatest far
Among Achaeans, do not be angry
now;
Such grief has fallen upon the host.
The men
Who once stood foremost lie beside
the ships,
Struck down or wounded. Diomedes
is wounded,
Tydeus' son; Odysseus of the spear,
And Agamemnon too; Eurypylus
Has taken an arrow through the
thigh. Physicians
Rich in remedies labor over them,
Healing their wounds; but you
remain unmoved.
“May no such anger seize me—your
own anger,
Which you preserve as though it
were a virtue.
Who will be helped by you in
aftertime,
Though you were born of noble
blood, if you refuse
To turn this ruin from the Argives?
Hard man!
Your father was not horseman
Peleus, nor
Was Thetis your mother; gray sea
and steep rocks
Gave birth to you, for your mind is
pitiless.
But if some prophecy troubles you,
and your
August mother has told you a word
from Zeus,

Send me at least, and give me your
Myrmidons,
That I may become a light to the
Danaans.
Put your armor on my shoulders, so
the Trojans,
Taking me for you, may withdraw
from war,
And the war-worn sons of Ares
breathe again.
The respite would be small; and
while we are fresh
And they are weary, we could drive
them back
From ships and huts toward the
city.”
So he pleaded, greatly foolish; for he
asked
The evil death already marked for
him.
Swift-footed Achilles, troubled,
answered:
“Ah me, Patroclus, born of Zeus,
what words
Have passed your lips? I do not heed
the prophecy
I know; nor has my mother brought
me any word
From Zeus. But this unbearable grief
lies hard
Upon my heart: when one who is my
equal
Would take the prize from me, and
rob me once again
Of honor that was mine, though he
has risen
Beyond me in authority. That grief
I carry, having endured it in my
heart.

“The girl the sons of Achaeans chose
my prize,
Whom I won with my spear when I
sacked the walls
Of a strong city, Agamemnon took
Back from my hands, as if I were a
stranger
Dishonored and without a name. Let
what is past
Lie quiet; it was not meant that I
should rage
Forever. I declared I would not cease
My anger till the tumult and the
battle
Reached my own ships.
“Put my famous armor on your
shoulders,
And lead the war-loving Myrmidons
to war,
If the dark cloud of Troy has covered
all
The ships by force, while Argives
pressed against
The sea's edge possess but little
ground,
And all the city has grown bold
against them;
For they no longer see beside them
shine
The front of my helmet. Fleeing, they
would fill
The channels with their dead, if
Agamemnon
Knew mercy now. But Tydeus' son
no longer
Wields the spear that warded death
from Danaans;
Nor have I heard the son of Atreus
call

From his detested head. Hector,
killer of men,
Shouts orders, and the Trojans hold
the field,
Overcoming Achaeans with their
cry.
“Drive this ruin from the ships with
all your force,
Lest fire consume them and destroy
our homeward
Return. But hold this order in your
heart:
Win honor and great glory for me
before
The Danaans, and bring the lovely
girl
And shining gifts they will return to
me.
When you have driven them from
the ships, come back.
And if the thunder-loving husband
of Hera
Grants you glory, do not wish to
fight the Trojans
Without me; you would lessen my
renown.
Do not, rejoicing in the war and
slaughter,
Lead them toward Ilium, lest some
deathless god
Come down from high Olympus; far
above all,
Apollo loves that city. Turn back
once
You have brought light to the ships,
and leave them still
To fight across the plain.”
If only Father Zeus, Athena, and
Apollo

Would let no Trojan escape
death—not one
Of all who stand here—nor an
Argive either,
And we two alone withdraw from
ruin,
And loose Troy's sacred veils.
Ajax could hold no longer. The
missiles pressed
Him hard; the will of Zeus and
splendid Troy
Wore down his strength. His bright
and terrible helm
Rang round his temples under blows
that struck
Its well-made bosses. His left
shoulder ached,
Yet still he held the shining shield
before him;
They could not stagger him by
leaning spears
Against it. Breath came painfully;
sweat poured
From every limb; one evil followed
on
Another, and no place remained for
breath.
Tell me now, Muses of Olympian
halls,
How first the fire fell on Achaean
ships.
Hector stood near him, struck his
ashen spear
Behind the blade, where bronze met
wood, and cut
It through. Ajax held the useless
stump;
The bronze point fell far from him
and rang

Upon the ground. He knew within
his blameless heart
The gods' work, and shuddered:
Zeus, the thunderer,
Was cutting off the counsel of the
fight,
Desiring victory for Troy. Ajax
Withdrew beneath the missiles. Then
the Trojans
Cast tireless fire upon the swift ship;
At once the flame ran over stern and
timbers.
Achilles struck his thighs and called
aloud:
"Rise, Patroclus, born of Zeus, driver
of horses!
I see beside the ships the cry and
breath
Of hostile fire. Let them not take the
vessels,
And leave us no retreat. Put on the
armor
With speed; I will assemble all the
people."
He spoke. Patroclus clothed himself
in bronze.
First he set beautiful greaves about
His legs, and clasped them at the
ankles with
Bright silver fastenings. Then he
drew the starry,
Many-colored corselet of Aeacides
Across his breast; around his
shoulders hung
The bronze sword, hilted in shining
silver,
And then the great, strong shield.
Upon his head
He set the well-made helmet,
horse-haired;

Above it nodded the dread crest. He
took
Two stout spears that fitted to his
hands.
But not the spear of blameless
Aeacides—
Heavy, immense, and massive, which
no other
Achaean could brandish. Only
Achilles
Knew how to wield the Pelian ash
that Chiron
Had given Peleus, for the death of
heroes.
Achilles ordered Automedon to yoke
The horses, whom he honored most
beside
Himself, the faithful one who stood
with him
Within the battle's shout.
Automedon
Brought Xanthus and Balius beneath
the yoke,
Swift horses flying on the breath of
wind.
Podarge, the Harpy, bore them to
the West Wind
As she grazed beside the stream of
Ocean.
Beside the trace he set blameless
Pedasus,
Whom Achilles had taken when he
sacked
Eetion's city. Mortal though he was,
The horse kept pace with horses
born immortal.
Achilles went among the huts and
armed
The Myrmidons. They rushed like
flesh-eating wolves,

Whose hearts hold measureless
strength after they tear
Apart a great-antlered stag upon the
hills.
Their cheeks are red with blood; in a
pack they go
Down to a black-water spring, and
lap the dark
Water with thin tongues, belching
out the clot
Of blood. Their courage has no fear
within;
Their bellies swell with strength of
what they killed.
So captains and commanders moved
around
The brave companion of swift-footed
Peleus' son;
Among them stood Achilles, urging
horses
And men behind their shields.
Fifty swift ships belonged to him,
whom Zeus
Loved, and bore him toward Troy. In
each were fifty
Companions at the oars. Five leaders
he had set
Whom he trusted to give commands;
he himself
Held the great mastery over all.
Menesthius, flashing bronze, led the
first;
The son of Spercheius, heaven's river.
Fair
Polydora, Peleus' daughter, bore him
To the tireless stream after lying
with
The god; but Borus, son of Perieres,
Was called his father, for he openly
married

Her and gave bride-price beyond
measure.
Eudorus, warlike and unmarried, led
The second. Lovely Polymele,
daughter
Of Phylas, bore him after Hermes
saw
Her among Artemis' bright dancers,
loved
Her eyes, and climbed in secret to
her room.
He gave her Eudorus, glorious son,
Swift-footed, excellent in war. When
Eileithyia,
Goddess of birth, brought him into
the light
To see the sun, Echeclus, Actor's son,
Took the child's mother to his house,
and gave
Countless bride-gifts; but old Phylas
reared
The child, and loved him as he were
his own.
Peisander, son of Maemalus, led
The third, and all the Myrmidons
surpassed
In spear-fight beside Peleus' son. The
fourth
Was old Phoenix, driver of horses;
fifth,
Blameless Alcimedon, Laerces' son.
When Achilles had arrayed them
with their leaders,
He gave a stern command: "Let none
forget
The threats you uttered at the swift
ships once,
While anger held me, and each one
accused me:

'Cruel son of Peleus, your mother
nourished
You in gall; pitiless, you keep us here
Against our will beside the ships. Let
us
Return across the sea, since such a
bitter
Anger has entered your heart.' You
often spoke
Those words when you gathered
around me. Now
The great work of the war you once
desired
Stands plain before you. Let each
man who carries
A valiant heart go fight the Trojans."
He stirred the spirit in them; at his
words
The ranks drew close. As when a
builder lays
A wall with stones close-fitted, to
hold back
The violent winds from a
high-roofed house,
So shield leaned against shield,
helmet against
Helmet, and man against his fellow
man;
Horsehair crests touched with bright
ridges as they stood.
Before them Patroclus and
Automedon,
Of one accord, armed themselves to
lead the host.
Achilles rose and entered his hut.
From a chest
He took the beautiful cup Thetis had
set
There, silver-footed, when she
brought it aboard,

With shirts, wind-sheltering cloaks,
and woven rugs.
No other man had drunk burning
wine from it,
Nor had Achilles poured a god a
libation
From that cup, save to Father Zeus.
He took
It from the chest, cleansed it first
with sulfur,
Then washed it in pure streams, and
washed his hands.
He drew the dark wine, stood amid
the yard,
And poured it, looking upward
toward the sky.
Zeus, who delights in thunder, did
not fail
To hear him:
"Lord Zeus of Dodona, Pelasgian,
dwelling
Far off, guardian of stormy Dodona,
Where Selloi, your interpreters, live
round you,
Unwashed of foot, and sleep upon
the ground—
Once you heard my prayer, and
honored me,
Humbling the Achaean people
greatly;
Grant me this prayer also. I remain
here
Beside the ships, but send my
companion out
To fight among the many
Myrmidons.
Send glory with him, wide-seeing
Zeus, and make
His heart courageous, that Hector
may know

Whether my friend alone has learned
to fight,
Or whether his hands rage invincibly
only
When I enter the tumult of Ares.
When he has driven the war-cry
from the ships,
Let him return unharmed to me,
with all
His armor and his close-fighting
companions.”
So prayed Achilles; and the
counselor heard.
The father granted one half, denied
the other:
Patroclus would drive battle from
the ships,
But would not come safe home from
that battle.
When he had poured the offering
and prayed to Zeus,
Achilles went inside and set the cup
Within the chest; then came and
stood before
His hut, still longing in his heart to
see
The terrible encounter of the
Trojans
And Achaeans.
The men, in arms together with
Patroclus,
Marched forth; and, bold within
their hearts, they fell
Upon the Trojans. At once they
poured like wasps
Beside a road, whom foolish children
tease,
Delighting in their sport, while the
insects keep

Their homes beside the path, making
one evil
For many. If a traveler passing near
Disturbs them without meaning, all
at once
The strong-hearted wasps fly
forward to defend
Their young. So from the ships the
Myrmidons
Streamed forth, and an
unquenchable cry rose.
Patroclus lifted up his voice:
“Companions
Of Peleus' son Achilles, be men,
friends,
And remember your furious
strength, that we may
Honor the son of Peleus, best by far
Among the Argives here, and his
companions,
The best in close combat. Let
Agamemnon,
Son of Atreus, learn his
blindness—he honored
Not the best of the Achaeans.”
Thus he stirred
The courage of them all. Together
they fell
Upon the Trojans, and the ships
around them
Rang terribly beneath the Achaean
shout.
When the Trojans saw Menoetius'
brave son,
Himself and his companion shining
in the armor,
Every heart shook, and every rank
was moved.
They hoped that swift-footed Peleus'
son

Had laid his anger by the ships and
chosen
Friendship once more; each looked
for some escape
From steep and sudden death.
Patroclus first cast his shining spear
Into the densest crowd, beside the
stern
Of great Protesilaus' ship. He struck
Pyraechmes, leader of the
horse-armored Paeons,
Who came from broad Amydon
beside the Axios.
The spear drove through his right
shoulder; backward
He fell into the dust with a groan.
His people
Scattered around him, for Patroclus
cast
Fear among them by killing their
first fighter.
He drove them from the ships and
quenched the fire.
The half-burned ship remained; the
Trojans fled
With a god's tumult, and Danaans
poured
Among the hollow vessels. An uproar
rose
That would not cease.
As Zeus, the gatherer of lightning,
drives
A heavy cloud from a mountain's
high peak,
And watchtowers, ridges, valleys all
appear
While heaven opens into boundless
sky,
So Danaans, having driven the
hostile fire

From the ships, drew breath a little.
Yet the war
Gave them no rest. The Trojans did
not flee
Headlong from the black ships
before the Achaeans,
But still resisted, yielding them only
Under compulsion.
When the battle-line broke, man
took his man.
First Menoetius' son, as Areilycus
Turned, struck his thigh with the
sharp spear; bronze
Passed through, and shattered bone.
Face downward
Areilycus fell. Menelaus struck
Thoas in the bare chest beside his
shield,
And loosed his limbs. Meges watched
Amphiclus
Rush toward him, and struck the
upper leg,
Where muscle is thickest in a man's
body;
The point split sinew, and darkness
covered him.
Antilochus, Nestor's son, struck
Atymnius
Within the flank; the bronze passed
through, and he fell.
Maris stood beside his brother's
body,
And sprang at Antilochus in rage.
But godlike
Thrasymedes thrust before he could
strike,
And pierced his shoulder; the spear
severed muscle,
Passed through the bone, and Maris
fell with a crash.

Darkness covered his eyes. Thus the
two friends
Of Sarpedon, the spear-fighting sons
Of Amisodarus, went down to
Erebus—
The man who raised the
unconquerable Chimera,
A great evil for many.
Ajax, Oileus' son, sprang upon
Cleobulus,
Still living, stunned among the
confusion.
He struck his neck with the sword's
hilt and loosed
His strength; the blade grew warm
with blood, and death
And the strong portion of fate seized
his eyes.
Peneleus and Lycon rushed together;
Their spears went wide, and each
cast his shaft in vain.
Then they met again with swords.
Lycon struck
The boss of Peneleus' horse-haired
helmet,
But his sword broke around the
shaft. Peneleus
Cut Lycon's neck beneath the ear;
the blade
Went through, and only skin held on
the head
While all the limbs gave way.
Meriones, running swiftly, caught
Acamas
As he climbed to his horses, and
struck his shoulder.
He fell from the chariot; mist
covered his eyes.
Idomeneus struck Erymas in the
mouth

With pitiless bronze. The spear
passed beneath
The brain, shattering the white
bones; teeth sprang out,
Both eyes filled with blood, and
blood broke from
His mouth and nostrils. Black death
covered him.
So each Danaan leader took a man, as
wolves
Fall on lambs or kids when scattered
mountain flocks
Have lost their shepherd—snatching
them away.
And when the wolves have seen
them, quickly tear
The helpless lambs apart. So Danaans
fell
Upon the Trojans; but the Trojans
remembered
The loud terror of flight, and lost the
furious
Strength that had been theirs.
Great Ajax still hurled himself
against
Hector in bronze. But Hector,
practiced in war,
Covered his broad shoulders with a
bull's hide,
And watched the whistling arrows
and the spears
That struck with weight. He knew
well that victory
Had turned toward the other side,
yet still remained,
And saved his steadfast companions.
As when a cloud comes down from
bright Olympus
Into the clear air, when Zeus
stretches out

The storm, so from the ships rose
shout and terror.
They did not draw back in an
ordered way.
Swift horses carried Hector with his
armor;
He left the Trojan people in the
trench,
Held there unwillingly. Many swift
horses,
Dragging their chariots, broke their
yokes within it,
And left their lords' vehicles behind.
Patroclus followed, shouting, calling
out
To Danaans, filled with evil thoughts
for Troy.
The roads were full of their cry and
fear; the whirlwind
Scattered high beneath the clouds,
and one-hoofed horses
Stretched themselves toward the
city, running back
From ships and huts. Wherever he
could see
The greatest multitude in confusion,
there
He drove them with his cry. Beneath
the axles
Men fell face-first from chariots;
overturned,
The cars lay broken. Deathless
horses, gifts
The gods had given Peleus, leaped
the trench.
Hector's heart desired to cast at
Patroclus,
But swift horses bore him out of
reach.

As when in autumn rain the black
earth grows
Heavy, when Zeus pours down his
fiercest storm
In anger at men who in the assembly
judge
Crooked judgments by force and
drive out justice,
Heeding no god's regard—then all
the rivers
Rise as they run, and ravines cut the
hills,
Roaring from mountains toward the
purple sea,
While the works of men grow
small—so Trojan horses
Raced and groaned beneath their
harness.
When Patroclus had broken through
the first ranks,
He drove them back toward ships.
He did not let them
Reach the city, but between the
ships, the river,
And the high wall he leaped upon
and killed,
Exactng the price of many. First he
struck
Pronous with his shining spear in the
bare chest
Beside the shield, and loosed his
limbs; he fell
With a crash. Then he rushed upon
Thestor,
Enops' son, who crouched within his
polished car,
His wits struck senseless; reins had
fled his hands.
Patroclus stood beside him, drove
the spear

Through his right jaw and teeth, and
drawing him
Above the rim, pulled him from the
chariot—
As a fisherman upon a jutting rock
Draws a holy fish from the sea with
line
And glittering bronze. So he drew
Thestor out,
Mouth gaping on the spear, and
thrust him down
Upon his face; the life departed him.
Then Erylaus came rushing; with a
stone
He struck the middle of his head.
The skull
Split under the heavy helmet, and he
fell
Face downward; death poured round
him. After him
He sent Erymas, Amphoteron,
Epaltus,
Tlepolemus son of Damastor, Echius,
Pyris, Ipheus, Euippus, and
Polymelus,
Argeas' son—all in succession
brought
Down to the nourishing earth.
When Sarpedon saw his companions
fall,
Their tunics stripped of armor,
beneath the hands
Of Menoetius' son, he called the
Lycians:
“Shame, Lycians! Where do you flee?
Be swift!
I will myself meet this man, and
learn who he is,
Who holds such power and has done
so much harm

To Troy, unbinding the knees of
many brave men.”
He leaped from his chariot with his
armor;
Patroclus, seeing him, sprang down
from his own.
They rushed together, crying out,
like two
Curved-clawed vultures fighting on a
high rock,
Their cry enormous and terrible.
The son of crooked-counseling
Cronus saw them,
And pitied Sarpedon, dearest of all
men
To him. He spoke to Hera, sister and
wife:
“Ah me! Fate has appointed that
Sarpedon,
Dearest of men to me, be overcome
By Menoetius' son. My heart divides
me
As I deliberate: shall I seize him
living
From this tearful battle, set him
down in rich
Lycia—or let him fall beneath the
hands
Of Menoetius' son?”
Ox-eyed Hera answered:
“Most terrible son of Cronus, what
have you said?
Would you free from death a mortal
long ago
Appointed by his fate? Do so; but
know
The other gods will not approve.
Hold this
Within your heart: if you send your
beloved son

Alive from battle, every god may wish
To send his own dear son away.
Many sons
Of immortals fight before Priam's city;
You would awaken dreadful envy in them all.
But if he is dear, and your heart laments him,
Let him be overcome by Menoetius' son.
When breath and life have left him, send Death and Sleep
To bear him to the people of broad Lycia.
There brothers and companions will prepare
His burial, with mound and pillar; that is
The honor given the dead.”
She spoke; the father of gods and men did not
Refuse. He poured red drops upon the earth,
Honoring his dear son, whom Patroclus
Was destined to kill in fertile Troy, Far from his fatherland.
When the two were near, Patroclus struck
Thrasymelus, Sarpedon's excellent friend,
Low in the belly; he loosed his limbs. Sarpedon
Cast his bright spear again, but missed, and struck
Pedasus, the horse, upon the right shoulder.

The horse cried out as life went from him, fell
Into the dust, and his spirit flew away.
The other horses sprang apart; the yoke broke,
The reins were tangled when the side horse lay.
Automedon, famous for his spear, found the cure.
He drew the long sword thick upon his thigh,
Sprang forward, and cut away the side horse.
The other two straightened; the reins pulled taut.
Once more the heroes met above the battle
That eats the heart. Again Sarpedon missed;
The point passed over Patroclus' left shoulder.
Then Patroclus rose behind his bronze, and cast
No vain spear: he struck Sarpedon where the midriff
Encloses the inward heart. He fell as falls
An oak, a poplar, or a tall pine that men
Cut on the mountain with their sharpened axes,
Preparing it to be a ship's timber.
So he lay before his horses and his car,
Roaring, and clutching dust turned red with blood.
As a lion kills a great-horned bull among

The herd, the bull bellowing beneath
its jaws,
So the shield-bearing lord of Lycia,
dying
Beneath Patroclus, struggled and
called his friend:
“Glaucus, dear friend, now you must
be a spearman,
A bold fighter among men, if you are
swift.
Let this evil battle be your desire.
Go first among the Lycian leaders,
urge them
To fight around Sarpedon; then fight
for me
Yourself with bronze. I shall be
shame and reproach
To you each day if Achaeans strip my
armor
When I fall among the ships. Stand
fast, and rouse
The people.”
When he had spoken, death covered
his eyes
And nostrils. Patroclus set his foot
upon
His chest and drew the spear from
out his body;
With it the point came forth, the
midriff and
The spirit following. Then he drew
the spear
From flesh. At once the Myrmidons
held back
The horses, snorting, eager to escape,
Their masters' chariot left behind.
When Glaucus heard the cry, a
dreadful grief
Came over him; his heart was
shaken, though

He could not yet give help. He
pressed his arm,
For a wound tormented him—the
wound Teucer
Had given him before the high-built
wall,
Defending his friends from
destruction. He prayed:
“Hear me, lord, whether in rich Lycia
Or Troy; you hear the man in
trouble everywhere.
I bear this wound; sharp pains run
through my arm,
The blood will not dry, and my
shoulder grows heavy.
I cannot hold my spear, nor go
against
The enemy. The best of men has
fallen,
Sarpedon, Zeus's son; yet Zeus
himself
Defends him not. But you, lord, heal
this wound,
Quiet the pain, and give me strength,
that I
May call the Lycians, urge them on,
and fight
Myself around the dead.”
He prayed; Apollo heard. At once he
stilled
The pain, dried black blood from the
wound,
And poured strength into Glaucus'
heart. He knew
The god had heard him, and rejoiced.
First he went among the Lycian
leaders,
Urging them to fight around
Sarpedon; then

With long strides sought Polydamas
and Agenor,
And came beside Aeneas and
bronze-clad Hector:
“Hector, you have forgotten the allies
Who waste their lives, far from their
friends and land,
For you, while you do not come to
their aid.
Sarpedon lies here, leader of the
shields
Of Lycia, who ruled his land by
judgment,
Strength, and the spear. Bronze Ares,
under
Patroclus, has overcome him. Come,
dear friends,
Stand by us; let your hearts be
shamed. Do not let
The Myrmidons strip off his armor,
dishonor
The dead, for all the Danaans we
killed
Beside the ships.”
He spoke; an unbearable grief seized
Troy,
For Sarpedon had been the city's
support,
Though foreign there, and many
followed him.
They went against the Danaans,
eager for war;
Hector led them, enraged for
Sarpedon.
But Patroclus' shaggy heart aroused
The Achaeans. He spoke to both the
Ajaxes:
“Ajaxes, let it be dear to you to guard
us

As you have done before—or better
still.
Here lies the man who first leaped on
our wall,
Sarpedon. If we could seize and
dishonor him,
Strip off his armor, kill one of those
who guard
The dead with pitiless bronze!”
They desired to drive the danger off.
Trojans and Lycians, Myrmidons and
Greeks
Strengthened their ranks and joined
with dreadful cries
Around the dead; the armor rang
aloud.
Zeus stretched hateful night across
the fight,
That war's hard labor might
surround his son.
The Trojans drove the bright-eyed
Achaeans back;
Epigeus had been struck, not least
among
The Myrmidons, Agacles' godlike
son.
Once he ruled Budeion; but after
killing
His noble cousin fled to Peleus and
Silver-footed Thetis, who sent him
out
With Achilles to horse-rich Ilium.
As Epigeus touched the dead, bright
Hector struck
His head with a stone; his skull split
within
The heavy helm; face downward on
the corpse
He fell, and death poured round him.

Patroclus grieved, and sprang
through the foremost
Fighters like a hawk that scatters
jackdaws.
So upon Lycians and Trojans you
rushed,
Angered for your companion. With a
stone
You struck Sthenelaus, Ithaemenes'
son,
Upon the neck and shattered the
tendons.
The foremost fighters and bright
Hector gave ground,
As far as a long javelin reaches when
a man
Tests it in war; so far the Trojans
fled.
Glaucus, first among shield-bearing
Lycians,
Turned and killed great-hearted
Bathycles,
Chalcon's beloved son, a wealthy
man
Among the Myrmidons. Bathycles
caught
Him in pursuit; Glaucus turned
suddenly,
And struck the middle of his chest.
He fell.
Greeks grieved; Trojans rejoiced
around him.
Yet Achaeans remembered strength,
and carried
Their courage straight against the
enemy.
Meriones took Laogonus, brave son
Of Onetor, priest of Idaean Zeus,
Honored among his people as a god.

He struck beneath the jaw and ear;
life swiftly
Left his limbs, and hateful darkness
took him.
Aeneas cast his bronze spear at
Meriones,
But Meriones saw it and bent away.
The long spear planted itself behind
him,
Its butt-end quivering in the earth.
There Ares
Robbed it of force; it sank, having
leaped
Vainly from Aeneas' hand. Aeneas
said:
"Though you are a dancer, my spear
would have stilled
You had it found you." Meriones
replied:
"Though you are strong, you cannot
quench the spirit
Of every man who comes against
you. You too
Are mortal. If sharp bronze struck
you, though you
Trust in your strength, you would
give glory and life
To Hades of the famous horses."
Menoetius' son rebuked him: "Why
speak such things?
The Trojans will not leave the dead
for taunts;
The earth will hold one of us first.
War's end
Lies in the hands; words belong to
counsel.
We must fight." He led; Meriones
followed.
The sound of woodcutters rose in
mountain valleys;

So from the earth rose crash of
bronze and hide,
Of shields and double-edged swords
striking spears.
No man, however wise, could know
divine
Sarpedon now; arrows, blood, and
dust concealed him.
The fighters crowded round the dead
as flies
Buzz around full milk-pails in spring,
the vessels wet.
Nor did Zeus turn his shining eyes
away.
He watched and pondered Patroclus'
death:
Should Hector kill him beside
Sarpedon, strip
The armor from his shoulders—or
heap still more
Grievous labor on the many? This
seemed best:
That Patroclus drive the Trojans and
bronze-clad
Hector back to Troy, and take the
lives of many.
First he put cowardice into Hector's
heart.
Hector climbed his chariot and
turned to flee,
Calling the Trojans; for he knew
Zeus's balance.
Nor did the Lycians stay. Fear seized
them all
When they saw their king among the
dead,
His heart struck through. Many had
fallen on him
When Cronus' son drew out the
fierce quarrel.

They took the bronze armor from
Sarpedon; then
Menoetius' son sent it to his friends
To carry to the hollow ships. Zeus
spoke to Apollo:
“Go, dear Phoebus, cleanse the dark
blood from him;
Lift Sarpedon from the arrows, carry
him,
And wash him in the river's streams.
Anoint him
With ambrosia, clothe him in
immortal garments.
Then send him with swift guides,
Sleep and Death,
Twin brothers, who will set him
down in Lycia,
Rich land of broad peoples. There his
brothers
And friends shall prepare the body,
with mound
And pillar; that is honor for the
dead.”
Apollo did not disobey. Down from
Ida
He went into the dreadful battle,
lifted
Sarpedon from the arrows, carried
him far,
Washed him, anointed him, and
clothed him in
Immortal garments. Then he sent
him with
The twins, Sleep and Death, who
swiftly set him down
In broad Lycia.
But Patroclus ordered horses and
Automedon,
And chased the Trojans and Lycians,
deluded.

Had he kept Peleus' son's command,
he would
Have escaped black death. But Zeus's
will is stronger
Than the will of men: it frightens
even the brave,
Takes victory away with ease, then
gives
The courage back to fight.
Whom did you first kill, Patroclus,
and whom last,
When gods called you to death?
Adrestus first,
Autonous, Echeclus, Perimus, Megas'
son,
Epistor, Melanippus; then Elasmus,
Mulijs, Pylartes—these you took,
while all
The others turned and fled.
The Achaeans would have taken
steep-gated Troy
Under Patroclus' hands, so fiercely he
raged,
If Phoebus had not stood upon the
wall,
Planning his death and aiding Troy.
Three times
Patroclus climbed the high wall at
the corner;
Three times Apollo thrust him back,
touching
His shining shield with immortal
hands.
When Patroclus, godlike, rushed the
wall
A fourth time, Apollo cried in
winged wrath:
“Draw back, Patroclus, born of Zeus.
It is not

Your portion to sack Troy with your
spear—
Nor even Achilles', better far than
you.”
He spoke; Patroclus drew far back,
avoiding
The Far-Shooter's anger.
Hector held his one-hoofed horses at
The Scaean Gate, and wondered
whether he should
Drive once more into the battle's
heart,
Or call the people back within the
wall.
As he considered, Phoebus came
beside him
In the likeness of a strong young
man, Asius,
Hector's mother's brother, Hecabe's
full
Brother, Dymas' son, who dwelt in
Phrygia
Beside the streams of Sangarius. In
his shape
The son of Zeus spoke: “Hector, why
have you ceased
From battle? It is not fitting. Would
that I
Were weaker than you by as much as
I might be
Stronger; then I would soon make
you turn away
From hateful war. Drive your
strong-hoofed horses now
Against Patroclus. Perhaps you may
seize him,
And Apollo grant you glory.”
He spoke; the god returned among
the labor

Of mankind. Hector ordered wise
Cebriones
To lash the horses into battle. Apollo
entered
The multitude and threw confusion
on
The Argives, giving glory to the
Trojans
And Hector. Hector left the others,
did not
Strip armor, but drove straight at
Patroclus.
From the other side Patroclus leaped
down,
Holding his spear in his left hand; in
the right
He took a sharp and glittering stone,
large enough
To cover it, and hurled it without
delay.
The cast was not in vain: he struck
Cebriones,
Priam's renowned bastard, who held
the reins,
Between the brows. The stone
crushed both eyebrows;
Bone could not hold, and eyes fell in
the dust
Before his feet. Like a diver he fell
out
Of the well-made chariot; life left his
bones.
Patroclus mocked him: "How lightly
he has leaped!
He turns a neat somersault. If only
he
Were somewhere in the fish-filled
sea, this man
Could fill a hungry belly, diving from
a ship

For oysters, though the sea were
rough. So lightly
He tumbles now upon the plain.
There are divers
Among the Trojans too."
So he sprang upon Cebriones like a
lion
Ravaging a fold, wounded in the
chest,
Whose courage ruins it. Hector
leaped from
The horses on the other side. The
two fought round
Cebriones like lions on a mountain
summit,
Hungry, high in spirit, fighting over
a deer—
Patroclus, Menoetius' son, and
radiant Hector,
Masters of the war-cry, rushing to
cut flesh
With pitiless bronze. Hector seized
the head
And would not let it go; Patroclus
held
The foot. Trojans and Danaans
joined the fight,
And the war grew strong.
As East Wind and South Wind strive
in mountain valleys,
Shaking the deep oak, ash, and
smooth-barked cornel,
When long branches strike with
terrible sound
And broken boughs crash, so Trojans
and Achaeans,
Leaping upon each other,
slaughtered men,
And neither thought of ruinous fear.
Spears

And feathered arrows sprang from
bowstrings, fixed
Around Cebriones; great stones
battered shields.
He lay immense within the whirl of
dust,
Forgetful of his horsemanship.
While the sun stood high at heaven's
middle,
The weapons of both sides reached
their marks and men
Fell. But when the sun turned toward
the hour
Of unyoking, then beyond what fate
allowed
The Achaeans grew stronger. They
dragged Cebriones
Away from weapons and Trojans,
stripped the armor
From his shoulders.
Patroclus rushed upon the Trojans,
Evil in heart. Three times he sprang
among them,
Like swift Ares, shouting terribly;
three times
Nine men he killed. But when he
rushed a fourth time,
Equal to a god, the end of life
appeared.
Phoebus came against him in the
fierce battle,
Wrapped in thick mist, unseen. He
stood behind
And struck his broad back with the
flat of his hand;
Patroclus' eyes spun round. Apollo
knocked
The helmet from his head; it rolled
beneath

The horses' feet with ringing sound,
its horsehair
Stained by blood and dust. Until that
hour the helm
Had not been fated to be fouled, for
it guarded
The head and fair brow of godlike
Achilles.
But now Zeus gave it Hector, though
the day
Of his destruction was already near.
The long-shadowed spear was
shattered in Patroclus'
Hands, heavy, great, and crested;
from his shoulders
The shield fell by its strap onto the
earth.
Apollo loosened the corselet from
him.
Delusion took his mind; his shining
limbs
Grew slack. He stood stunned.
Behind, between his shoulders,
A Dardanian struck him with a sharp
spear—
Euphorbus, Panthous' son, who
surpassed his age
In spearmanship, horsemanship, and
running feet.
He had first come with chariot and
brought down
Twenty men while learning war. He
was the first
To cast at you, Patroclus, but could
not master you.
He ran back into the crowd, drawing
the ash
Spear from your flesh; he did not
stand to face you,
Though you were naked in the battle.

Patroclus, struck by god and spear,
withdrew
Among companions, fleeing his
appointed death.
When Hector saw him draw back,
wounded by bronze,
He came through the ranks and
struck him in the belly;
The bronze passed through.
Patroclus fell with a crash,
And deep grief seized Achaeans.
As when a lion overcomes an
unwearied boar,
And both, high in the mountains,
fight beside
A little spring, each thirsting to
drink, till force
At last subdues the panting boar—so
Hector,
Priam's son, near his spear, took life
away
From brave Patroclus, who had
killed so many,
And spoke in triumph:
“Patroclus, surely you said you would
lay waste
Our city, take the free day from
Trojan women,
And carry them by ship to your dear
fatherland—
Fool! Before them Hector's swift
horses have
Stretched their feet to battle. I excel
with spear
Among the Trojans who defend their
day;
But vultures will devour you here.
Poor man,
Achilles did not help you, though he
gave you

Many commands: ‘Do not return to
hollow ships,
Driver of horses, until you strip the
bloody
Tunic from the breast of man-killing
Hector.’
So he spoke, I think, and your foolish
mind obeyed.”
With failing strength Patroclus
answered him:
“Boast now, Hector. Zeus, Cronus'
son, and Apollo
Gave you victory; they easily
subdued me,
And stripped the armor from my
shoulders. If twenty
Men like you had met me, all would
have perished
Here beneath my spear. But deadly
fate and Leto's
Son have killed me, and among men
Euphorbus;
You are the third to strip me. Hear
this and hold
It in your heart: you shall not live
long. Death
And mighty fate stand near; you
shall fall beneath
The hands of blameless Achilles,
Aeacus' son.”
He spoke; death covered eyes and
nostrils. His spirit
Flew from his limbs and went to
Hades, lamenting
Its fate, leaving its manhood and its
youth.
Even dead, bright Hector answered:
“Why prophesy
My steep destruction, Patroclus?
Who can know

If Achilles, fair-haired Thetis' son,
will not
First be struck beneath my spear and
lose his life?"
He spoke, set foot upon him, drew
the bronze
Spear from the wound, and thrust
him from it backward.
Then after Automedon he went with
spear,
The godlike friend of swift-footed
Aeacides,
Desiring to strike him; but immortal
horses,
Beautiful gifts the gods had given to
Peleus,
Carried Automedon away.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Patroclus enters battle in borrowed armor

Original plate candidate by CastaliaInstitute; not by William Blake; informed by the repository's Blake-informed visual language, not by a specific Blake plate. Concept-review placement only.

BOOK 17

First-pass working translation

Nor did Patroclus' fall escape
Menelaus,
Atreus' son, dear to the war-god.
Through
The foremost fighters in his flashing
bronze
He went, and circled round
Patroclus as
A cow circles her first-born calf,
lowing,
Unskilled in birth. So golden-haired
Menelaus
Moved round the body, holding
spear and shield
Before him in all directions, eager to
kill
Whoever came against him.
Nor did Panthous' son, skilled with
the ash spear,
Neglect Patroclus when he fell. He
stood
Near him and spoke to war-loving
Menelaus:
"Son of Atreus, nourished by Zeus,
leader,
Draw back; leave the corpse and let
the spoils be mine.
No Trojan or renowned ally first
struck him
With spear in the bitter battle. Let
me win
Good glory among Troy's men; I
might strike you,
And take the sweet breath from your
life."

Golden-haired Menelaus answered
angrily:
"Father Zeus, it is not good for any
man
To boast so fiercely. Neither leopard,
lion,
Nor boar whose heart swells with
great strength has such
A spirit as the sons of Panthous,
skilled
With spears. Nor did the strength of
horse-taming
Hyperenor profit him, when,
glorying
In youth, he called me weakest of
Danaans.
He never thought his feet would
carry him home
To gladden wife and parents. So I
too
Will break your courage if you stand
before me.
Go back among the crowd; do not
stand against me
Until you learn what harm a fool
may learn too late."
But Euphorbus would not yield:
"Now, Menelaus,
Son of Zeus, you shall pay for the
kinsman slain.
You made his wife a widow in her
chamber,
And brought deep mourning to his
father and mother.
Would I could comfort those poor
mourners, carrying
Your head and armor to Panthous
and godlike
Phrontis! Yet the labor will not wait
long

Untried; courage and fear must meet
their trial.”

He struck Menelaus' shield on every
side;

The bronze could not pierce it, and
the point bent

Within the strong shield. Atreus' son
rose

Behind his bronze and prayed to
Father Zeus.

When Euphorbus drew back, he
thrust beneath

The belly, leaning his full weight
upon

The spear; the point passed through
the tender neck.

Euphorbus fell with a crash; his
armor rang.

His hair, like the Graces', braided
locks bound up

With gold and silver, was drenched
in blood.

As a man raises a young and
flourishing olive

Where water runs abundantly, newly
green,

Shaken by every wind and white
with flower,

Until a violent storm tears it from
the trench

And lays it stretched upon the earth,
so fell

Euphorbus beneath Menelaus' spear;
And Menelaus stripped his shining
armor.

As when a mountain lion, trusting in
his strength,

Seizes the finest bull from a grazing
herd,

First breaking its neck, then
swallowing blood

And inward parts, while distant dogs
and herdsmen

Cry out but dare not come, for green
fear holds them,

So no Trojan found courage in his
breast

To stand before glorious Menelaus.

He would have carried off the
famous armor

Of Panthous' son, if Phoebus had not
grown

Angry with him. Apollo roused up
Hector,

Like swift Ares, in the form and
voice of Menthēs,

Leader of Cicones, and spoke to
Hector:

“Hector, you chase the horses of
Aeacides;

They are hard for mortal men to
master—none

But Achilles can control them, he
whom bore

His deathless mother. Meanwhile
warlike Atreus'

Son has straddled Patroclus and has
killed

The best of Trojans, Euphorbus,
Panthous' son.

Come now, drive against him;
perhaps Apollo

Will grant you glory.”

So the god returned

Among the labor of mankind. Dark
grief

Enclosed the heart of Hector.

Through the ranks

He looked, and saw one man
carrying away
The armor, and another lying in
blood.
Hector went through the foremost
fighters in
His shining bronze, crying sharply,
like a fire
Of Hephaestus that no one can put
out.
Menelaus heard the keen cry, and
spoke
Within his troubled heart: "If I
abandon
The armor and Patroclus, who lies
here
Because of me, will any Danaan
seeing me
Be angry? Yet if alone I fight with
Hector,
Lest many surround me—Hector
leads them all—
What profit is there in these words?
Whenever
A man fights a godlike warrior
whom a god
Honors, great sorrow soon rolls over
him.
No Danaan who sees me go against
Hector
Will blame me, since a god sustains
his fight.
If only I could hear great Ajax' cry!
Then we two might return and keep
our courage,
Even against a god, and draw away
the dead."
He weighed the matter in his heart,
but then

The Trojan ranks came on, with
Hector leading.
Menelaus drew back from the corpse,
turning
Again and again, like a long-maned
lion
Whom dogs and men drive from a
fold with spears
And shouts; his brave heart chills
within him, and
Against his will he leaves the yard. So
Menelaus
Went from Patroclus, then turned
and stood among
His friends, looking for great
Telamonian Ajax.
At once he saw him on the left of
battle,
Giving his companions heart and
urging them
To fight; Apollo had cast a wondrous
fear
Among them. Menelaus ran and
stood
Near him: "Ajax, dear friend, let us
hurry now
For dead Patroclus, and, if possible,
Bring him without his armor back to
Achilles.
But Hector has his shining armor."
He spoke and stirred
The warlike heart of Ajax. Through
the foremost
Fighters Ajax went, and
golden-haired
Menelaus followed. Hector, after
stripping
Patroclus of the famous armor,
dragged the corpse,

Desiring with sharp bronze to cut his
head off
And give the body to the Trojan
women
And dogs. But Ajax came near, his
shield spread out
Like a tower. Hector drew back
among his friends,
Leaped into his chariot, and gave the
armor
To Trojans, who carried it toward
the city,
A great glory for him.
Ajax spread his broad shield around
Menoetius'
Son, and stood above him like a lion
Above its cubs, when hunters meet it
in
The forest as it leads its little ones;
The lion swells with strength and
draws its brow
Down over both its eyes. So Ajax
stood
Around Patroclus. On the other side
Menelaus stood, enlarging sorrow in
him.
Glaucus, Hippolochus' son, leader of
The Lycians, looked Hector darkly in
the face
And spoke hard words: "Hector, your
appearance shines,
But in the battle you have proved
deficient;
You have an empty name, though
you are one
Who flees. Consider how you may
now save
The city and its people, you alone
With those born in Ilium. No Lycian
will

Go forth and fight the Danaans
around
The city; there is no gratitude in
fighting
Without end. How could you save a
lesser man
Among the multitude, pitiless one,
When you have left Sarpedon,
guest-friend and ally,
To be a spoil and prize for Argives?
He
Was great support to you and to the
city
While living, but you did not dare to
keep
The dogs from him. If any Lycian
will obey,
Let us go home; ruin without remedy
Has come to Troy. If Trojans had the
courage
That enters men who set their
fatherland
Before their labor and their lives, we
might
Drag Patroclus into Ilium. If this
dead
Man came to Priam's city and we
dragged him
From the battle, the Argives would
strip the beautiful
Armor from Sarpedon and carry him
Into Ilium; his companion has fallen,
The best of Argives by the ships,
whose friends
Were best in close combat. Yet you
did not dare
To stand before great Ajax, meet his
eyes
Amid the cry, or fight him straight,
for he

Is stronger than you.”
Shining-helmeted Hector answered:
“Glaucus,
Why speak such an over-bold word? I
thought
You greater in mind than all rich
Lycia's men;
Now I despise your judgment, saying
I
Would not stand against monstrous
Ajax. I do not
Fear battle or the thunder of horses;
But Zeus's will is stronger than the
brave,
Putting them to flight, or urging
them to fight.
Come, dear friend, stand beside me
and watch the deed:
Shall I be weak all day, as you have
said,
Or hold some Danaan back, however
eager,
From guarding Patroclus, who has
died?”
He called aloud: “Trojans, Lycians,
Dardanians,
Be men, dear friends, remember
furious strength,
Until I put upon me the blameless
armor
Of Achilles, beautiful armor which,
When I killed Patroclus, I stripped
from him.”
He spoke and left the deadly battle,
ran
And overtook his companions, who
had not
Gone far with Peleus' son's famous
armor.

Apart from tearful battle he
exchanged it:
He gave his own for Ilium, and
clothed
Himself in Peleus' son's immortal
armor,
Which heaven's gods had given to his
dear father,
And Peleus, growing old, had handed
down.
But the son would not grow old in
that armor.
When cloud-gathering Zeus saw him
putting on
The armor of godlike Peleus' son, he
shook
His head and spoke within his
mighty heart:
“Poor man, death is not within your
thoughts,
Though it stands near. You wear
immortal armor
Of the best man, before whom other
men
Tremble; his gentle, strong
companion you
Have killed, and stripped his armor
head to foot
Against all order. I will grant you
strength;
But Andromache shall not receive
the armor
Of Peleus' son when you return no
more.”
So Cronus' son nodded beneath his
dark brows,
And fitted armor to the body of
Hector;
Then Enyalios, terrible god of war,

Entered his limbs, and filled them
with great strength.
He went among his famous allies,
calling
In a great voice, and seemed to all
the men
To wear the armor of great-hearted
Peleus' son.
He urged Mesthles, Glaucus, Medon,
Thersilochus,
Asteropeon, Deisenor, Hippothous,
Phorcys, Chromius, and Ennomus
the seer:
“Hear me, unnumbered allies
gathered round!
I did not call you here because I
lacked
A multitude, nor from some need
draw you out
Of your own cities. I brought you
here to guard
The wives and innocent children of
our Troy
Against the war-loving Achaeans.
For this
I wear your people out with gifts and
food,
And magnify the courage in each
man.
Now turn straight on the enemy: let
him die,
Or let him live—that is the speech of
war.
“Whoever drags Patroclus, even dead,
Into the horse-taming city, and Ajax
yields
Him, I will give that man half the
spoils;
I keep the other half. His glory shall
Be equal to my own.”

He spoke; they went
Straight against the Danaans, hoping
to drag
The dead man from beneath
Telamonian Ajax.
Fools! Many would give up their lives
before
They gained the body.
Ajax spoke to warlike Menelaus:
“Dear Menelaus, nourished by Zeus, I
no
Longer hope that we two shall come
alive
From this battle. I fear less for
Patroclus,
Who soon may feed the dogs and
birds of Troy,
Than for my head and yours, since
war's cloud covers all
And Hector is sudden destruction
here.
Call now the best of Danaans, if any
hear.”
He spoke; Menelaus did not disobey.
He shouted through the Greeks until
his voice
Carried: “Dear friends, leaders and
guardians,
You who drink the people's due
beside the kings,
And each gives signs of command to
his own people—
Honor and glory from Zeus follow
you all.
It is hard to seek each leader one by
one
Within this tumult. Let whoever can
come
Come now, and let his heart be
shamed that Greeks

Should leave Patroclus for the Trojan
women
And dogs.”
Swift Ajax, Oileus' son, heard him
and first
Came running to the battle. After
him came
Idomeneus and Meriones, his friend,
Equal to murderous Enyalios. Who
could
Name all the others who stirred the
Achaean fight
Again from behind?
The Trojans came together, Hector
leading them.
As a great wave roars at the mouth of
a river
Fed by the sky, while sea and shore
thunder round it,
So Troy advanced with a cry. The
Achaeans stood
Around Menoetius' son with one
heart,
Fenced by their bronze shields;
Cronus' son poured mist
Around their shining helmets. He
had not hated
Menoetius' son while he lived beside
Achilles;
He hated that the man should
become prey
For Trojan dogs, and therefore
roused the friends
Around him to defend him.
The Trojans drove bright-eyed
Achaeans back.
They left the dead behind and
shrank away;
Yet the high-hearted Trojans, eager
as they were,

Could take no living man with spear,
but dragged
The corpse alone. For a little while
the Greeks
Were forced to yield; then Ajax
turned them back—
Ajax who surpassed all Danaans in
form
And deed, after blameless Peleus'
son.
Through the foremost fighters he
sprang like a boar
Whose courage scatters dogs and
mountain youths
When, wheeling in the valleys, it
breaks their ranks.
So glorious Ajax scattered all who
stood
Around Patroclus, thinking to drag
him home
And win renown.
Hippothous, Lethus' glorious
Pelagian son,
Had tied a strap around Patroclus'
ankle,
And dragged his foot through bitter
battle, wishing
To please both Hector and the
Trojans. But no man
Could hold the evil back.
Telamonian Ajax
Sprang through the crowd and
struck him close at hand
Through the bronze cheek-piece of
his helmet. The crest
Rang on the shaft beneath the spear's
great blow;
His brain ran bloody by the ear. His
strength

Was loosed; Patroclus' great foot fell
away.
He fell face forward by the dead, far
off
From rich Larissa, and could not
repay
His parents for their rearing; brief
his life,
Cut short beneath great Ajax' spear.
Hector cast his shining spear at Ajax.
Ajax
Saw it and turned aside a little; but
the spear
Struck Schedius, Iphitus'
great-hearted son,
Best of the Phocians, ruler of
Panopeus.
The bronze passed beneath his
collarbone and came
Out above the farther shoulder.
Down he fell;
His armor rang around him.
Ajax struck Phorcys, son of
Phaenops, as he stood
Above Hippothous, in the middle of
his belly.
He split the hollow corselet; bronze
poured through
His inward parts. Phorcys fell into
the dust
And clutched the earth. The
foremost fighters and
Bright Hector gave ground; Argives
raised a cry,
Dragged Phorcys and Hippothous
away, and stripped
The armor from their shoulders.
The Trojans then would have
entered Ilium,

Overcome by Argives and their
failing courage;
And Greeks would have won glory
by their strength,
Beyond the will of Zeus—if Apollo
had not
Roused Aeneas, taking the shape of
Periphas,
Epytus' son, the herald grown old
beside
Aeneas' aged father, faithful in
speech.
In his likeness Zeus's son spoke to
Aeneas:
“Aeneas, how could you defend Ilium
even
Against a god, when you have seen
men trust
In strength, in courage, numbers,
and a people
Greater than our own? Zeus desires
victory
For us, not Danaans; yet you tremble
here
And will not fight.”
Aeneas knew Apollo when he looked
him in
The face, and called to Hector and
the leaders:
“Hector, and all you captains of the
Trojans
And allies, it would be shameful to
enter Troy
Because Achaeans conquered us
through cowardice.
Some god, I think, has stood beside
me and said
That Zeus, the highest counselor, is
our help.

Let us go straight against the
Danaans, and not
Let them carry Patroclus, though
dead, toward
The ships.”
He spoke, and leaped beyond the
foremost fighters,
And stood before them; the others
turned and faced
The Achaeans. Then Aeneas struck
Leiocritus
With his spear.
Lycomedes pitied Arisbas' fallen son,
His noble friend; he came close and
cast his spear.
It struck Apisaon, Hippasus' son,
Shepherd of men, beneath the liver,
under
The midriff, and his knees gave way
at once.
From deep-soiled Paeonia he had
come,
And often with Asteropeus had held
The foremost place in battle. Seeing
him fall,
Asteropeus rushed forward, grieving,
eager
To fight the Danaans, but could not
reach them:
Everywhere shields stood around
Patroclus,
And spears projected. Great Ajax
moved among
Them all, giving commands: “Let no
man draw back
From the dead, nor stand apart
before the Argives
In the first rank. Let us plant
ourselves close

Around him, and fight hand to
hand.”
The dark earth ran red; near-set
fighters fell,
Trojans and Danaans together. Yet
the Greeks
Did not fight without bloodshed;
fewer died,
For each remembered how to ward
death from
The companion standing in the
press.
So fought they like a fire; you could
not say
The sun or moon still shone, so thick
the mist
Around the foremost warriors by the
dead
Menoetius' son. The other Trojans
and
Well-greaved Achaeans fought
beneath clear sky;
The sun's sharp light lay spread
across the earth,
And no cloud covered mountain or
the plain.
They fought by pauses, standing far
apart,
Avoiding arrows' groans; but those
within
The mist and battle bore the pitiless
bronze,
Which wore the bravest down.
Still Thrasymedes and Antilochus
Had not heard that blameless
Patroclus died;
They thought him living, fighting
foremost still
Among the Trojans. They had gone
apart,

Looking toward death and the flight
of friends,
As Nestor had commanded from the
ships.
All day the grievous strife rose;
weariness
And sweat soiled knees, shins, feet
beneath each man,
His hands and eyes, as they fought
around the good
Companion of swift-footed
Aeacides.
As when a man gives his people a
great ox-hide,
Wet with oil, to stretch; they stand
apart and draw
It round in a circle, and the moisture
leaves,
The oil sinks inward, and the hide
grows wide
As many pull it outward from each
side—
So there they dragged the corpse a
little way
In either direction. Each believed it
would prevail:
Trojans to haul him toward the city,
Greeks
Toward hollow ships. Around him
rose a struggle
That Ares or Athena could not
scorn,
Though anger reached its height.
Such evil Zeus
Stretched over Patroclus that day, on
men
And horses alike.
And Achilles still had not learned his
friend's death.

Far from the ships he fought beneath
Troy's wall;
His heart expected Patroclus to live,
Pressed at the gates, and surely to
return.
He could not think to take the city
without
His friend, nor his friend without
him. Many times
His mother had told him the great
purposes
Of Zeus, but not the full evil fallen
on him:
His dearest companion had perished.
The fighters held their sharpened
spears around
The body, pressing on and
slaughtering.
Then one bronze-clad Achaean cried:
“Friends,
There is no honor in returning to the
ships.
Let black earth open here for every
man;
That is far better than to yield this
body
To horse-taming Troy, that they may
drag him in
And win themselves renown.”
A great-hearted Trojan
Answered: “Even if fate has fixed that
all
Of us be overcome beside this man,
Let no one flee the battle.”
So each aroused
The strength of each; the iron,
brazen uproar
Rose through the tireless air to
heaven.

The horses of Aeacus' son stood
apart
And wept when first they learned
their charioteer
Had fallen in the dust beneath
man-killing Hector.
Automedon, brave son of Diores,
struck
Them often with the lash, and often
spoke
In gentleness, and threatened them;
but they
Would neither turn back to the ships
beside
The broad Hellespont, nor enter the
battle.
They stood like a pillar set upon a
tomb
Of man or woman, holding splendid
chariot,
Their heads fixed firmly toward the
ground. Hot tears
Ran down their eyelids to the earth
as they mourned
The charioteer; their thick manes,
fallen from
The yoke, were soiled on either side.
Cronus' son saw them mourning and
pitied them.
He shook his head and spoke within
his heart:
"Poor creatures, why did we give you
to mortal Peleus,
You ageless, deathless ones, to suffer
sorrow
Among wretched men? Of all that
breathe and creep,
Nothing is more miserable than a
man.

Yet Hector, Priam's son, shall not
drive you and
Your wrought car away; I will not let
him.
Is it not enough that he possesses
armor
And boasts above it vainly? I will put
Courage into your knees and spirit,
so you carry
Automedon safely from the fight to
ships.
I grant you glory still: you shall kill
until
You reach the well-benched ships,
and the sun sinks
And holy darkness comes."
He breathed courage into them.
They shook the dust
From their manes and swept the
chariot through
Trojans and Achaeans. Automedon
fought,
Grieving his friend, leaping with the
horses like
A hawk among geese. He could flee
the uproar,
And spring upon the crowd to follow
them,
But could not take a man while
driving fast;
Alone within the sacred car, he could
not
Thrust with spear and hold the eager
horses.
At last Alcimedon saw him, Laerces'
Son, Haemon's son, and stood
behind the car:
"Automedon, what god has put this
fruitless

Counsel in your breast, robbed you
of your sense?
How do you fight Trojans alone in
front,
While your companion lies dead, and
Hector wears
Aeacus' armor on his shoulders?"
Automedon replied: "What other
Achaean
Could equal you to hold these
deathless horses,
Unless Patroclus, equal to the gods
In counsel, lived? But death and fate
have found him.
Take whip and silent reins; I will
leap down
And fight."
Alcimedon sprang forward to the
team
And took the whip and reins.
Automedon leaped down.
Glorious Hector saw, and called to
Aeneas,
Who stood close by: "Aeneas,
counselor of
The bronze-clad Trojans, I see these
two horses
Of swift Aeacus appearing in the
battle
With wretched charioteers. Perhaps
we could seize
Them, if your heart agrees; for
neither of us
Could stand against the charge of
Ares himself
If they came at us."
The son of Anchises did not refuse.
They went straight at the team, their
shoulders wrapped

In dry, hard oxhide; much bronze
flashed upon them.
With Hector came Chromius and
godlike Aretus;
Both pressed the team, hoping to kill
the two
And drive away the high-necked
horses. Fools!
They were not destined to leave
Automedon
Unblooded. Automedon prayed to
Father Zeus;
His dark heart filled with courage
and with strength.
He spoke to faithful Alcimedon:
"Do not hold back the horses far
from me;
Let them breathe on your back. I do
not think
That Hector, Priam's son, will check
his fury
Until he mounts the fair-maned
horses of Achilles,
And kills us two, throwing the
Argive ranks
Into a flight—unless he first is taken
there.
"Ajax, leaders of Argives, and
Menelaus,
Leave the dead to those who stand
around him,
The best men, to defend him from
the ranks;
But guard us two while we ward off
pitiless death.
For Hector and Aeneas, best of
Trojans,
Have made this tearful battle fierce
against us.

Yet all these things lie on the gods'
knees;
I too will cast my spear, and Zeus
will care
For what remains."
He hurled the long-shadowed spear.
It struck
Aretus' even shield; the shield gave
way,
And bronze passed beneath the belt
into
The lower belly. As a young man
with a sharp
Axe, striking behind a field-fed ox's
horns,
Cuts through the sinew, and the
beast springs forward
Then falls upon its back, so Aretus
sprang
And fell backward; the spear
quivered in his belly
And loosed his limbs.
Hector cast his shining spear at
Automedon;
Automedon saw it and bent aside.
The spear
Passed behind him, sank into the
earth,
And spent its force of war. The two
would now
Have rushed together with their
swords at close
Quarters, but both Ajaxes, hearing
their friend,
Came through the crowd. Hector,
Aeneas, and
Godlike Chromius recoiled, leaving
Aretus
With his heart torn out.

Automedon, like swift Ares, stripped
the dead
Man of his armor and spoke in
triumph:
"Now surely I have lightened, just a
little,
The grief for Menoetius' fallen son,
Though one man lies beneath my
hand for him."
He lifted the blood-stained spoils
into
The chariot, mounted, feet and
hands above them,
Bloodied like a lion after feeding on
a bull.
Again the hard and tearful battle
broke
Around Patroclus. Athena came
from heaven
To wake the struggle; Zeus, whose
voice is wide,
Had sent her, for his purpose now
had changed.
As when Zeus stretches a purple
rainbow through
The sky, a sign to men of war or
storm
That makes them cease their labor
and afflicts
The sheep, so she wrapped herself in
purple cloud,
Entered the Achaeans, and stirred
every man.
First she urged Menelaus, Atreus'
son,
Mighty in battle, taking Phoenix'
shape
And tireless voice: "Shame and
reproach will be yours

If Troy's swift dogs drag under their
wall the friend
Of noble Achilles. Stand fast with all
your strength,
And stir the army."
Menelaus answered:
"Old father Phoenix, ancient in your
years,
If only Athena would give me
strength,
And turn the weapons' rush aside! I
would gladly
Stand by Patroclus and defend him;
the dead
Has struck my spirit deeply. But
Hector holds
A terrible courage, and destroys with
bronze;
Zeus gives him glory."
The bright-eyed goddess rejoiced
that he had asked
Her first among the gods. She put
strength into
His shoulders and his knees, and in
his breast
The courage of a fly that, driven
from a man's
Skin, will not cease to bite, for
human blood
Is sweet to it. With such courage she
filled
His heart. He came to Patroclus and
cast
His shining spear.
Among the Trojans stood rich and
brave Podes,
Eetion's son, whom Hector honored
most,
His dear companion at the feast.
Menelaus

Struck him beneath the belt as he
rushed away;
The bronze passed through. Podes
fell with a crash,
And Menelaus dragged him from the
Trojans
Into the ranks of his companions.
Apollo stood beside Hector, taking
the shape
Of Phaenops, Asius' son, dearest of
Hector's guest-friends, living in
Abydos.
In his likeness the Far-Shooter spoke:
"Hector, who would fear you now
among Achaeans,
When you yield to Menelaus, once a
soft-handed
Spearman? Now he goes alone,
bearing the dead
Away from Troy, and has killed your
faithful friend,
Podes, Eetion's son, first among the
brave."
A black cloud covered Hector's
heart. He went
Through the first ranks in flashing
bronze. The son
Of Cronus took the tasselled, shining
aegis,
Hid Ida in the clouds, and thundered
greatly,
Flashing and shaking it. He granted
victory
To Troy and put the Achaeans to
flight.
First Boeotian Peneleus began to flee;
Polydamas had struck his shoulder as
he faced
The enemy, and the spear grazed
bone beneath

The flesh. Hector wounded Leitus,
son
Of Alectryon, near the wrist, and
stopped his fight.
He looked about and fled, no longer
hoping
To face the Trojans with a spear in
hand.
As Hector charged after Leitus,
Idomeneus
Struck him in the corselet, breast
beside
The nipple; the long spear broke
within its socket.
The Trojans cried. Hector cast his
spear at him,
But missed by little. Then he struck
Coeranus,
Meriones' companion and charioteer,
Who followed him from well-built
Lycus.
Meriones had left the ships and come
on foot;
Coeranus drove the fleet horses to
him,
Bringing him light and warding off
the day,
But losing his own life beneath
man-killing Hector.
The spear struck under jaw and ear,
drove out
His teeth, and cut the tongue in two.
He fell
From the chariot; reins spilled upon
the ground.
Meriones bent and gathered them,
then called:
"Now lash the horses till you reach
the ships;

You know the Achaeans have no
strength remaining."
Idomeneus lashed the fair-maned
horses toward
The hollow ships, for fear had
entered his heart.
Nor did great Ajax or Menelaus
escape
The notice of Zeus, when he gave
Troy the victory.
Great Telamonian Ajax began to
speak:
"Even the most childish man can
know that Zeus
Himself is helping Troy. Every
weapon strikes,
Whether a bad man casts it or a
good;
Zeus directs all. Our weapons fall
uselessly.
Come, let us find the counsel best:
how to drag
The dead away, and return alive,
bringing joy
To friends who look this way in
anguish and no longer
Think Hector's murderous hands can
be held back.
Would some companion quickly
carry word
To Peleus' son; I do not think he has
heard—
The grievous message that his dearest
friend is dead.
But nowhere can I see such a man
among
The Danaans; men and horses alike
are held
In mist. Father Zeus, deliver us from
dark;

Make clear air come, and grant our
eyes to see;
Then slay us in the light, if that is
your will.”
He spoke, and Father Zeus pitied
him. He scattered
The mist and thrust the cloud away;
the sun
Shone forth, and all the battle stood
revealed.
Ajax, strong in the war-cry, spoke to
Menelaus:
“Look now, Menelaus, child of Zeus,
and see
If Nestor's great-hearted son
Antilochus lives.
Urge him to run to swift Achilles,
and tell him
His dearest friend has fallen.”
Menelaus did not refuse. He went
like a lion
From a fold, when weary of rousing
dogs and men
Who will not let him take the fat of
cattle,
Though they have watched all night.
Hungry for flesh,
He presses on but gains nothing;
thick spears leap
From bold hands, brands burn in the
air; he rushes,
Yet fears them, and at dawn goes off
with wounded heart.
So Menelaus unwillingly left
Patroclus,
Fearing the Greeks, overcome by
grievous flight,
Would leave him prey. He gave
commands to Meriones
And both the Ajaxes:

“Ajax, leaders of Argives, and
Meriones,
Remember each the kindness of poor
Patroclus,
Gentle to all while living. Now death
and fate
Have found him.”
Then golden-haired Menelaus went,
Searching like an eagle, said to have
the keenest sight
Among all birds beneath the sky;
even high above,
The hare beneath a leafy bush
escapes him not.
He swoops and takes its life. So
everywhere
Menelaus searched the many ranks of
friends,
To see if Nestor's son still lived.
At last he saw him on the battle's
leftmost wing,
Encouraging his companions, urging
them to fight.
Menelaus came near and said:
“Antilochus,
Child of Zeus, come and learn the
grievous news,
The thing that should not have
occurred. You see already
What evil god rolls over Danaans,
and that
The Trojans hold the victory.
Patroclus,
Best of Achaeans, is dead; a great
longing
Has fallen on the Danaans. Run at
once
To Achilles beside the ships, and tell
him whether

He may save the naked body for the ship;
Hector of the shining helmet holds the armor.”
Horror struck Antilochus at these words.
For a long time speechlessness held him; his eyes
Filled with tears, his clear voice could not rise.
Yet he did not neglect the command.
He ran,
And gave his armor to blameless Laodocus,
Who was turning the single-hoofed horses near him.
With tears falling, his feet bore him from the fight
To Peleus' son, carrying the evil message.
Menelaus' heart still would not leave his weary friends
Unprotected where Antilochus had gone. He sent
Noble Thrasymedes to them, while he himself
Returned again to Patroclus and stood beside
The Ajaxes: “I sent that man to the ships,
To run to swift Achilles. Yet I do not think
He will come, though he is terribly angered at Hector;
He cannot fight the Trojans naked. Let us devise
The best counsel: how to drag away the corpse,
And how to escape death and fate amid Troy's uproar.”

Great Telamonian Ajax answered:
“You have spoken
In due measure, glorious Menelaus. But you
And Meriones must stoop, lift up the body,
And carry it out of battle; we two behind
Will fight the Trojans and divine Hector,
Of one spirit, as we have always stood together
And endured sharp Ares.”
They bent and lifted the corpse high from the ground.
The Trojan host cried out when they saw them raise
The dead, and rushed like dogs upon a wounded boar
Before young hunters. For a time they run to tear it;
But when it turns in strength, they scatter trembling.
So Trojans followed in a mass with swords
And double-edged spears; but when the Ajaxes turned
And faced them, every color changed, and no one dared
To spring against the corpse.
Thus the two carried Patroclus with all their strength
From battle toward the hollow ships, while war
Stretched behind them like fire that rushes on
A city, blazing high while houses shrink
In glare and wind roars through it.
The unwearied uproar

Of horses and spear-bearing men
followed.
As mules that gather all their
strength drag down
From mountains by a rugged path a
great beam
Or long ship's mast, their hearts and
bodies spent
In haste, labor, and sweat, so these
men strained
And bore the corpse. Behind them
the two Ajaxes
Held back the Trojans like a wooded
ridge that checks
Water above a plain, restraining
river streams
And turning all their rush across the
fields;
Waters cannot break it by their
force. So always
The Ajaxes drove the battle back.
The Trojans followed,
And above all Aeneas and bright
Hector.
As starlings or jackdaws come
clamoring on
When they see a hawk approaching,
bringing death
Among the little birds, so beneath
Aeneas
And Hector Achaeans fled with
dreadful cries,
Forgetting courage. Many handsome
pieces of armor
Fell around the corpse and around
the ditch
As Danaans fled; the war would not
grow slack.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 18

First-pass working translation

The armies fought like a flame
consuming all,
And Antilochus came to Achilles,
who stood
Before the beaked ships, troubled in
his heart:
“Why are the long-haired Achaeans
driven back
Again from the plain? May the gods
not bring
The grief my mother once
foretold—that, while I live,
The best of Myrmidons would leave
the light
Of day beneath Troy's hands. Surely
now
Menoetius' brave son is dead; I
charged him,
When he had driven the fire away, to
turn
Back to the ships and never meet
with Hector.”
The noble son of Nestor came in
tears:
“Son of Peleus, warrior most terrible,
You hear a bitter message, would it
had not been.
Patroclus lies dead; the armies fight
around
His naked body. Hector holds the
armor.”
A black cloud covered Achilles. With
both hands
He seized the smoking dust and
poured it over

His head; ash stained the
nectar-bright tunic.
He stretched his body full-length
upon the dust,
And tore his hair with his own
hands. The women,
Taken in war by Achilles and his
friend,
Cried round him, beat their breasts,
and ran from tents.
Antilochus poured tears and held his
hands,
Fearing he might cut his throat with
iron.
Achilles cried; his honored mother
heard him
Deep in the sea beside her aged
father.
She cried aloud, and all the Nereids
gathered:
Glauce, Thalia, Cymodoce, Nesaia,
Speio, Thoe, Halia, Cymothoe,
Actaia, Limnoreia, Melite, Iadera,
Amphithoe, Agave, Doto, Proto,
Pherusa, Dynamene, Dexamenê,
Amphinome,
Callianeira, Doris, Panope, Galatea,
Nemertes, Apseudes, Callianassa,
Clymene, Ianira, Ianassa, Maira,
Oreithyia, fair-haired Amatheia,
And all the others dwelling in the
sea's depth.
Their bright cave filled with them;
all struck their breasts.
Thetis began: “Hear me, sisters,
Nereids,
That all may know the grief within
me. I bore
A son blameless and strong beyond
the heroes,

Who sprang like a young tree. I
raised him like
A plant within a garden, sent him
out
On curved ships to Ilium; but I shall
not
Receive him returning to Peleus'
house.
While he lives and sees the sun, he
suffers, and
I cannot help him. Still I go to hear
What sorrow has reached him."
She left the cave; the goddesses went
with her.
The sea waves opened round them.
At Troy's rich shore
They rose in close array beside the
ships
Of many swift Myrmidons. The
honored mother
Stood near her groaning son, seized
his head, and said:
"Child, why do you weep? What grief
has entered you?
Speak it; do not conceal it. All the
things
You prayed for with uplifted
hands—Achaeans
Penned against the sterns, needing
you—Zeus has done."
Swift-footed Achilles answered
through his groan:
"My mother, Zeus has brought these
things to pass.
But what joy remains, since my dear
friend is dead,
Patroclus, whom I honored as my
own head?
Hector killed him and stripped the
armor from him,

The splendid gifts the gods gave
Peleus when
They joined you, goddess, to a mortal
man.
"Would you had stayed among the
deathless sea-gods,
And Peleus taken a mortal wife!
Now grief
Beyond measure enters your heart;
you will not
Receive your son returning. Nor does
my spirit
Command me to live unless Hector
first,
Struck beneath my spear, loses life
and pays
The price for Menoetius' son. Let me
die now:
Far from his fatherland he fell,
needing me.
I shall not return to my own land,
nor was
I light to Patroclus or the friends
whom Hector
Laid low. I sit useless beside the
ships,
A burden on the earth.
"Would strife might perish from
gods and men,
And anger, sweeter than honey in
the mouth,
That makes the wise grow harsh and
swells like smoke.
Agamemnon angered me; let the past
lie past.
Necessity now master us. I go to find
Hector, then take the death Zeus
sends. Not even
Heracles escaped it, dearest to Zeus;

Fate mastered him and Hera's anger.
So shall I
Lie when my fate comes. But now let
me win fame,
And make Trojan and Dardanian
women wipe
Their tears, and know I have rested
from the war.
Do not restrain me; you cannot."
Silver-footed Thetis answered
through her tears:
"It is right to defend companions in
destruction.
Yet your armor is among the
Trojans; Hector
Wears it and glories in it. He will not
glory long.
Do not enter Ares' labor till you see
me return;
At dawn I shall come with beautiful
armor
From Hephaestus."
She turned and spoke to her sisters:
"Sink beneath
The sea's broad fold, see our father,
tell him all.
I go to Olympus, to the famed smith,
And ask for glorious armor for my
son."
They sank beneath the wave; Thetis
went toward
Olympus and the master of the forge.
Thetis' feet bore her toward
Olympus; meanwhile
Well-greaved Achaeans fled before
man-slaying Hector,
Reaching ships and Hellespont. They
could not yet
Drag Patroclus from the weapons:
host and horses

Came upon him again, and Hector,
flame-like in
His strength. Three times he seized
the dead man's feet,
Eager to drag him, calling to the
Trojans;
Three times the Ajaxes, clothed in
furious strength,
Shook him away. Yet Hector trusted
in
His steadfast might, leaping into the
tumult,
Standing and shouting terribly,
refusing to withdraw.
As shepherds in the fields cannot
drive a lion,
Bright-maned, from a great and
famished beast's dead body,
So the two Ajaxes could not make
Hector fear
Or draw him from the fallen. He
would have dragged
The corpse away and won boundless
glory, had not
Swift Iris, wind-footed messenger,
run from Olympus
To Peleus' son, secretly summoning
him to arm;
Hera had sent her before Zeus or the
immortals
Around snow-crowned Olympus
knew.
She stood near him and spoke: "Rise,
son of Peleus,
Most terrible of men. Defend
Patroclus,
For whom the bitter battle stands
beside
The ships, and men destroy each
other—some

Defend the dead, while Trojans drag
him toward
Windy Ilium. Hector most of all
desires
To haul him off, sever his tender
neck,
And set his head upon the stakes.
Rise! Let reverence
For Patroclus enter you, lest he
become
A plaything for Trojan dogs, and
shame be yours.”
Swift-footed Achilles answered: “Iris,
goddess,
Which of the gods has sent you as a
messenger?”
Wind-footed Iris answered: “Hera
sent me,
The glorious wife of Zeus. The
high-throned son
Of Cronus does not know, nor any
immortal
Who dwells on snowy Olympus.”
Achilles replied: “How can I go to
battle?
They hold my armor. My dear
mother would not let
Me arm until I saw her come before
my eyes;
She promised beautiful weapons
from Hephaestus.
I know no other shield I could put
on,
Unless it were great Ajax’s—but I
think
He stands among the foremost,
striking round
The body of Patroclus.”
Iris answered: “We know your
famous armor lies

Within their hands. Go as you are to
the trench,
Show yourself to Troy; perhaps they
will fear you,
Hold back from battle, and the
war-worn sons
Of Achaeans draw one breath from
all their labor.”
She spoke and left. Achilles, dear to
Zeus, arose;
Athena cast the tasselled aegis round
his shoulders,
Set a golden cloud about his head,
and kindled
Within it flame that shone afar.
As smoke rises from a city toward
the sky,
From an island far away where
hostile armies
Fight around the walls, and through
the day are judged
By hateful Ares outside their native
city,
But when the sun goes down the
watch-fires blaze
In triple ranks, their light leaping
high that neighbors
May see and bring defenders in their
ships,
So from Achilles’ head the shining
reached the air.
He went from the wall and stood
upon the trench,
Not mingling with Achaeans, for he
watched
His mother’s solemn command.
There he stood and cried aloud; far
off Athena
Lifted her voice, and among the
Trojans raised

An immeasurable panic. As a
trumpet's cry,
Clear and piercing round a city when
enemies
Surround it, so rang the voice of
Aeacus' son.
All hearts were shaken; fair-maned
horses turned
Their chariots back, foreseeing grief.
Charioteers
Were struck with terror when they
saw the tireless fire
Burning above the head of Peleus'
son,
Kindled by bright-eyed Athena.
Three times divine Achilles cried
above the trench;
Three times Troy and her allies fell
confused.
Twelve bravest men died beside their
cars and spears.
Then Achaeans gladly dragged
Patroclus out
From underneath the weapons, laid
him on a bier,
And dear companions stood around
him mourning.
Achilles followed, shedding hot
tears, when he saw
His faithful friend upon the bier,
torn by bronze—
The man he sent with horses and a
chariot,
But never welcomed home.
Ox-eyed, honored Hera forced the
tireless sun
To turn back into Oceanus' streams
against
Its will. The sun went down; divine
Achaeans ceased

From war's fierce force and from the
equal battle.
The Trojans withdrew, unyoked
their swift horses,
And gathered in council before the
evening meal.
They stood upright; none dared sit,
for trembling held
Them all since Achilles, long absent
from the fight,
Had shown himself. Prudent
Polydamas alone
Could see before him and behind;
Hector's companion,
Born with him in one night, one
strong in speech,
The other in the spear, he addressed
the assembly:
"Consider, friends. Let us go into the
city;
Do not await bright dawn here on
the plain beside
The ships, far from the wall. While
this man raged
Against Agamemnon, Achaeans were
easier;
I was glad to sleep beside the ships,
hoping
To take the curved vessels. But now I
fear
Swift-footed Peleus' son; his spirit
overmasters him.
He will not stay where Troy and
Achaeans divide
The strength of Ares; he will fight
for city
And women. Come within the city
and believe me.
Tonight immortal night has stopped
him; if tomorrow

He finds us here, roused with his
armor, one among us
Will know him well. Gladly will
reach holy Ilium
The man who escapes; many Trojans
will the dogs
And vultures eat—would that the
word might pass
From ear into the deed!
“If we heed my counsel,
Though our hearts grieve, we will
hold the assembly
Through night, and shut the towers,
gates, and long-fitted
Doors within the city. At dawn we
arm and stand
Upon the towers. Then he will find it
hard,
Coming from ships to fight around
our wall.
He will return to ships when he has
tired
His high-necked horses driving
beneath the city;
His spirit will not let him rush
within,
Nor will he take it. Before that, white
dogs
Will eat him.”
Crest-bright Hector answered
darkly: “These words
No longer please me when you tell us
to go back.
Have you not had enough of being
penned within
The towers? Once men called Priam's
city rich
In gold and bronze; now our
beautiful treasures

Are gone, possessions sold to Phrygia
and
Fair Maeonia, since Zeus has grown
angry.
“Now Cronus' son has granted me
the glory to win
Beside the ships and drive Achaeans
to the sea;
Do not, fool, bring such thoughts
before the people.
No Trojan will obey you, nor will I
permit it.
Let every man obey as I command:
take food
Throughout the camp, remember
watch, and stay awake.
Let any Trojan overly proud of
possessions
Give them out for the common feast;
it is better
One of our own should enjoy them
than Achaeans.
At dawn we arm and wake sharp
Ares beside
The hollow ships. If godlike Achilles
has risen,
It will be worse for him if he desires
it so;
But I will not flee the bitter fight. I
stand
Face to face, whether he carries
strength away,
Or I carry it. Enyalios is common to
all:
The killer may himself be killed.”
The Trojans shouted their approval,
poor fools;
Athena had taken their wits away.
They praised

Hector, who counseled evil; no one remembered
The excellent counsel of Polydamas.
They ate throughout the camp. All night Achaeans
Mourned Patroclus. The son of Peleus led
The loud lament, laying his man-killing hands
Upon his friend's breast, groaning like a bearded lion
Whose cubs a hunter has snatched from the forest.
Too late the lion comes, searching ravines along
The man's tracks, possessed by bitter anger.
Achilles groaned among the Myrmidons:
"Ah me, I spoke a vain word when I encouraged
Menoetius in his halls, promising to bring
His glorious son back to Opous, after sacking
Ilium, and give him his share of spoil. Yet Zeus
Fulfills not every thought of men. For both of us
It is fated to stain this earth in Troy; Nor shall horse-driving Peleus
receive me home,
Nor Thetis; earth herself will hold me here.
"Patroclus, since I go beneath the earth after you,
I will not bury you till I have brought here
The armor and the head of Hector, your slayer.

Before your pyre I will cut the throats of twelve
Glorious Trojan children, furious because you died.
Until then lie beside the curved ships, while Trojan
And deep-bosomed Dardanian women mourn you,
Shedding tears through night and day—women whose rich
Cities we took by force and our long spear."
He ordered his companions to set a great tripod
Upon the fire, to wash Patroclus quickly
Of blood-stained mortal dust. They set the bath-tripod,
Poured water in, and kindled wood beneath it.
Fire surrounded the belly; water warmed
Within the shining bronze. When it boiled, they washed
The body, anointed it with oil, and filled
The wounds with ointment aged nine years. They laid
Him on the bier, covered him from head to foot
With soft linen, and over it a white sheet.
All night the Myrmidons lamented around
Swift-footed Achilles. Then Zeus spoke to Hera:
"You have accomplished your purpose, ox-eyed Hera;
You roused swift-footed Achilles. Surely the long-haired

Achaeans were born from you
yourself.”
So they spoke. Silver-footed Thetis
came
To Hephaestus' house, imperishable,
starry,
Conspicuous among immortals—a
bronze house
The crooked-footed smith had made
for himself.
She found him sweating as he moved
among
The bellows, working urgently; he
made
Twenty tripods to stand around the
wall
Of his well-founded hall. Beneath
each base he set
Golden wheels, that they might move
of themselves
Into the gods' assembly, then
return—
A wonder to behold. They lacked
only handles;
He fitted these, fastening every
bond,
Working with all the craft his
knowing heart possessed.
As Thetis came, Charis of the lovely
veil,
Whom the famed smith had made
his wife, saw her approach.
She took her hand and called her by
name:
“Why have you come, Thetis,
long-robed goddess,
Honored and dear? You seldom visit
us.
Come farther in; I will set
friendship's gifts before you.”

She led her inward, seated her upon
A silver-studded throne, beautiful,
with footstool.
Then she called Hephaestus, famous
for his craft:
“Hephaestus, come; Thetis has need
of you.”
The crippled smith answered: “Then
a goddess terrible
And honored must be here, one who
saved me when
Pain came upon me after my
shameless mother
Cast me far away, wishing to hide
me, lame.
I would have suffered grievously if
Eurynome
And Thetis had not caught me in
their arms—
Eurynome, daughter of Ocean
turning back.
With them I lived nine years, forging
ingenious works
Within their hollow cave: curved
clasps, spiral brooches,
Cups, and necklaces; around us
Ocean's stream,
Immeasurable, roared and foamed.
No god or man
Knew me there, but only Thetis and
Eurynome,
Who saved my life. Since Thetis has
come here,
I owe the fair-haired goddess a full
return.
Set gifts of welcome before her while
I put away
My bellows and my tools.”
The huge and wondrous smith rose
from the anvil,

Limping; his thin legs moved with difficulty.
He set the bellows away and gathered up
His tools into a silver chest. With a sponge
He wiped his face and hands, his strong neck and
His hairy breast; then put a tunic on,
Took up a heavy staff, and limped outside.
Two golden maidens hurried beneath their lord,
Like living young women. In their breasts they had
Mind, voice, and strength; from gods they had learned
The works of gods. They moved beneath his steps
Until he came where bright-throned Thetis sat.
He took her hand and called her by her name:
“Why have you come, Thetis, long-robed goddess,
Honored and dear? You seldom visit us.
Tell me your purpose; my heart commands me to fulfill it,
If I can, and if the thing lies within completion.”
Thetis answered with tears:
“Hephaestus, is there
Among Olympian goddesses one who has endured
Such grievous sorrows as Zeus, Cronus' son,
Has given me? Of all the sea-born sisters he gave
Me to a mortal, Aeacides Peleus;

Against my will I endured the marriage bed.
Now he lies in his house, broken by old age.
And I have further sorrow: when he gave me a son
To bear and raise, a hero beyond all others,
Who sprang like a young tree, I raised him as
A garden plant and sent him on curved ships
To Ilium to fight the Trojans; but I shall not
Receive him home again to Peleus' house.
While he lives and sees the sun, he suffers;
I cannot help him, though I go to him.
“The maiden the Achaeans gave him as his prize,
Agamemnon took from him. For her my son
Consumed his heart in grief; while Troy drove Greeks
Back to the sterns and kept them past the ships.
The elders of Argos pleaded, naming splendid gifts;
He refused to ward off ruin. Yet he clothed
Patroclus in his armor and sent him out,
Giving him a great host; all day they fought
Around the Scaean Gates, and would have taken Troy
Had not Apollo, after doing much harm,

Killed Menoetius' brave son among
the foremost,
And given glory to Hector.
"Therefore I come to your knees: if
you are willing,
Give my short-lived son a shield, a
helmet,
Beautiful greaves fitted at the ankles,
and a corselet.
His own were lost with his faithful
friend, subdued
By Trojans; he lies upon the earth in
grief."
The famous smith answered: "Take
courage; let not
These things trouble you. Would
that I could hide him
From death's grievous noise when his
fate comes,
As surely as beautiful armor shall be
his,
Such as another man, among the
many generations,
Will wonder at when he looks upon
it."
He left her there and went among
the bellows.
He turned them toward the fire and
bade them work.
Twenty bellows blew together
through their mouths,
Breathing every wind that kindles
flame; now rushing
To help him in his haste, now falling
quiet,
As Hephaestus willed and as the
work required.
He cast untiring bronze upon the
fire,

Tin, precious gold, and silver; set the
great anvil
Firmly in its stand; grasped the
mighty hammer
In one hand, and in the other took
the pincers.
First he made a shield, great and
strong, and wrought
Its surface everywhere with cunning
art.
Around it he laid a shining triple
rim,
And fastened on a silver strap. The
shield
Had five folds; within its breadth he
worked
Many things, with all the wisdom of
his heart.
There he made the earth, the
heavens, and the sea,
The tireless sun, the full moon, and
all the signs
With which the sky is crowned: the
Pleiades,
The Hyades, Orion's strength, and
the Bear,
Whom men call Wain, turning in its
place and watching
Orion, yet alone denied the baths of
Ocean.
Upon it he made two cities of mortal
men,
Beautiful. In one were weddings and
splendid feasts;
Brides were led beneath the
torchlight from their chambers
Through the city, while the marriage
song rose loud.
Young dancers whirled; flutes and
lyres sent music out,

And women stood in every doorway,
watching, amazed.

The people gathered in the
market-place. A quarrel

Had arisen: two men disputed
blood-price for

A dead man. One promised to pay
all, speaking it

Before the people; one refused to
take it.

Both wished a judge to bring the
matter to an end.

The crowd shouted for each,
supporting each in turn,

But heralds held them back. The
elders sat on stones

Polished within the sacred circle,
holding staffs

Of clear-voiced heralds. Each rose
and gave judgment.

In the midst lay two talents of gold,
to be given

To the man among them who should
speak most straightly.

Around the other city two armies sat
in bronze,

Their counsel divided: whether to
sack the lovely city,

Or share among themselves the
wealth it held within.

Its people did not yield, but went
secretly

To lie in ambush. Wives and dear
children stood

Upon the wall to guard it, with old
men held back

By age. The hidden army moved;
Ares and Athena

Led them, both golden, clad in
golden raiment,

Beautiful and great, conspicuous
above the men.

They reached the river where the
herds came down to drink,

And sat apart in flashing bronze.
Two scouts stood off

From the army, waiting till they saw
the sheep

And horned cattle. Soon the herds
appeared, two herdsmen

Following, glad in their pipes,
foreseeing no deceit.

The ambushers rushed upon them,
cut down the cattle,

The white-fleeced sheep, and killed
the shepherds.

The besiegers heard the uproar
among the herds;

The scouts mounted their
high-stepping horses, rode out,
And swiftly came upon the raiders.

They halted,

Fought beside the river, cast
bronze-tipped spears.

Strife was there, and Tumult, and
deadly Death;

Death held a newly wounded man
still alive,

Another unwounded, another
already dead,

And dragged a corpse by its feet
through the tumult.

Her garment on her shoulders was
red with blood

Of men she had slain. They mingled
like living men,

Fought, and drew away each other's
dead.

Upon it he set a fallow field, rich and
soft,

Thrice-plowed and broad. Many
plowmen turned their teams
Of oxen back and forth. Whenever
they reached
The boundary, a man came forward,
gave each hand
A cup of honey-sweet wine; then
back they turned
Along the furrows, eager for the far
boundary.
Behind them earth grew dark,
though all the gold remained—
A wonder wrought in metal.
Upon it he set a royal estate. Reapers
held
Sharp sickles and cut the standing
grain; the sheaves
Fell thick along the furrow. Three
binders stood
At work; behind them boys gathered
cut stalks,
Carrying them forward without
pause. The king stood
Among them, silent, glad at heart,
staff in hand,
Upon the furrow. Apart, beneath an
oak,
Heralds prepared a feast; they had
sacrificed
A great ox, while women scattered
white meal
For supper to the reapers.
Upon it he set a vineyard, beautiful
and golden,
Heavy with dark clusters. Vines
stood in rows
Upon silver poles; around them ran a
trench
Dark-blue, and around the trench a
fence of tin.

One path alone led through, by
which the gatherers
Walked when they carried grapes.
Young women, youths
Unwed and innocent, bore the
honeyed fruit
In woven baskets. Among them a boy
With clear lyre sang Linos' lovely
song;
The others followed, striking earth
together,
Leaping in time to song and cry.
Upon it he set a herd of
straight-horned cattle.
The cows were gold and tin; lowing,
they hurried
From the dung-yard to pasture by
the river,
Beside the trembling reeds. Four
golden herdsmen
Went in line, and nine white-footed
dogs followed.
Two terrible lions seized a bellowing
bull
Among the first cattle; they dragged
him off,
Lowing long. Dogs and young men
pursued; the lions
Tore open his hide and gulped his
entrails,
Drank the dark blood. The herdsmen
sent swift dogs,
But dogs held back from biting; close
beside them
They barked, then drew away, afraid
of jaws.
The famous smith made also a
pasture in
A lovely valley for great flocks of
white sheep,

With covered folds, huts, and roofed
pens.

He wrought a dancing floor, like that
Daedalus

Made in broad Knossos for
fair-haired Ariadne.

There young men and maidens,
whose wealth was won
By labor, danced, holding each
other's wrists.

The maidens wore fine linen; young
men wore tunics

Woven with care, shining softly with
oil.

The maidens wore beautiful crowns;
the youths had

Golden knives hanging from silver
baldrics.

Now they ran with practiced feet, as
when a potter

At work tries a wheel beneath his
palms to see

If it will run; now rows moved
toward each other.

A crowd stood round the lovely
dance, delighted;

A divine singer played the lyre, while
two tumblers

Whirled through the midst, leading
the song and dance.

Upon the outer rim of the
well-wrought shield

He set Oceanus, the mighty river,
Flowing around the world.

When the famed smith had finished
that great shield,

He made a corselet brighter than
fire's gleam,

A heavy helmet fitted to the temples,

Beautifully wrought, and set a golden
crest

Upon it; then he made greaves of
pliant tin,

Fitted about the ankles.

When the crippled smith had
completed all

The armor, he lifted it and laid it
down

Before Achilles' mother. Like a hawk
She sprang from snowy Olympus,
carrying

The flashing armor from Hephaestus.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 19

First-pass working translation

Rose the saffron-robed Dawn from
Ocean's streams,
bringing light to immortals and to
mortal men.
She came to the ships, bearing the
gifts of the god;
and there she found her dear son
Achilles
weeping clearly beside Patroclus,
while many companions
mourned around the dead.
She stood among them, took her
son's hand, and called him by name:
"My child, let us leave him here,
though we grieve,
since by the will of the gods he was
first subdued.
But you receive from Hephaestus the
famous armor,
beautiful as no man has ever borne
upon his shoulders."
So speaking, the goddess laid the
armor before Achilles;
and all its cunning work rang out
terribly.
Trembling seized every Myrmidon;
no one dared to look
straight upon it. They shook with
fear.
But Achilles, when he saw it, felt his
anger deepen;
and beneath his eyelids his eyes
shone terribly,
as though a flame had broken forth.
He rejoiced to hold in his hands the
glorious gifts of the god.

When he had gazed his fill upon the
shining work,
he spoke to his mother in winged
words:

"My mother, the god has given me
these weapons;
they are works such as immortal
hands should make,
not such as mortal man could finish.
I will arm myself. Yet I greatly fear
lest, meanwhile,
flies enter the bronze-struck wounds
of Menoetius's brave son,
breed worms there, disfigure the
dead,
and his life depart while all his flesh
decays."

The silver-footed goddess Thetis
answered:

"Let not these things trouble your
mind.

I will try to keep from him the savage
tribes of flies,
which devour men slain in war.
Even if he lies here through a full
turning year,
his skin shall remain whole, or even
fairer than before.

But you call the heroes of the
Achaeans to assembly;
renounce your anger against
Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
arm yourself quickly for war, and
clothe yourself in strength."

So speaking, she breathed great
courage into his heart;
and over Patroclus she poured
ambrosia and red nectar
through his nostrils, that his flesh
might remain unspoiled.

Divine Achilles went along the shore
of the sea,
crying aloud in a dreadful voice, and
roused the Achaean heroes.
Even those who had remained before
beside the ships,
the helmsmen who held the
steering-oars,
and the storekeepers who served out
the grain beside the vessels,
then went to the assembly, because
Achilles had appeared,
after a long absence from the
grievous battle.
Two servants of Ares came limping
to the assembly,
the steadfast son of Tydeus and
godlike Odysseus,
leaning upon their spears, for their
grievous wounds
still troubled them. They went and
sat in the foremost places.
Last of all came Agamemnon, lord of
men,
bearing his wound; for Coön, son of
Antenor,
had struck him with a bronze spear
in the hard battle.
When all the Achaeans had gathered
together,
swift-footed Achilles rose among
them and spoke:
“Son of Atreus, was this perhaps
better for both of us—
for you and for me—that we should
consume our hearts
with soul-devouring strife over the
girl?
Would that Artemis had killed her
with an arrow

beside the ships on that day when I
took Lyrnessus
and destroyed it. Then not so many
Achaeans
would have bitten the broad earth
beneath the hands
of their enemies, while I remained in
anger.
It would have been an advantage for
Hector and the Trojans;
but I think the Achaeans will
remember for a long time
the strife between you and me.
“But let what is past be left, though
we grieve;
let us master the dear heart within
our breasts by necessity.
Now I put aside my anger, and it is
not fitting
for me to remain forever in wrath.
Come, rouse the long-haired
Achaeans to battle,
that I may go and try the Trojans
face to face
beside the ships, and see whether
they wish to sleep there.
I think that many of them will gladly
bend the knee,
whoever escapes the war beneath my
spear.”
So he spoke; and the well-greaved
Achaeans rejoiced,
because great-hearted Peleus’s son
had laid aside his anger.
Then Agamemnon, lord of men,
spoke to them from his seat;
he did not rise and stand among the
people:
“Friends, heroes, Danaans, servants
of Ares,

it is beautiful to listen when a man is
standing among others;
it is not fitting to interrupt him, for
even a skilled speaker
is hindered by the noise of the
multitude.
How could one hear or speak clearly
in a great throng?
Even a clear-voiced orator is
weakened there.
“I will make my defense to the son of
Peleus;
and the other Argives, attend and let
each understand my words.
Often the Achaeans have spoken this
reproach to me,
and blamed me for it; but I am not
the cause.
Zeus is, and Fate, and the Erinys who
walks in darkness;
they cast savage Delusion into my
mind
on that day when I took Achilles’s
prize from his hands.
But what could I do? A god brings all
things to completion.
“Delusion is the eldest daughter of
Zeus,
the accursed one who deludes all; her
feet are delicate,
for she does not set them upon the
ground,
but walks upon the heads of men and
harms them,
and binds one man beneath another.
Even Zeus, they say, was once
deluded,
though they call him greatest among
gods and men.

Hera deceived him by her cunning
on the day
when the strength of Heracles was
about to be born
to Alcmena in well-crowned Thebes.
“Zeus, rejoicing, spoke among all the
gods:
‘Hear me, all you gods and all you
goddesses,
that I may tell what my heart within
my breast commands.
Today Eileithyia, she who brings the
hard birth,
shall bring to the light a man who
will rule
all his neighbors, a man from the
blood of my generation.’
“But honored Hera, planning deceit,
answered him:
‘You will lie, nor will you bring your
word to completion.
Come now, swear me a mighty oath,
Olympian Zeus,
that the man who is born today from
the feet of a woman,
among the men who are of your
blood,
shall rule over all his neighbors.’
“She spoke; Zeus did not perceive the
deceit,
but swore a great oath, and then was
terribly deluded.
Hera sprang from Olympus’s peak
and quickly reached Argos,
where she knew the strong wife of
Sthenelus, son of Perseus.
She was seven months with her dear
son;
Hera brought him forth into the
light, though premature,

and stopped Alcmena's labor,
holding back Eileithya.
Then she herself told Zeus, son of
Cronus, the news:
'Father Zeus, lord of the bright
lightning, I will put a word
into your mind: already a noble man
has been born
who will rule the Argives,
Eurystheus, son of Sthenelus,
of your blood; it is not unworthy
that he should rule the Argives.'
"Sharp grief struck Zeus deeply when
he heard it.
At once he seized Delusion by her
shining hair,
anger in his heart, and swore a
mighty oath:
never again should Delusion, who
harms all,
come to Olympus and the starry
heaven.
He whirled her and cast her from the
sky;
soon she reached the works of men.
And whenever he saw his dear son
performing
the shameful labors forced upon him
by Eurystheus,
he would groan.
"So now, when Hector of the shining
helmet was destroying
the Argives beside the sterns of the
ships,
I could not forget the Delusion with
which I first was deluded.
But since I was deluded, and Zeus
robbed my mind,
I wish to make amends and give
boundless recompense.

Rise to battle, and rouse the other
people.
All the gifts that glorious Odysseus
promised you yesterday
in your hut I will provide here.
If you wish, wait here, though your
spirit presses toward Ares;
my attendants shall bring the gifts
from my ship,
that you may see I will give them in
full."
But swift-footed Achilles answered
him:
"Most glorious son of Atreus,
Agamemnon, lord of men,
give the gifts if you wish, as is fitting,
or keep them beside you. Now let us
remember the battle
quickly; there is no need to linger
here or delay,
for a great work remains unfinished.
Let a man see Achilles once more
among the foremost ranks,
destroying the Trojan phalanxes
with his bronze spear—"
The much-minded Odysseus
answered him:
"Not so, Achilles, excellent though
you are and godlike.
Do not urge the sons of the
Achaeans, empty of food,
to go against Ilium and fight the
Trojans;
for the battle will not be short when
first the ranks
of men meet, and a god breathes
courage into both sides.
But command the Achaeans to take
food and wine

beside the swift ships; food is
strength and courage.
No man can fight face to face all day
until the sun goes down
without food; even if his spirit longs
to fight,
his limbs grow secretly heavy, and
thirst and hunger find him,
and his knees fail beneath him as he
walks.

But the man who has had his fill of
wine and food,
and fights the enemy all day, keeps a
bold heart within him;
his limbs do not grow weary until all
have withdrawn from battle.

“Come, scatter the people, and
command the evening meal.

Let Agamemnon, lord of men, bring
the gifts into the midst
of the assembly, so that all the
Achaeans may see them
and you may be glad in your spirit.

Let him rise among the Argives and
swear an oath
that he has never mounted the girl’s
bed or joined with her,
as is lawful for a lord over men or
women;

and let your own heart within you be
gentle again.

Afterward let him make amends to
you with a rich feast,
so that you may lack nothing of
justice.

And you, son of Atreus, shall
hereafter be more just
in other matters as well. It is no
cause for blame
when a king makes amends to a man

whom he first treated harshly.”

Agamemnon, lord of men, answered
him:

“Son of Laertes, I rejoice to hear your
words;

you have spoken all things in due
measure and set them forth.

These things I am willing to swear, as
my heart commands;

I will not swear falsely before the
god.

Let Achilles remain here, eager
though he is for Ares,

and let all the others remain
gathered,

until the gifts are brought from the
hut

and we cut the faithful oaths.

“To you yourself I give this charge
and command:

choose the best young men among all
the Achaeans

and bring from my hut all the gifts
we promised Achilles yesterday,
and bring the women as well.

Let Talthybius quickly prepare a
boar

to cut in sacrifice for Zeus and the
Sun.”

Swift-footed Achilles answered him:

“Most glorious son of Atreus,
Agamemnon, lord of men,
you should have made this provision
at another time,

when there might be a pause in the
battle,

and the strength within my breast
was not so great.

But now those men lie torn apart
whom Hector, son of Priam,

subdued, when Zeus gave him glory.
You urge the men to eat; but I could
now command
the sons of the Achaeans, empty and
without food,
to fight until the sun goes down,
and then prepare a great meal after
we have paid back the outrage.
Before that, no drink or food could
pass down my throat,
while my companion lies dead, torn
by sharp bronze,
within the hut, turned toward the
doorway,
and his companions mourn around
him.
No such thing is in my mind now,
but killing,
and blood, and the grievous groaning
of men.”
The much-minded Odysseus
answered him:
“Achilles, son of Peleus, far the best
of the Achaeans,
you are stronger than I, and by no
small measure better
with the spear; but I might surpass
you greatly in counsel,
for I was born before you and know
more.
Therefore let your heart endure my
words.
Men soon grow weary of war,
in which bronze has scattered the
greatest harvest upon the earth,
and the harvest is smallest when
Zeus, the keeper of war for men,
weighs the scales toward stillness.
The Achaeans cannot mourn the
dead with the belly;

for many fall, and fall in heaps, every
day.
When, then, could a man draw
breath from his labor?
“The dead must be buried, with a
hard heart,
after weeping for him through the
day in which he died.
But those who remain from the
hateful war
must remember food and drink,
that we may fight the enemy without
ceasing,
clothed in unwearied bronze.
Let no man hold back, waiting for
another summons
from the army; this will be a
summons of evil
for whoever remains beside the
Argive ships.
Let us all rise together and awaken
sharp Ares
against the horse-taming Trojans.”
So he spoke, and brought with him
the sons of glorious Nestor,
Phyleides, Meges, Thoas, and
Meriones,
Creontiades Lycomedes, and
Melanippus.
They went into the hut of
Agamemnon, son of Atreus.
In the same moment the word
became deed:
seven tripods were carried from the
hut,
the ones Agamemnon had promised;
twenty shining cauldrons, twelve
horses,
and seven women skilled in
blameless work,

with Briseis, fair-cheeked, as the eighth.
Odysseus set ten talents of gold in the midst,
and the young Achaeans carried the other gifts.
They set them in the center of the assembly,
and Agamemnon rose among them.
Talthybius, whose voice was like a god's,
stood beside the shepherd of the people,
holding the boar in his hands.
Agamemnon drew the knife that hung always
beside the great sheath of his sword;
beginning at the bristles of the boar,
he lifted his hands to Zeus and prayed.
All the Argives sat silent in their proper places,
listening to the king.
When he had prayed, looking toward the wide heavens,
he spoke:
"Let Zeus first of the gods be witness,
and Earth, and the Sun, and the Erinyes beneath the earth,
who punish whoever swears falsely among men,
that I have never laid a hand upon the girl Briseis,
neither seeking her bed nor any other purpose;
she remained untouched within my hut.
If I have sworn falsely in this, let the gods give me

many sorrows, all those they give to the man
who sins after swearing an oath."
So he spoke, and cut the boar's throat with the pitiless bronze.
Talthybius whirled the carcass and cast it
into the great gulf of the gray sea,
food for the fishes.
Then Achilles rose and spoke to the war-loving Argives:
"Father Zeus, surely you give great delusions to men—"
"Agamemnon's quarrel stirred the whole matter from its beginning;
no girl could he have led away against my will,
but somewhere Zeus desired that many Achaeans should die.
Now go to your meal, that we may gather the strength of Ares."
So he cried, and dismissed the swift assembly.
The men scattered, each to his own ship;
but the great-hearted Myrmidons set themselves to their gifts,
and carried them aboard the ship of divine Achilles.
They placed the gifts within the huts,
seated the women, and the noble attendants drove the horses into the herd.
Then Briseis, like golden Aphrodite,
when she saw Patroclus torn by the sharp bronze,
fell upon him and cried aloud;
with her hands she tore her breast,
her tender throat,

and her beautiful face. The woman
like a goddess spoke,
weeping:
“Patroclus, most dear to me, unhappy
woman that I am,
when I left your hut you were living;
now, returning, I find you dead, lord
of the people.
So evil follows evil forever upon me.
The man to whom my father and
honored mother gave me
I saw lying before the city, torn by
the sharp bronze;
and I saw my three brothers, whom
one mother bore with me,
all dear to me, and all met their fatal
day.
“Nor would you let me mourn when
swift Achilles
killed my husband and sacked the
divine city of Mynes;
you told me that you would make me
the wedded wife
of divine Achilles, and lead me in the
ships to Phthia,
and appoint the marriage feast
among the Myrmidons.
Therefore I mourn you without
ceasing, though you are dead,
you who were always gentle.”
So she spoke weeping, and the
women groaned around Patroclus,
using him as the occasion for each
woman’s own grief.
The elders of the Achaeans gathered
around Achilles,
entreating him to eat; but he refused,
groaning:
“I beg you, if any dear companion
will obey me,

do not command me to take food or
drink
and gladden my heart before the sun
has gone down.
I will remain and endure it
nevertheless.
Before then no food or drink could
pass my throat,
while my companion lies dead, torn
by sharp bronze,
within the hut, turned toward the
doorway,
and his companions mourn around
him.
No other thought delights me
now—only killing,
and blood, and the grievous groaning
of men.”
So speaking, he scattered the other
kings;
but the two sons of Atreus remained,
with godlike Odysseus, Nestor,
Idomeneus,
and old horse-taming Phoenix,
trying with careful words to delight
the grief-stricken man.
But his spirit found no delight before
he entered
the mouth of the blood-stained war.
Remembering his companion, he
groaned deeply and spoke:
“Ah, poor friend, most dear of all
companions!
You yourself once set a pleasant meal
before me
quickly and eagerly in the hut,
whenever the Achaeans hastened to
carry tearful war
against the horse-taming Trojans.

But now you lie torn apart, while my
heart within me
is barren of food and drink because I
long for you.

No worse thing could befall me,
not even if I should hear that my
father had died—
he who now perhaps sheds a tender
tear in Phthia,
in want of such a son, while I fight
the Trojans
in a foreign land for hateful Helen;
nor even if I heard of my dear son,
who is being raised in Scyros—if
godlike Neoptolemus
still lives there.

“Before, my heart within me hoped
that I alone should perish far from
horse-pasturing Argos,
here in Troy, while you returned to
Phthia,
that you might bring my son from
Scyros
in your swift black ship, and show
him all my possessions,
my servants, and my great
high-roofed house.

For now I think Peleus is either
wholly dead,
or still living a little, suffering
bitterly
in hateful old age, and waiting
always for the grievous news
that I am dead.”

So he spoke weeping, and the elders
groaned,
each remembering what he had left
in his own house.

The son of Cronus saw them
mourning and pitied them.

At once he spoke to Athena in
winged words:

“My child, you have wholly
abandoned your own man.

Have you no care at all for Achilles?
There he sits before the beaked ships,
mourning his dear companion, while
the others have gone
to their meal; but he remains
without food or portion.

Go now, and pour sweet nectar and
ambrosia into his breast,
that grievous hunger may not reach
him.”

So he urged Athena, who was already
eager to go.

She flew down from heaven through
the upper air,
like a hawk with clear voice and
outspread wings.

Meanwhile the Achaeans armed
themselves throughout the camp.
She poured sweet nectar and lovely
ambrosia into Achilles’s breast,
that painful hunger might not reach
his knees;

then she returned to the strong
house of her father,
while they poured out from beside
the swift ships.

As when thick snowflakes pour forth
from Zeus—

—cold beneath the blast of
clear-born North—so then the
helmets,

brightly gleaming, came forth from
the ships, and the bossed shields,
the corselets hard against the storm,
and the ashwood spears.

Their splendor reached the sky, and
all the earth laughed around them
beneath the flashing bronze; and the
sound of men's feet rose.

In the midst divine Achilles armed
himself.

The clatter of his teeth sounded; his
two eyes flashed
like the gleam of fire, and intolerable
grief entered his heart.

Burning with rage against the
Trojans, he put on the god's gifts
which Hephaestus had wrought for
him.

First he fastened the beautiful
greaves around his legs,
fitted at the ankles with silver clasps.
Second he placed the corselet around
his breast.

Around his shoulders he hung the
bronze sword,
with its silver-studded hilt; and then
he took
the great and strong shield, whose
light shone far away
like the moon.

As when a gleam appears to sailors
from the sea
of a burning fire, high upon a lonely
mountain farm,
while storms against their will carry
them across
the fish-filled sea, far from their
friends—
so from Achilles's beautiful, cunning
shield
the brightness rose into the upper
air.

Then he lifted the heavy helmet and
set it upon his head;

the horse-haired helmet shone like a
star,

and the golden hairs which
Hephaestus had set thickly
around the crest streamed and
trembled.

Divine Achilles tested himself in his
armor,

to see whether it fitted and whether
his splendid limbs
moved freely within it. It seemed to
him as if wings had grown,
and it lifted the shepherd of the
people.

From its sheath he drew his father's
spear,

heavy, great, and strong. No other
Achaean

could brandish it; Achilles alone
knew how to wield

the Pelian ash, which Chiron had
given to his dear father
from the summit of Pelion, to be
death to heroes.

Automedon and Alcimius busied
themselves with the horses;
they yoked them, set the beautiful
collars around their necks,
put the bits between their jaws, and
stretched the reins

back to the chariot's fitted rail.

Automedon took the bright,
well-made whip in his hand
and sprang upon the horses; behind
him Achilles mounted,
shining in his armor like the sun that
never tires.

He called dreadfully to his father's
horses:

“Xanthus and Balius, far-famed
children of Podarge,
consider well how you may bring
your charioteer back
again into the ranks of the Danaans,
when we have had our fill of war.
Do not leave him there dead, as you
left Patroclus.”

The swift-footed horse beneath the
yoke, Xanthus,
bowed his head; and all his mane,
falling from the collar,
reached the ground beside the yoke.
The white-armed goddess Hera had
given him a human voice,
and he spoke:

“Even now we shall save you, mighty
Achilles;
but your day of death is near, and we
are not to blame—
it is the great god and powerful Fate.
Nor was it by our slowness or our
carelessness
that the Trojans stripped Patroclus’s
armor from his shoulders;
but the best of the gods, whom
fair-haired Leto bore,
killed him among the foremost
fighters
and gave glory to Hector.
“We two could run even with the
breath of Zephyr,
which they say is the lightest of
winds;
but it is appointed for you yourself
to be subdued by a god and by a
man.”

When he had spoken, the Erinyes
stopped his voice.

Swift-footed Achilles answered him
in deep displeasure:

“Xanthus, why do you prophesy
death to me?

It is not your task. I know it myself
very well:

it is my fate to perish here, far from
my dear father and mother.

Yet even so I will not cease
until I have driven the Trojans to the
full measure of war.”

So he spoke, and shouting among the
foremost ranks,

he held the single-hoofed horses.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 20

First-pass working translation

So they armed themselves beside the
curved ships,
the Achaeans gathered around you,
son of Peleus,
insatiable of battle; while the
Trojans again came on,
leaping out upon the rising plain.
Then Zeus commanded Themis to
summon the gods
to assembly from many-folded
Olympus.
She went everywhere and called
them to the house of Zeus.
No river was absent, except Oceanus;
nor any nymph who dwells in
beautiful groves,
beside the springs of rivers and in the
grassy meadows.
They came to the house of
cloud-gathering Zeus
and sat in the polished halls which
Hephaestus,
working with knowing thought, had
made for his father.
All the gods gathered within Zeus's
house;
nor did the Earth-Shaker fail to hear
the goddess's summons.
He came from the sea, sat in their
midst,
and questioned Zeus about his
purpose:
"Why have you called the gods again
to assembly,
lord of the bright lightning? Are you
pondering something

concerning Trojans and Achaeans?
For now the battle and the war burn
nearest them."
Cloud-gathering Zeus answered him:
"You know my thought already,
Earth-Shaker,
and why I have gathered you. I care
for them,
though they are perishing.
But I shall remain here, seated in a
fold of Olympus,
where I may delight my spirit as I
watch.
You others go, until you come among
Trojans and Achaeans,
and help whichever side each of you
favors.
"For if Achilles alone fights against
the Trojans,
they will not hold even for a little
while
against swift-footed Peleus's son.
Even before now they trembled at
the sight of him;
but now, since he is fiercely enraged
for his companion,
I fear he may destroy the wall beyond
what is fated."
So spoke the son of Cronus, and
roused a battle without restraint.
The gods went to war, divided in
their hearts.
Hera went with the assembly of the
ships,
and Pallas Athena, and Poseidon,
lord who holds the earth,
and gracious Hermes, eminent in
prudent thought;
and Hephaestus went with them,
blazing in strength,

limping, his thin legs moving
beneath him.
To the Trojans went Ares of the
shining helmet,
and Phoebus with unshorn hair, and
Artemis the archer,
Leto, Xanthus, and Aphrodite who
loves laughter.
While the gods remained apart from
mortal men,
the Achaeans exulted greatly because
Achilles had appeared,
after a long pause from the grievous
battle;
but terrible trembling entered every
Trojan limb,
when they saw swift-footed Peleus's
son
shining in his armor, like Ares who
destroys men.
When the Olympians came among
the host of men,
strong, man-driving Strife rose up;
Athena stood now beside the dug
trench outside the wall,
now upon the resounding shore and
cried aloud.
Ares shouted from the other side,
like a dark storm, calling the Trojans
from the city's height,
and at times running beside the
Simois upon Callicolone.
So the blessed gods urged on both
armies,
and drove them together; among
themselves they broke open
a heavy, bitter quarrel.
The father of gods and men
thundered terribly from above;

and below, Poseidon shook the
boundless earth
and the steep heads of the
mountains.
All the feet and summits of Ida with
its many springs trembled,
and the city of the Trojans and the
ships of the Achaeans.
The lord of the dead beneath the
earth was afraid.
In fear he leaped from his throne and
cried out,
lest Poseidon, the Earth-Shaker, split
the ground above him,
and reveal to mortals and immortals
alike
his dreadful, moldering dwellings,
which even the gods hate to behold.
So great was the uproar when the
gods met in strife.
Phoebus Apollo stood face to face
with lord Poseidon,
holding his winged arrows; and the
gray-eyed goddess Athena
stood opposite Enyalios, Ares.
The loud, golden-bowed archer
Artemis, sister of the Far-Shooter,
stood against Hera; Hermes, gracious
and strong,
stood against Leto; and the great
deep-eddying river,
whom the gods call Xanthus and
men call Scamander,
stood against Hephaestus.
Thus the gods went against gods. But
Achilles longed above all
to enter the crowd against Hector,
son of Priam;
his spirit commanded him to sate
Ares, the shield-bearing warrior,

with Hector's blood.
Apollo, driver of armies, roused
Aeneas straight against him,
and breathed good courage into his
heart.
He made himself like Lycaon, son of
Priam,
and in his likeness, Apollo the son of
Zeus spoke to Aeneas:
"Aeneas, counselor of the Trojans,
where are the threats
you promised the kings of Troy
while drinking wine—
that you would fight Achilles, son of
Peleus, face to face?"
Aeneas answered him:
"Son of Priam, why do you command
me to do this,
though I do not wish to fight face to
face
with the overbearing son of Peleus?
This is not the first time I shall stand
against swift Achilles;
before this he drove me away with
his spear from Ida,
when he came against our cattle,
sacked Lyrnessus and Pedasus.
But Zeus saved me then, who roused
my strength
and gave speed to my knees.
I should have fallen beneath the
hands of Achilles and Athena,
who went before him, setting light in
his path
and commanding him to kill Leleges
and Trojans with bronze.
"No man can fight Achilles face to
face;
for a god is always beside him to
ward off ruin.

And even otherwise his
straight-flying spear does not stop
until it has passed through a man's
flesh.
If a god made the end of battle equal,
he would not easily overcome me,
not even if he boasts that he is all
bronze."
Apollo, son of Zeus, answered him:
"Hero, pray also to the everlasting
gods;
they say that you too were born of
Aphrodite,
daughter of Zeus, while he is born of
a lesser goddess—
she from Zeus, you from the old man
of the sea.
Carry the unwearied bronze straight
against him;
do not let pitiful words or threats
turn you back."
So speaking, he breathed great
courage into the shepherd of the
people.
Aeneas went through the first ranks,
armed in flashing bronze.
White-armed Hera saw the son of
Anchises going straight
against the son of Peleus through the
ranks of men.
She halted the gods apart and spoke
among them:
"Consider this in your minds,
Poseidon and Athena,
how these things shall be
accomplished.
There is Aeneas, armed in flashing
bronze,
going against the son of Peleus;
Phoebus Apollo has driven him.

Come, let us turn him back from the place;
or let one of us stand beside Achilles,
give him great strength, and let nothing fail him,
that he may know how the best of the immortals love him,
and how empty are those who have defended the Trojans
and their battle before this.
“All of us came down from Olympus to this battle,
that he might suffer no harm today among the Trojans.
His fate will later bring him whatever he must endure,
when his mother bore him and spun his thread.
If Achilles does not learn these things from the voice of the gods,
he will fear afterward whenever a god comes face to face with him in battle, for the gods are terrible when they appear clearly.”
The Earth-Shaker Poseidon answered:
“Hera, do not be angry beyond measure; it is not fitting.
I would not wish to drive the other gods into strife,
when we are much stronger than they.
Let us go and sit apart, withdrawing from the battle;
let war concern the men.
But if Ares or Apollo begins the fight,
or holds Achilles back and will not let him fight,

then a quarrel will rise among us at once.
I think we shall quickly break apart and return to Olympus, subdued by our own hands.”
So speaking, the dark-haired god led them to the high,
sea-washed wall of divine Heracles,
which the Trojans and Pallas Athena had built for him,
that he might escape the sea-monster whenever it drove him from the shore toward the plain.
There Poseidon sat, and the other gods with him;
around their shoulders they wrapped an unbreakable cloud.
On the other side, upon the heights of Callicolone,
sat Phoebus and city-sacking Ares, each devising counsel.
Thus they sat on either side, devising plans,
and both hesitated to begin the painful battle;
while Zeus, seated high above, commanded them.
The whole plain was filled and flashed with bronze,
with men and horses; the earth rang beneath their feet.
Two men, far the best, came eagerly into the space between them,
desiring to fight: Aeneas, son of Anchises,
and divine Achilles.
Aeneas came first, threatening, nodding beneath his heavy helmet;
before his breast he held his sturdy shield,

and brandished his bronze spear.
From the other side Peleus's son
came against him like a lion,
a ravager whom all the gathered
country people desire to kill.
At first he goes on, despising them;
but when one of the bold,
war-loving young men—
—and is struck by the spear, and falls
back, foaming at the mouth;
his brave heart groans within him,
and he lashes his flanks
and both his thighs with his tail,
driving himself toward battle;
his green eyes fixed straight ahead,
he rushes on in strength,
whether he kills some man or is
himself the first to perish.
So courage and his proud spirit
drove Achilles
to meet great-hearted Aeneas.
When they came near one another,
swift-footed divine Achilles spoke
first:
“Aeneas, why have you come so far
through the crowd and stood here?
Does your spirit command you to
fight me,
hoping to rule the horse-taming
Trojans in Priam's honor?
Yet if you should kill me, Priam
would not place that prize in your
hands;
he has sons of his own, and his mind
is sound, not foolish.
Or have the Trojans cut out for you,
apart from all the others,
a beautiful estate of vineyard and
plowland,

that you may possess it if you kill
me?
But I think you will find that
difficult.
“Before this, I say, I drove you away
with my spear.
Do you not remember when you
were alone among the cattle?
I chased you swiftly down from the
mountains of Ida.
Then you never turned to face me as
you fled;
from there you escaped to Lyrnessus,
while I came after you
with Athena and father Zeus, sacked
the city,
and carried away its women, taking
the free day from them.
But Zeus and the other gods saved
you.
Now I do not think they will save
you, whatever your heart supposes.
I tell you: go back into the crowd,
and do not stand before me,
before some evil reaches you. A fool
learns only after the deed.”
Aeneas answered him:
“Son of Peleus, do not think to
frighten me with words
as though I were a child; I know
mockery and shameful speech as
well.
We know one another's birth and
have heard the famous words
of mortal men about our fathers; but
you have never seen mine,
nor have I seen yours.
They say you are the blameless son of
Peleus,

and of Thetis, the fair-haired
sea-born goddess;
while I declare myself the son of
great-hearted Anchises,
and Aphrodite is my mother.
Today the parents of one of us shall
mourn a beloved son;
we shall not go back from this battle
as children after words.
“If you wish to learn our lineage, that
you may know it well—
many men know it already—then
first cloud-gathering Zeus
begot Dardanus, who founded
Dardania,
before holy Ilium, city of mortal
men, had yet been built
upon the plain; men still lived
beneath the slopes
of many-springed Ida.
“Dardanus begot Erichthonius, a
king,
who became the richest of mortal
men.
Three thousand mares grazed for
him in the marsh,
rejoicing in their tender foals.
Boreas loved them as they grazed;
he took the form of a dark-maned
stallion and lay with them,
and they conceived and bore twelve
foals.
When they ran and leaped over the
life-giving earth,
they skimmed the tops of the
grain-bearing stalks
and did not break them; but when
they ran and leaped
upon the broad back of the sea,

they skimmed the crest of the gray
salt water.
“Erichthonius begot Tros, king of the
Trojans;
and Tros had three blameless sons:
Ilus, Assaracus, and godlike
Ganymede,
who was the most beautiful of all
mortal men.
The gods carried him away because
of his beauty,
that he might pour wine for the
immortals.
Ilus begot the blameless Laomedon;
Laomedon begot Tithonus, Priam,
Lampos, Clytius,
and Hicetaon, a branch of Ares.
Assaracus begot Capys, and Capys
begot Anchises;
Anchises begot me, and Priam begot
divine Hector.
This is the blood and lineage from
which I claim descent.
“Zeus increases and diminishes a
man’s strength
as he wills, for he is the strongest of
all.
But come, let us speak no longer like
children,
standing here in the midst of the
battle’s slaughter.
There are insults enough for either of
us to speak,
many indeed—no ship with a
hundred benches
could carry their burden.
The tongue of mortals is pliant,
and there are many kinds of words
within it,

a wide pasture of speech in every direction.

Whatever word you speak, such a word you shall hear.

But what need have we to quarrel and accuse one another, face to face like women, who, angered by soul-consuming strife, go into the middle of the street and reproach one another, saying much that is true and much that is not?

Their anger makes them speak it. You will not turn me from my eager courage with words; not before we have fought face to face with bronze.

Come, let us quickly taste one another's strength with bronze-tipped spears."

So he spoke, and drove his mighty spear against the dreadful shield; the shield bellowed greatly beneath the spear's point.

But Peleus's son held the shield away with his broad hand, thinking that Aeneas's long-shadowed spear would easily pass through.

He was a fool; he did not understand in his heart that the glorious gifts of the gods are not easily broken or made to yield before mortal men. Yet the mighty spear of wise Aeneas did not break the shield.

Gold, the gift of the god, held it back.

It drove through two folds, while three still remained,

since the crooked-footed smith had made five folds:

two of bronze, two within of tin, and the one of gold that stopped the ashen spear.

Achilles cast his long-shadowed spear in turn.

He struck Aeneas's perfectly rounded shield

beneath the first rim, where the bronze was thinnest and the oxhide was thinnest as well. The Pelian ash pierced through, and the shield split beneath it.

Aeneas sprang back and lifted the shield from his body in fear.

The spear, driven onward, stood in the earth behind him; its point had passed through both circles of the mortal shield.

He avoided the long spear, but a boundless grief spread over his eyes, struck with terror

when the weapon stood so near him. But Achilles, rushing upon him fiercely, drew his sharp sword and cried aloud.

Aeneas seized a great stone in his hand,

a mighty deed, such as two men of this present generation could not carry together; but he wielded it easily alone.

There Aeneas would have hurled the stone and struck either the helmet or the shield that had held off his grievous destruction;

and Peleus's son, rushing close,
would have taken his life with the
sword,
had not Poseidon, the Earth-Shaker,
perceived it quickly.
He spoke among the immortal gods:
"Ah me, I grieve for great-hearted
Aeneas,
who soon, subdued by Peleus's son,
will go down to Hades, obeying
Apollo the Far-Shooter—
a fool, since Apollo will not save him
from grievous death.
Why should this guiltless man suffer
pain for nothing,
on account of another's grief, while
he continually offers
pleasing gifts to the gods who hold
the wide heaven?
Come, let us draw him away from
death,
lest the son of Cronus grow angry if
Achilles kills him.
It is his destiny to escape, so that the
race of Dardanus
may not perish seedless and vanish
altogether—
Dardanus, whom the son of Cronus
loved above all the children
born to him from mortal women.
For the son of Cronus has come to
hate the house of Priam;
but now the strength of Aeneas shall
rule the Trojans,
and the children of his children who
are born afterward."
Ox-eyed, honored Hera answered
him:
"Earth-Shaker, consider in your own
spirit

whether you will rescue Aeneas,
or leave him, excellent though he is,
to be subdued by Achilles, son of
Peleus.
I and Pallas Athena have sworn many
oaths
before all the immortals never to
defend the Trojans
from the evil day—not even when all
Troy burns
in consuming fire and the warlike
sons of the Achaeans
set it ablaze."
When Poseidon, Earth-Shaker, heard
her,
he went through the battle and the
clash of spears,
and came to the place where Aeneas
and glorious Achilles stood.
At once he spread a mist before the
eyes of Achilles,
and drew the bronze spear from the
shield of great-hearted Aeneas.
He laid it before Achilles's feet,
and lifted Aeneas from the ground
into the air.
Across many ranks of heroes, across
many ranks of horses,
Aeneas leaped by the god's hand,
and came to the far edge of the
tumultuous battle,
where the Cauconians stood armed
for war.
Poseidon, Earth-Shaker, came close
and spoke to him:
"Aeneas, what god commands you, in
your blindness,
to fight face to face with the
overbearing son of Peleus?"

He is stronger than you, and dearer
to the immortals.
Withdraw whenever you meet him,
lest you go to the house of Hades
beyond your portion.
But when Achilles has met death and
fate,
then fight boldly among the
foremost ranks;
for no other Achaeon will kill you.”
So speaking, he left him there, since
he had made all clear.
At once he scattered the divine mist
from Achilles’s eyes.
Achilles looked around and saw with
his own eyes,
troubled, and spoke within his great
heart:
“Ah me, what great wonder do I see
with my eyes?
My spear lies here upon the ground,
but I see no man at whom I hurled it
in my fury.
So Aeneas too must be dear to the
immortal gods;
and I thought his boasts were empty
wind.
Away with him! His spirit shall not
try me again,
since he has gladly escaped death.
Come, I will command the
war-loving Danaans,
and go against the other Trojans.”
So he spoke, and leaped upon the
ranks,
calling to every man:
“No longer stand far off from the
Trojans, divine Achaeans;
let man go against man, and let each
desire to fight.

It is hard for me, mighty though I
am,
to pursue so many men and fight
them all.
Not even Ares, an immortal god, or
Athena
could pursue the mouth of so great a
battle
and labor through it.
But whatever strength I have in
hands and feet
and courage, I declare that I will not
hold back
even for a little; I will go straight
through the ranks,
and I think no Trojan will rejoice
who comes within reach of my
spear.”
Thus he urged them on. On the
Trojan side glorious Hector
called aloud and commanded them
to go against Achilles:
“High-hearted Trojans, do not fear
Peleus’s son.
I could fight even with words against
the immortals,
but with the spear it is hard, for they
are far stronger.
Nor will Achilles bring every word
to fulfillment;
one thing he will accomplish,
another he will cut short halfway.
I will go against him, even if his
hands are like fire,
and his strength like burning iron.”
So he urged them on; and the
Trojans lifted their spears against
him,
their strength mingled, and the
war-cry rose.

Then Phoebus Apollo, standing
beside Hector, spoke:
“Hector, no longer fight Achilles in
the first ranks.
Receive him among the multitude,
away from the tumult;
lest he strike you with a spear or
wound you at close quarters.”
So he spoke; and Hector again
entered the ranks of men,
afraid when he heard the voice of the
god.
But Achilles leaped among the
Trojans,
clothed in courage, and cried aloud.
First he took Iphition, son of
Otrynteus,
a good leader of many people.
A water-nymph had borne him to
Otrynteus,
the sacker of cities, beneath snowy
Tmolus,
in the rich land of Hyde.
Divine Achilles struck him straight
through the middle of the head
with his spear; the skull split cleanly
in two,
and he fell with a crash.
Then divine Achilles boasted over
him:
“There you lie, son of Otrynteus,
most terrible of all men.
Here is your death; your father’s
estate is beside Lake Gygaea,
where you have a paternal holding,
by fish-filled Hyllus and the swirling
Hermus.”
So he boasted; and darkness covered
the man’s eyes.

The horses of the Achaeans tore him
apart
with their wheels in the first line of
battle.
Then Achilles struck Demoleon, son
of Antenor,
a good defender in war, beneath the
temple,
driving the spear through the bronze
cheek-piece of his helmet.
The bronze helmet did not stop it;
the spear passed through, shattered
the bone,
and all the brain was spattered
within him.
He subdued the man as he rushed
against him.
Then he struck Hippodamas, who
sprang from his horses
and fled before him, in the back with
his spear.
He gave up his spirit and roared like
a bull
when young men drag it around the
lord of Helicon;
the Earth-Shaker delights in the
sound.
So the brave spirit left that man as he
roared,
and his bones remained behind.
Then he went with his spear against
godlike Polydorus,
son of Priam. His father would not
let him fight,
because he was the youngest of all his
children,
and dearest to him; in the folly of
youth
he surpassed them all in speed of
foot.

Then he rushed among the foremost ranks,
displaying his childish swiftness,
until he lost the life he loved.
Swift-footed divine Achilles struck
him in the middle of his back
as he ran past, where the golden
fastenings of his belt held him,
and the doubled corselet met.
The spear-point came straight
through beside the navel.
He fell upon his knees with a cry,
and a dark cloud covered him;
he crouched toward the earth,
holding his entrails in his hands.
When Hector saw his brother
Polydorus
lying upon the earth and clutching
his entrails,
a mist spread over his eyes.
He could not bear to remain far off
any longer,
but came straight against Achilles,
shaking his sharp spear, like a flame.
When Achilles saw him, he sprang
forward
and spoke in triumph:
“The man is near who has struck my
heart most deeply,
who killed my honored companion.
We shall not shrink from one
another any longer
through the paths of war.”
He looked darkly at divine Hector
and called:
“Come nearer, that you may reach
the limits of death more quickly.”
Hector, not afraid, answered him:
“Son of Peleus, do not expect to
frighten me with words

as though I were a child. I know
mockery and shameful speech
as well as you do. I know that you are
a good man,
and that I am far worse than you.
Yet these things lie upon the knees of
the gods.
Perhaps, though I am the weaker, I
may take your life
by striking you with my spear; for
my weapon too has been sharp
before.”
So speaking, he cast his spear; but
Athena turned it back
with a breath from glorious Achilles,
blowing upon it very softly.
The spear came back to divine
Hector
and fell before his feet.
Achilles rushed forward fiercely,
eager to kill him, crying aloud;
but Apollo snatched Hector away
easily,
like a god, and hid him in thick mist.
Three times swift-footed divine
Achilles sprang
with his bronze spear; three times he
struck the deep mist.
But when he rushed a fourth time,
equal to a spirit,
he shouted terribly and spoke
winged words:
“Again you have escaped death, dog!
Surely evil came near you; but
Phoebus Apollo
has saved you once more, to whom
you must pray
when you go into the clash of spears.
I shall certainly finish you later,

when we meet again—if some god
stands beside me as well.
Now I will go after the others,
whoever comes within my reach.”
So speaking, he struck Dryops in the
middle of the neck
with his spear, and Dryops fell before
his feet.
Achilles left him there and caught
Demouchus,
son of Philetor, strong and great,
striking him in the knee with his
spear and holding him back;
then he took his life with his great
sword.
Next he rushed upon Laogonus and
Dardanus,
both sons of Bias, and drove them
from their horses,
throwing one to the ground with his
spear,
and striking the other at close
quarters with his sword.
Then Tros, son of Alastor, came
straight to his knees,
hoping he might take hold of them
and be spared,
and that Achilles, pitying a man of
his own age,
would not kill him.
Fool! He did not understand what he
was about to suffer.
Achilles was not gentle-hearted or
merciful,
but terribly enraged.
While Tros touched his knees and
begged,
Achilles struck him with the sword
in the liver.

The liver slipped out; dark blood
filled his lap,
and darkness covered his eyes as his
spirit failed.
Then Achilles, standing near, struck
Mulius
with his spear beneath the ear;
the bronze point passed at once
through the other ear.
Then he struck Echeclus, son of
Agenor,
in the middle of the head with the
sword's hilt.
The whole sword grew warm with
blood,
and purple death and powerful fate
seized his eyes.
Then he struck Deucalion, where the
tendons
hold the elbow together, and pierced
his arm
with the bronze point through the
flesh.
He stood before him, his arm grown
heavy,
looking upon death; but Achilles laid
the sword
upon his neck and sent his head far
away
with the helmet still upon it.
The marrow leaped from the
vertebrae,
and he lay stretched upon the earth.
Then Achilles went against Rigmus,
son of Peireus,
who had come from rich-soiled
Thrace.
He struck him in the middle with the
spear;
the bronze fixed itself in his belly,

and he fell from the chariot.
Then he struck his charioteer
Arēithoön,
who had turned the horses back,
in the back with his sharp spear,
and drove him from the car; his
horses were thrown into confusion.
As a fire, divinely sent, rages in the
deep valleys
of a parched mountain, and the deep
forest burns,
while the wind drives the flame in
every direction—
so he rushed everywhere, equal to a
spirit,
following those he killed with his
spear;
and the black earth ran with blood.
As when a man yokes broad-browed
oxen
to tread white barley in a well-built
threshing floor,
and the small grains quickly come
loose
beneath the bellowing oxen's feet—
so beneath great-hearted Achilles
the single-hoofed horses trampled
corpses and shields together;
all beneath the axle and the rims
around the chariot
were spattered with blood,
from the horses' hooves and from the
wheels.
But the son of Peleus longed to win
glory,
and his invincible hands were stained
with gore.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 21

First-pass working translation

When they reached the ford of the
fair-flowing river,
the whirling Xanthus, whom
immortal Zeus had fathered,
Achilles cut some of them apart and
drove them toward the plain,
toward the city where the Achaeans
had fled in terror
the day before, when glorious Hector
raged among them.
They poured forward in flight; Hera
spread a deep darkness before them,
and half of them were driven into the
silver-whirling river.
They fell with a great crash; the steep
banks roared around them,
and the men swam here and there,
whirling in the eddies with a cry.
As when locusts flee before a blast of
fire
toward a river, while the tireless
flame rushes suddenly upon them,
and they cower beneath the
water—so beneath Achilles
the deep-whirling Xanthus was filled
with the mingled stream
of horses and men.
The son of Peleus, born of Zeus, left
his spear
leaning against a tamarisk upon the
bank;
he leaped into the river like a god,
carrying only his sword,
and planned evil in his heart. He
struck men down,

turning from side to side; and an
unlovely groan rose
from those he cut, while the water
grew red with blood.
As fish flee a great sea-beast and fill
the hidden corners
of a well-sheltered harbor,
terrified—for it devours
whatever it can seize—so the Trojans
cowered beneath
the dreadful river's banks, while
Achilles,
when his hands grew weary of
killing, chose twelve living youths
from the stream as payment for
Patroclus, son of Menoetius,
who had died.
He led them out of the river, stunned
like fawns,
bound their hands behind them with
well-cut straps,
the straps they themselves wore upon
their folded tunics,
and gave them to his companions to
lead down
to the hollow ships.
But he himself sprang back, eager to
destroy.
There he met the son of Priam, the
Dardanian Lycaon,
fleeing from the river—him whom
Achilles himself
had once led away captive from his
father's orchard,
coming upon him by night while he
cut young branches
from a fig tree with sharp bronze to
make the rails of a chariot.
An unforeseen evil then came upon
divine Achilles.

He carried Lycaon through the
well-built Lemnos
and sold him there; the son of Jason
paid the price.
But a guest-friend, Eetion of Imbros,
freed him for much, and sent him to
sacred Arisbe;
from there he escaped and came to
his father's house.
Eleven days he delighted his heart
among his dear ones
after returning from Lemnos; but on
the twelfth
a god cast him again into the hands
of Achilles,
who was destined to send him
unwillingly to Hades.
When swift-footed divine Achilles
saw him,
naked, without helmet or shield, and
carrying no spear—
he had thrown all these aside, for
sweat and weariness
from his flight out of the river
weighed upon his knees—
Achilles, troubled, spoke within his
great heart:
“What a wonder I behold with my
eyes!
Will the great-hearted Trojans
whom I have killed
rise again from the mist and
darkness,
as this man has come back from
Lemnos,
having crossed the kindly
sea—though the sea's gray surface
holds back many men against their
will?

Come, let him taste the point of my
spear,
that I may see and learn in my heart
whether he will return from there as
well,
or whether the life-giving earth will
hold him,
though it holds even the strong.”
While he waited, Lycaon came close,
eager to seize Achilles's knees and
escape
the evil death and black fate.
Divine Achilles raised his long spear,
eager to strike;
but Lycaon ran beneath it, bent
down, and grasped his knees.
The spear stood quivering in the
earth behind him,
thirsting to drink the blood of a man.
With one hand he clasped Achilles's
knees in supplication;
with the other he held the sharpened
spear and would not release it.
He spoke in winged words:
“I clasp your knees, Achilles; respect
me and pity me.
I come before you as a suppliant,
fostered by Zeus.
With you I first ate the fruit of
Demeter's field
on the day you captured me in the
well-built orchard,
and led me away from my father and
my friends
to sacred Lemnos, where you sold me
for a hundred oxen.
Now I have paid three times that
price,
and this is the twelfth dawn since I
came to Ilium

after enduring much; now evil fate
has placed me again
in your hands. I must be hated by
father Zeus,
who has given me to you a second
time.
My mother is Laothoe, daughter of
old Altes,
who rules the war-loving Leleges
and holds steep Pedasus beside the
Satnioeis.
Priam took her as a wife, among his
many wives;
we were two sons born of her, and
you will cut the throats of both—
you subdued godlike Polydorus in
the first ranks
when you struck him with your sharp
spear,
and now evil will come upon me
here.
I do not think I shall escape your
hands,
since a god has brought me near
them.
But I will tell you another thing, and
lay it up in your heart:
do not kill me. I am not Hector's full
brother,
who killed your gentle and strong
companion."
So the glorious son of Priam spoke,
entreating him;
but he heard a voice that would not
yield:
"Fool, do not speak to me of ransom
or make speeches.
Before Patroclus met his appointed
day,

it was more pleasing to my heart to
spare Trojans,
and I captured many alive and sold
them beyond the sea.
But now no Trojan shall escape
death,
whom a god casts before my hands
here before Ilium—
not one of all the Trojans, and least
of all a son of Priam.
Die, my friend. Why do you mourn
so?
Patroclus died too, though he was far
better than you.
Do you not see how great and
beautiful I am?
I am the son of a noble father, and a
goddess bore me;
yet death and powerful fate stand
over me as well.
There shall come a dawn, an evening,
or a noon,
when some man will take my life in
battle,
striking with his spear or an arrow
from the bow."
So he spoke; and Lycaon's knees and
dear heart were loosened.
He let go the spear, and sat with
both hands spread.
Achilles drew his sharp sword and
struck him beside the neck,
driving the double-edged blade
wholly inward.
He fell face down, stretched upon
the earth;
black blood ran from him and wet
the ground.
Achilles seized him by the foot and
cast him into the river,

and spoke over him in triumph:
“Lie there among the fish; let them
lick the blood
from your wound without care. Your
mother will not lay you
upon a bier and mourn you; the
whirling Scamander
will carry you into the broad gulf of
the sea.
Some fish will leap through the black
wave
and gnaw the shining fat of Lycaon.
Perish, until we reach the holy city of
Ilium—
you fleeing, and I destroying behind
you.
Nor will the river, though
fair-flowing and silver-whirling,
save you, to which for so long you
have sacrificed many bulls
and cast living single-hoofed horses
into the eddies.
Even so you shall die an evil death,
until all of you have paid for
Patroclus’s death
and for the ruin of the Achaeans,
whom you killed beside the swift
ships while I was away.”
Thus he spoke; and the River grew
yet more angered
within his heart, and pondered how
to make the godlike
Achilles cease from his labor, and
ward from the Trojans
the doom that followed. Meanwhile
the son of Peleus,
holding his long-shadowed spear,
sprang upon Asteropaeus,
the son of Pelegon, resolved in his
heart to slay him.

Pelegon was born of the
wide-flowing Axios
and Periboea, eldest daughter of
Acessamenus;
with her the deep-eddying River had
mingled.
Against him Achilles rushed; but he
stood forth from the River,
holding two spears, for Xanthus had
set courage within him,
angered at the young men slain,
whom Achilles butchered
along his stream and pitied not.
When they had come near,
swift-footed, shining Achilles spoke
before him:
“Who are you, and from what people,
that you have dared
to come against me? Unhappy are the
children of those men
who meet my strength in battle.”
Then the glorious son of Pelegon
answered him:
“Great-hearted son of Peleus, why do
you question my lineage?
I come from fertile Paeonia, far
away,
leading the long-speared Paeonians;
and this is the eleventh
dawn since I came to Ilium. But my
blood is from the Axios,
the broad-flowing Axios, whose
waters are fairest
of all that he sends across the earth;
he begot
the famous spearman Pelegon, and
Pelegon, men say,
begot me. Now, glorious Achilles, let
us fight.”

He spoke, and threatened him. Then
shining Achilles lifted
the Pelian ash; but Asteropaeus,
being ambidextrous,
cast both his spears together. With
one he struck the shield,
but could not pierce it through, for
the god's gold gifts
held it fast. With the other he struck
the right forearm,
slanting above the elbow; and the
dark blood sprang forth.
The spear stood fixed in the earth
beyond him,
longing to drink his flesh. Then
Achilles, in his turn,
sent forth the straight-pointed ash,
eager to kill him;
but he missed, and the spear struck
the lofty bank,
where it stood driven halfway
through the river-cliff.
The son of Peleus drew the sharp
sword from beside his thigh
and leapt upon him, fierce to strike.
Asteropaeus could not
with his broad hand wrench Achilles'
ash from the steep bank.
Three times he shook and strained to
tear it free;
three times the strength failed and
his arms released it;
the fourth time he bent his heart to
break and bow
the ash-spear of Aeacus' son. But
before that could be done,
Achilles came close and robbed him
of his life.
He struck him in the belly beside the
navel,

and all his entrails spilled out upon
the ground;
darkness covered his eyes as he
gasped for breath.
Achilles sprang upon his breast,
stripped away his armor,
and, exulting, spoke this word:
"Lie there so. It is hard to contend
with the sons
of mighty Cronus, even when one is
born from a river.
You said that you were sprung from
a wide-flowing River;
but I proclaim my lineage from great
Zeus.
My father was a man who ruled over
many Myrmidons,
Peleus, son of Aeacus; and Aeacus
was born from Zeus.
Zeus is mightier than rivers flowing
into the salt sea,
and the offspring of Zeus is mightier
than a river's child.
For you have beside you a great
River, if he can help you;
but there is no fighting Zeus, the son
of Cronus.
Not even lordly Achelous can equal
him in strength,
nor Oceanus, deep-flowing and
mighty, from whom all rivers,
every sea, every spring, and every
deep well are born.
Yet even Oceanus fears the
thunderbolt of great Zeus
and the terrible thunder, when it
crashes down from heaven."
So he spoke, and drew the bronze
spear from the steep bank;

but left the other there, since he had
taken away his life.

He lay upon the sands, and the black
water drenched him.

Eels and fish gathered around him,
gnawing the flesh,
and cropping the fat that lay along
his kidneys.

Achilles went on against the
Paeonians, horse-crested,
who still remained beside the
whirling River,
terrified when they saw their best
man overcome
by the hands of Peleus' son and by his
mighty sword.

There he seized Thersilochus,
Mydon, and Astypylus,
Mneseus, Thrasios, Aenius, and
Ophelestes—

and the Paeonian ranks were broken
before him.

And now swift Achilles would have
slain still more

of the Paeonians, had not the
deep-eddying River,
appearing in the likeness of a man
and speaking from his deep whirl,
addressed him in anger:

“Achilles, you surpass in strength,
and you do deeds beyond all measure
against men; for the gods themselves
are ever your defenders.

If the son of Cronus has granted you
all the Trojans to destroy,
drive them from me at least, and do
your dreadful work upon the plain;
for my lovely channels are already
filled with corpses,

and I can find no way to pour my
stream into the bright sea,
so choked am I with the dead, while
you kill without pity.

Come now, desist; dread seizes me,
shepherd of the people.”

Swift-footed Achilles answered him:
“It shall be so, Zeus-nurtured
Scamander, as you command;
but I will not cease from slaughtering
the overweening Trojans
until I have driven them beneath
their city and tried my strength
against Hector face to face—whether
he shall master me,
or I shall master him.”

So he spoke, and like a god sprang
upon the Trojans.

Then the deep-eddying River
addressed Apollo:

“Ah me, god of the silver bow, son of
Zeus!

You have not kept the commands of
Cronus's son,
who charged you earnestly to stand
beside the Trojans
and guard them, until the
late-setting sun should come,
and darkness cover the fertile fields.”

He spoke; and Achilles, famous for
his spear, leapt
from the river-bank into the midst of
the stream.

But the River rushed upon him,
raging and swelling;
he stirred all his channels into
confusion, pushed onward
the many corpses that lay thick
about him—those whom Achilles

had slain—and cast them out upon
the dry land,
bellowing like a bull; but the living
he saved
within his beautiful channels, hiding
them in deep,
great whirlpools.
Around Achilles stood a terrible
wave, tossed and seething;
the stream fell upon his shield. He
could no longer
stand firm upon his feet. With both
hands he grasped
a great and flourishing elm; but it fell
from its roots,
and in its fall drove down the whole
steep bank,
and checked the lovely channels with
its thick branches,
bridging them as it plunged inward.
Achilles sprang
out of the whirl and fled across the
plain on swift feet,
in fear; yet the great god did not
cease, but rose against him,
dark-crested, that he might make the
godlike Achilles
desist from his labor and ward the
doom from Troy.
The son of Peleus leapt as far as a
black hunting eagle,
the strongest and swiftest of winged
creatures,
launches itself; so he flew, and the
bronze upon his breast
rang terribly. Beneath him he turned
aside and fled,
while the River followed behind with
mighty uproar.

As when a man who leads water
from a dark spring
guides its running course among the
plants and gardens,
holding a mattock in his hands and
casting the barriers
from the channel; while the stones
are all upheaved
beneath the water rushing forth, and
the stream, descending swiftly,
gurgles through the hollow land, and
outruns even the guide—
so always the wave of the River
overtook swift-footed Achilles.
For the gods are stronger than men.
As often as shining, swift-footed
Achilles tried
to stand against it and discover
whether all the immortals,
who possess the wide heaven, were
driving him in fear,
so often the great wave of the
heaven-fed River
struck him above the shoulders. He
leapt high with his feet,
his spirit in anguish; but the River,
rushing beneath,
struck at his knees and swept the
dust from under his feet.
Then the son of Peleus groaned,
looking into the wide heaven:
“Father Zeus, how has no god stood
beside me in pity
to save me from the River?
Afterward let any other grief come.
No other one of the heavenly gods is
so greatly to blame,
but my dear mother, who charmed
me with false words—

she told me that beneath the wall of
the armored Trojans
I should perish by Apollo's flying
arrows.
Would that Hector had slain me,
who was bred here
and was the best of men! Then a
good man would have killed me,
and a good man stripped my armor.
But now fate has decreed
that I should be taken by a pitiless
death,
caught in the great River, like a
swineherd's boy
whom a torrent sweeps away as he
crosses it in winter."
So he spoke; and Poseidon and
Athena came very swiftly near him,
likened in form to mortal men. They
took him by the hand
and strengthened him with words.
Earth-shaking Poseidon began:
"Son of Peleus, do not fear so greatly,
nor be afraid;
for we two are beside you, a strong
defense among the gods,
with Zeus's approval—myself and
Pallas Athena.
It is not your fate to be overcome by
this River;
he will soon grow quiet, and you
yourself shall see it.
But we shall give you good counsel, if
you will obey us:
do not cease from the battle that lays
men low
until you have driven the Trojan host
beneath
the renowned walls of Ilium,
whoever escapes.

Then, when you have taken Hector's
life,
go back again to the ships; and we
grant you glory."
Having spoken thus, the two
withdrew among the immortals.
Achilles went out upon the plain,
compelled by the mighty command
of the gods. All the plain was filled
with water poured abroad;
many fine weapons of the young men
slain, and many corpses,
floated upon it. Achilles leapt high
above the rising stream
and sprang straight against the
current; the broad-flowing River
could not hold him back, for Athena
had given him great strength.
Nor did Scamander lay aside his own
might. He was angered still more
against Peleus's son, and lifted the
wave of his current high;
then he called aloud to Simoeis, his
dear brother:
"Dear brother, let us both restrain
this man's strength,
since soon he will sack the great city
of Priam,
and the Trojans will not stand
within the battle.
Come swiftly to my aid, and fill your
channels
with water from your springs; stir up
all your torrents;
raise a mighty wave, and awaken a
great uproar
of trees and stones, that we may stop
this savage man,
who now prevails and is bent on
being equal to the gods.

For I declare that neither his
strength nor his beauty
nor his bright armor shall help
him—those armor-pieces
will lie far below in the mud of the
pool.
Himself I will wrap in sand, pouring
about him
an infinite mound; nor shall the
Achaeans know
to gather up his bones, so much ruin
will I heap upon him.
There, too, his monument shall be
made; he shall have no need
of a mound-builder when the
Achaeans bury him.”
So he spoke, and rushed upon
Achilles, tossing high,
roaring with foam and blood and
corpses.
The purple wave of the heaven-fed
River stood lifted,
and swept away the son of Peleus.
Then white-armed Hera cried aloud,
greatly afraid for Achilles,
lest the deep-eddying River should
carry him away.
At once she called to her own dear
son, Hephaestus:
“Rise, my lame-footed child.
Opposite you we have made
the whirling Xanthus a match for
battle.
Come swiftly to his aid, and make a
mighty flame appear.
But I will bring from the sea a bitter
storm of the West Wind
and the bright South Wind, and raise
it terribly;

it shall burn the heads and armor of
the Trojans,
carrying an evil blaze. You must burn
the trees
along the banks of Xanthus, and cast
the fire into the River itself.
Do not let soft words or threats turn
you aside;
do not cease from your strength until
I cry aloud.
Then restrain your tireless fire.”
So she spoke; and Hephaestus
kindled the fire divine.
First the fire spread across the plain
and burned the many corpses
that lay thick around it, whom
Achilles had slain;
the whole plain was dried, and the
bright water was held back.
As when the autumn North Wind
quickly dries
the newly watered garden, and the
gardener rejoices,
so the whole plain was dried, and the
corpses burned;
then Hephaestus turned his bright
flame toward the River.
The elms and willows burned, and
the tamarisks;
the lotus burned, and the rush and
the sedge,
which had grown in abundance
around the River’s lovely banks.
Eels and fish were wearied, and the
fish that leapt
here and there through the fair
channels,
distressed by the breath of
resourceful Hephaestus.

The River's strength was burning; he spoke and called by name:

"Hephaestus, no god can stand against you in contest, nor could I fight with you here, against this blazing fire.

Cease from the quarrel; and let glorious Achilles drive the Trojans from their city at once.

What have I to do with quarrel and with aid?"

He spoke, burning in the fire; and the lovely channels boiled.

As when a cauldron boils within, urged by a great fire, melting the fat of a tender, well-fed hog on every side, while the dry wood lies beneath it crackling,

so his lovely channels were burned by fire, and the water boiled; he would not flow forward, but was held back,

and the breath of thoughtful Hephaestus tormented him.

Then he addressed white-armed Hera with many winged words:

"Hera, why has your son afflicted my stream for the sake of others?

I am not so much to blame as all the others,

all who bring aid to the Trojans.

Yet I will cease, if you command it; and let that other one cease also. I swear you this besides:

never again will I ward the evil day from the Trojans,

not even when all Troy burns in ravening fire,

and the warlike sons of the Achaeans set it ablaze."

When the white-armed goddess Hera heard him, she at once spoke to her own dear son, illustrious Hephaestus:

"Hephaestus, glorious child, hold back; for it is not fitting that an immortal god should scourge another so harshly for mortals."

So she spoke; and Hephaestus quenched the fire divine.

The lovely wave withdrew backward into its channels.

When the strength of Xanthus had been subdued, both ceased their struggle, for Hera, though still angry, held them back.

Among the other gods a heavy quarrel now arose; hard strife divided them, and their hearts were blown apart.

They fell together with a mighty crash, and the broad earth groaned; the great heaven rang around them. Zeus heard it,

sitting upon Olympus, and his dear heart laughed for joy, when he saw the gods coming together in their strife.

They did not stand apart for long. Ares, the shield-piercer,

began, and first sprang upon Athena with his bronze spear;

he spoke a word of reproach:

"Why again, dog-faced one, do you drive the gods together

in strife, with this unwearied boldness, while your great heart

urges you on? Do you not remember
when you stirred Diomedes,
son of Tydeus, to wound me, and
yourself took up his spear,
and drove it straight at me, tearing
my fair flesh?

Therefore I think I shall now make
you pay for all you did.”

So he spoke, and struck the dread,
tasselled aegis,
which not even Zeus’s thunderbolt
can conquer;

with his blood-stained, long spear
Ares struck it.

But Athena drew back, and with her
broad hand lifted

a dark, rough, mighty stone that men
of an earlier age
had set there as a boundary of the
fields.

With it she struck furious Ares upon
the neck,

and loosed his limbs. Seven acres
covered him as he fell;
the dust rose about his hair, and his
armor clattered.

Pallas Athena laughed and, boasting
over him, spoke:

“Fool! You have not yet learned how
much stronger I claim to be,
since you have matched your
strength against mine.

So may you pay the Furies of your
mother,

who, angered because you
abandoned the Achaeans,
now plots evil for you while you
defend the overweening Trojans.

Thus long ago we should have ceased
from battle

and sacked the well-built city of
Ilium.”

So she spoke; and the white-armed
goddess Hera smiled.

Then Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,
took Ares by the hand,
groaning heavily; and with difficulty
he gathered back his spirit.

When white-armed Hera saw her,
she at once spoke winged words
to Athena, daughter of Zeus who
bears the aegis:

“Ah me, child of the aegis-bearing
Zeus, unwearied one!

There is that dog-faced woman
leading the man-destroyer Ares
away from the furious battle through
the tumult.

Go after her.”

So she spoke; and Athena rushed
after them, glad at heart.

She came close, and with her broad
hand struck Aphrodite
upon the breast; her knees and dear
heart gave way.

Both lay together upon the earth that
feeds all.

Then Athena, exulting, spoke these
winged words:

“Would that all who bring help to
the Trojans were such
whenever they fought the armored
Argives—bold and enduring
as Aphrodite was when she came to
aid Ares,

standing against my strength. Then
long ago we should have
ended the war and sacked the
well-built city of Ilium.”

So she spoke; and the white-armed
goddess Hera smiled.
Then the mighty Earth-shaker
addressed Phoebus Apollo:
“Phoebus, why have we two held
ourselves apart?
It is not fitting when others have
begun.
It would be shameful if we went
unchallenged back to Olympus,
to the bronze-floored house of Zeus.
Begin, since you are younger;
it would not be seemly for me, who
was born first
and know more than you.”
But the far-shooting Apollo
answered him:
“Earth-shaker, you would not call me
sound-minded
if I should fight with you for the sake
of pitiful mortals,
who are like the leaves of trees: for a
time they flourish,
eating the fruit of the field, and for a
time they wither,
without strength. Let us quickly
cease from battle;
let them fight among themselves.
“Have you forgotten all the evils we
two suffered around Ilium,
alone among the gods, when we came
to proud Laomedon
from Zeus and served him for a full
year at a fixed wage,
under whatever orders he gave? I
built for the Trojans
a wall around their city, broad and
very fair,
so that the city might be unbroken;
while you, Phoebus,

kept the long-horned,
twisting-footed cattle of Laomedon
in the folds of woody, many-ridged
Ida.
But when the joyful seasons brought
the wage due at last,
then mighty Laomedon cheated us of
all our payment,
and sent us away with threats. He
threatened to bind
our hands and feet above us, and sell
us beyond the distant islands;
he boasted that he would cut the ears
from both of us with bronze.
So we went back in anger, resentful
of the wage
which he had promised and did not
fulfill.
And now you bring favor to his
people, nor will you join us,
that the overweening Trojans may
perish utterly,
with their children and their
honored wives.”
Then lord Apollo, the far-shooter,
answered him:
“Earth-shaker, you would not call me
sound-minded
if I should fight with you for the sake
of mortals.
They are like leaves: one moment
they burn with life,
feeding upon the harvest of earth;
another they wither,
without a heart. Let us quickly cease
from battle;
let them fight among themselves.”
So he spoke, and turned away; for he
was ashamed

to join battle with his father's
brother in his hands.
His sister, the lady of the wild,
Artemis, rebuked him sharply:
"You flee, far-shooter, and have given
all the victory
to Poseidon, granting him glory for
nothing. Fool!
Why do you carry a useless bow? May
I never hear you again
boasting in our father's halls, as once
you did among
the immortal gods, that you would
fight Poseidon face to face."
So she spoke; but the far-shooter
answered her nothing.
Then the revered wife of Zeus, angry,
rebuked the archer goddess:
"How now? You shameless hound, do
you intend to stand
against me? Hard it is for you to
match my strength,
though you carry the bow; for Zeus
has made you a lion
among women, and granted you to
kill whom you will.
Better it is to destroy wild beasts
upon the mountains,
and the forest deer, than to contend
in strength with the stronger.
But if you wish to learn war, that you
may know clearly
how much stronger I am, since you
match your strength against mine—"

So she spoke, and seized both her
wrists in her left hand;
with her right she took the bow from
her shoulders.
With it she struck her about the ears,
smiling,

as Artemis twisted to and fro; and
the swift arrows fell.
Tearful, the goddess fled beneath her
blows,
as a dove, flying before a hawk, darts
into a hollow rock;
for it was not her fate to be taken. So
she fled in tears
and left her bow there upon the
ground.
Then Hermes, the guide and slayer of
Argus, addressed Leto:
"Leto, I will not fight with you; it is a
hard thing
to box with the wives of Zeus,
gatherer of the clouds.
But among the immortal gods, boast
freely that you defeated me
by your strong might."
So he spoke; and Leto gathered the
curved bow and arrows,
scattered here and there in the
whirling dust,
and went back carrying them to her
daughter.
"Leto, I will not fight with you; it is a
hard thing
to box with the wives of Zeus,
gatherer of clouds.
But among the immortal gods, boast
freely that you defeated me
by your strong might."
So he spoke; and Leto gathered the
curved bow and arrows,
scattered here and there in the
whirling dust,
and went back carrying them to her
daughter.
Artemis came to Olympus, to the
bronze-floored house of Zeus;

weeping, she sat upon her father's
knees, and her ambrosial robe
quivered around her. Her father,
Cronus's son, took her close,
smiling sweetly, and asked her:
"Who has done this to you, dear
child, so rashly,
as though you had been caught
openly in some wrongdoing?"
Then the fair-crowned, loud-voiced
goddess answered him:
"Your wife, white-armed Hera,
father, struck me;
from her arise the strife and quarrels
among the immortals."
While they spoke thus together,
Phoebus Apollo entered holy Ilium;
for his thought was fixed upon the
city's well-built wall,
lest the Danaans should sack it on
that day beyond its fate.
The other gods, who live forever,
went back toward Olympus,
some angry and some greatly
exulting, and sat down beside
their father, wrapped in dark cloud.
But Achilles kept killing
the Trojans themselves, and their
single-hoofed horses with them.
As when smoke rises to the wide
heaven from a city burning,
and the wrath of the gods has lifted
it aloft,
bringing toil to all and many sorrows
upon the people,
so Achilles brought toil and sorrow
upon the Trojans.
The old king Priam stood upon the
tower of the god,

and saw enormous Achilles. Beneath
him the Trojans
were scattered in flight; no courage
remained in them.
The old man groaned, descended
from the tower,
and urged the famous gatekeepers
along the wall:
"Keep the gates open in your hands
until the people reach
the city in their flight; for Achilles is
near,
driving them before him. Now I
think evil will come upon us.
But when they have drawn breath
together within the wall,
close the strong-fitted doors again
upon their sockets;
I fear that this savage man may
spring into the city."
So he spoke; and they opened the
gates and thrust back the bars.
The gates, thrown wide, made a light
before them.
Then Apollo leapt out to meet them,
to ward destruction from the
Trojans.
The Trojans fled straight toward the
city and the high wall,
parched with thirst and thick with
dust from the plain.
Achilles pursued them fiercely with
his spear;
violent fury held his heart, and he
yearned to win the glory.
Then the sons of the Achaeans would
have taken high-gated Troy,
had not Phoebus Apollo stirred the
noble Agenor,

the blameless, mighty son of
Antenor.
Apollo cast courage into his heart,
and stood beside him,
leaning against a beech, and warding
off the heavy hands of death;
he hid him round about in a thick
mist.
When Agenor saw Achilles, the
sacker of cities,
he stood still, and his heart beat hard
as he waited.
Distressed, he spoke to his
great-hearted spirit:
“Woe is me! If I flee before mighty
Achilles,
where the others flee in terror, he
will seize me even so
and cut my throat, helpless as I am.
But if I leave these men
to be driven and scatter from
Achilles, and flee on foot
from the wall toward the plain of
Ilium, until I reach
the lower slopes of Ida and enter the
thickets,
then at evening I could wash away
my sweat in the River
and return at nightfall to Ilium. But
why has my dear spirit
held this argument? He might see me
leaving the city
for the plain, and overtake me with
his swift feet.
Then there would be no escape from
death and destruction;
for he is far stronger than all other
men.
“But if I go forth before the city and
meet him face to face—

his flesh too is vulnerable to the
sharp bronze;
there is one life in him, and men say
that he also is mortal.
Yet Zeus, the son of Cronus, grants
him glory.”
So he spoke, and held his ground;
and a bold heart rose within him
to wage war and fight. As a leopard
comes forth from the deep wood
to face the hunter, and is not
troubled or afraid when it hears
the barking; for even if the hunter is
first to wound or strike it,
the beast, pierced around by the
spear, does not cease from courage
until it has met him or been
subdued—so the noble son of
Antenor,
godlike Agenor, would not flee
before he had tried Achilles.
He held his shield, smooth on every
side, before him,
and aimed his spear at Achilles,
crying loudly:
“Surely in your heart you hope,
glorious Achilles,
to sack the city of the proud Trojans
on this day—fool!
Many sorrows shall still be wrought
around it.
Within it are many men, brave men,
who defend Ilium
before their dear fathers and
mothers, their wives and children.
But here you shall meet your death,
though you are a terrible
and fearless warrior.”
So he spoke, and sent the sharp spear
from his heavy hand;

he struck Achilles beneath the knee
in the shin,
and did not miss. The greave of
newly wrought tin
rang terribly around him; the bronze
leapt back from the blow
and did not pierce it, for the gifts of
a god held it away.

Then the son of Peleus sprang upon
Agenor, his equal in battle;
but Apollo would not yet grant him
the glory.

He snatched Agenor away, wrapped
him in thick mist,
and sent him quietly out of the war.
Then Apollo himself, the far-shooter,
standing before Achilles,
took the exact likeness of Agenor.

Achilles rushed after him,
running at his feet, while Apollo led
him away from the people,
turning him beside the deep-eddying
Scamander,

and running a little ahead of him. By
his deceit Apollo charmed him,
so that always he hoped to catch the
man with his feet.

Meanwhile the other Trojans,
escaping in fear, came gladly
together

to the city, and the city was filled
with them.

They did not dare remain outside the
city and the wall,

to count one another and learn who
had escaped

and who had fallen in battle; but
eagerly they poured into the city,
each one whose feet and knees had
saved him.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 22

First-pass working translation

So the Trojans, fleeing through the city, like young deer,
leaned against the fair battlements,
cooling their sweat,
and drank away their thirst; while
the Achaeans drew nearer
to the wall, their shields slanted
upon their shoulders.

But Hector was held there before the Scaean gates,
by his ruinous fate, before the city of Ilium.

Then Phoebus Apollo spoke to the son of Peleus:

“Why do you pursue me with swift feet, son of Peleus,
yourself a mortal, while I am an immortal god?

You have not yet recognized me as a god,

though you rage on without rest. Do you care so little

for the distress of the Trojans whom you routed,

who have gathered into the city while you wandered here?

You shall not kill me, since death is not appointed for me.”

Swift-footed Achilles answered him in great anger:

“You have harmed me, far-shooter, most destructive of all the gods, turning me away from the wall; otherwise many Trojans would have bitten the earth before they reached Ilium.

Now you have robbed me of great glory, but saved them easily, since you feared no vengeance afterward. I would pay you back, if only I possessed the power.”

So he spoke, and with great thoughts turned toward the city, leaping forward like a racehorse that bears a prize-winning chariot, and runs easily, stretching itself across the plain.

So Achilles drove his swift feet and knees onward.

The old king Priam first saw him with his eyes,
shining across the plain like the star that comes in autumn,
whose rays stand conspicuous among the many stars
in the dead darkness of night—the star they call
the Dog of Orion. Brightest it is among the stars,
yet it is made a baleful sign, and carries a great fever
to suffering mortals. So the bronze flashed around Achilles’ breast as he ran.

The old man groaned, and struck his head with his hands,
raising them high; loudly he cried and begged his dear son.

But Hector stood before the gates, unwearied,
eager to meet Achilles in battle.

The old man stretched out his hands and spoke to him in pity:

“Hector, my dear child, do not wait for this man alone,

apart from the others, lest you
quickly meet your fate,
overcome by the son of Peleus, since
he is far stronger—
that pitiless man. Would that he
were as dear to the gods
as he is to me! Then dogs and
vultures would soon devour him
as he lay dead; and bitter grief would
leave my heart—
he who has made me bereft of so
many sons, brave men,
killing them and selling them beyond
the distant islands.
“Even now I cannot see two of my
sons, Lycaon and Polydorus,
among the Trojans gathered into the
city—sons whom Laothoe,
the lady among women, bore to me.
If they still live among
the army, then we shall ransom them
with bronze and gold;
there is wealth within, for old Altes,
famous by name,
gave much of it to his child. But if
they are already dead
and within the house of Hades, there
will be grief to my heart
and to their mother, who bore them;
but for the other people
the grief will be shorter, unless you
too are killed by Achilles.
“Come inside the wall, my child, that
you may save
the Trojan men and women; and do
not grant great glory
to the son of Peleus, while you
yourself are deprived
of your own beloved life. Have pity
on me, unhappy as I am,

while I still possess my mind—the
doomed old man upon whom
the son of Cronus has laid, at the
threshold of old age,
many cruel things to see: sons
destroyed, daughters dragged away,
bedchambers plundered, and little
children thrown upon the ground
in the hateful tumult; and
daughters-in-law dragged away
by the murderous hands of the
Achaeans.
“And last of all, when someone has
taken my life
with sharp bronze, the ravening dogs
will drag me
before the first gates—those dogs I
raised in my halls,
guardians of the door and feeders at
my table;
they will drink my blood and lie
crazed around the vestibule.
For a young man slain and torn by
sharp bronze,
all things are fitting, whatever
appears before him;
all is beautiful in death. But when
dogs disgrace
the gray head and gray beard of an
old man slain,
and dishonor the naked shame of an
old man—
that is the most pitiful thing for
wretched mortals.”
So the old man spoke; and he tore
the gray hairs from his head,
plucking them with his hands. Yet he
could not move Hector’s heart.
His mother, standing on the other
side, poured out her tears,

opened her breast, and lifted the
other breast toward him.
She shed tears and spoke these
winged words:
“Hector, my child, respect this and
pity me,
if ever I held out my comfort-giving
breast to you.
Remember it, dear child, and defend
yourself from that man
within the wall; do not stand forth
against him.
For if he kills you, I shall never again
mourn you
upon the bed, my beloved child
whom I bore,
nor shall your rich-gifted wife; but
far from us,
beside the ships of the Argives, swift
dogs will devour you.”
Thus the two, weeping, addressed
their dear son,
begging him at length; but they
could not move Hector’s heart.
They wept and pleaded at length; but
they could not move Hector’s heart.
He waited there for enormous
Achilles as he drew near.
As a mountain serpent waits for a
man beside its lair,
having eaten evil herbs, and a
dreadful anger enters it,
while it watches terribly, coiling
about its lair—
so Hector, holding an anger that
would not be quenched,
did not withdraw, but leaned his
shining shield
against the projecting tower.
Distressed, he spoke

to his great-hearted spirit:
“Woe is me! If I enter through the
gates and the wall,
Polydamas will be the first to heap
reproach upon me—
he who urged me to lead the Trojans
toward the city
on this ruinous night, when noble
Achilles rose.
But I would not listen; and it would
have been far better.
Now I have destroyed the people
through my own recklessness.
I am ashamed before the Trojans and
the Trojan women,
lest some lesser man than I should
say hereafter:
‘Hector, trusting in his own strength,
destroyed the army.’
“So they will speak. Then it would be
far better for me
either to meet Achilles face to face
and kill him,
or to perish before the city with
honorable fame.
But what if I lay down my shield
with its central boss,
and my strong helmet, lean my spear
against the wall,
and go out myself to meet blameless
Achilles?
I would promise him Helen and all
the possessions with her,
all that Alexander brought home in
the hollow ships
when he carried her to Troy—the
beginning of strife—
to return to the sons of Atreus, and
with them to divide

among the other Achaeans all the
treasures this city holds.
Then I would take from the Trojan
elders a solemn oath
to hide nothing, but to divide in two
every possession
that this lovely city encloses.
“But why has my dear spirit reasoned
thus?
If I go to him, he will show me no
mercy or respect;
he will kill me naked, unarmed, as
though I were a woman,
once I have laid aside my armor.
There is no longer a way
to converse beside an oak or a rock,
as maiden and young man
converse with one another. Better to
drive the battle together
as swiftly as we may, and learn to
which of us
the Olympian will grant the glory.”
So he pondered, standing still; and
Achilles came near,
like Enyalios, the helmeted god of
war,
shaking the Pelian ash above his
right shoulder,
while the bronze around his body
flashed like the light
of a burning fire or the rising sun.
When Hector saw him, trembling
seized him; he could no longer
endure to remain there, but left the
gates behind in fear.
The son of Peleus rushed after him,
trusting in his swift feet.
As a hawk, swiftest of winged
creatures upon the mountains,

easily launches after a trembling
dove—
the dove flees beneath him, while the
hawk cries sharply
and darts close again and again, its
heart commanding it to seize her—
so Achilles flew straight on in his
fury, and Hector fled
beneath the wall of Troy, driving his
swift knees.
They passed the watchtower and the
wind-bent fig tree,
and sped continually along the
wagon-road beneath the wall.
They reached the clear-flowing
springs; and there two fountains
leap up from the whirling
Scamander.
One flows with warm water, and
smoke rises from it
as though from a burning fire; the
other in summer pours forth
like hail, or cold snow, or water
frozen into crystal.
Beside these fountains lie broad
washing-places,
beautiful, made of stone, where the
lovely wives
and daughters of the Trojans once
washed their shining garments,
in the days of peace, before the sons
of the Achaeans came.
Past these they ran: Hector fleeing
before,
and the great man pursuing behind,
swift-footed.
The noble one fled; the far greater
pursued him eagerly.
For they did not race for a sacrificial
beast or an ox-hide,

such as men set up as prizes in their games;
they ran for the life of Hector,
breaker of horses.
As when swift-footed, prize-winning
horses race around the turning-posts,
and a great prize is laid there—a
tripod or a woman,
the prize for a man who has died—
so the two of them circled the city of
Priam three times
upon their swift feet. All the gods
watched them.
Then the father of men and gods
began to speak among them:
“Ah me! With my own eyes I behold
the man I love pursued
around the wall. My heart grieves for
Hector,
who burned many ox-thighs for me
upon the heights of Ida,
rich in folds, and at other times in
the highest city.
But now noble Achilles pursues him
swiftly around
the city of Priam. Come, gods, take
counsel and consider:
shall we save him from death, or shall
we now let the good man
be mastered by Achilles, son of
Peleus?”
Then the gray-eyed goddess Athena
answered him:
“Father, hurler of the bright thunder,
what is this you say?
Do you wish to loose a mortal man,
long since marked by fate,
back from harsh-sounding death? Do
it; but all the other gods
will not approve your deed.”

Cloud-gathering Zeus answered her:
“Take courage, Tritogeneia, dear
child. I do not speak
with a willing heart, nor do I wish to
be harsh toward you.
Do as your mind has determined; do
not hold back.”
So he spoke, and urged Athena,
already eager for the deed;
she sprang down from the peaks of
Olympus.
Swift Achilles pursued Hector
without rest,
as when a hound in the mountains
chases a fawn,
rousing it from its bed and driving it
through ravines and valleys.
Even if the fawn slips beneath a bush
and crouches,
the hound runs on its scent until it
finds the trail again;
so Hector could not escape the
swift-footed son of Peleus.
Whenever he tried to rush toward
the Dardanian gates
and the well-built towers, hoping the
men above might shield him
with their arrows, Achilles would
always dart across before him
and turn him back toward the plain,
while himself he flew
toward the city. As in a dream one
cannot pursue a fugitive—
neither can the one who flees escape,
nor the pursuer catch him—
so Hector could neither seize
Achilles with his feet,
nor Achilles escape from him.
How could Hector have escaped the
black spirits of death,

unless Apollo, for the final and last
time, had come near him
and stirred his courage and swift
knees?
But noble Achilles shook his head
toward his people
and would not let them hurl their
bitter arrows at Hector,
lest someone else win the glory by
striking him,
and he himself arrive second.
When for the fourth time they
reached the springs,
the father stretched out the golden
scales.
Within them he placed two spirits of
death,
bearing sorrow to its end: one for
Achilles,
and one for Hector, breaker of
horses.
He lifted the scales by their middle;
and Hector's day of fate sank down.
He went away toward the house of
Hades,
and Phoebus Apollo abandoned him.
Then the gray-eyed goddess Athena
came to Achilles,
stood close beside him, and spoke
these winged words:
"Now, I think, beloved of Zeus,
shining Achilles,
we shall carry great glory to the
Achaeans beside the ships,
having slain Hector, insatiable as he
is for battle.
There is no escape for him from us
now,
not even if far-shooting Apollo
should suffer greatly,

crawling in supplication before
father Zeus who bears the aegis.
Stand here now and draw breath,
while I go to him
and persuade him to stand and fight
you face to face."
So Athena spoke; and Achilles
obeyed, glad in his heart.
He stood leaning upon his
bronze-tipped ash spear.
She left him there, and reached noble
Hector,
likened in form to Deiphobus, and
possessing his unwearied voice.
She stood near him and spoke these
winged words:
"My dear brother, surely swift
Achilles presses you hard,
pursuing you with swift feet around
the city of Priam.
Come, let us stand and defend
ourselves where we are."
Then great Hector, the
flashing-helmeted warrior, answered
her:
"Deiphobus, before this you were by
far the dearest
of all the brothers whom Hecuba and
Priam bore;
but now I shall honor you even more
in my heart,
since you dared to come outside the
wall for my sake,
when the others remain within."
Gray-eyed Athena answered him:
"My dear brother, my father and
honored mother pleaded
with me at length, kneeling before
me, and so did my companions,

begging me to remain there—for all
tremble before this man.
But my heart was worn down within
by grievous sorrow.
Now let us go straight on, eager to
fight; let no sparing
of spears be made, so that we may
learn whether Achilles
will kill us both and carry our
blood-stained armor
to the hollow ships, or whether he
will be mastered
by your own spear.”
So she spoke, and by her cunning led
him forward.
When they had come close, Hector,
the great helmeted warrior,
spoke first:
“I shall no longer fear you, son of
Peleus, as before,
when three times I fled around the
great city of Priam,
never daring to stand and await your
coming. But now my heart
has urged me to stand before you; I
shall kill you, or be killed.
Come, let us call the gods to witness,
for they are the best
witnesses and guardians of our
agreements.
I shall not outrage you terribly, if
Zeus grants me strength
and I take your life; but when I have
stripped your famous armor,
Achilles, I shall give your body back
to the Achaeans.
Do the same for me.”
Swift-footed Achilles looked darkly
at him and answered:

“Hector, do not speak to me, you
hateful man, of agreements.
As there are no faithful oaths
between lions and men,
and wolves and lambs do not keep
one mind toward one another,
but think evil continually against
each other,
so there can be no friendship
between you and me,
nor shall there be oaths between us,
until one of us has fallen
and glutted the steadfast warrior
Ares with blood.
Remember now every kind of valor;
for you must be
a spearman and a fearless warrior
today.
There is no escape for you; Pallas
Athena will soon
subdue you by my spear, and now
you shall pay all together
for the grief of my companions,
whom you killed with your spear.”
So he spoke, and hurled his
long-shadowed spear.
Glorious Hector saw it coming and
avoided it;
he had crouched down before it, and
the bronze spear flew over him
and struck the ground. Athena
snatched it up unseen by Hector,
she gave it back to Achilles, and
Hector, shepherd of the people,
did not see her.
Then Hector spoke to the blameless
son of Peleus:
“You missed, Achilles, like a god, and
you did not know from Zeus

my fate—though you said so. You
have proved a smooth-tongued
cheat in words, hoping that I would
fear you and forget my courage.
You shall not drive your spear into
my back as I flee;
drive it straight through my breast as
I come against you,
if the god has granted you that. Now
in turn avoid my bronze spear;
would that you might take the whole
of it into your flesh!
The war would be lighter for the
Trojans if you were dead,
for you are their greatest affliction.”
So he spoke, and hurled his
long-shadowed spear;
it struck the middle of the son of
Peleus’ shield and did not miss.
Far from the shield the spear sprang
away; Hector was angered
that the swift weapon had flown
uselessly from his hand.
He stood there, downcast, and had
no other ash spear.
He called aloud for Deiphobus of the
white shield,
asking him for a long spear; but
Deiphobus was nowhere near him.
Then Hector knew within his heart,
and spoke aloud:
“Ah me! The gods have surely called
me to death.
I thought the hero Deiphobus stood
beside me,
but he is within the wall, and Athena
has deceived me.
Now evil death is close to me, no
longer far away;

and long ago it must have been dear
to Zeus and the far-shooter,
son of Zeus, who once defended me
willingly.
But now fate has overtaken me. Let
me not die without a struggle,
without glory, but after doing some
great deed,
for those yet to come to know.”
So he spoke, drew his sharp sword,
which hung beneath his flank, great
and strong,
and gathered himself like a
high-flying eagle
that plunges through the dark clouds
upon the plain
to seize a tender lamb or a crouching
hare.
So Hector rushed, shaking his sharp
sword.
Achilles came against him, his spirit
filled with savage fury.
Before his breast he held his
beautiful, richly wrought shield;
and upon his shining, four-plated
helmet he nodded,
while the lovely golden tassels
streamed thickly around it—
the plumes Hephaestus had set
densely about the crest.
As the evening star goes among the
stars in the darkness of night,
and stands the fairest star in heaven,
so flashed the point of the sharp
spear Achilles brandished
in his right hand, plotting evil for
noble Hector,
as he searched his fair flesh to find
where it would yield.

But all the rest of his body was held
by the bronze armor,
beautiful armor, which Hector
stripped from Patroclus
when he had killed him by force.
Only where the collarbones hold the
neck from the shoulders,
the throat, where the soul's
destruction is swiftest—
there the noble Achilles drove his
spear upon Hector,
as he rushed against him. The heavy
ash passed straight through
the tender neck; yet the Pelian spear
did not sever the windpipe,
so that Hector could still answer him
with words.
He fell into the dust; and noble
Achilles exulted over him:
“Hector, when you stripped
Patroclus, you thought he would be
safe,
and you showed no fear of me, since I
was far away.
But I, his avenger, much greater than
he, remained behind
beside the hollow ships; I have
loosened your knees.
You the dogs and birds shall drag
away shamefully,
but the Achaeans shall give Patroclus
burial.”
Hector, fainting, the
flashing-helmeted warrior answered
him:
“I beg you by your life, by your knees,
by your parents,
do not let the dogs devour me beside
the ships of the Achaeans.

Accept the bronze and gold in
abundance—gifts your father
and honored mother will give
you—and give my body back home,
that the Trojans and the wives of the
Trojans may grant me fire
when I am dead.”
Swift-footed Achilles looked darkly
at him:
“Do not beg me, dog, by my knees or
by my parents!
Would that my spirit and my heart
could drive me
to cut away your flesh and eat it raw,
for what you have done!
There is no one who could keep the
dogs from your head,
not even if they brought here ten
times and twenty times
the ransom, and promised yet more,
nor even if Priam,
son of Dardanus, should command
them to weigh you out in gold.
Not even then would your honored
mother lay you upon the bed
and mourn the son she bore; dogs
and birds shall divide you whole.”
Hector, dying, answered him:
“I knew you well, and therefore I
look to you without hope;
I was never going to persuade you,
for your heart is iron.
Take care, lest I become the anger of
the gods against you,
on that day when Paris and Phoebus
Apollo shall destroy you,
brave as you are, beside the Scaean
gates.”
So he spoke; and the end of death
covered him.

His spirit flew from his limbs and
went down to Hades,
weeping its fate, leaving its manhood
and youth.

Even dead, noble Achilles addressed
him:

“Die. My own death I shall accept at
whatever time

Zeus and the other immortal gods
may wish to bring it.”

So he spoke, and drew the bronze
spear from the dead man,
and laid it far away; then he stripped
the bloody armor

from Hector’s shoulders. The other
sons of the Achaeans
came running around him; they
gazed upon the stature
and the wonderful beauty of Hector.
Yet no man stood near him
without striking; and one would say,
looking at his neighbor:

“Ah me, Hector is far softer to touch
now

than when he set the ships ablaze
with destructive fire!”

So each would speak, and, standing
near, strike him.

When swift-footed, noble Achilles
had stripped the armor,
he stood among the Achaeans and
spoke these winged words:

“Friends, leaders and rulers of the
Argives,

since the gods have granted us to
master this man,

who wrought as many evils as all the
others together,

come, let us test the city around him
in his armor,

that we may still learn what the
Trojans intend:

will they abandon the high city when
this man has fallen,

or are they resolved to remain,
though Hector is no more?

“But why has my dear spirit reasoned
thus?

There lies beside the ships Patroclus,
unwept and unburied;

I will not forget him while I live and
my knees still move.

And if the dead forget in Hades’
house,

even there I shall remember my
beloved companion.

Come now, young men of the
Achaeans, singing the paean,
let us go back to the hollow ships,
and take this man with us.

We have won great glory: we have
slain noble Hector,
whom the Trojans prayed to through
their city as to a god.”

So he spoke; and he devised shameful
things against noble Hector.

Behind both feet he pierced the
tendons above the ankles,

from heel to heel, and fastened
ox-hide thongs there;

he tied them to the chariot, but left
the head to be dragged.

Then he mounted the chariot, lifted
the famous armor,

and lashed the horses to drive. They
flew forward willingly.

A great cloud of dust rose around the
one being dragged;

his dark hair spread out on either
side,

and his whole head—once so
gracious—lay in the dust.
Then Zeus gave him to his enemies
to dishonor
in his own fatherland.
His mother saw him and tore her
hair from her head;
she cast her shining veil far from her,
and cried aloud when she looked
upon her son.
His dear father groaned, and the
people throughout the city
were seized by wailing and
lamentation.
It seemed most like this: as if all
steep-browed Ilium
were smoldering in fire from its
highest roof.
The people could scarcely restrain
the old man,
who longed to leave through the
Dardanian gates.
He rolled himself in the dung and
pleaded with all of them,
calling each man aloud by name:
“Hold me back, my friends, and leave
me alone,
though you grieve for me. Let me go
out from the city
and reach the ships of the Achaeans.
I shall beg that reckless, mighty
worker of evil—
perhaps he may respect my age and
pity my old age.
For he too has such a father, Peleus,
who begot him and raised him to be
the ruin of the Trojans.
Most of all he has brought grief upon
me.

So many flourishing sons he has
killed!
Yet I do not lament all of them so
greatly,
though I grieve, as I lament one
alone—
Hector, whose sharp grief will carry
me down into Hades.
Would that he had died in my hands!
Then his mother, who bore him, and
I ourselves
would have had enough of weeping
and mourning over him.”
So he spoke, weeping, and the
citizens groaned around him.
Among the Trojan women Hecuba
began the close lament:
“My child, unhappy as I am! Why
shall I live on,
after suffering such things, with you
dead?
You were my pride through night
and day in the city,
and a blessing to all the Trojans and
Trojan women throughout it;
they welcomed you like a god, for
while you lived
you were a great glory to them. But
now death and fate overtake you.”
So she spoke, weeping; but Hector’s
wife had not yet heard.
No truthful messenger had come to
tell her
that her husband remained outside
the gates.
She was weaving within the high
chamber of her house
a double purple mantle, and sewing
many colored flowers into it.

She had called her fair-haired
maidens through the halls
to set a great tripod upon the fire, so
that warm baths
might be ready for Hector when he
returned from battle—
poor woman, not knowing that far
from the baths
gray-eyed Athena had overcome him
beneath Achilles' hands.
Then she heard the cry and wailing
from the tower.
Her limbs spun around, and the
shuttle fell to the ground.
Again she spoke to her well-haired
maidens:
"Come, two of you, follow me, that I
may see what has happened.
I heard the voice of my honored
mother-in-law;
my heart leaps within my breast to
my mouth,
and beneath me my knees are frozen.
Some evil is near the children of
Priam.
Would that the word had fallen far
from my ears!
But I greatly fear that noble Achilles
has cut down
my bold Hector alone, has driven
him from the city
onto the plain, and ended that
grievous pride
which held him, since he never
remained among the crowd of men,
but ran far ahead, yielding his
strength to no one."
So speaking, she rushed from the
chamber like a woman possessed,

her heart beating hard; and the
maidens went with her.
When she reached the tower and the
gathering of men,
she stood upon the wall and looked
around.
There she saw him dragged before
the city;
the swift horses drew him without
pity toward the hollow ships
of the Achaeans. Darkness covered
her eyes;
she fell backward, and her spirit
breathed out.
Far from her head she cast the
shining ornaments:
the headband, the hair-net, the
woven circlet,
and the veil that golden Aphrodite
gave her
on the day when Hector, the
flashing-helmeted warrior,
led her from the house of Eetion,
after bringing countless gifts.
Around her stood her sisters-in-law
and the wives of her brothers;
they held her, as one terrified of
dying.
When she had drawn breath again
and her heart gathered itself,
she began the lament among the
Trojan women:
"Hector, I am wretched! We were
born under one fate,
you in Troy, in Priam's house, and I
in Thebes beneath wooded Placos,
in the house of Eetion, who raised me
while I was still a child—
unhappy, born to an unhappy lot.
Would that he had never begotten

me!

“Now you go to the hidden houses of
Hades beneath the earth,
and leave me a widow in the halls, in
hateful grief.

Our child is still a little one, whom
you and I,

unhappy parents, brought forth.

Neither will you be a help to him,

Hector, since you are dead, nor will
he be a help to you.

For even if he escapes the tearful war
of the Achaeans,

there will always be toil and sorrow
for him afterward;

others will divide the fields that were
his father’s.

“The day of orphanhood makes a
child without companions.

He hangs his head, and tears wet
both his cheeks;

in need, the boy goes to his father’s
companions,

pulling one by the cloak and another
by the tunic.

One of them, moved to pity, gives
him a little cup;

he wets his lips, but does not moisten
his palate.

Then the well-fed child, whose
parents both live,

drives him from the feast with blows
and harsh words:

‘Go away! Your father does not share
a meal with us.’

“The tearful child returns to his
widowed mother,

Astyanax, who once upon his father’s
knees

ate only the marrow and rich fat of
sheep.

When sleep took him and he ceased
his childish crying,

he would sleep in the soft bed, in the
arms of his nurse,

flourishing there and filled with joy.

But now, having lost his beloved
father,

he will suffer many
things—Astyanax,

as the Trojans call him by name—for
you alone

guarded their gates and their long
walls.

“Now the writhing worms beside the
curved ships,

far from his parents, will eat you
when the dogs are sated,

and you will lie naked; while here in
the halls

your garments lie, fine and beautiful,
made by women’s hands.

But I will burn them all in blazing
fire;

they bring no benefit to you, since
you will not lie in them.

Yet they shall be glory for the Trojan
men and women.”

So she spoke weeping, and the
women groaned beside her.

Source range: Book 22. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 23

First-pass working translation

So the Trojans groaned throughout
the city; but the Achaeans,
when they had reached their ships
and the Hellespont,
scattered each man to his own vessel.
Achilles would not let the
Myrmidons scatter,
but spoke among his horse-loving
companions:
“Myrmidons, my eager companions,
do not yet unyoke
the single-hoofed horses from
beneath the chariots.
Let us draw near with horses and
chariots themselves,
and mourn Patroclus; for that is the
honor of the dead.
But when we have satisfied ourselves
with bitter lament,
we shall unyoke the horses and take
our meal here.”
So he spoke; and all together they
groaned, while Achilles led them.
Three times they drove the
fair-maned horses around the dead
man,
mourning him; and Thetis stirred
within them the desire to weep.
The sands were wet with tears, and
the armor of the men
was wet with tears as well; such was
their longing for the leader of flight.
Then the son of Peleus began the
close lament,
laying his man-slaying hands upon
the breast of his companion:

“Farewell, Patroclus, even in the
house of Hades.

I am fulfilling for you all that I
promised before:

I have dragged Hector here, and will
give him raw to the dogs;
and before your pyre I will cut the
throats of twelve

glorious children of the Trojans, in
anger because you are dead.”

So he spoke; and he devised shameful
things against noble Hector,
stretching him face-down in the dust
beside the bed of Menoetius’ son.

The others stripped off their shining
bronze armor,

unharnessed the loud-neighing
horses,

and sat down by the swift son of
Aeacus’ ship,

many thousands of them. Achilles
gave them a noble funeral feast.

Many white cattle bellowed as they
were slaughtered around the steel;
many sheep and bleating goats were
killed;

many white-tusked boars, rich with
fat,

were stretched out and singed across
the fire of Hephaestus.

All around the dead man the blood
ran in streams from the cups.

Meanwhile the Achaean kings led
swift-footed Achilles

to great Agamemnon, persuading
him with difficulty,

for anger at his companion was heavy
upon his heart.

When they reached Agamemnon’s
shelter,

they immediately ordered the
clear-voiced heralds
to set a great tripod upon the fire,
hoping to persuade
the son of Peleus to wash away the
blood and dust.
But he firmly refused, and swore an
oath:
“No, by Zeus, the highest and
greatest of the gods,
it is not right that a bath should
come near my head
before I have laid Patroclus upon the
fire,
raised a mound over him, and cut my
hair.
For no second grief like this shall
ever come to my heart
while I remain among the living.
“But let us now submit to the hateful
meal;
and at dawn, lord Agamemnon,
marshal of men,
stir the army to bring wood, and
have ready all that is fitting
for the dead man to go beneath the
dark mist,
so that tireless fire may burn him
quickly from our eyes
and the people turn again to their
work.”
So he spoke; and they listened closely
and obeyed.
They hastily prepared the meal, each
man at his station,
and ate; nor did any heart lack its
equal share.
When they had satisfied their desire
for drink and food,

the others went away, each man to
his shelter and his bed.
But Achilles lay upon the shore of
the loud-roaring sea,
among the many Myrmidons, in an
open place
where the waves washed over the
beach.
When sweet sleep seized him and
loosened the cares of his heart—
for his shining limbs had grown very
weary
from pursuing Hector toward windy
Ilium—
then the soul of unhappy Patroclus
came to him,
like him in stature, eyes, voice, and
clothing upon his skin.
It stood above his head and spoke
these words:
“You sleep, Achilles, and have
forgotten me.
You did not neglect me while I lived,
but now that I am dead.
Bury me as quickly as you can, that I
may pass through
the gates of Hades. The souls, the
images of the weary dead,
hold me far away; they do not yet
permit me to mingle
with them beyond the River, but I
wander aimlessly
around the broad-gated house of
Hades.
“Give me your hand; I mourn, for I
shall not return again
from Hades once you have granted
me my portion of fire.
We shall never again, alive and apart
from our dear companions,

sit together and plan our counsels;
hateful fate has swallowed me,
the fate that was mine when I was
born.

And for you yourself, godlike
Achilles, there is a fate:
to perish beneath the wall of the
prosperous Trojans.
“I will tell you one more thing, and
charge it upon you,
if you will obey me: do not lay my
bones apart from yours,
Achilles, but together, as we were
raised together
in your house, from the time when
Menoetius brought me
from Opus, still a little child, to your
home,
after I had killed Amphi-damas’ son
unwillingly,
in anger over a game of
knucklebones.
Then horseman Peleus received me
into his house,
raised me tenderly, and named me
your companion.
So let one golden urn, the great
two-handled vessel
that your honored mother gave you,
cover our bones together.”
Swift-footed Achilles answered him:
“Why have you come here, dear
brother, and charged me with each of
these things?
I shall fulfill them all, and obey as
you command.
But come nearer; let us at least for a
little while
embrace one another and take our
fill of bitter mourning.”

So speaking, he reached out with his
dear hands,
but did not take him. The soul, like
smoke, went beneath the earth
with a shrill sound; and Achilles
sprang up in amazement,
clapped his hands together, and
spoke this mournful word:
“Ah me! There is indeed something
in the house of Hades—
a soul and an image—but there is no
mind in it at all.
For all night the soul of unhappy
Patroclus
stood beside me, weeping and
lamenting,
and charged me with every matter; it
was wonderfully like him.”
So he spoke; and he stirred in them
all the desire for lament.
While they mourned, rosy-fingered
Dawn appeared around the pitiable
dead.
Then lord Agamemnon urged the
mules and men
to bring wood from every shelter;
and brave Meriones,
companion of noble Idomeneus, rose
among them.
They went out with axes in their
hands and well-woven ropes,
and the mules went before them.
They climbed and descended,
crossed slopes and level ground, and
turned along the paths.
But when they came to the folds of
many-fountained Ida,
they quickly cut the high-tressed
oaks with sharp bronze.

The trees fell with a great crash; the
Achaean split them,
and tied them behind the mules; the
mules tore up the earth
with their feet as they hurried
through the thick brush,
eager to reach the plain. All the
woodcutters carried logs,
as Meriones, companion of noble
Idomeneus, had commanded.
They threw the timber down in rows
upon the shore,
where Achilles had marked the great
monument for Patroclus
and for himself. When they had cast
down the measureless wood
on every side, they sat and waited,
gathered together.
Then swift-footed Achilles
commanded the war-loving
Myrmidons
to put on their bronze and yoke each
man his horses beneath the cars.
They sprang up, clothed themselves
in armor, and mounted the chariots,
drivers and companions alike; the
horsemen went in front,
and behind them followed a cloud of
footmen, many thousands.
In the midst the companions carried
Patroclus.
They covered the whole dead man
with the hair they had cut;
and behind him noble Achilles held
the head in his hands,
grieving, for he was sending his
blameless companion to Hades.
When they reached the place
Achilles had shown them,

they laid him down and hastily
heaped up the fitting timber.
Then noble, swift-footed Achilles
conceived another thought.
He stood apart from the pyre and cut
off his yellow hair,
which he had let grow thick for the
River Spercheius.
Angered, he looked across the
wine-dark sea and spoke:
“Spercheius, my father Peleus prayed
to you in vain
when he vowed that, if I should
return to my beloved fatherland,
I would cut my hair for you and
perform a holy hecatomb,
and sacrifice there beside your
springs fifty unhorned sheep,
where your precinct and fragrant
altar stand.
So the old man prayed; but you did
not fulfill his thought.
Now, since I shall not return to my
beloved fatherland,
let my hair be carried as a gift to the
hero Patroclus.”
So he spoke, and placed the lock in
the hands of his dear companion;
and he stirred in them all the desire
for lament.
The light of the sun would have gone
down upon their mourning,
if Achilles had not stood near
Agamemnon and spoken:
“Son of Atreus, the Achaean army
will listen to your words
more than to any other. There is a
time to satisfy grief;
now scatter the people from the pyre
and order the evening meal.

But let those remain here who care
most for the dead,
and let them stay beside us.”
When Agamemnon, lord of men,
heard him,
he immediately scattered the people
among their equal ships.
The mourners remained there and
heaped the wood;
they made the pyre a hundred feet in
length on every side,
and set the dead man upon the
highest part,
their hearts full of grief.
Before the pyre they flayed and
tended many strong sheep
and horned, crooked-hoofed cattle.
From all these
great-hearted Achilles took the fat
and covered the dead man
from head to foot; near the bier he
leaned two-handled jars
of honey and oil. Four-necked horses
he cast swiftly
upon the pyre, groaning loudly. Nine
table-dogs
belonged to the lord, and Achilles
cut the throats of two
and cast them upon the fire. Twelve
noble sons of the Trojans
he killed with bronze and threw
upon the pyre—
his heart devising evil things—then
set within it
the iron strength of the fire, that it
might spread.
Afterward he groaned and called his
dear companion:
“Farewell, Patroclus, even in the
house of Hades.

I have fulfilled all that I promised
before:
twelve noble sons of the
great-hearted Trojans
the fire is devouring together with
you.
But Hector, son of Priam, I will not
give to the fire;
I will give him to the dogs.”
So he threatened; but the dogs did
not tear at him.
For Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus,
kept them away,
day and night, and anointed him
with rose-scented,
ambrosial oil, so that Achilles would
not strip his skin
as he dragged him along.
And Phoebus Apollo brought a dark
cloud from heaven
down over the plain, and covered all
the ground
where the dead man lay, so that the
strength of the sun
would not dry his skin and sinews all
around him.
The pyre of Patroclus still would not
burn.
Then noble, swift-footed Achilles
conceived another thought.
He stood apart from the pyre and
prayed to the two winds,
Boreas and Zephyrus, promising
beautiful offerings;
many libations he poured from a
golden cup and entreated them
to come, so that the dead might be
burned swiftly by the blazing fire
and the timber be driven into flame.
Swiftly Iris,

hearing his prayers, came as
messenger to the winds.
They were feasting together in the
house of stormy Zephyrus.
Iris, running, stood upon the
threshold of stone;
when they saw her with their eyes,
they all sprang up
and each called her to himself. But
she refused to sit,
and spoke these words:
“There is no time to sit. I must go
again to the streams of Oceanus,
to the land of the Ethiopians, where
they offer hecatombs
to the immortals, that I too may
share in the holy feast.
But Achilles prays that Boreas and
loud-sounding Zephyrus
will come, and promises beautiful
offerings,
that you may stir the pyre where
Patroclus lies,
whom all the Achaeans mourn.”
So she spoke and departed; and the
winds rose
with wondrous roaring, driving the
clouds before them.
Swiftly they reached the sea, and a
wave rose
under their shrill breath. They came
to fertile Troy,
fell upon the pyre, and the divine fire
cried out loudly.
All night they blew upon the flame
together,
breathing sharply; and swift Achilles
through the night,
taking wine from a golden,
two-handled mixing-bowl,

poured it upon the ground and wet
the earth,
calling upon the soul of unhappy
Patroclus.
As a father mourns the bones of a
son, a bridegroom newly dead,
whose death has brought grief to his
unhappy parents,
so Achilles mourned the bones of his
companion,
creeping around the pyre and
groaning deeply.
When the star that brings the light
goes forth to announce the dawn,
and rosy Dawn spreads above the sea,
then the pyre’s flame faded and the
fire ceased.
The winds turned back again to their
home across the Thracian sea,
and the sea groaned, swelling
beneath them.
Achilles, turning away from the pyre,
lay down exhausted,
and sweet sleep rushed upon him.
But the others gathered around the
son of Atreus;
the murmur and uproar of their
approach awoke him.
He sat upright and spoke to them:
“Son of Atreus, and all you other
leaders of the Achaeans,
first quench the whole fire wherever
the strength of the flame remains,
with bright wine; and afterward let
us gather the bones
of Patroclus, Menoetius’ son,
carefully distinguishing them,
for they are easy to recognize. He lay
in the middle of the pyre,

while the others burned at the edge,
horses and men together.

Let us place them in a golden vessel
and a double fold of fat,
until the time when I too shall lie
hidden in Hades.

“I do not command you to labor over
a great mound,
but only one that is fitting. Later,
when I am gone,
you Achaeans who remain behind
beside the many-oared ships
shall raise it broad and high.”
So he spoke; and they obeyed
swift-footed Achilles.

First they quenched the fire with
bright wine,
wherever the flame had reached; and
the deep ash fell.

Weeping, they gathered the
companion’s white bones
into a golden vessel and a double fold
of fat.

They placed them within the shelter
and covered them
with fine, soft linen. Then they
marked the place of the grave,
laid its foundations around the pyre,
and immediately poured
the heaped earth over it; afterward
they went away.

But Achilles held the people there
and seated them
in a wide assembly. From the ships
he brought forth the prizes:
cauldrons, tripods, horses, mules, the
strong heads of oxen,
women with beautiful girdles, and
gray iron.

For the horsemen he first set forth
splendid prizes:

a woman skilled in fine works, and a
two-handled tripod

holding twenty-two measures, for
the first man;

for the second, a six-year-old mare,
unbroken,

pregnant with a mule foal;
for the third, an untouched cauldron,
beautiful,

white still, holding four measures;

for the fourth, two talents of gold;

and for the fifth, a two-handled cup,
untouched by fire.

Then he stood upright and spoke
among the Argives:

“Son of Atreus, and all you
well-greaved Achaeans—”

“The prizes for the horsemen lie here
in the assembly, ready to be won.

If the Achaeans were now competing
in some other contest,

I myself should take the first and
carry it to my shelter.

You know how far my horses surpass
the others in excellence:

they are immortal, and Poseidon
gave them to my father Peleus,

who in turn gave them to me. But I
shall remain here,

and my single-hoofed horses with
me, for they have lost

their gentle charioteer, whose fame
was great—

the man who often poured soft oil
over them

after washing them in clear water.

They stand there grieving him, their
manes fallen upon the ground,

and the two remain motionless, their hearts heavy with sorrow.

But let the others who trust their horses and well-joined chariots make ready throughout the army.”

So spoke the son of Peleus; and the swift horsemen gathered.

First rose lord Eumelus, beloved son of Admetus,

who was distinguished beyond all men in horsemanship.

After him rose the strong son of Tydeus, Diomedes,

and brought beneath the yoke the Trojan horses

which he had taken from Aeneas, though Apollo saved Aeneas himself.

After him rose golden-haired

Menelaus, son of Atreus,

of Zeus’s line, and brought beneath the yoke his swift horses:

Aethē, Agamemnon’s mare, and his own Podargus.

Aethē was given to Agamemnon by Echeolus, son of Anchises,

as a gift, so that he would not have to follow the army

to windy Ilium, but might remain at home in pleasure;

Zeus had granted him great wealth, and he dwelt in broad Sicyon.

Menelaus brought her beneath the yoke, though she strained to hold back the rush of the race.

Antilochus, fourth, harnessed his thick-maned horses,

the shining son of Nestor, great-hearted ruler,

son of Neleus. His horses, born in Pylos,

carried his swift chariot. His father stood near him

and spoke with good counsel to his thoughtful son:

“Antilochus, though you are young, Zeus and Poseidon

have loved you, and taught you every kind of horsemanship;

there is little need for me to teach you, since you know well

how to turn around the turning-post.

But your horses

are slowest to run, and I fear this will bring you ruin.

The horses of the others are swifter, but the men themselves

know no more cleverness than you.

Come, put every kind

of cunning into your heart, so that the prize may not escape you.

“The woodcutter is not so much aided by strength as by skill,

nor does the helmsman with skill alone guide his swift ship

through the wine-dark sea when the winds beat upon it;

so skill lets charioteer surpass charioteer.

The man who trusts his horses and chariot,

and turns carelessly far out along the course,

lets the horses wander and does not hold them back.

But the man who knows how to drive even weaker horses

keeps his eyes forever upon the turning-post,

turns close beside it, and does not forget

how at the beginning to stretch the
hide reins.
“I shall tell you a sign that will be
plain,
and you will not fail to see it. A dry
stump stands there,
about a fathom above the ground, of
oak or pine;
rain has not rotted it. Two white
stones stand against it
on either side, where the roads meet,
and the race-course
is smooth around it. It may be the
monument of a man
long dead, or it may once have been a
turning-post
set there by men of former days; now
swift Achilles
has made it the turning-point.
“Drive as close to it as you can, with
chariot and horses;
lean yourself in the well-woven car
toward the left,
but spur the right-hand horse, crying
aloud,
and give him the reins to yield in
your hands.
Let the left-hand horse draw close to
the turning-post,
so that the wheel’s rim may seem
almost to graze its edge.
But beware the stone, lest you wound
your horses
and break the chariot; that would
delight the others
and bring shame upon you.
Therefore be prudent and watchful.
“For if, driving in pursuit, you pass
the turning-post,

there is no one who could catch you
by rushing forward,
nor pass you—not even if behind you
he drove noble Arion,
Adrastus’s swift horse, born from a
god,
or the horses of Laomedon, the
excellent ones
that were raised here.”
So spoke Nestor, son of Neleus, and
sat back in his place,
having told his son every limit of the
course.
Meriones, fifth, harnessed his
thick-maned horses.
They mounted the chariots and cast
lots;
Achilles shook them, and the lot
sprang out for Nestor’s son,
Antilochus. Next the lot fell to lord
Eumelus;
after him, Menelaus, famous with the
spear;
then Meriones received the turn to
drive;
and last, though by far the best,
Diomedes received the lot.
They stood in line, and Achilles
marked the turning-post
far off in the smooth plain. Beside it
he set Phoenix,
his father’s godlike companion, to
watch the race
and report the truth of what was
done.
All together they lifted their whips
above the horses,
struck them with the reins, and
urged them with their voices.

Swiftly they flew across the plain, far
from the ships;
the dust rose beneath their breasts
like a cloud or storm,
and their manes streamed backward
in the breathing wind.
Now the chariots touched the earth,
now sprang upward;
the drivers stood within their cars,
and each man's heart
beat hard with desire for victory.
Each called to his horses,
and they flew through the dust across
the plain.
But when the swift horses completed
the last stretch
and turned again beside the gray sea,
then each man's skill appeared, and
the horses stretched their speed.
Swiftly the horses of the son of
Pheres, Eumelus,
came racing ahead; after them came
the stallions of Diomedes,
the Trojan horses, and they were not
far away,
but very near. They seemed always
about to leap
upon the back of Eumelus's chariot;
their breath warmed his broad back
and shoulders,
for they held their heads above him
as they flew.
The son of Tydeus would have
passed him or made the race even,
if Phoebus Apollo had not grown
angry with him
and knocked the shining whip from
his hands.
Tears poured from his eyes in anger,

because he saw the other horses
running yet more swiftly,
while his own were checked without
the goad.
But Apollo did not escape the notice
of Athena;
she quickly came after the shepherd
of the people,
gave the whip back to him, and put
strength into his horses.
She went in anger after the son of
Admetus,
and broke his horse's yoke. The
horses ran apart
from the course, and the pole fell
loose upon the ground.
Eumelus himself rolled out beside
the wheel;
his elbows, mouth, and nostrils were
torn,
his brow was battered above the eyes,
his eyes filled with tears, and his
strong voice was stopped.
Diomedes turned his single-hoofed
horses aside,
and sprang far ahead of the others;
for Athena
had put strength into his horses and
set glory upon him.
After him came golden-haired
Menelaus, son of Atreus.
Antilochus called to his father's
horses:
"Come on, both of you; stretch
yourselves as swiftly as you can.
I do not command you to race those
horses of Diomedes,
the son of Tydeus, to whom Athena
has now given speed

and placed the glory upon him. But
reach the horses
of the son of Atreus; do not let the
mare Aethē,
though she is female, pour shame
upon you by falling behind.
Why do you lag, when you are the
better horses?
“For I tell you this, and it shall surely
be fulfilled:
there will be no more care of you
beside Nestor, shepherd of the
people;
he will kill you with sharp bronze, if
through our carelessness
we carry home a lesser prize.
Therefore follow and hasten.
I myself will devise and think how to
pass them
at the narrow place, and the chance
shall not escape me.”
So he spoke; and the horses, afraid of
their master’s cry,
ran harder for a little while. Soon
strong-hearted Antilochus
saw the narrow place in the road.
There was a hollow where winter
rain had broken through the earth
and torn away the road, deepening
the whole ground.
Menelaus was guiding there,
avoiding the wheel-tracks.
But Antilochus turned his
single-hoofed horses outside the
road,
and drove after him, swerving only a
little.
Then the son of Atreus grew afraid
and cried to Antilochus:

“Antilochus, you drive without
wisdom; hold back your horses!
The road is narrow, but soon it will
be wider, and you may pass.
Take care lest, striking both chariots,
you harm us—”
But Antilochus drove on, pressing
them with the goad,
as though they could not hear him.
The distance between them
was no greater than the reach of a
discus when a young man,
testing his strength, hurls it from his
shoulder.
So far the horses ran ahead; but
Menelaus himself
had willingly let them go, lest the
single-hoofed horses
should meet upon the road and
overturn the well-woven cars,
and the drivers fall in their eager
struggle for victory.
Then, rebuking him, golden-haired
Menelaus spoke:
“Antilochus, no other mortal is more
destructive than you.
Go, since the Achaeans have never
called you wise.
Yet even so you shall not carry off
the prize without an oath.”
So he spoke, and called to his horses:
“Do not hold back or stand there
grieving.
The feet and knees of those horses
will tire before yours;
both teams are deprived of youth.”
So he spoke; and, fearing their lord’s
cry,
the horses ran harder, and soon drew
near.

The Argives, seated in the assembly,
watched the horses
flying over the plain and raising dust.
First Idomeneus, leader of the
Cretans, recognized them;
he sat outside the assembly on a high
lookout.
Although he was far away, he heard
the caller's voice,
and recognized the conspicuous
horse running in front—
the horse that was chestnut
everywhere else,
but bore a round white mark upon
its brow,
like the full moon.
He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:
“Friends, leaders and rulers of the
Argives,
do I alone see these horses, or do you
also see them?
Other horses seem to me to be ahead,
and another driver appears to be
leading them.
The horses that led at first have
surely been harmed
somewhere upon the plain; I saw
them first
turning beside the post, but now I
cannot see them.
My eyes search everywhere across the
Trojan plain.
Perhaps the driver let the reins slip
from his hands,
and could not hold them well around
the turning-post;
I think he fell out there and broke his
chariot.

The mares run on, after gathering
their strength.
Rise and look for yourselves; I
cannot see clearly.
The man seems to me to be Aetolian
by birth,
the strong son of Tydeus, Diomedes,
who rules among the Argives.”
Swift Ajax, son of Oileus, rebuked
him:
“Idomeneus, why are you so loud in
your talk?
The horses are still far away, leaping
over the broad plain.
You are not so young among the
Argives,
nor do the eyes in your head look so
sharply.
Yet you are always boastful in
speech;
it is not fitting for you to be a
loud-talker,
since there are better men here.
Those are the same mares as before,
Eumelus's own,
and he himself holds the reins and
drives among them.”
The Cretan leader answered him
angrily:
“Ajax, best at quarrel, witless in all
things,
you fall short of the Argives in
everything
because your mind is harsh. Come,
let us wager
a tripod or a cauldron, and make
Agamemnon
judge between us, so that you may
learn by paying
which horses are first.”

So he spoke; and swift Ajax, son of
Oileus,
rose at once, angry and eager to
answer him with harsh words.
The quarrel would have grown still
further between them
if Achilles himself had not risen and
spoken:
“Do not answer one another now
with bitter words,
Ajax and Idomeneus; it is not seemly.
It would be shameful if anyone else
behaved so.
Stay seated in the assembly and
watch the horses;
they will soon arrive here themselves,
running for victory.
Then each of you will know which
horses of the Argives
are second, and which were ahead
before.”
So he spoke. Then Diomedes, son of
Tydeus, came near,
driving hard and ever lashing
downward with the whip.
His horses leapt high and quickly ran
their course.
Drops of dust struck the charioteer
again and again;
the chariot, thickly plated with gold
and tin,
ran after the swift-footed horses, and
no broad trail
of wheel marks rose behind them in
the fine dust.
They came to the center of the
assembly;
the horses poured heavy sweat from
mane and breast.

The strong Sthenelus leapt down
from the shining chariot,
leaned the whip against the yoke,
and did not miss his prize.
He gave the woman and the
two-handled tripod
to his proud companions to carry;
but he himself unyoked the horses.
After him Antilochus drove the
horses of Neleus's son,
passing Menelaus by cunning, not by
speed.
Yet Menelaus kept his swift horses
very near him.
As far as the horse of a chariot stands
from its wheel,
when it draws its lord across the
plain with the car,
so that the tips of its tail hairs brush
the wheel,
and it runs close, with little space
between it
and the wheel racing over the wide
plain—
so far Menelaus was behind noble
Antilochus.
At first he had been left farther back,
almost as far
as a discus can be thrown, but
quickly he reached him again;
for the fine-maned Aethē,
Agamemnon's mare,
gave him fresh strength. If the road
had been longer
for both of them, he would have
passed him,
and the race would not have been in
doubt.
Meriones, good companion of
Idomeneus,

was behind glorious Menelaus by the length of a spear-cast.

His fine-maned horses were slowest, and he himself was least skilled at driving in the assembly.

The son of Admetus came last of all, dragging his beautiful chariot and driving his horses before him.

Swift-footed noble Achilles saw him and pitied him.

He stood among the Argives and spoke these words:

“The best man comes last, driving his single-hoofed horses.

Come, let us give him a prize that is fitting for second place;

but let the son of Tydeus carry off the first.”

So he spoke; and all approved his command.

They would have given Eumelus the mare,

for the Achaeans approved the thought,

if Antilochus, great-hearted son of Nestor,

had not risen and answered Achilles in justice:

“Achilles, I shall be very angry with you if you fulfill this word.

You intend to take away my prize because his chariot and swift horses were harmed, though he himself is an excellent man.

He should have prayed to the immortal gods;

then he would not have come last in pursuit.

But if you pity him and he is dear to your heart,

there is much gold in your shelter, bronze, sheep,

serving women, and single-hoofed horses.

Take from these and give him a greater prize,

even now, so that the Achaeans may praise you.

But I will not give up this mare; let any man among us

who wishes to fight me with his hands contend for her.”

Swift-footed Achilles smiled, glad for Antilochus,

because he was a dear companion, and answered him:

“Antilochus, if you command me to give Eumelus something else from my own shelter, I shall do that as well.

I will give him the bronze breastplate I stripped from Asteropaeus,

the armor around which a bright casing of tin is coiled;

it will be worth much to him.”

So he spoke, and commanded his dear companion Automedon to bring it from the shelter.

Automedon went and brought it; Achilles placed it in the hands of Eumelus,

who received it gladly.

Then Menelaus rose, grieving in his heart,

and was fiercely angry with Antilochus.

The herald placed the staff in his hand

and ordered the Argives to be silent.

Menelaus, a man like the gods, spoke:

“Antilochus, what have you done?
You were thought wise before,
but you have shamed my skill and
harmed my horses,
driving your own horses before mine,
though they were far worse.
Come, leaders and rulers of the
Argives, judge fairly between us;
do not favor either side, lest one of
the bronze-clad Achaeans say:
‘Menelaus used lies and force against
Antilochus,
and went away with the mare,
though his horses were much worse,
while he himself was superior in skill
and strength.’
If you wish, I myself will judge, and I
say no other Danaan
will rebuke me; my judgment shall be
straight.
“Antilochus, son of Zeus, come here,
as justice requires.
Stand before your horses and
chariot,
holding in your hands the slender
whip with which you drove before;
lay your hand upon the horses and
swear by Earth-shaking Poseidon
that you did not deliberately block
my chariot by guile.”
Then thoughtful Antilochus
answered him:
“Hold back now, lord Menelaus; I am
far younger than you,
and you are older and better. You
know what excesses
belong to a young man: his mind is
quick,
and his judgment is light. Therefore
let your heart endure.

I will give you the mare I won for
myself.
Even if you should ask some greater
thing from my shelter,
I would give it to you at once, rather
than fall forever
from your heart, son of Zeus, and
become guilty before the gods.”
So he spoke, and led the mare and
placed her in Menelaus’s hands.
Menelaus’s heart was refreshed, as
dew lies upon the ears of grain
when the field is ripening and the
crops bristle;
so, Menelaus, your heart was
refreshed.
He spoke to Antilochus:
“Antilochus, now I myself will yield
to you in anger,
since you were not a reckless or
senseless man before;
but now youth overcame your
judgment.
In the future avoid deceiving better
men.
No other Achaean could have
persuaded me so quickly.
But you and your good father and
brother have suffered much
for my sake; therefore, when you beg
me, I will obey.
I will give you the mare, though she
is mine,
so that these men may know that my
heart is never
overbearing or pitiless.”
So he spoke, and gave the mare to
Noemon,
the companion of Antilochus, to lead
away;

and Eumelus took the shining
cauldron.
Eumelus took the shining cauldron;
Meriones lifted
two talents of gold, fourth in the
race.
The fifth prize remained, the
two-handled cup.
Achilles carried it through the
assembly of the Argives
and gave it to Nestor, speaking as he
stood beside him:
“Here, old man; let this be a treasure
kept by you,
a memorial of Patroclus’s burial. You
will never again
see him among the Argives. I give
you this prize
without a contest, for you will not
box,
nor wrestle, nor enter the
spear-throwing,
nor run upon your feet; grievous old
age presses you now.”
So speaking, he placed it in his
hands; and Nestor received it gladly,
and answered him:
“Yes, my child, you have spoken all
these things in due measure.
My limbs are no longer firm, nor my
feet, nor do my hands
spring lightly from either shoulder.
Would that I were young again,
and my strength as it was when the
Epeians buried lord Amarynceus
in Buprasium, and the sons of the
king appointed prizes for him!
Then no man was my equal, neither
among the Epeians,

nor among the Pylians, nor among
the great-hearted Aetolians.
In boxing I defeated Clytomedes, son
of Enops;
in wrestling I overcame Ancaeus of
Pleuron, who rose against me;
I outran noble Iphiclus on my feet;
and with the spear I surpassed
Phyleus and Polydorus.
“Only the two sons of Actor passed
me with their horses,
throwing themselves ahead by the
crowd’s favor,
for the greatest prizes had been left
there.
They were twins: one held the reins
steadily,
while the other urged the horses with
the whip.
Such was I once; now let younger
men contend
in such contests; and I must obey
grievous old age,
though then I stood forth among the
heroes.
Go now, and honor your companion
with these games.
I receive this gift willingly, and my
heart rejoices
that you remember me always, and
do not forget the honor
that it is fitting I should have among
the Achaeans.
May the gods give you a fitting
reward in return.”
So he spoke; and the son of Peleus
went through the great crowd
of Achaeans, having heard all the
praise of Neleus’s son.

Then he set out other prizes for the
grievous boxing match:
a hard-working mule, six years old,
unbroken,
and tied her in the middle of the
assembly;
for the defeated man he placed a
two-handled cup.
He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:
“Son of Atreus, and all you
well-greaved Achaeans,
we call upon two men to rise and
contend for these prizes,
lifting their fists and striking one
another.
To whichever man Apollo grants
enduring strength,
and all the Achaeans recognize as
victor,
let him lead the hard-working mule
back to his shelter;
but the defeated man shall carry
home the cup.”
So he spoke; and at once Epeius rose,
handsome and great, the son of
Panopaeus,
skilled in boxing. He grasped the
hard-working mule
and spoke aloud:
“Let whoever will come near to carry
away the cup.
I say no other Achaean will lead the
mule away
by defeating me in boxing; I claim to
be the best.
Is it not enough that I fall short in
battle?
It was never possible for one man to
know every task.

But I tell you this, and it shall surely
be fulfilled:
I will break his flesh and crush his
bones face to face.
Let those who care for him remain
gathered here;
they will carry him away when he is
overcome beneath my hands.”
So he spoke; and all became silent.
Only Euryalus rose against him, a
man like the gods,
son of Mekisteus, son of the lord
Talaius,
who once came to Thebes at the
burial of Oedipus,
and there defeated all the Cadmeans.
The famous son of Tydeus stood
beside him,
encouraging him with words and
desiring greatly
that he should win. First he set a belt
around his waist,
and afterward gave him gloves, well
cut from the hide
of a wild ox.
When the two had girded
themselves, they went into the
middle
of the assembly, raised their strong
hands,
and rushed together, their heavy fists
meeting.
The terrible grinding of their jaws
arose;
sweat streamed from every limb.
Then noble Epeius sprang upon him,
and struck the watching Euryalus
upon the cheek.
He could not stand there long; his
shining limbs gave way.

As when a fish leaps upon a
seaweed-covered shore
under the shuddering blast of Boreas,
and the black wave covers it—
so Euryalus leapt beneath the blow.
But great-hearted Epeius seized him
and raised him;
his dear companions stood around
him,
and led him through the assembly,
his feet dragging,
spitting thick blood and letting his
head fall to one side.
They seated him among them, dazed;
then they themselves went and
carried away the two-handled cup.
The son of Peleus immediately set
out other prizes,
the third, to display the painful art of
wrestling:
for the victor, a great tripod for
setting upon the fire,
valued by the Achaeans at twelve
oxen;
for the defeated man he brought into
the middle a woman,
skilled in many works, and valued at
four oxen.
He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:
“Rise, you who will also make trial of
this prize.”
So he spoke; and great Telamonian
Ajax rose,
and resourceful Odysseus rose,
knowing every advantage.
They girded themselves and went
into the middle of the assembly,
then seized one another around the
waist with strong hands,

as when the beams of a high house
are joined by a famous builder
to guard it against the violence of the
winds.
Their backs creaked, pulled tightly
by their powerful hands;
sweat streamed down them,
and many red welts rose along their
ribs and shoulders,
as they both forever desired victory
for the wrought tripod.
Neither Odysseus could throw the
other upon the ground,
nor Ajax; for the strong force of
Odysseus held firm.
But when they had begun to weary
the well-greaved Achaeans,
great Telamonian Ajax spoke to him:
“Divine son of Laertes, resourceful
Odysseus,
either lift me, or I will lift you; and
let Zeus care for the rest.”
So he spoke, and lifted him; but
Odysseus did not forget his cunning.
He struck him from behind upon the
hollow of the knee,
loosed his legs, and threw him
backward.
Odysseus fell upon his breast, and
the people looked on,
astonished and admiring.
Then long-suffering noble Odysseus
lifted Ajax in his turn;
he stirred him a little from the
ground, but could not raise him.
He bent one knee, and both men fell
upon the earth together,
close beside one another, and were
soiled with dust.

They would have sprung up and
wrestled for a third time,
if Achilles himself had not risen and
held them back:
“Do not strain yourselves any longer
or wear yourselves down
with harm. Victory belongs to you
both. Take equal prizes and go,
so that the other Achaeans may also
compete.”
So he spoke; and they listened closely
and obeyed.
They wiped the dust away and put
their tunics on again.
Then the son of Peleus swiftly set out
other prizes for speed:
a silver mixing-bowl, beautifully
wrought, holding six measures.
In beauty it surpassed all vessels
throughout the land,
for the many-skilled Sidonians had
fashioned it well;
Phoenician men had brought it
across the misty sea,
set it in harbors, and given it as a gift
to Thoas.
The son of Jason, Euneus, gave it as
the price
of Lycaon, son of Priam, to Patroclus
the hero.
Achilles set it forth as the prize for
the swiftest runner.
For the second he set a great ox, rich
with fat;
and for the last he placed half a
talent of gold.
He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:
“Rise, you who will make trial of this
prize.”

So he spoke; and swift Ajax, son of
Oileus, rose at once;
resourceful Odysseus rose after him;
and then Antilochus,
son of Nestor, for he surpassed all
the young men with his feet.
They stood in line, and Achilles
marked the turning-point.
From the line Ajax sprang first;
noble Odysseus rose after him,
very close, as close as a woman’s
loom-measuring rod lies
against her breast when she stretches
it carefully with her hands,
drawing the shuttle from the thread
and holding it close to her chest.
So Odysseus ran close behind him,
and struck the tracks
with his feet before the dust could
settle;
as he ran swiftly, his breath fell upon
Ajax’s head and shoulders.
All the Achaeans cried aloud for
victory,
urging him on as he hastened.
When they were completing the last
part of the course,
Odysseus prayed within his heart to
gray-eyed Athena:
“Hear me, goddess; come as a good
helper to my feet.”
So he prayed; and Pallas Athena
heard him.
She made his limbs light, his feet and
hands above.
But when they were about to spring
upon the prize,
Ajax slipped as he ran—for Athena
harmed him.

He slipped where the dung of the
bellowing cattle lay scattered,
the cattle swift-footed Achilles had
slain for Patroclus.

The dung filled his mouth and his
nostrils.

But long-suffering, noble Odysseus
seized the mixing-bowl first,
while glorious Ajax took the ox.

He stood holding the horn of the
wild ox in his hands,

spitting out the dung, and spoke
among the Argives:

“Ah me, the goddess harmed my
feet—she who, like a mother,
has always stood beside Odysseus
and helped him.”

So he spoke; and all laughed sweetly
over him.

Smiling, Antilochus carried off the
last prize and spoke:

“I will tell you something you all
know: even now the immortals
honor older men. Ajax is only a little
older than I am,
but this other is of an earlier
generation,
of men who lived before; they call
him an old man.

It is hard for an Achaeon to contend
with him on foot,
unless it is Achilles.”

So he spoke, and praised the
swift-footed son of Peleus.

Achilles answered him with winged
words:

“Antilochus, your praise shall not be
without reward;

I will add to it half a talent of gold.”

So he spoke, and placed it in his
hands;

and Antilochus received it gladly.

Then the son of Peleus brought into
the assembly

the long-shadowed spear, the shield
and helmet,

and the armor of Sarpedon, which
Patroclus had stripped from him.

He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:

“We call upon two men, the best, to
contend for these things.

Let them put on the armor that cuts
the flesh,

take bronze, and try one another
before the crowd.

Whichever first reaches the fair flesh
of the other,

touches the entrails through the
armor,

and draws dark blood, shall receive
this silver-studded sword,

the beautiful Thracian weapon I
stripped from Asteropaeus.

But let both men carry away this
armor as a common prize,
and we shall prepare a noble meal for
them in our shelters.”

So he spoke; and great Telamonian
Ajax rose,

and strong Diomedes, son of Tydeus,
rose.

They armed themselves on opposite
sides of the crowd,

then came together into the middle,
eager to fight,

with terrible eyes; and all the
Achaeans were held in wonder.

When they had come close, they
rushed three times
against one another, and three times
drew back.
Ajax struck the shield, smooth in
every direction,
but did not reach the flesh; the
corslet held the blow within.
But the son of Tydeus continually
reached above the great shield
with the point of his shining spear,
always toward the neck.
Then the Achaeans, afraid for Ajax,
told them to cease,
and to take equal prizes.
The hero gave Diomedes the great
sword,
with its sheath and well-cut baldric.
Then the son of Peleus set a solid
mass of iron
in the assembly, the same that
mighty Eetion
had once used to hurl with all his
strength;
but swift-footed Achilles killed him,
and brought the iron aboard the
ships with his other possessions.
He stood upright and spoke among
the Argives:
“Rise, you who will also make trial of
this prize.
Even if a man’s fields lie far away and
are rich,
this will sustain him for five circling
years;
his shepherd and plowman will not
lack iron,
but it will supply them.”
So he spoke; and strong Polypoetes
rose,

and the strength of godlike Leonteus
rose,
and Telamonian Ajax, and noble
Epeius.
They stood in line; and noble Epeius
took the mass,
whirled it, and cast it. All the
Achaeans laughed.
Leonteus, branch of Ares, threw
second.
Great Telamonian Ajax cast third
from his strong hand,
and sent it beyond all the marks.
But when Polypoetes, steadfast in
battle, took the mass,
he threw it as far as a shepherd
throws his curved staff
through the herd of cattle; it flew
beyond the whole assembly,
and the people shouted.
The companions of strong
Polypoetes rose
and carried his prize to the hollow
ships of their king.
Then the son of Peleus set out iron
for the archers:
ten axes, and ten half-axes.
Far off upon the sand he planted the
mast
of a dark-prowed ship, and tied a
trembling dove
by the foot with a slender cord.
He commanded them to shoot at it:
“Whoever strikes the trembling dove
shall carry all the axes
back to his shelter; but whoever
misses the bird
and hits only the cord, since he is the
weaker archer,
shall carry home the half-axes.”

So he spoke; and the strength of
Teucer rose first,
and good Meriones, companion of
Idomeneus, rose after him.
They shook lots in a bronze helmet;
Teucer's lot came first.
At once he shot strongly, but did not
promise
to sacrifice a glorious hecatomb of
first-born lambs
to the lord of the bow.
He missed the bird—for Apollo
begrudged him that—
but struck the cord beside its foot;
the bitter arrow cut through the
cord.
The bird flew upward toward
heaven,
while the cord fell upon the earth;
and the Achaeans shouted.
Meriones eagerly drew the bow from
his hand;
he had long held the arrow ready as
he aimed.
At once he vowed to far-shooting
Apollo
that he would offer a glorious
hecatomb of first-born lambs.
High beneath the clouds he saw the
trembling dove,
and struck her as she wheeled
beneath the wing.
The arrow passed straight through
her;
it fell and fixed itself in the earth
before Meriones's feet,
while the bird sat upon the mast of
the dark-prowed ship,
her neck hanging down, her dense
wings drooping.

Swiftly her spirit flew from her
limbs,
far from her; and the people looked
on in wonder.
Meriones lifted all ten axes,
while Teucer carried the ten
half-axes to the hollow ships.
Then the son of Peleus brought forth
a long-shadowed spear
and a cauldron, untouched by fire,
worth an ox,
and set them in the assembly. The
spear-men rose:
wide-ruling Agamemnon, son of
Atreus,
and Meriones, good companion of
Idomeneus.
Then swift-footed Achilles addressed
them:
“Son of Atreus, we know how far you
stand above all men,
and how much you surpass them in
strength and skill.
Take this prize, the cauldron, and
carry it to the hollow ships;
but let us give the spear to the hero
Meriones,
if you are willing in your heart. So I
command.”
So he spoke; and Agamemnon, lord
of men, did not refuse.
He gave the bronze spear to
Meriones;
and the hero gave the beautiful prize
to the herald Talthybius.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 24

First-pass working translation

The games were loosed; the people,
each to his swift ship,
scattered to take his supper and the
gift of sleep.
But Achilles remembered his beloved
companion,
and sleep, the conqueror of all,
would not receive him.
He turned from side to side, recalling
Patroclus—
his manhood and his strength, and
all they had endured,
the wars of men, the grievous
crossings of the sea.
Remembering these things, he let the
living tears fall,
now on his side recumbent, now
upon his back,
now on his face; then rising upright,
paced unresting
beside the shore; nor did the dawn
escaping over sea
and shore elude his eyes. And when
he had yoked beneath
the car his swift-hoofed horses, he
made Hector fast
behind the chariot, and three times
around the tomb
of Menoetius' dead son dragged him;
then again
he rested in his hut, and left the body
stretched
face downward in the dust. But
Phoebus kept from Hector
all dishonor, pitying him even in
death;

with the golden aegis all around his
flesh he covered him,
lest Achilles, dragging him, should
tear the skin.

Thus in his fury Achilles dishonored
noble Hector;
but the blessed gods, beholding,
pitied him,
and urged the clear-eyed Slayer of
Argus to steal him away.

All this was pleasing to the other
gods; but never
to Hera, nor Poseidon, nor the
gray-eyed Maid,
for still they held the sacred city and
Priam hateful,
and all his people, for the ruin
wrought by Alexander,
who scorned the goddesses when
they came into his court
and praised the one who gave him
that destructive desire.

But when the twelfth dawn rose,
then Phoebus spoke among
the immortals: "Cruel gods, and gods
of harm! Was Hector
never the one to burn for you the
thigh-bones of oxen,
and goats without defect? Yet now
you will not save him,
though he is dead, that his wife and
mother may behold him,
his child, and aged Priam, and the
people of Troy,
who would soon burn him in fire and
give him burial rites.

No—rather you would serve
destructive Achilles,
whose heart is not made right, nor
has a mind that bends,

but knows the savage law, as knows
the lion who yields
to neither strength nor proud heart
when he springs among
the flocks of mortal men, to seize his
meal.
So Achilles has destroyed all pity;
shame, which harms
and helps mankind in turn, finds no
dwelling in his breast.
Yet some man loses one still
dearer—brother, child—
and, having wept and mourned, at
last lets go;
for the relentless Fates have made the
mortal heart
enduring. But Achilles, after taking
Hector's life,
still binds him to the tomb of his
beloved companion
and drags him. This is neither fair
nor good for him.
Though he is brave, let us not be
angry with him:
he dishonors only the mute earth in
his fury."
White-armed Hera answered,
angered: "Silver-bowed,
your word might stand, if Hector
and Achilles shared
one honor. Hector was mortal, and a
woman gave him suck;
but Achilles is the child of a goddess,
whom I myself
nursed and adorned, and gave as
bride to Peleus,
the man beloved among immortals.
You all came to the wedding;
and there you feasted, holding your
lyre, false friend."

Then cloud-gathering Zeus answered
her: "Do not be wholly
enraged against the gods, Hera. Their
honor shall not be one;
yet Hector was the dearest of the
men in Ilium to the gods,
as he was dear to me, for never did he
fail in gifts.
My altar never lacked its equal feast,
libation, or smoke—
the honor that we have received. Let
us leave the stealing
of Hector; it cannot be done unseen
from Achilles:
his mother stands beside him, night
and day alike.
But let some god call Thetis nearer
to me, that I may speak
a careful word: Achilles shall receive
the gifts from Priam,
and release Hector from his hands."
So he spoke, and Iris, swift as a
storm-wind, rose
to carry the message. Between steep
Samos and Imbros
she leapt into the dark sea; the water
groaned beneath her.
Like lead she plunged into the deep,
as a wild bull's horn
receives the weight and bears it
down among the fish,
carrying death to them. She found
Thetis in a hollow cave;
around her sat the gathered
sea-goddesses, and in their midst
she mourned the fate of her
blameless son, who was to die
far from his country, in broad-soiled
Troy.

Swift-footed Iris stood beside her
and said: "Arise, Thetis.
Zeus calls you—the god whose
counsels do not perish."
Silver-footed Thetis answered: "Why
does that mighty god
command me? I am ashamed to
mingle with the immortals;
my heart is full of grief without
measure. Yet I will go;
his word shall not be spoken vainly,
whatever it may be."
She took the dark veil about her,
darker than any garment,
and went; before her swift-footed
Iris led the way,
while the sea's wave curved and
parted around them.
They rose from the shore and sped
into heaven, and found
the wide-seeing Son of Cronus; all
the blessed gods,
ever enduring, sat assembled there.
Thetis sat beside
her father Zeus; Athena yielded her
place. White-armed Hera
set a beautiful golden cup into her
hand, and welcomed her
with words of comfort; and Thetis
drank from it.
Then the father of gods and men
began among them:
"You have come to Olympus, goddess
Thetis, grieving still,
though I know your sorrow and its
unforgotten weight.
Yet I will tell you why I called you
here. For nine days now
the quarrel has risen among the
immortals over Hector's corpse

and city-sacker Achilles; they urge
the clear-eyed Slayer
of Argus to steal the body. But I
confer this honor upon Achilles,
guarding your reverence and the love
you shall retain hereafter.
Go quickly to the army, and charge
your son: the gods are angry,
and I, beyond all others, am angered,
because in his maddened mind
he keeps Hector beside the curved
ships and will not release him.
Perhaps he may fear me, and release
the body. And I shall send
Iris to great-hearted Priam, bidding
him ransom his dear son,
and carry gifts to Achilles—gifts that
may soothe his heart."
Thetis did not refuse. From
Olympus' heights she sprang,
and reached the shelter where her
son was found, beside
the ships, lamenting deeply; all his
dear companions
were busied with the preparation of
their meal,
and in the hut a great, thick-fleeced
sheep was slain.
The august mother sat beside him,
stroked him with her hand,
and called him by his name, and
spoke: "My child, how long
wilt thou consume thy heart in
mourning and in pain,
forgetful of thy food and of thy bed?
It is a good thing
to join in love with a woman; for thy
life shall not be long:
death and the mighty Fate already
stand beside thee.

Hear me at once. I come to thee
bearing Zeus' word.
He says the gods are angered with
thee, and that he himself,
beyond all other immortals, is most
deeply angered,
because with mind distraught thou
keepest Hector by the ships
and hast not let him go. Come, then:
release the dead,
and take the ransom offered for
him."
Swift-footed Achilles answered: "So
let it be—let him come
who brings the ransom and carries
away the dead,
if the Olympian himself commands
it with a willing heart."
Thus mother and son beside the
ships exchanged their many
winged words. Meanwhile the Son of
Cronus sent Iris
to sacred Ilium: "Go, swift Iris, leave
Olympus' seat;
tell great-hearted Priam, within the
city, to ransom
his dear son, going alone to the ships
of the Achaeans,
and to bring gifts to Achilles—gifts
that may soothe his heart.
Let no other Trojan follow him.
Only some older herald
may go with him, to guide his mules
and his well-wheeled wagon,
and afterward bring back to the city
the dead man
whom noble Achilles killed. Let
death not trouble his mind,
nor let him fear; we shall give him as
guide the Slayer of Argus,

who will conduct him safely until he
brings him near Achilles.
When he has led him within Achilles'
shelter, neither Achilles
himself shall kill him, nor shall he let
the others kill him;
for he is neither foolish, heedless, nor
transgressing,
but will show great care for the
suppliant man."
So he spoke, and storm-swift Iris
went bearing the word.
She reached the house of Priam, and
found there cries and grief.
His sons sat round their father in the
inner court,
wet with their tears; the old man in
their midst was wrapped
in a cloak, close-folded, and much
dung lay upon his head
and neck, which, rolling on the
ground, he had gathered
with his own hands. His daughters in
the halls, and daughters-in-law,
mourned, remembering the many
brave men who had fallen,
their lives destroyed beneath the
Argives' hands.
The messenger of Zeus stood beside
Priam and spoke softly;
but trembling seized the old king's
limbs: "Take courage,
Priam, son of Dardanus; let no fear
enter thy heart.
I have not come with evil in my
sight, but with good intent.
I am a messenger of Zeus, who,
though far away, cares for thee
and pities thee. The Olympian bids
thee ransom noble Hector,

and carry gifts to Achilles—gifts that may soothe his heart.

Let no other Trojan follow thee.

Only some older herald

may accompany thee, to guide thy mules and well-wheeled wagon,

and afterward bring home the dead man whom noble Achilles killed.

Let death not trouble thy mind, nor fear; for such a guide

as the Slayer of Argus shall follow with thee, and lead thee

until he brings thee near Achilles.

When he has led thee within

the shelter, neither Achilles himself shall kill thee,

nor shall he let the others kill thee;

for he is neither foolish,

nor heedless, nor a transgressor, but will carefully spare

the suppliant man.”

Having spoken thus, swift-footed Iris departed. But Priam

commanded his sons to make ready the smooth-running mule-cart,

and to fasten its wicker basket upon it. He himself went down

into the fragrant chamber, built high of cedar,

which held within it many treasures.

There he called

his wife Hecuba, and spoke: “Strange one, a messenger

from Zeus has come to me,

commanding that I go to the ships

of the Achaeans, to ransom my

beloved son, and bring gifts

to Achilles—gifts that may soothe his heart. Tell me,

what seems this counsel to thy mind?

For a terrible force

and desire urges me to go there, within the wide Achaean host.”

She cried aloud and answered: “Ah me! Where has thy reason fled,

for which thou wert renowned among strangers and those thou rulest?

How canst thou wish to go alone among the ships of the Achaeans, into the eyes of the man who has destroyed so many of thy sons, so brave and noble? Thy heart must be made of iron.

If that savage, faithless man should seize thee and behold thee,

he would show thee no mercy, nor any reverence. Let us sit

here in the hall apart and mourn; for such a thread the mighty Fate

spun for thy son when I bore him: that he should feed

the swift-footed dogs far from his parents, beside a powerful man.

Then might I bite the liver of that man, clinging to him—

such deeds would answer for my child, since he did not kill him

while shrinking back, but stood before the Trojans and their wives,

remembering neither fear nor flight.”

Then godlike aged Priam answered her: “Do not restrain me

when I desire to go; do not become an evil bird of omen

within my house. Thou shalt not persuade me. If another man

among earth’s people had

commanded this—some seer who

reads
the sacrifices, or a priest—we should
call it false,
and turn away the more. But now I
have heard the god himself,
and looked upon him face to face;
therefore I shall go,
and his word shall not be vain. If it is
my portion to die
beside the ships of the bronze-clad
Achaean, so be it;
let Achilles kill me at once, after I
have embraced my son
and satisfied my heart with
mourning.”
So speaking, he opened the beautiful
lids of the chests.
From them he drew twelve beautiful
robes,
twelve cloaks of single fold, and as
many rugs,
as many shining coverlets, and tunics
for them all.
Ten talents of fine gold he weighed
and carried forth;
two tripods he brought, and four
great cauldrons;
and from the chamber came a cup of
surpassing beauty,
which Thracian men had given him,
when he went among them
as envoy—a noble treasure. Yet the
old king spared it not,
for all his heart was set on ransoming
his beloved son.
Then he drove all the Trojans from
the porch with shameful words:
“Away, ye blemished cowards! Is
there no mourning in your houses,

that ye have come to trouble me? Do
ye rejoice that Zeus the Son
of Cronus has given me this sorrow,
and destroyed my best son?
Ye shall learn it too: the Achaeans
will find it easier now
to kill you, when he is dead. But
I—before I see the city
laid waste and ravaged with the
sword, may I descend
into the house of Hades!”
With his staff he drove them out;
they went before the old man,
hastening at his rebuke. He called his
sons together,
and scolded Helenus, Paris, noble
Agathon,
Pammon, Antiphonus, the
brave-voiced Polites,
Deiphobus, Hippothoon, and godlike
Agavus:
“Make haste, my evil children,
hateful as ye are!
Would that ye all had perished in
Hector’s place beside
the swift ships! Ah me, most utterly
unfortunate,
who fathered sons of excellence in
spacious Troy,
yet none remains, neither godlike
Mestor, nor horse-loving Troilus,
nor Hector, who seemed a god
among mankind, and was no son
of mortal man, but seemed the child
of some divinity.
The War-god slew the others; these
are left—our shame:
false speakers, dancers, masters of
the chorus-step,

thieves of the lambs and kids that
belong to their own people.
Will ye not swiftly harness the cart
for me, and load on it
all these things, that we may set out
upon the road?"
He spoke; and they, afraid of their
father's rebuke,
lifted the smooth-running mule-cart,
beautiful, newly made,
and bound its wicker basket firmly
upon it. From the peg
they took the mule-yoke, boxwood,
rounded at its center,
well fitted to its handles; then they
carried out the yoke-band,
nine cubits long, with the yoke itself.
They laid it well
upon the polished pole's first step,
and cast the ring
upon its pin; three times on either
side they tied it fast
around the knob, then drew it tight
in order beneath the tongue.
They brought from the chamber to
the polished wagon
countless gifts, the ransom set upon
Hector's head;
and yoked the strong-hoofed mules,
whose harness once had been
a shining gift the Mysians gave to
Priam. The old king
brought up the horses which he
himself had raised and fed
beside the polished manger. Within
the lofty house
the herald and Priam, both holding
wise thoughts, yoked them.
Then Hecuba, her heart oppressed,
came near, carrying wine,

sweet as honey, in her right hand,
within a golden cup,
that they might pour before their
going. She stood before
the horses and spoke, calling the old
king by name:
"Pour now to Father Zeus, and pray
that thou mayest return
home again from the men who hate
thee, since thy heart drives thee
toward the ships, though I am
unwilling. Pray to the dark-clouded
Son of Cronus on Ida, who looks
upon all Troy;
ask him for a swift eagle, his beloved
messenger,
whose strength is greatest among
birds, appearing on the right,
that thou mayest see it with thine
own eyes, and go to the ships
of the swift-footed Danaans, trusting
in the sign.
But if wide-seeing Zeus will not
grant his own messenger,
then, though thy desire be fierce, I
would not send thee
to the ships of the Argives."
Godlike Priam answered: "Wife, I
will not disobey thee;
it is good to lift one's hands to Zeus,
and see whether he may pity."
He called a housekeeper and bade
her pour pure water over his hands.
The attendant stood near, bearing
the basin and pitcher together.
The old man washed, received the
cup from his wife,
then stood within the court, poured
wine while gazing upward,

and prayed aloud: "Father Zeus, most glorious and greatest,
who rulest from Ida, grant that I may come to Achilles,
beloved and pitiful, and send a swift eagle, thy own
most cherished messenger, whose strength is greatest among birds,
appearing upon the right, that I may see it with my eyes,
and go to the ships of the swift-footed Danaans,
trusting in the sign."
So he prayed; and Zeus, the counsellor, heard him. At once he sent an eagle, the most perfect of winged birds,
the dark hunter, whom men also call the dusky one.
As broad as the high-roofed door of a rich man's chamber,
strongly fitted with its shining panels, were its wings
on either side. It flashed upon the right across the city.
Those who saw it rejoiced, and every heart within them
was eased. The old man, hastening, climbed upon his chariot;
he drove out from the doorway and the echoing court.
The mules drew first the four-wheeled wagon—Idaeus,
the thoughtful herald, guided them; and behind, the horses,
which the old king followed, urging them with the whip,
swiftly through the city. All his friends followed with him,

lamenting loudly, as though he were already going to death.
When they had descended from the city and reached the plain,
the sons and sons-in-law turned back toward Ilium;
but the two did not escape the notice of wide-seeing Zeus.
When he saw the old man upon the plain, he pitied him,
and quickly spoke to his own beloved son, Hermes:
"Hermes, for thou lovest most of all to be a companion
to mortal men, and hearest any man whom thou desirest,
go now, and lead Priam to the hollow ships of the Achaeans,
so that none of the other Danaans may see or know of him
before he comes to Peleus' son."
He spoke; nor did the messenger, the Slayer of Argus, disobey.
At once he bound beneath his feet the beautiful immortal sandals,
golden, ambrosial, which carried him over wet sea and boundless land,
together with the breath of wind. He took the wand with which
he charms the eyes of mortal men, whom he wishes, and wakes again those who are sleeping. Holding it in his hands, the mighty Slayer
of Argus flew; and soon he reached Troy and the Hellespont.
He went upon the road in the likeness of a young prince,
just entering the first bloom of youth, when that youth is loveliest.

When they had driven past the great
tomb beyond the city of Ilium,
they stopped the mules and horses,
that they might drink from the river;
for dusk had already spread itself
upon the earth. Then the herald,
seeing Hermes near them, recognized
him and spoke to Priam:

“Dardanid, take thought; I see a man,
and soon, I fear,

he will destroy us both. Come, let us
flee upon the horses,
or clasp his knees and supplicate
him, if perhaps he may pity us.”

So he spoke; and terror poured
through the old man’s mind;
the hairs stood straight upon his
bending limbs. But the gracious god
came near, took the old man’s hand,
and asked him:

“Father, how dost thou guide these
horses and mules through
the immortal night, when other
mortals sleep? Hast thou no fear
of the Achaeans breathing fury,
though they are near thee,
hostile and fierce? If one of them
should see thee carrying
such precious treasures through the
swift black night,
what thought would then possess
thee? Thou art not young thyself,
and this companion is an old man
too—hardly able to ward off
the first who should begin a quarrel.
But I will do thee no harm,
and even from another I would
shield thee; for thou art like
my beloved father.”

Then godlike aged Priam answered:
“My dear child, in all this
thou hast spoken truly. Yet some god
has stretched a hand above me,
and sent such a traveler to meet
me—one whose form and beauty
are fortunate, and whose mind is
wise, and whose parents are blessed.”

Then the messenger, the Slayer of
Argus, answered him:

“Yes, old man, all this thou hast
spoken according to fate.

But come, tell me this truth, and do
not hide it:

are ye sending these many beautiful
and precious treasures
to foreign men, that they may remain
safe for thee elsewhere?

Or are all of you already abandoning
sacred Ilium,

in fear, since such a man, thy son, the
best of all,

has fallen—and he lacked nothing in
the battle against the Achaeans?”

“And who art thou, most excellent,
and of what parents born?

Thou hast spoken well concerning
my unhappy son.”

The messenger, the Slayer of Argus,
answered him:

“Old man, thou testest me, and
askest me of noble Hector.

I have seen him often in the glorious
battle where men win fame;

I saw him also when he drove the
Argives toward the ships,

slaying them with sharp bronze. We
stood and wondered;

for Achilles, angered with the son of
Atreus, would not let us fight.

I am his servant; in a well-built ship
I came from Phthia, land of the
Myrmidons.

My father is Polyctor. He is rich, but
already old as thou art;

six sons he has, and I am the seventh.
By lot I was chosen

to come here among them. Now I
have come from the ships upon the
plain;

at dawn the bright-eyed Achaeans
will make battle round the city.

Their kings are impatient as they sit,
and cannot hold back
the army's eagerness for war."

Godlike old Priam answered: "If thou
art indeed a servant
of Peleus' son Achilles, tell me all the
truth:

is my son still beside the ships, or has
Achilles already cut him
limb from limb and laid him out for
his own dogs?"

The messenger, the Slayer of Argus,
answered him:

"Old man, the dogs have not eaten
him, nor the birds;
he still lies there beside Achilles'
ship, within the shelter,
just as he was. The twelfth dawn has
risen while he lies there,
yet his flesh does not decay, nor do
the worms consume him,
those worms that eat the men who
fall in battle.

At daybreak Achilles drags him
without pity around the tomb
of his beloved companion; but he
does not dishonor him.

Go and see for thyself how fresh he
lies, with blood washed away,
and no stain upon him. All the
wounds are closed—those wounds
where the bronze entered him,
though many struck him.

So greatly do the blessed gods care
for thy son, even in death,
because he was dear to them, and
dear beyond measure."

The old man rejoiced and answered:
"My child, it is good

to give the immortals their due gifts;
my son never forgot them,
not once, if ever he lived, within his
halls. Therefore they remember
him now, even in the portion of
death. But come, receive this
beautiful cup

from my hand; save me, and guide
me under the gods' protection,
until I reach the shelter of Peleus'
son."

The messenger answered: "Thou
testest me, old man, though I am
younger;

thou wouldst persuade me to accept
gifts from thee, without Achilles'
word.

I fear and reverence him too much to
rob him, lest some evil afterward
come upon me. But I would be thy
guide, even as far as famous Argos,
whether I walked beside thee on foot
or sailed in a swift ship;
no man would despise thy guide and
rise against thee."

So he sprang upon the chariot, took
the whip and reins,

and breathed good strength into the
horses and the mules.
When they reached the towers, the
trench, and the ships,
the guards had only just begun their
evening meal;
then the messenger, the Slayer of
Argus, poured sleep over them all,
and at once opened the gates and
thrust back the bars,
leading Priam and the shining gifts
inside upon the wagon.
When they came to the high shelter
of Peleus' son,
which the Myrmidons had built for
their king,
cutting the pine-tree beams and
roofing it above
with a thatch of meadow-grass; and
when around it they had made
a great court for their lord, with
close-set stakes,
and one pinewood gate, fastened by a
single bar,
which three Achaeans used to close
and three to open—
though Achilles alone could close
and open it—
then gracious Hermes opened the
gate for the old man,
and brought in Priam and the
glorious gifts to the swift-footed son
of Peleus. He stepped down from the
horses to the earth and spoke:
“Old man, know that I am Hermes,
an immortal god.
My father sent me as thy guide. But
now I return;
I will not enter the eyes of Achilles;
it would be unseemly

for an immortal to show such honor
face to face to mortals.
But go thou within, clasp the knees
of Peleus' son,
and supplicate him for his father, his
fair-haired mother,
and his child, that thou mayest stir
his heart.”
So speaking, Hermes departed
toward high Olympus.
Priam leapt down from the chariot
and left Idaeus there,
to guard the horses and the mules.
The old king went straight
into the shelter where Achilles was
accustomed to sit.
He found Achilles within; his
companions sat apart.
Only two heroes, Automedon and
Alcimus, branches of Ares,
served him as he sat; he had newly
ended his food and drink,
and the table still stood beside him.
Great Priam entered unseen, stood
near, clasped Achilles' knees,
and kissed the hands terrible in
battle, hands that had killed
so many of his sons. As when a man,
stricken by a sudden madness,
having killed a countryman, comes
among strangers to the house
of a wealthy man, and wonder seizes
all who see him—
so Achilles wondered when he saw
godlike Priam;
the others wondered too, and looked
upon one another.
Then Priam spoke to him,
supplicating:

“Remember thy father, godlike
Achilles, like me upon
the grievous threshold of old age.
Perhaps the neighbors around him
wear him down, and there is no one
to ward off trouble and ruin.
Yet he, hearing that thou livest,
rejoices in his heart,
and every day hopes to see his dear
son returning from Troy.
But I am altogether unfortunate: I
fathered the best of sons
in spacious Troy, and not one, I
think, remains.
Fifty sons I had when the Achaeans
came;
nineteen were born to me from one
womb,
and the others women bore within
my halls.
Most of them swift Ares loosened at
the knees.
But the one who stood alone,
defending the city and its people—
Hector, whom thou hast killed but
lately as he fought for his country—
for his sake I have come now to the
ships of the Achaeans,
to ransom him from thee; and I bring
a ransom beyond counting.
Revere the gods, Achilles, and have
pity upon me,
remembering thy father. I am more
pitiable than he;
for I have endured what no other
mortal on earth has endured:
I have brought my hand to the
mouth of the man who killed my
son.”

So he spoke, and stirred in Achilles
the desire to weep for his father.
He took the old man's hand and
gently pushed him away.
Then, remembering each other, the
one mourned Hector the man-killer,
lying released before Achilles' feet;
and Achilles mourned his father,
and at times Patroclus. The sound of
their lament rose throughout the
house.
When noble Achilles had taken his
fill of mourning,
and the desire had gone from his
heart and limbs,
he rose at once from his seat and
lifted the old man by the hand,
pitying his gray head and gray beard.
He spoke winged words:
“Ah, wretched man, thou hast
endured many sorrows in thy heart.
How couldst thou dare to come
alone among the ships of the
Achaeans,
into the eyes of the man who has
destroyed so many of thy brave sons?
Thy heart must be made of iron.
Come, sit upon this seat;
though we are grieving, let us lay our
pains down within our hearts.
There is no profit in the chill lament;
for the gods have spun
this destiny for miserable mortals: to
live in grief,
while they themselves are free from
care.
“Two jars stand upon Zeus' floor,
filled with gifts he gives:
one holds evils, the other blessings.
To the man with whom

Zeus who delights in thunder
mingles the gifts, now evil comes,
now good; but to the man to whom
he gives only the sorrowful gifts,
he makes him disgraced, and grim
hunger drives him over the bright
earth;

he wanders honored neither by gods
nor mortals.

“So the gods gave Peleus splendid
gifts from his birth;

he surpassed all men in happiness
and wealth,

and ruled the Myrmidons. Though
mortal, the gods gave him a goddess
for his wife; yet even upon him a god
laid this evil:

no race of mighty sons was born to
him within his halls,

but only one son, born to a death
before his time.

Nor do I care for him now that he
grows old, since far from his country
I sit in Troy, bringing sorrow to thee
and to thy children.

“And thou, old man, we once heard,
wert blessed:

as far as Lesbos, Makar’s seat, bounds
thee within,

and Phrygia lies above, and the
boundless Hellespont—

men said thou didst surpass all elders
in wealth and sons.

But since the gods of heaven brought
this sorrow upon thee,

battles and slaughter have forever
surrounded thy city.

Endure, and do not lament without
ceasing within thy heart;

thy grief will win thee nothing, nor
wilt thou raise thy son again,
before another evil first befall thee.”

Godlike aged Priam answered him:

“Do not make me sit,
nurseling of Zeus, while Hector lies
uncared for in the shelter.

Release him quickly, that I may see
him with my eyes;

receive the abundant ransom we
have brought thee;

enjoy it, and mayest thou return to
thy native land,

since thou hast first allowed me to
live and look upon the sun.”

Swift-footed Achilles looked darkly
upon him and answered:

“Stir me no further now, old man. I
myself know well

that I must release thy Hector; from
Zeus there came to me

my mother, daughter of the ancient
lord of the sea.

And I know thee too, Priam; thou
dost not escape my mind:

some god has led thee to the swift
ships of the Achaeans.

No mortal, not even one in the first
strength of youth,

would dare to come into our army;
he could not escape

the watchmen’s eyes, nor easily move
the bar across our gate.

Therefore trouble my heart no
further in its grief,

lest, old man, I leave thee not even
here within my shelter,

though thou art my suppliant, and
transgress the commands of Zeus.”

He spoke; the old man feared and obeyed his word.
Then Peleus' son sprang like a lion from the shelter,
not alone: Automedon and Alcimus followed him,
the two companions whom Achilles honored most
after Patroclus, who had fallen. They loosed the horses
and the mules from beneath the yoke, and brought within
the herald, the old man's clear-voiced companion;
they set him down upon a seat, and from the polished wagon
they lifted the immeasurable ransom for Hector's head.
But they left two robes and one well-woven tunic,
that he might wrap the dead man and carry him home.
Achilles called the serving-women and commanded them
to wash the body and anoint it, carrying it aside,
so that Priam might not see his son. For, seeing Hector,
the old man's wounded heart might fail to restrain his anger,
and Achilles' heart might rise again, and he might kill him,
transgressing the commands of Zeus. When the serving-women
had washed him and anointed him with oil, they cast around him
a beautiful robe and tunic. Achilles himself lifted him
from the bier and laid him upon it; his companions

raised him and placed him upon the polished wagon.
Then Achilles groaned and called his beloved companion by name:
"Be not angry with me, Patroclus, if thou hearest in Hades,
that I have released noble Hector to his dear father;
for he has given me no unworthy ransom. Of these gifts also
I will divide with thee whatever portion is fitting."
So speaking, noble Achilles went again into the shelter,
and sat upon the richly worked seat from which he had risen,
against the farther wall; then he spoke to Priam:
"Thy son is released, old man, as thou didst command;
he lies upon the bier. At the rising of the bright dawn
thou shalt see him thyself and carry him away. But now
let us remember food.
"For even fair-haired Niobe remembered food, though twelve children
perished within her house—six daughters and six sons in the flower
of youth. Apollo, with his silver bow, killed the sons,
angered with Niobe; and Artemis, the archer, killed the daughters,
because Niobe had compared herself with fair-cheeked Leto,
saying that Leto bore two children, while she herself had borne many.
Though they were only two, they destroyed them all.

For nine days they lay in their blood,
and no one was there to bury them;
the Son of Cronus had turned the
people into stone. On the tenth day
the gods of heaven buried them. Yet
she remembered food,
when she had grown weary with
shedding tears.

And now, somewhere among the
rocks, in the lonely mountains,
on Sipylus, where they say the
goddess-nymphs have their beds,
the nymphs who dance around
Achelous, there, though she is stone,
she still digests the sorrows given by
the gods.

“Come, then, noble old man; let us
also take food.

Afterward thou shalt weep again for
thy beloved son,
when thou hast brought him into
Ilium; and he shall bring thee
many tears.”

Swift Achilles sprang up and
slaughtered a white-fleeced sheep.
His companions flayed it and
prepared it properly;
they cut the meat with skill, spitted
it, and roasted it carefully,
then drew all the portions away.
Automedon took the bread
and set it out in handsome baskets
upon the table;
Achilles divided the meat. They
reached their hands
toward the ready food set before
them.

When they had put away their desire
for drink and food,

Dardanian Priam wondered at
Achilles—how great he was,
and what a man he seemed, for he
resembled the immortal gods.

And Achilles wondered at
Dardanian Priam in turn,
beholding his noble face and hearing
his words.

When they had taken their fill of
looking upon each other,
godlike aged Priam spoke first:

“Tell me now, nurseling of Zeus, and
tell me quickly, that already
we may find sweet sleep and rest
ourselves in slumber.”

“That we may take our fill of sweet
sleep and rest in slumber.

For never yet have my eyes closed
beneath their lids

since by thy hands my son gave up
his life;

but always I groan, and in the court I
digest

countless griefs, rolling myself in the
dust and dung.

Now I have tasted food and poured
the dark wine down my throat;
before this I had tasted nothing.”

Achilles commanded his companions
and the serving-women

to set two beds beneath the porch,
and spread upon them

beautiful purple coverlets; over these
to lay rugs,

and woolen cloaks above, that they
might wrap themselves.

The women went out from the
chamber, carrying torches,

and quickly, busied, spread the two
beds.

Then swift-footed Achilles spoke
half in jest:
“Lie outside, dear old man, lest one
of the Achaeans enter,
some counselor who sits beside me as
they sit and devise
the counsels that are lawful. If such a
man should see thee
through the swift black night, he
would at once report it
to Agamemnon, shepherd of the
people; and the release
of the dead might then be delayed.
Come, tell me this truth:
how many days dost thou intend to
mourn noble Hector,
that I may stay here myself and hold
the people back?”
Godlike aged Priam answered: “If
thou wilt grant us to bury
noble Hector, thou wouldst make
thyself most gracious to me
by doing as I say. Thou knowest how
we are enclosed within the city,
and how far the wood must be
brought down from the mountain;
the Trojans are very much afraid. For
nine days we would mourn him
within our halls; on the tenth we
would bury him, and give a feast
to the people; on the eleventh we
would make his burial mound;
and on the twelfth, if need should be,
we would fight.”
Swift-footed noble Achilles
answered: “These things too shall be,
old Priam, as thou commandest. I
shall hold back the battle
for as long a time as thou hast asked.”

So speaking, he took the old man’s
right wrist,
that he might not fear within his
heart.
There, in the forecourt, the herald
and Priam slept,
both holding prudent counsels in
their hearts;
but Achilles slept in the recess of the
well-built shelter,
and beside him lay fair-cheeked
Briseis.
All the other gods and men, the
horse-harnessed warriors,
slept through the night, mastered by
gentle sleep;
but sleep did not seize gracious
Hermes, who pondered
within his heart how he might send
King Priam from the ships,
unseen by the sacred guards who
kept the gates.
He stood above the old man’s head
and spoke:
“Old man, thou hast no care for
danger, sleeping thus among
the enemy, after Achilles has spared
thee. Thou hast now released
thy beloved son, and given much for
him; but while thou livest,
thy sons who remain might give
three times as much in ransom,
if Agamemnon, son of Atreus, should
learn of thee,
and all the Achaeans should learn of
it.”
He spoke; and the old man was
afraid, and woke the herald.
Hermes himself yoked the horses and
the mules,

and swiftly drove them through the army; no one knew him.

When they reached the ford of the fair-flowing, eddying Xanthus, whom immortal Zeus himself begot, Hermes then descended and went away toward high Olympus. Dawn, clothed in saffron, was spreading over all the earth; and they drove their horses into the city with lamentation and groaning.

The mules carried the dead man. No other man or woman among the beautiful-girdled Trojans knew them; but Cassandra, like golden Aphrodite in her beauty, having climbed upon Pergamos, saw her beloved father standing in the chariot, and the herald who called the city; then she saw Hector lying upon the bed upon the mules.

She cried aloud, and her voice went throughout the city:

“Behold, ye Trojans and Trojan women, and go forth to meet Hector, if ever, while he lived, ye rejoiced when he returned from battle; for he was a great joy to the city, and to all the people!”

So she spoke; nor did any man or woman remain within the city, for unbearable grief had reached them all. They met the dead man near the gates. First his beloved wife and his august mother rushed to the smooth-running wagon, tearing at their hair,

and touched his head; the crowd stood round them, weeping.

And now they would have mourned Hector there the whole day, until the sun had gone down, shedding tears before the gates, had not the old man spoken from the chariot to the people:

“Make way for me, that I may pass among the mules;

after I have brought him home, ye shall have your fill of weeping.”

So he spoke; and they parted, making room for the wagon.

When they had brought him into the glorious house, they laid him upon the pierced bier, and set beside him singers,

leaders of the dirge, to begin the song of mourning.

They sang the lament, and the women groaned around them.

White-armed Andromache began the wailing among them, holding in her hands the head of Hector, slayer of men:

“Hector, thou hast died young, and left me widowed here

within our halls; and our child is still a little one,

our child, whom thou and I, unhappy parents, bore.

I do not think he shall come into his youth; before that time this city from its height shall be utterly destroyed.

For thou art dead, who wast its guardian, and didst defend it, and keptest safe its reverend wives and little children;

soon they shall be carried away in the hollow ships,
and I among them. And thou, my child, shalt follow me,
where thou shalt do disgraceful labor before a pitiless lord;
or some Achaean, seizing thee by the hand, shall hurl thee
from the tower to a bitter death, in anger because Hector killed
his brother, or his father, or his son—so many Achaeans
bit the vast earth beneath Hector's hands.

"For thy father was not gentle in the grievous battle.

Therefore the people mourn him throughout the city;
thou hast made thy parents a lament and sorrow not to be forgotten,
Hector; but for me, most of all, grievous pains remain.

For when thou wert dying, thou didst not stretch thy hands to me from the bed, nor speak a thoughtful word which I might remember, shedding tears through the nights and days."

So she spoke in tears, and the women groaned around her.

Then Hecuba began the loud, unceasing lament:

"Hector, dearest of all my children to my heart,
while thou wert living, thou wert beloved by the gods;
and even in death they have cared for thee. For all my other sons
swift-footed Achilles sold, whoever he took beyond the barren sea,

to Samos, Imbros, and Lemnos veiled in mist.

But when he took thy life with his long-pointed bronze,
many times he dragged thee round the tomb of his companion,
Patroclus, whom thou hadst killed; yet he could not raise him again.
And now thou liest fresh and dewy in our halls,
like one whom silver-bowed Apollo, moving gently,
has struck and killed with his soft arrows."

So she spoke in tears, and stirred an unending cry.

Then Helen, third among them, began her lament:

"Hector, dearest of all my brothers by marriage,
my husband is Alexander, beautiful as a god,
who brought me here to Troy—would that I had died before!
This is now the twentieth year since I came from my country
and left it; yet never have I heard from thee a harsh word,
nor one that cut me with reproach. If another in the halls
rebuked me—one of thy brothers, or sisters, or the wives
of thy well-robed brothers, or thy mother, or thy father,
who was always gentle as a father—thou wouldst restrain him
with words, through thy own gentleness and gentle speech.
Therefore I mourn thee and myself together, with a grieving heart;

for no one else remains in spacious
Troy who is gentle to me
or a friend. They all look upon me
and shudder.”

So she spoke in tears, and the
countless people groaned.

Then old Priam spoke among them:
“Bring wood now, ye Trojans, from
the city, and fear not
the Achaeans’ close ambush in your
hearts. Achilles charged me,
when he sent me away from the
black ships, not to suffer harm
until the twelfth dawn should come.”
So he spoke; and beneath the wagons
they yoked oxen and mules,
then swiftly gathered together before
the city.

For nine days they brought an
immeasurable store of wood.

But when the tenth dawn, the
light-bringer, appeared,
they carried forth bold Hector,
shedding tears,

set the dead man upon the highest
part of the pyre,
and cast the fire upon him.

When early-born, rose-fingered
Dawn appeared,
the people gathered around the pyre
of glorious Hector.

When they had gathered and
assembled together, first they
quenched
all the fire wherever the strength of
flame had reached,
pouring bright wine over it. Then his
brothers and companions
gathered the white bones, mourning,
and hot tears flowed down

their cheeks. They lifted them and
laid them in a golden chest,
wrapping them in soft purple robes.
Swiftly they placed the chest within
a hollow grave,
and covered it above with great
stones, closely set.

They raised the mound with speed,
while watchers sat around it,
guarding on every side, lest the
well-greaved Achaeans
should attack before the mourning
had been completed.

When they had raised the mound,
they returned again;
then, gathered well together, they
held a splendid feast
within the house of Priam, the king
whom Zeus had nourished.

Thus they tended the tomb of
Hector, breaker of horses.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional
draft. Not approved for final layout.



PLATE — Priam kneels before Achilles in the night shelter

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